THE GILDED DOOR

The Gilded Door

Ken Follett

ROME · A.D. 112

CONTENTS

PART I — THE HOUSE

Chapter One *The House That Money Built*
Chapter Two *Fifteen Years*
Chapter Three *The Price of Paper*
Chapter Four *The Tiber Keeps Its Own*
Chapter Five *Contracts and Silence*
Chapter Six *The Soft Voice*

PART II — DEBTS

Chapter Seven *The Circus*
Chapter Eight *A Father at the Door*
Chapter Nine *The Baths*
Chapter Ten *Hilarus's Table*
Chapter Eleven *Borrowed Money*
Chapter Twelve *The Raid*

PART III — WHISPERS

Chapter Thirteen *Terms*
Chapter Fourteen *Blood on the Sand*
Chapter Fifteen *The Wife's Bargain*
Chapter Sixteen *Ostia*
Chapter Seventeen *The Witnesses*
Chapter Eighteen *The Citation*
Chapter Nineteen *A Wedding in Rome*

PART IV — PAYMENT

Chapter Twenty *Custody*

Chapter Twenty-One *Fire*
Chapter Twenty-Two *The Forum, First Day*
Chapter Twenty-Three *The Forum, Second Day*
Chapter Twenty-Four *The Consul's Choice*
Chapter Twenty-Five *The Gilded Door*

PART I

THE HOUSE

CHAPTER ONE

The House That Money Built

The last guest left at cockcrow, carried out between two of his own slaves with his garland askew and a line of Greek poetry drowning in his throat. Festus shut the gilded door behind him, dropped the bar into its brackets, and stood for a moment with his broad back against the wood, listening to the litter bearers' footsteps fade down the Carinae.

“Gone,” he said.

Antonia Cassia was seated at the counting table in the atrium, where the lamps had burned low and the dawn light was beginning to grey the opening in the roof. She had not sat down once during the six hours of the supper. Now she wrote in her ledger by the uneven flame, her stylus moving quickly across the wax, setting down what each man had drunk, what he had said, and what it was worth.

“Not all gone,” she said, without looking up. “Praetor Gratus left his signet ring again. Send it back at the third hour with a note saying nothing. His wife opens his correspondence.”

Festus grinned. The scar that split his left eyebrow whitened when he did it. “Third hour. She'll think he spent the night in a temple, praying for chastity.”

“She'll think whatever she likes, so long as she does not think of this house.” Antonia turned the stylus and smoothed the wax flat with its broad end. “The consular's fish: he had three helpings of the mullet and none of the wild boar. Note it. Men who refuse boar are either ill or afraid of dying, and either makes them generous. The olive merchant from Baetica drank four cups of unmixed wine and wept about his mother. See that he wakes to a wreath of the flowers she'd have liked. Whatever those were.”

“Roses,” said Phyllis, coming through from the garden court with a ring of keys at her belt and a folded cloth over her arm. “His mother grew roses. He told the cook. I've already had the garland made.” She was sixty years old, thin and straight as a reed, with grey hair drawn tight under her kerchief and the shrewd, tired eyes of a woman who had managed other people's households since before Antonia was born. She looked at the lamps, the scattered cushions, the dark wine pools on the mosaic. “You should sleep. The girls are abed. I'll see to the wreckage.”

“I'll sleep when the house is clean enough that I could eat off its floor.” Antonia closed the ledger. “In this house, my dear, the floor is the first thing

they remember and the second thing they pay for.”

It was a house worth remembering. From the street a passer-by saw only a long blank wall of tufa and the celebrated door, its bronze leaves overlaid with gold leaf so that it glowed even on rainy mornings, flanked by two footmen in matched blue tunics. Beyond the door lay a vestibule paved in black-and-white mosaic showing leaping dolphins, then an atrium with Corinthian columns, a marble impluvium where fish moved under lily pads, and walls painted in the new style, deep red above and black below, with slender architectural fantasies rising between them. To the left was the dining wing, three triclinia that could be thrown into one; to the right the private rooms, the baths, the kitchens humming like a small town. At the back, a colonnade looked onto a garden of clipped box and roses, with a fountain in the shape of a boy wrestling a goose.

Everything in it had been bought, and everyone who came through the gilded door knew it. That was the house's particular genius. Old money pretended to have sprung from the earth like the stones of its own villas. Antonia's money admitted, calmly and without apology, that it was money — counted, weighed, and spent with perfect judgement.

She rose and walked the rooms now, as she did after every supper, while the household slaves

moved around her with cloths and bowls and armfuls of fresh roses. In the great triclinium the couches still bore the hollows of men's bodies. A plate of dates had been overturned; a second-century silver cup — a Greek piece, worth a small fortune — lay under a table where a praetorian officer had kicked it. She picked it up herself and set it on the sideboard.

“Anything broken that I must pretend not to notice?”

“One glass goblet, Alexandrian,” said Phyllis, following her. “The one cut like a flower. The procurator's cousin. He knocked it over reaching for the dancer.”

“Add it to his bill with a tenth on top. He'll pay without a murmur and tip the messenger besides, to keep us quiet about the dancer.” Antonia touched a cushion; the silk was damp. “Burn the myrrh. The whole wing smells of a Syrian temple.”

Chloe appeared in the colonnade, barefoot, wrapped in a saffron mantle with her black hair loose to her shoulders. She was Greek, from Athens by way of the slave market at Delos, and she carried herself like a woman who had decided long ago that the world could take her as it found her. She yawned, saw Antonia, and lifted one hand in a kind of salute.

“Is he gone? The procurator's cousin? He told me his wife didn't understand him. At length. In verse.”

“His wife understands him perfectly,” said Antonia. “That is why he must come here to be misunderstood.”

Chloe laughed, then winced and pressed a hand to her temple. “Wine. I shall drink water for a month. Tell me I said nothing damaging.”

“You told him that a man with his income should buy better poets. He took it as flirtation.”

“It was flirtation. Flirtation is the house's trade. I'm going to the bath. Is there hot water?”

“There is always hot water in this house,” said Phyllis, with the pride of a general stating that the grain ships had arrived. “Go on. All of you. I'll call you at noon.”

Antonia watched her go with the particular attention she gave each of the women under her roof — checking the set of the shoulders, the tone of the voice, the small signs that told her whether a night had been merely long or had turned ugly. Chloe was tired, nothing more. Good. The rules were written into the doorposts as far as Antonia was concerned: the guests paid for music, wine, conversation, beauty, and the company of women who knew how to make a man feel remarkable. What happened beyond that, between consenting adults in a closed room, was arranged in daylight, with contracts, and never under this roof against a woman's will. Men who forgot the rule once were shown it by Festus. Men who forgot it twice were shown it by Festus in the street, in front of their litters.

It had taken her eleven years to make the rule stick. Rome had a thousand houses where a man with money could do exactly as he pleased. There was only one, Antonia had decided, where he could not, and the rarity of it was what filled the gilded door every night.

She was turning back toward the atrium when Festus appeared again, and this time the scarred eyebrow was drawn together.

“Someone at the postern. A man named Nucerinus, with a girl. He says you're expecting goods.”

“I'm expecting fish from the market and snow from the mountains,” Antonia said. “I am not expecting Nucerinus. What does he want?”

“He has papers. He wants money, and he wants it before the street wakes up.” Festus hesitated, which with Festus meant a great deal. “The girl's in the passage. She doesn't look like goods.”

Antonia set down her stylus. “Bring him to the tablinum. And bring the girl to the garden bench. Phyllis, give her something hot. Not wine — water with honey. And close the postern behind them. The neighbours count everything.”

⁂

Nucerinus was a freedman with soft hands and a mantle too fine for the hour, the sort of man who had discovered that Rome's debts were more profitable than Rome's goods. He came in smiling,

bowing, holding out a folded document as though it were a birthday gift.

“Domina Antonia. Honoured. My patron, the lender Vipsanius, sends his deepest respects. A small matter of contract, settled discreetly at this hour so that no one's dignity need suffer in daylight.”

“Your patron's dignity has never kept me awake,” Antonia said. She did not ask him to sit. “Show me the paper.”

It was a contract of debt, written in the cramped hand of a public scribe and sealed with two witnesses' marks. Quintus Avianius, a smallholder from the land beyond the fourth milestone on the Appian Way, had borrowed three thousand sesterces against his next two harvests. The harvests had failed, or the price had failed, which came to the same thing in the end. Beneath the debt was written the security he had pledged: himself, his wife, and his unmarried daughter, to be bound to the lender's service until the principal and interest were discharged.

Antonia read it twice. The form was legal. Everything about it was legal, the way a knife between the ribs can be legal if the right man holds the handle.

“Interest at thirty-six per cent,” she said.

“Twelve per cent, domina, compounded each quarter. The law permits it.”

“The law permits a great many things it would be kinder to drown. Where is Avianius now?”

“His wife is sick. He stayed at the farm. The girl came of her own accord, under the terms.” Nucerinus smiled again, small and quick. “Vipsanius has no use for a farm girl in his own house. He thought of you. A handsome piece, young, sound, unbroken. In the Subura they'd take her for whatever she'd fetch and turn her out at thirty. In a house like this — well. A girl could learn a trade here. Refined company. Music. Perhaps you'd keep her yourself.”

The implication hung in the room like smoke. Antonia kept her face still. “How much?”

“Five thousand sesterces. The debt, the costs, and a small consideration for the discretion of the hour.”

“The debt is three thousand. The costs are invented. I'll give four thousand, and I'll take the contract and the girl together, with a full quittance signed before my own witnesses. At that price Vipsanius has his money back before breakfast and his consideration besides. At any higher price I send you to the public auction, where she'll go for two thousand and he'll wait a month for it.”

Nucerinus opened his mouth. Antonia looked at him. She had been looking at men like him across tables for fifteen years, and she had learned that silence, held one beat longer than was comfortable, was worth two cohorts of soldiers.

“Four thousand,” he said.

“Festus will count it out in the strong room. Sit there. Do not touch anything.”

She went out through the colonnade to the garden.

The girl was on the stone bench under the pergola, clutching a cloth bundle on her knees. Phyllis sat beside her with a cup, but the cup sat untouched. She was seventeen, perhaps eighteen, with the broad shoulders and sun-weathered hands of a girl who had carried water and cut grapes since she was small. Her dress was clean but mended twice at the hem. She had a wide, plain, honest face, and she was doing everything she knew how to do not to cry. Her eyes moved over the garden, the fountain, the painted colonnade, with the expression of a person watching a ship sink from the shore.

Antonia sat down at the other end of the bench and left a careful space between them.

“What is your name?”

“Sabina.” The voice was steady, though the hands on the bundle were not. “Sabina Aviania. My father is Quintus Avianius. He's an honest man. The grapes rotted on the vine two years running, and then the olive fly—”

“I know how farms fail. It is rarely the farmer's fault, and it is always the farmer's ruin.” Antonia spoke plainly, without the soothing tone men used to frighten slaves. “Do you know what this house is?”

Sabina's jaw tightened. “Yes, domina.”

“Then tell me what you think it is, and we'll find out how much of it is true.”

“A place where men come. Where women —” She stopped, swallowed, began again. “Where women entertain them. My mother said I'd be better off throwing myself in the Tiber. My father said honour was a luxury for people who ate regularly.” The steadiness cracked at the edges. “He cried when I left. He went down on his knees in the yard. I told him to get up, because my mother needed him standing.”

Antonia regarded her for a long moment. Under the fear there was something hard, a knot of something that would not bend. She recognized it. She had carried the same knot herself, once, into houses far worse than this one.

“Listen to me, Sabina Aviania, and remember it, because I say it once. In this house no man will touch you unless you agree to it, in writing, before witnesses, for a price you have seen and accepted. No one will beat you. No one will lend you out. In return, you will work — hard, at whatever you are given — and you will learn. Reading, figures, music, the proper way to carry a cup and the proper way to answer a consul. Girls who leave this house leave with silver in their hands and a trade. Do you understand?”

The girl stared. “Why would you buy me, then, if not—”

“Because Vipsanius would sell you to someone who would. Because four thousand sesterces is

less than I lose in a bad evening at dice, and because a house is only as strong as the people in it.” Antonia stood. “Phyllis will take you to the bath. You'll sleep in the women's wing, in a room with a door that bolts on the inside. Tomorrow you begin lessons. The bolt is your right. The lessons are your duty.” She paused. “Your father's debt paper comes to me now, not to Vipsanius. That means he answers to me. I may have use for an honest farmer one day. Honest men are rarer than girls, and Rome has always been short of both.”

Sabina looked down at the cup in her hands as if she had never seen honey-water before. When she looked up, the tears had won, but she was angry at them, wiping them away with the heel of her hand.

“Why are you doing this?”

Antonia almost smiled. “Because I was the girl on the bench. A long time ago. And no one said any of it to me.” She turned toward the house. “Phyllis. See to her. And send Festus to me with the quittance. I want it in the strong room before Nucerinus's foot touches the street.”

⁂

On the Esquiline Hill, in the domus of the Aelii, the morning began as every morning began, with the salutatio.

Marcus Aelius Severus came down before sunrise in a plain white tunic, his sandals freshly soled, his beard trimmed by a slave whose one duty in life was to keep it exactly even. He was thirty-eight years old, tall and straight, with the long, narrow face of the old Roman statues and grey beginning at his temples that the senators' wives said made him look like a man out of the Republic. He carried himself the way his father had taught him, as though the whole city were watching even in an empty room, which in Rome was very nearly true.

The atrium was already full. Clients stood in careful order against the walls, in the careful order they had spent years earning — old friends near the open doors, newer petitioners further back, the professional morning-callers who lived on the sportula dole near the exit where their baskets could be filled without disturbing anyone. The nomenclator Stichus stood at his master's elbow, murmuring names and circumstances into his ear in a voice pitched for no one else.

“Lucius Gavius, farm dispute with his neighbour over a boundary wall. Gaius Memmius, the schoolmaster, comes about the rent. The widow Hortensia, her son's army discharge papers, she was here last month. The two Greeks are poets, they want a patron, they have been told not to recite before the eighth hour.”

Marcus took his chair — the old curule chair his grandfather had used, its ivory arms worn smooth — and the first man came forward.

He did the morning's work the way he did everything: thoroughly, without warmth but without cruelty, giving each man the full force of his attention and a decision he would have to live with. The boundary wall, he ruled, would be surveyed at the shared cost of both neighbours, and he would lend his own surveyor; the schoolmaster's rent would wait until the new term's fees came in, and he was not to be charged interest; the widow's papers he signed himself, cutting through three offices of army clerks with a single line and the name that opened every door in Rome. The poets he gave a small sum and a polite refusal, and bore their thanks with the expression of a man having a tooth drawn.

It took two hours. When the last client had bowed himself out, a small boy appeared in the atrium doorway with a scroll clutched to his chest and ink on his nose.

“Gaius,” said Marcus, and something in the formal face softened, just slightly, the way a frost softens when the sun reaches it. “You have ink on your nose.”

“I know, Father. I put it there to make the slaves think I've been working.” The boy came forward and presented the scroll. “It's my translation. The Xenophon. The part where the army reaches the sea.”

Marcus took it and read a page, slowly, while his son stood rigid with pretended patience. “Your word order is better. Here, though — you've made the soldiers shout ‘the sea, the sea' as if they were ordering dinner. They had marched through a desert. They thought they were going to die. Make the words smaller. Big feelings go in small words.”

Gaius considered this with complete seriousness. “Small words. Yes. I'll do it again.”

“Again, and then again after that. Nothing good is ever finished, it is only stopped in time.” Marcus handed back the scroll. “Where is your sister?”

“Trying to teach the cat to sit on a perch. The cat considers it beneath her.”

“A sensible cat. Go and wash your nose.”

The boy went, and Marcus watched him go with the private weight that fathers in great houses carried. Gaius was fourteen, bookish and tender-hearted, born to a class that required its sons to be neither. The army would take him in two years, as it took every young man of his rank, and Marcus had already begun the long, quiet work of making him hard enough to survive it without making him cruel enough to suit it. It was the most difficult thing he had ever attempted, and there was no one to ask whether he was doing it well.

Livia came down the stairs as the boy crossed the hall, and paused to let him pass with a hand

on his shoulder. She was a handsome woman of thirty-three, dressed with the severe elegance of the old aristocracy — no eastern silks, no pearls the size of chickpeas, just fine wool, gold at her ears, and her dark hair wound in the fashion of the emperor's wife. She managed the household's five hundred slaves, its accounts, its rituals, and its reputation with a competence that Marcus respected entirely and a distance that had become, over fifteen years, the settled weather of their marriage.

“Good morning,” she said. It was a courtesy between diplomats.

“Good morning. The widow Hortensia's business is done. I signed the discharge.”

“You sign everything she brings. Half the widows in Rome are beginning to lose their husbands on purpose.” She sat across from him, and Stichus poured her water. “Your brother is breakfasting in the garden. He arrived an hour ago in a litter with four Syrians and perfume you can smell in the street. I have put him where the clients can't see him.”

“Thank you. I'll deal with Celer.”

“There's more. A note came from the consul's office. They want you at the treasury at the fourth hour, something about supply contracts. And an invitation.” She held out a folded square of pale, expensive paper, sealed with no name, only a small gilded door pressed into the wax. “A supper. Tonight. Every woman I know has a husband who

has received one, and none of them will say what the place is, which means they all know perfectly.”

Marcus turned the seal over in his fingers. “Where is it?”

“The Carinae. The house of Antonia Cassia.” Livia's voice was perfectly neutral, the neutrality of a woman who had made neutrality into armour. “They say it is the best table in Rome. They also say a great many other things. You are not obliged to go.”

Marcus set the invitation on the table. His first instinct was to refuse, and he nearly said so; but he was a man trained to examine his instincts for self-indulgence, and he examined this one. The truth was that he disliked the idea of the house because he disliked the idea of being the sort of man who needed such houses, and that was a personal discomfort, not a reason of state.

“I'll think on it,” he said.

Livia rose. “Do that. Your brother is eating my best figs.”

⁂

He found Decimus Aelius Celer reclining on a garden couch under the plum tree, with a plate of figs, a dish of olives, and a young slave to fan him, looking like a portrait of the god Bacchus done by a painter who had been paid too much. Celer was four years younger than Marcus, handsome in a

soft, golden way, and gifted with the family charm in the same proportion that Marcus had been given the family stubbornness. He smiled broadly and lifted his cup.

“Brother. The terror of the morning clients. Sit. Eat a fig. These are from the consul's own gardens, though I shouldn't tell you how I know.”

“You should not.” Marcus sat on the bench, upright, the way he sat on benches. “You are out early. And out of breath. The four Syrians again?”

“One must make an entrance. A litter with two bearers is merely transport. With four it's a statement.” Celer ate a fig, examined his fingers, and wiped them on the cloth the slave offered. “I came because I need a word before the treasury business. You're to look at the supply contracts, aren't you? The eastern preparations. Everyone knows the consuls want an honest name on the review, and your name is the only honest one left that hasn't got gout.”

“Who told you?”

“Rome told me. Rome is a woman with a very loud voice and no secrets.” The charm held, but Marcus saw the flicker beneath it, the quick calculation behind the smile. “I'd take it as a brother's kindness if you'd — well. Move carefully. There are good men in those contracts. Men with families. A review that turns into a persecution ruins people who never meant harm.”

Marcus looked at him. “Are you in those contracts, Decimus?”

“Me?” The laugh was a half-beat too quick. “I'm a gentleman, not a grain merchant. I merely know some of the firms. Subscribed to one or two, the way one does. Nothing that wouldn't bear the light.” He reached for another fig. “Do come to the supper with me tonight. Antonia Cassia's. I've an invitation, you've an invitation, all the best men have invitations. It's where the contractors talk when they think no one's listening. If you're going to audit their accounts, hear their confessions first. And the music is said to be extraordinary.”

“I've heard.”

“Then say yes. For Rome. For the treasury. For the honour of the Aelii.” Celer grinned. “And because if you spend one more evening reading legal commentaries in an empty house, Stichus will die of boredom and leave you without a nomenclator.”

Marcus did not smile. He was thinking about contracts, and about the way his brother's fingers had tightened, very slightly, on the fig.

“I'll decide at the treasury,” he said. “Eat your figs. And Decimus — if there is anything in those contracts that ought to bear the light and doesn't, come to me before it comes to the consuls. That is the only kindness I can offer, and it has an expiry.”

The charm held. The smile did not waver. But after Marcus had risen and walked back into the house, Celer sat for a while without eating, looking at the little fountain in the fishpond, and

the fig in his hand slowly bruised black where his thumb pressed into it.

⁂

At the fourth hour, Marcus walked down to the Forum with Stichus behind him and two footmen ahead to clear the lane. Rome roared around him, as Rome did at every hour — bakers shouting from shop fronts, a mule train loaded with building stone, children chasing a dog with a tin cup tied to its tail, a water-seller ringing his bell, the long low thunder of a hundred thousand lives being lived at close quarters. He crossed the new forum the emperor had built beyond the old one, where workmen were putting the last touches to the great column that would carry his campaigns to the sky, and allowed himself one moment of the feeling that always touched him there: the cold, heavy sense of Rome's scale, of the machine he had been born to serve.

At the treasury the praetor in charge handed him a bundle of sealed tablets with the weariness of a man washing his hands.

“Army supply, eastern schedule. Grain, leather, tents, transport. The consuls want a name above suspicion on the tally, and yours came up first. Don't thank me. Half the firms are senators' investments, including men you dine with. You'll make enemies.”

“I have enemies,” said Marcus. “They are among my few comforts.”

He walked home through the crowded streets with the tablets under his arm and his brother's fig-bruised fingers in his mind, and somewhere on the slope of the Esquiline he made his decision. That evening, he told Stichus, he would go to the supper in the Carinae. He would eat the famous food, listen to the famous music, and watch the contractors when the wine went round. A man who intended to audit the accounts of the richest men in Rome could not afford to be the only man in the city who had never seen behind the gilded door.

He said the name to himself as he walked. Antonia Cassia. It meant nothing to him. He had never heard it. Why should he? Rome was full of clever foreigners and freedwomen with money. He expected a painted old woman with a shrewd eye and a flock of musicians.

He expected nothing at all, in fact, which is exactly when life chooses to strike.

⁂

In the house in the Carinae, the morning's work was done. The floors were clean, the lamps were trimmed, the fish in the impluvium had been fed, and the strong room now held, beside the night's silver, a signed quittance and the debt-paper of one Quintus Avianius.

Antonia went up to her private room at the top of the house, the only room in the building with a lock on the inside rather than the outside, and opened the small cedar box she kept beneath her bed. It held a few things: a pair of good earrings, her manumission papers, folded thin and soft with handling, and at the bottom, wrapped in a scrap of old cloth, a chipped wooden disc about the size of a coin, with letters carved into it by a boy's unsteady hand.

She unwrapped it and sat with it in her palm.

She did not do this often. The past was a country from which she had emigrated without papers, and she had no intention of visiting it. But the girl in the garden had opened a door in her, and behind that door there was a kitchen, much smaller than this one, and a hand covering hers around a stylus, and a boy's voice, low and patient, saying: Again. From the top. A — B — C. You're quicker than I am, and if the tutor knew I'd be beaten.

She could not remember the boy's face any more. She had trained herself not to. She remembered the hand, though. Hands were harder to forget.

She wrapped the disc again and locked the box and put it away, and was standing at her window looking over the tiled roofs when Phyllis came in with the evening's acceptances, written out in the clerk's neat hand.

“Twelve for supper, four for the smaller dining room, the governor of Syria's agent among them. The poet's coming back, the one Chloe frightens. And—” Phyllis paused, in the flat voice she used for things she considered dangerous. “One new name. Accepted this morning by his man.”

Antonia took the list. She read it down, past the praetors and the merchants and the officers of the guard, and stopped at the last line but two.

Marcus Aelius Severus.

The room was very quiet. Somewhere in the street a cart went by, its wheels shrieking on the stone.

Phyllis watched her. “I can send a refusal. We're full. A death in the house, even. I'll think of something.”

“No.” Antonia folded the list once, precisely, along its crease. Her voice had not changed. It never changed, which was how she had survived everything. “No. The door is open to everyone. That is the rule, and the rule is what protects us. A man's money is as good as his name here, and his name is as good as his manners.”

“You know what this will cost you.”

“I know what everything costs. It is my one talent.” Antonia set the list down on the table, and for a single moment, before the smooth mask came down, Phyllis saw the girl she had carried out of another house, long ago, white and bleeding and half dead in a dealer's cart.

Then the moment passed.

“Have the blue room made ready,” Antonia said. “The best lamps. And tell Chloe I want her beside me all evening. Tell Festus to double the door. Whatever happens tonight, Rome is going to watch us do it perfectly.”

CHAPTER TWO

Fifteen Years

The gilded door was even more striking by torchlight.

Marcus saw it first from the litter as the bearers turned off the Subura lane into the Carinae: two long leaves of bronze overlaid with gold leaf, framed in white marble, flanked by footmen in blue who stood as still as the columns behind them. A small crowd had gathered on the opposite pavement to watch the litters arrive, the way Romans gathered to watch anything that cost more than they would earn in a year, and the crowd was being managed, he noticed, without roughness and without eye contact, by a pair of steady-looking slaves who guided the sightseers back as gently as shepherds with sheep.

“Observe,” said Celer, who had insisted on sharing the litter and was now arranging his garland. “No names are called at the door. No announcements. A man can come here without his distinction going all over the street by supper-time. That's the first thing she sells, before the wine or the women. Discretion.”

“She?” said Marcus.

“Antonia Cassia. The mistress. You'll see.”

The litter set them down. A footman opened the door before they reached it, and another slave knelt to unlace their outdoor shoes and offer soft dining slippers. Inside, the vestibule was lit by bronze lamps on tall stands, and the dolphin mosaic gleamed under a thin film of fresh oil. There were flowers somewhere, roses and something sharper underneath, and the sound of a water flute drifting from the inner rooms, played softly enough that a man could still hear himself think.

Marcus had entered the houses of the richest men in Rome. He knew luxury the way a farmer knows weather, by instinct and long habit, and he took the measure of this one with a professional's eye. The marble was Greek, not the local Luna stone that new men used. The statues in their niches were genuinely old, two of them signed by Athenian masters. The Corinthian capitals were correctly proportioned, which alone separated the house from ninety per cent of the ostentatious domus on the Palatine. Everything here said the same thing in the same calm voice: whoever owns this has nothing to prove.

It made him uneasy. He had expected vulgarity. Vulgarity he could despise and be done with.

Other guests were crossing the atrium in pairs and threes — a legionary prefect in a gold ring, a grain contractor whose barges Marcus had seen

unloading at the Aemilian bridge, two junior senators he knew by sight, and, moving among them with the ease of a man in his own club, Sextus Perperna.

Marcus knew Perperna, as every senator knew him, the way every traveller knows the location of the swamp on the road. He was an equestrian of obscure family who had made himself one of the wealthiest men in Rome through the single Roman trade that required no goods, no ships and no skill except nerve: prosecution. Under the laws against treason, extortion and adultery, a successful accuser received a share of the condemned man's property, and Perperna had accused successfully for twenty years. His victims included two consulars, a governor, and a Vestal Virgin's lover, and the city's attitude toward him was the ancient Roman attitude toward venomous snakes — not admiration, exactly, but a respectful distance.

He was dressed, as always, like a schoolmaster: plain dark tunic, no rings, no perfume, his greying hair cut short. His face was narrow and kindly, with deep lines around the mouth that looked, at first glance, like the marks of laughter. He came forward smiling and clasped Marcus's forearm.

“Severus. The most honest man in the Senate, come to see how the other half dines. I'm delighted. I shall tell everyone I saw you smile, and no one will believe me.”

"Then tell them I did not," said Marcus. "It will confirm their opinion of me, and I dislike disappointing expectations."

Perperna laughed, a warm, easy laugh. "There it is. The famous austerity. Rome needs men like you, Severus. We who do the practical work require someone to disapprove of us. It gives the city its moral architecture." His eyes moved past Marcus to Celer, and the smile changed by a fraction, becoming something with knowledge in it. "Aelius. Your servant. I've a word for you later, about that little subscription. Nothing unpleasant. Later."

Celer's answering smile was bright, but Marcus saw the swallow move in his brother's throat. Then a slave was bowing them through to the dining wing, and the evening closed over them like water.

⁂

The great triclinium held three couches around a low table of citrus wood, with a second room opened beyond it for the larger party, so that twenty men could dine in sight of one another without crowding. The couches were dressed in Tyrian purple, and behind them the walls were painted with garden scenes so that the room seemed to open onto impossible groves of fruit trees and fountains. In the space between the couches, a girl was dancing with castanets,

moving with a trained, unhurried grace to the music of a water organ and a pair of flutes.

Marcus took his place on the middle couch, Celer beside him, and accepted the first cup — a seasoned wine, honeyed and cooled with snow from the mountains, served in a glass so thin it bent slightly in his fingers. The gustus came round: eggs in anchovy sauce, olives steeped in wine, little sausages on silver skewers, oysters brought live from the Lucrine lake. He ate sparingly, as he did everything, and watched.

That was when he noticed the women.

There were perhaps eight of them in the two rooms, moving among the couches with wine jugs and conversation, and none of them behaved the way the women in the cheap houses off the Subura behaved. They wore fine dresses and modest jewellery; they laughed at the men's jokes without hanging on them; one was arguing Greek philosophy with the governor of Syria's agent, and from the expression on his face, winning. A dark woman with a musician's long fingers was tuning a lyre near the fountain. Another, older, moved quietly through the rooms checking cups and lamps like a housekeeper, though she wore a lady's rings.

“Chloe,” said Celer, following his glance as the dark woman looked up. “The Greek. The best conversationalist in Rome, they say, which is worth more than the face, and the face is

considerable. But the one you want to watch is the mistress. She's here somewhere."

The first main course arrived — a whole boar brought in on a vast silver tray with steam rising from its flanks, its tusks gilded, attended by four carvers who took it apart in a kind of dance. Marcus had seen the dish at a dozen aristocratic tables. Here, he noticed, the smaller dishes that came with it were the more telling thing: mullet seasoned with pepper from India, a pâté of songbirds, asparagus, a sauce of garum and wine so precisely balanced that even the epicure beside him, a man who prided himself on being impossible to please, ate it in silence.

The wine worked quickly, as it was meant to. These were men who guarded their tongues in the Forum and the Senate as carefully as vestals guarded the flame, and here, among the lamps and the roses and the women who knew exactly when to laugh, the guard came down seam by seam. The grain contractor was soon explaining to anyone who would listen that the coming eastern war would make the fortunes of everyone with a contract and a cool head, and dropping names of firms as a fisherman drops bait. The Syrian agent argued that the emperor's new column was vulgar. The two junior senators competed for the attention of a red-haired girl from Alexandria with stories of their own courage, each story growing by the telling.

Marcus watched it with the cold interest of a man examining a machine. He understood now what the house truly sold. Not women, though women were its brightest merchandise; not food, though the food was the best in Rome. It sold the moment when a man believed himself off the stage of Rome — when the masks slipped, and the things he would never say in daylight came swimming up through the wine. And the woman who owned the room collected every word.

Chloe rose with her lyre and the talk softened into attention. She tuned the strings without haste, lifted her chin, and began to sing a poem of Sappho's, in the old Greek, her voice clear and a little husky, trained to fill a room without ever seeming to raise it. The officers and contractors fell quiet one by one, the way loud men fall quiet when real skill enters the room. Even Celer stopped talking. Marcus, who had been taught Greek from the age of six by a grammaticus who beat him for accents, followed the words: the moon had set, the Pleiades had gone, midnight was passing, time was passing, and she lay alone.

It was a poem about desire and waste and the small, private griefs that public men were not permitted to have. Chloe sang it straight, without ornament, looking at no one, and when the last note died the room applauded with the slight embarrassment of people who had been touched more deeply than they had intended.

“Extraordinary,” said the epicure beside Marcus, mopping his eyes with his napkin and pretending he had not wept. “What a house. What a house.”

The dessert came: figs and apples and grapes, honey cakes, sweet wine from Chios, and a confection of crushed nuts and dates shaped into pyramids. The castanet dancer returned, and now a second girl joined her, and the two of them moved through a pattern of feigned pursuit and flight that left the older men breathing hard. Marcus noticed that the women of the house never performed the more explicit dances that the cheaper taverns offered. Antonia Cassia understood something that the tavern keepers did not: that a man's appetite, kept just short of satisfaction, paid better than appetite fulfilled.

It was during the second course that the music changed, and the women shifted, and the room's temperature altered in the way a room alters when its owner enters it.

She came through from the garden colonnade with the dark Greek woman a step behind her, and Marcus did not at once understand why every head turned. She was not the most beautiful woman in the room, though she was handsome enough in a strong-boned, composed way, dressed in a deep blue stola that covered her shoulders, with a single string of pearls at her throat and her dark hair coiled simply. She moved without hurry, greeting a guest here with a word, checking a

servant there with a glance, and the whole room arranged itself around her the way iron filings arrange themselves around a magnet.

Then she turned toward his couch, and the floor seemed to move under Marcus Aelius Severus.

Fifteen years fell away in a single instant. He was twenty-three again, home on leave from the German frontier, and standing in the kitchen of his father's country villa with a wooden stylus in his hand; and a girl of sixteen with ink on her fingers was looking up at him from the table, laughing because she had written her first complete sentence, and the afternoon sun was coming through the olive press and making a golden bar across the floor.

His hand tightened on his cup. The glass bent further, and he set it down carefully because he was no longer certain of his fingers.

She had reached the couch. She saw him.

She did not stop. She did not blink. The composed hostess's smile did not alter by the width of a hair. Only the Greek woman beside her, watching with a professional's attention, saw the very slight change in the set of Antonia Cassia's shoulders, the way a hunting dog sees a twitch in the grass that no one else notices.

“Senator,” she said, in a low, clear voice pitched exactly for the couch and no further. “You are welcome to my house. The Aelii honour me.”

Marcus heard himself speak as though from a great distance. “You have the advantage of me, domina. Your face — forgive me. Have we met?”

It was the wrong thing, and he knew it. A flicker passed behind her eyes, something cold and ancient, gone before it could be named.

“We have not, Senator. I should remember. I remember everyone who comes through my door.” She inclined her head, perfectly polite, perfectly final. “Antonia Cassia. And you are Marcus Aelius Severus, though I hardly need tell a man his own name. They tell me you audit the army's accounts now. A grim trade for so distinguished a soldier. I shall have the cook send you something to compensate you for the evening.”

And with that she was moving on, greeting the grain contractor with the same smile, leaving Marcus holding a conversation that had ended before it began, while beside him Celer chattered about the boar and the water organ and the extraordinary quality of the snow.

He could not eat. He drank water and watched her across the room, and the longer he watched, the more certain he became, and the less he understood how he could ever have failed to know her at once. The girl's bones were under the woman's face. The way she held her head when she listened, the small gesture with which she tucked a thought behind before she spoke, the particular stillness of her attention — these were

not things a person learned. They were the architecture of a soul, built in childhood, unchangeable.

Anthe. Her name had been Anthe. A house-born slave, her mother a Greek woman who did the sewing, her father unknown; the child who had run wild in the villa's colonnades while he was being tutored in the library, whom he had taught his letters because she watched the lessons through the door with such hunger that the tutor had finally shrugged and let her sit in the corner. The girl who, at sixteen, had become the entire secret life of his heart.

And who, his father had told him, had been manumitted and gone south with a merchant, of her own free will, taking the manumission money and never once looking back.

He had believed it for fifteen years. He had built a marriage and a career and a wall of Roman virtue on top of the belief. Looking now at the woman in the blue stola moving among her guests like a queen among petitioners, he felt the wall develop its first crack.

“Chloe,” said a voice at his elbow, and the dark Greek woman had seated herself on the edge of his couch with a wine jug, her eyes clever and friendly and entirely unreadable. “The mistress said the senator drinks water. A man who drinks water at a supper like this is either ill or dangerous. Which is it?”

“Thirsty,” said Marcus, recovering himself. “And in no danger that I can see.”

“That depends on what you came looking for.” She poured for him anyway, a thin measure, and for Celer, who beamed. “Greek, aren't you?” Marcus said.

“Athenian, though Athens has forgotten me, which is typical of cities. I was sold at Delos at thirteen, bought by a school of rhetoric at fourteen — they needed someone to read the scrolls aloud — and manumitted at nineteen for correcting my master's pronunciation of Demosthenes.” She said it without self-pity, the way another woman might have given a recipe. “Now I read scrolls aloud for pay, and men pay a great deal more for it than the school did. You're looking at the mistress.”

Marcus said nothing.

“Everyone looks at the mistress. It's her room. But you're looking differently.” Chloe's voice stayed light, but her eyes were measuring. “She came from nothing, you know. Not poor — nothing. A slave. She freed herself, learned everything, built all this. In Rome, where a man with four generations of consuls behind him still can't arrange his own fish sauce. You'd think the city would admire her. Instead it calls her the whore of the Carinae and comes to supper every night.”

“Is that what she is? A whore?”

Chloe smiled, and the smile had a edge like a knife. “She is the woman who decides which men in this room get what they want. I'd be careful what I called her, if I were you. In this house, the names have a way of following a man home.”

⁂

Perperna found him in the garden, during the pause before the dessert.

The older man walked slowly along the colonnade, eating a date, and stopped beside him at the fountain where the bronze boy wrestled the goose. In the dining room behind them the water organ had started a new tune, and laughter rose and fell like surf.

“A remarkable establishment,” said Perperna. “Remarkable woman. You seemed struck dumb when she greeted you. An old acquaintance?”

“A resemblance. Nothing more.”

“Of course.” Perperna ate the date and dropped the stone into the fishpond. “We are all collections of resemblances, Severus. The trick is knowing which ones matter.” He looked out at the roses, his kindly face serene. “You've taken on the supply contracts, I hear. The eastern schedule. Brave. The consuls love to put an honest name on a dishonest ledge, so that when it crumbles, honesty falls with it.”

“I don't fall.”

“No. You don't. I've made a study of you, if you'll forgive the impertinence. You're a man who actually believes in the Republic's virtues, which is rare enough to be almost a kind of genius. I find it useful to keep such men in view. They do the unexpected.” Perperna turned toward him. “Take my advice, as one practical man to another. Sign the tallies as they're given to you. The grain is weighed, the seals are witnessed, the money has flowed through respectable hands. Ask nothing about the hands behind those hands. There are interests in those contracts that would ruin even your name, and the war in the East hasn't even begun.”

“Is that a warning or a threat?”

Perperna looked genuinely pained. “My dear fellow. It's an act of friendship. I have so few opportunities for friendship. My profession makes people uneasy.” He smiled. “Besides, I have a proposition forming, and a man with a proposition needs friends in high places. Watch this house, by the way. Its mistress has ambitions beyond wine and music. Such women are interesting until they become inconvenient. Then they become opportunities.”

He drifted back toward the lamps, leaving Marcus with the sound of the fountain and a coldness along his spine that had nothing to do with the night air.

He got his private word with her only at the door, as the slaves brought the shoes. The party

was breaking up; Celer had gone ahead in the company of the grain contractor, already deep in some negotiation of his own. Marcus lingered, and Antonia came to see the last guest out herself, as she always did, because a departure, in her trade, was as deliberate as an arrival.

"Domina." He kept his voice low. "A moment. I know you. Whatever you call yourself now, I know you. The villa at Tibur. The kitchen. The stylus. You wrote *Roma* on a wax tablet and the R came out backwards, and you laughed—"

"Senator." Her voice was quiet too, and absolutely even, but the knuckles of the hand on the doorframe were white. "Whatever you think you remember, I advise you to forget it. That girl, if she ever existed, is as dead as the men who founded the Republic. I am Antonia Cassia. I own this house. I pay my taxes, I hold my licenses, and I choose my own company. You were a guest here tonight. Be satisfied with that."

"He told me you were freed. My father. He said you took the money and went south willingly."

For the first time, something cracked. Not the composure — the composure held — but behind it, in the eyes, he saw a flare of something so raw and so old that he stepped back.

"Your father," she said, "told you a great many things, I'm sure. Sons usually believe their fathers. It costs them less than the truth." She pulled the door wide. "Good night, Senator. Do

not come back unless you can behave like a guest.”

The gilded door closed between them with a soft, heavy, final sound.

⁂

She stood on the inside of it for a long moment, her hand still raised where she had pushed it, while the household moved around her, clearing lamps, gathering cups, going through the nightly ritual of restoration. Festus appeared beside her, silent and solid, and after a moment Chloe came too, her mantle wrapped against the cold, her sharp face concerned.

“Phyllis says he was the last person you'd ever want at that door,” Chloe said.

“Phyllis is right, which is a habit of hers I find exhausting.” Antonia let her hand fall. Her voice was steady again. “He didn't know. He came in here tonight believing I walked away of my own free will, with my manumission silver in my hand. Can you imagine it? Fifteen years, and they told him I *chose* it.”

“Perhaps he's lying.”

“No.” She said it with the certainty of stone. “That's the unbearable part. He isn't. He looked at me like a man seeing a ghost he'd been taught never to believe in. They lied to him as thoroughly as they used me.” She drew a breath. “It changes nothing.”

“It changes him.”

“He's a senator with a consulship in his hand and a wife on the Esquiline. Nothing changes for men like him. The world was built to spare them.”

Phyllis had come in from the garden wing with her ring of keys, and she stood now in the shadow of the colonnade, where she had been standing, Antonia suspected, for some minutes. The old woman's face was impossible to read, the way old stone is impossible to read until the lamp moves across it.

“You knew him,” Antonia said. It was not a question.

“I knew the house. I was a slave in it before I was ever yours, remember. The Aelii bought me at nineteen and sold me at thirty, and in between I scrubbed that kitchen floor and carried that boy's porridge.” Phyllis's voice was level, but her hands, folded at her waist, were tight. “He was a good child, as the children of that house went. Taught you your letters when he'd have been beaten if his tutor caught him at it. Used to give you half his figs.”

“I remember the figs.” Antonia's voice was dry. “I try not to remember the figs.”

“There's things I've never told you. About that year. The year they sold you.”

Antonia turned fully then. The household moved around them, slaves carrying out the last of the silver, and in the noise of it the two women might have been alone on an island. “Why now?”

“Because he walked through that door tonight, and I saw your face, and I'm sixty-two years old and my chest pains me in the cold, and there may not be a great many more right moments.” Phyllis met her eyes. “But not tonight. Tonight you need sleep more than you need the past. When the time comes, I'll tell you all of it. Every word. Every name. I owe you that much, and I've owed it a long while.”

Antonia studied her. In fifteen years Phyllis had never once broken a promise or failed to name a thing plainly, and Antonia had built half her empire on the reliability of this one woman.

“Tomorrow, then. After the morning accounts. And Phyllis — whatever it is, it won't change how I run this house.”

“Won't it?” said Phyllis softly, and went back to her keys, and would say no more.

Antonia turned from the door. “Double the watch tonight. And tomorrow I want every name on the supply contracts that Hector sent word of. If the Aelius name is anywhere near those tallies, I want to know before he does.”

Chloe studied her. “You're going to fight him.”

“I'm going to make sure he can't hurt me. There's a difference. The first is anger. The second is survival.” She walked away down the colonnade, and after a moment Chloe heard the sound of her chamber door closing, very softly, upstairs.

⁂

Celer was waiting at the corner of the Carinae, swaying gently beside the litter with a half-eaten honey cake in one hand, and insisted that his brother share the ride up the hill. The bearers set off through the narrow torchlit streets, where the taverns were still roaring and a pair of drunken sailors were singing a marching song off-key, and for a while the two men rode in silence.

Then Celer said, into the dark, “She's Greek, you know. The singer. Gods above, what a voice. I'd give a year's income to have that voice in my own house.”

“You haven't got a year's income,” said Marcus. “That's the subject I want.”

The drunken affability dimmed by a quarter. “Who says I haven't?”

“Perperna. He called it ‘that little subscription.' He looked at you as a man looks at property he has already paid for. Decimus, look at me.” The litter jolted over a rut. “What have you put your name to?”

“Nothing. Nothing that won't bear the light, I told you.” Celer rallied, reaching for the old charm and finding it slightly dented. “A group of us, some firms, supply contracts for the eastern army — grain, hides, transport. We subscribe, the firms do the work, the treasury pays, the profit comes round. Half the Senate has money in it. It

isn't a crime to prosper, Marcus. Cato the Elder prospered."

"Cato the Elder didn't borrow his subscriptions from Sextus Perperna."

The silence that followed was answer enough. Celer stared out through the litter curtains at the passing torchlight, and when he spoke again his voice had lost all its music.

"He holds some paper of mine. That's all. A loan, properly sealed. The contracts will clear it — once the treasury pays the first instalment. Everyone's waiting on the treasury. You'll see when you audit the tallies; everything's in order, weights, seals, witnesses. By summer I'm square, and Perperna goes back to eating widows, and you and I never speak of it again." He tried a laugh. "You see? Nothing for the great censor to trouble himself with. Now tell me about the mistress, since she looked at you as if she'd like to bury you in the garden. What was *that*?"

"A mistake," said Marcus. "She mistook me for someone."

"Did she? Lucky fellow. A woman like that, with a house like that — do you know what she's worth? They say she keeps a bank of her own now, lends to merchants, buys paper. A freedwoman. Rome's gone strange, brother. Our grandfathers would have had her flogged."

"Our grandfathers," said Marcus, "never had to balance her ledgers."

He said nothing more, and Celer, taking silence for forgiveness, began to hum the Sappho tune and got it wrong, and so they climbed the Esquiline, the younger brother humming and the elder watching the street with the unblinking attention of a man who has begun to see, in every shadow, the shape of a trap.

On the Esquiline, Marcus dismissed the slaves and went down to the strong room himself, which he had not done in years.

It was a windowless vault off the atrium, smelling of cedar and dry stone, where the Aelii kept their silver, their title deeds, and the family archives in a row of cedar chests going back four generations. He lit a lamp, set it on the floor, and pulled out his father's private ledgers — the household books, not the public ones, the tallies of slaves bought and sold, rents collected, loans made. His hands were steady now, the way they had been in Germany before a battle.

He found it near the back of the volume for the year he had gone north to his tribunate. A line in his father's cramped hand, entered without explanation among the sale of three mules and a quantity of old wine:

Anthe, vernula, sold to Dinis the dealer, nine hundred and forty sesterces.

No manumission. No merchant going south. No money taken freely. A sale, plain and cold, for nine hundred and forty sesterces, the price of a decent mule.

Beside it, in a different ink, in his mother's hand, were four words.

Better for everyone concerned.

Marcus sat on the floor of the vault with the ledger open on his knees, and the lamp flame leaned in a draught he could not feel, and somewhere far above him in the great quiet house his wife slept, his children slept, his ancestors watched from their wax death-masks in the atrium, and every stone of the world he had built his life upon felt, for the first time, like a stone that might move.

His father had lied. His mother had known. And the girl in the kitchen, the quick laughing girl with the backwards R, had been sold like livestock while he was marching to the Rhine.

He closed the ledger very gently, as though it were a living thing he was afraid of waking, and sat in the dark a long time, holding the lamp, thinking about a gilded door and a woman's white-knuckled hand upon its frame.

CHAPTER THREE

The Price of Paper

The offices of the urban aediles stood at the corner of the Roman Forum, in a building whose stucco was always slightly stained by the smoke rising from the cookshops of the Argiletum. Antonia went there at the second hour, dressed not in the blue stola of last night's hostess but in the plain dark gown of a woman with ordinary business, her hair covered, her jewellery confined to a single gold ring. In Rome, a person who wished to hear the truth dressed below her station; the truth, like a cat, approached the quietest feet.

The scriba Palumbus kept the licensing rolls in a chamber full of shelves and pigeonholes, where the air tasted of old wax and lamp oil and the particular dry dust of documents that have outlived everyone who wrote them. He was a small man with a careful manner and ink under his fingernails, and he rose when she came in with the nervous speed of a functionary who dealt too often with people richer than himself.

“Domina Antonia. This is an honour. We don't often see you in person — your steward usually—”

“My steward is an ex-gladiator, and gentlemen in offices become defensive with ex-gladiators. I find I get further with a smile and a ring.” She sat, uninvited, on the stool across from his table, and placed a small purse on the wood between them. “The annual enrollment of my household's women. It's three months early, I know, but I want every name in order and witnessed. The licenses for music and entertainment likewise. Fresh copies, sealed, today if it can be managed.”

Palumbus did not touch the purse. That in itself told her a great deal. In eleven years, no clerk had ever failed to touch the purse.

“Well,” he said, and wiped his palms on his tunic. “There may be a difficulty. The aedile Macer has ordered a general review of houses of entertainment in three districts. Ours not to reason why, domina. A backlog. New enrollments are being held until the review concludes.”

“A review. On what grounds?”

“Public order. Morals. The usual language.” He looked miserable. “And there's a complaint. Lodged by the lender Vipsanius. He says a debt-bond was transferred to your house under — these are his words, not mine — under improper pressure, before the terms were fulfilled. A girl. Aviania, Sabina, by name. He wants her surrendered to the magistrate's keeping until the hearing. There's a gentleman of standing behind the complaint, though his name doesn't appear. These things are done quietly.”

“Of course they are.” Antonia kept her face pleasant. “And the gentleman of standing? You may tell me. I have never yet repeated a name given in this room, which is why you're all so comfortable giving them to me.”

Palumbus swallowed. He glanced at the door, leaned across the table, and breathed a name so quietly it might have been a sigh.

“Perperna.”

She had expected it. Expectation did not make the name taste any better. She sat with it for a moment, turning it like a coin, while Palumbus watched her with the anxious respect of a man watching a bomb decide whether to explode.

“Tell the aedile Macer,” she said at last, “that my licenses are in perfect order, that every woman in my house is enrolled by her own hand before witnesses, and that the debt-paper for Sabina Aviania bears Vipsanius's own seal, which is difficult work to call improper. Tell him also that I shall be making a donation to the festival fund this month — a generous one, given in the aedile's name. Aediles who give good festivals become praetors. He understands arithmetic; so do I.”

Palumbus permitted himself a thin smile. “And the girl?”

“The girl remains where she is, in lawful employment under a sealed contract, until a magistrate orders otherwise in open court. No one takes anyone from my house through a back

corridor. That is the one rule I have never broken and never will.” She rose. “The purse is for your trouble. If the review concludes, as I'm sure it will, with every license confirmed, there'll be a second purse on the day. Good morning, Palumbus.”

The way home led through the Argiletum, where the booksellers' stalls gave way to tenement blocks so tall they seemed to lean together overhead, and here the morning's business found her in a different shape. A crowd had gathered outside a timber insula, the kind of crowd Rome produced every day and ignored every day: a creditor's men carrying furniture into the street while a woman sat on a mattress nursing a baby and wept without noise, the way the very poor weep, having learned that noise only draws more creditors. The husband stood against the wall with his wrists bound, not cruelly, merely formally, a man being sold into his own debt.

Antonia stopped. Festus, who had followed at a distance through the crowd, materialised at her shoulder.

“Trouble, domina?”

“Not yet.” She watched the creditor's agent checking items off a list, and she read the scene as she read everything: the man's calloused hands were a carpenter's, the tools in the street were good ones and well cared for, the children were clean. This was not fecklessness. This was the

ordinary Roman arithmetic of a sick wife and a winter without work.

She crossed to the agent, a thin man in a stained tunic, and asked the debt.

“Fourteen hundred, domina, principal and costs. He's nexum-bound; the law's the law.”

“The law is an ass, but asses carry money.” She looked at the carpenter. “What's your name?”

“Vitalis, domina.” The man's voice was hoarse. “I'm a builder. Scaffolding, joinery, repairs. I'll work it off, by the gods I will, only don't put my name on the block — a man sold once is never hired again.”

She considered him. Her own house kept a carpenter on contract, an arrangement she had disliked for years; a man in the household, bound by gratitude rather than wages, was worth three contractors. And a man who had watched the street eat his family would have very particular opinions about who was allowed through a gilded door.

“Festus, pay him. Fourteen hundred, and take the debt paper, not a receipt. The tools go back upstairs, the cords come off, and the family stays.” To the agent: “Your fee is in the sum; don't imagine it isn't. To Vitalis: you and yours move to my house in the Carinae this afternoon. There's a porter's lodge going empty and a roof that leaks. You work off the paper at fair wages, and when it's cleared you stay on salary, if you're any good. Are you any good?”

The man stared at her. The baby had stopped crying. “Domina, I built the altar screen at the temple of Concord. I'm the best man you'll get for fourteen hundred.”

“Then we're both fortunate.” She turned away. “Festus, see to it. And Vitalis — in my house, the first thing you learn is that I keep every promise and forget every debt. The paper is to protect you from the next creditor, not to own you. Remember that, and remember who taught Rome how little its laws protect the honest.”

She walked on, leaving the crowd to its murmuring, and did not look back. Looking back cost time, and Antonia had long ago discovered that kindness, done quickly and without ceremony, was indistinguishable from business, and far less dangerous to the giver.

Outside, the Forum roared in full morning voice. Bankers' boys ran with sealed bags, lawyers argued on the tribunals, a soothsayer screamed about omens to a crowd of idlers, and beneath the rostra the auctioneer was selling the contents of an insolvent shipping merchant's warehouse to a knot of sharp-eyed men. Antonia crossed it with the unhurried step of a woman who had learned to move through crowds without ever being touched, and turned into the bankers' row between the old shops, where Beryllus the Alexandrian did his business in a marble-floored taberna guarded by two enormous Germans.

⁂

Beryllus was sixty, brown as a nut, with a shaved head and the eyes of a crocodile. He had begun as a money-changer in the harbour at Alexandria and now moved more money in a morning than the treasuries of client kings. He rose from behind his table and bowed with genuine warmth, because Antonia Cassia was among his most careful clients, and careful clients were the only kind Beryllus loved.

“Best customer. Wine? No, you never take it before noon. Water, then, and figs — the figs are from Syria, you'll be astonished.” He clapped for a slave, gestured her to a chair, and sat again with his steepled fingers. “You've come about the licenses. Word travels faster than horses in this street.”

While the water was brought, Antonia let her eyes run over the taberna the way she read a room at one of her own suppers. Two Germans at the door, armed with clubs rather than swords, which told her the banker feared thieves rather than soldiers; a wall of pigeonholes holding the wax tablets of deposit accounts, each in its named sleeve; a bronze assay balance on a side table, polished bright at the pans from daily handling; and, behind Beryllus himself, an iron-bound chest of the kind whose lock alone cost more than a clerk's yearly wage. Everything in the room said

the same sentence: money is a serious animal and will not live where the fencing is weak.

“You've changed your guards,” she said. “The old pair were Gauls.”

“The old pair took a gratuity from a litigant to report who visited me. Litigants are sentimental; they believe knowing a man's banker is knowing the man.” Beryllus shrugged his brown, nut-like shoulders. “Germans don't speak enough Latin to be bribed in it. It's the nearest thing to honesty available at that price. Now.” He folded his hands. “The licenses. Tell me what frightened you, because something did; you don't enroll three months early in a calm season.”

She told him, in the level voice she used for figures, about Palumbus and the untouched purse, and Beryllus listened without interrupting, which was his highest form of attention.

“A clerk who won't take money is either a zealot or a man who's been paid already by the other side,” he said when she finished. “Zealots in the aediles' office average two per generation, and I've known both; they're thin and they smell of leeks. Your Palumbus, by your description, is neither thin nor fragrant. Therefore the second. Someone is funding an interest in the licensing rolls, and an interest in the rolls means an interest in the houses the rolls describe. Yours first, because yours is the best run.” He selected a fig and considered it. “This is why I keep my ledgers in three copies, domina. The first copy is

for the tax farmer, the second is for my own hand, and the third is sealed with a banker in Alexandria who has never seen Rome and owes nothing to anyone in it. A woman in your position should do the same. Paper that exists in only one city is a wish, not a defence.”

“I have a temple coffer.”

“Good. Temples are better than bankers for women; no one expects a woman to have a banker, and everyone expects her to be pious. Use both. Piety and arithmetic, the two shields the city can't laugh off.” He bit the fig. “The figs, by the way. Syria. I'm always right.”

“I've come about everything. Start with my position.”

“Your position is excellent, which is precisely why people are studying it.” Beryllus opened a codex of parchment leaves — a new fashion, replacing the old rolls for accounts — and ran a finger down a column. “Deposits across three houses, mine included: sixty-two thousand sesterces in ready money. Loans out at good rates: a hundred and four thousand, secured on property and cargoes, no defaults worth the name. The house itself, freehold, worth perhaps two hundred thousand if sold, though only a fool would sell it. Plus your share in Hilarus's oil ships. You are, in plain terms, what the law calls a wealthy woman, and what the Senate calls an inconvenience.”

“Who's been asking?”

“The aedile's men, routinely. Two tax farmers, routinely. And one man who is not routine.” Beryllus closed the codex. “Sextus Perperna. Through an intermediary, then in person, very charming, very plain. He wanted to know your holdings, your debts, and — he made a point of this — whether any of your loans could be called in at once. I told him my clients' affairs were as sealed as a vestal's vow. I then increased the guards, because a man like Perperna doesn't ask a question unless he means to use the answer.”

Antonia said nothing. Outside, a banker's boy went past at a run, his coin-bag clinking.

“There's more,” said Beryllus, and allowed himself the small frown of a man forced to discuss unpleasantness before lunch. “A Greek came to me last week. A clerk on the supply board, the army contracts — Hector, freedman of some provincial. He was asking the same questions from the other side. Which firms hold the eastern supply subscriptions, where the money flows, who's behind the seals. I gave him tea and nothing else; he seemed frightened, and frightened men make bankers nervous. Then yesterday he didn't come as promised. I sent a boy round; his lodging's empty, rent unpaid, landlord complaining.” Beryllus looked at her directly. “A frightened clerk with questions, gone without his deposit. In Rome, that story has only two endings, and neither is good. If he's one of yours—”

“He's my friend's brother. Chloe's.” Antonia's voice was steady, but her mind was moving like a shuffled deck, cards falling into order: the contracts, Perperna's questions, the missing clerk, the complaint about Sabina, the review of the licenses. Separate stones, and beneath them all the same dark water. “Beryllus, if a man wanted to ruin this house, how would he begin?”

“With paper.” The answer came without hesitation. “Not fire, not knives — those things alarm the city and bring the vigiles. Paper. A challenge to your licenses. A charge of lenocinium, of profiting from vice without proper enrollment. A debt proved in a friendly court. A witness who remembers, suddenly, that she was coerced. Rome destroys people with documents, my dear, because documents don't weep and can't be cross-examined about their childhoods.” He pushed the figs toward her. “Buy witnesses. Seal everything twice. And if there's a document in this city that could hurt you, find it before Perperna does.”

Beryllus rose and walked to a shelf of tablets himself, an honour he accorded almost no one, and came back with a land register.

“Since you're asking about Perperna, look at this. I keep a private tally of his purchases, because a man's money tells the truth even when his mouth doesn't.” He opened it. “Seven houses in four years. Every one bought at a forced sale, every one sold by the treasury after a prosecution.

A senator's villa at Praeneste. Two tenements in the Subura. A shipping merchant's warehouse — the one being auctioned under the rostra today, in fact. The man feeds on ruin. He doesn't merely prosecute, Antonia. He buys the corpses."

"Then he'll need a steady supply of corpses."

"Exactly. And here's what keeps me awake." Beryllus tapped the register. "His prosecutions have grown bolder. Small debtors first, then merchants, then a governor. A man with that appetite must keep climbing, because the only thing more dangerous than succeeding at his trade is stopping; the families remember. He'll need a spectacular victim soon. Someone famous enough to make the city forget his methods. A consul-designate would do very well. Or a woman whose house half the Senate visits every night."

The implication settled between them like dust.

"Hilarus sent word, too," Beryllus continued, lowering his voice though the guards stood well out of hearing. "His Spanish oil ships are fine, but two of the grain vessels he's been asked to insure for the eastern schedule came in light — short-weighted at the warehouses, the tallies corrected upward at the counting house. He's putting the figures together. If the army's grain is being measured once in Ostia and written twice in Rome, then every name on those contracts is a rope waiting for its neck."

"Advice worth double my usual fee." She stood. "Send me the names of every firm in those

eastern contracts, as much as you know. Through Festus, at the postern, at night.”

“At night, at the postern, through an ex-gladiator. My favourite kind of business.” He bowed again. “Antonia. Be careful. I've seen what Perperna does. He doesn't accuse the strong. He makes them weak first, and accuses them afterward.”

⁂

Marcus reached the villa at Tibur at midday, riding a sure-footed mule up the via Tiburtina with Stichus behind him and a single groom, through the olive groves and the grey stone walls where his childhood was buried.

The villa sat on a terrace above the Anio, its old tufa walls mellow in the sun, its cypresses tall as sentinels. His father was seven years dead, his mother three, and the place was kept now by a bailiff and a skeleton staff, a museum of the Aelii that the family visited twice a year and otherwise forgot. The bailiff Barto came out into the courtyard as they dismounted, an old man now, stooped and half-blind, squinting against the light; then recognition moved across his face like sunrise.

“Little Marcus. Begging your pardon — Senator. Master Marcus.” His voice cracked. “I'd know that walk in the dark. Your grandfather

walked the same way, as if the stones owed him rent.”

“Barto. You're well?”

“Well enough for a man whose teeth have mostly deserted him. Come in, come in. There's wine, and the olives are good this year, though I say so who pruned them.”

Marcus let the old man fuss over him through the courtyard and into the shade of the colonnade, accepted wine and bread, asked the careful questions about the harvest, the slaves, the roof, that a good landlord asks. Then he sent Stichus and the groom to eat in the kitchen, and sat alone with Barto on the stone bench beside the fishpond, and said the name he had ridden twenty miles to say.

“Anthe. The house-born girl. My mother's sewing woman's daughter.”

Barto's hands went still around his cup. He was very old, and old men have their own relationship with time; the name seemed to reach him from a great distance, but it reached him clearly.

“I wondered if you'd come. Fifteen years, and I wondered. Your father made us swear on the household gods never to write of it. Gods and I have an arrangement now, at my age. I'll tell you.” Barto drank, set the cup down, and looked at the water. “She was a sweet child. Quick. You taught her to read in the kitchen, you and her against the world, and the whole household knew and said nothing because she was sweet and you were

lonely, the way boys in great houses are lonely. Then you went off to Germany. And she was carrying your child.”

The fishpond made its small, constant sound. Marcus said nothing. There was nothing to say. He had known, in some deep room of himself, since the ledger entry last night; the old man's words merely opened the door and showed him the furniture.

“Your mother found out at the wash tubs. There was a scene. I've never heard a voice like hers, before or since — cold as a well. Your father wouldn't see the girl. Dromo the steward did the work. Sold her to Dinis, the dealer from the Subura, nine hundred and forty sesterces, money down, no questions. I remember the price because Dromo laughed about it; said he'd got a bargain on a girl with letters.”

“The child.”

“Born in Rome, in the dealer's house, so the story came back. A girl. Small, and early, and dead before she drew breath, or so they said. The mother nearly went with her. Fever. A midwife from the temple of Juno came, and she lived, and after that—” Barto spread his hands. “After that she vanished into the city. A girl like that, with no man and no name. Rome eats girls like figs.”

“Letters. Did letters come for her? From me.”

The old man's face worked. “They did. Three, I think, and money with them, for her manumission. Dromo brought them to your mother. She had

them sent back unopened. All of it. ‘Let him forget her,' she said. ‘It is better for everyone concerned.' I heard her say it, standing in this very colonnade. Better for everyone. That's what the powerful call it, when someone else pays.”

Marcus stared across the valley, where the olive trees moved in the wind like a grey-green sea. He was a soldier; he had seen men die in the snow beyond the Rhine; he had kept his face through councils and courts and the death of his own father. He kept it now. Only his hands, clasped between his knees, were white.

“Did she know? That I wrote? That I sent money?”

“How could she? The letters went back to Germany unopened. You'd have been told she refused them. She'd have been told nothing at all, or told that you'd forgotten her. That's the genius of a thing like this, master. No one has to lie very much. You just make sure the two people never stand in the same room.”

Marcus laughed then, a short, terrible sound. “And last night,” he said, “we stood in the same room.”

Barto's milky eyes sharpened. “She's alive, then.”

“She owns a house in the Carinae. The most famous supper-house in Rome. She has money, and clients among the consulars, and she looked at me as though I were a stain on her floor.” He paused. “She thinks I knew. Or that I consented.”

“Did you?”

The question, put without flinching by a half-blind old slave on a stone bench, was the hardest thing anyone had asked him in his life. Marcus considered it honestly, as he considered all questions, and found the answer more shameful than any lie.

“I didn't know. But I didn't ask. I let my father tell me a story and I built my whole life on it because the story was convenient. The girl was gone, the honour of the family was saved, and my conscience was handed a clean tablet. I didn't dig because I was afraid of what I'd find. That's not innocence, Barto. That's just cowardice with good manners.”

The old man considered this, and nodded slowly, as a teacher nods when a slow pupil finally reaches the answer. From the pouch at his belt he drew, with some difficulty, a small oilskin packet, and unfolded it. Inside was a letter, yellowed, the wax broken long ago, the handwriting young and rushed and unmistakably Marcus's own.

“One of them. The last. I took it from Dromo's waste basket before he burned the lot. Kept it because it felt wrong to burn a man's words. I've carried it fifteen years, thinking you'd come or I'd die, and one of the two was bound to happen.”

Marcus took the letter. He knew its contents without reading; he had written it in a winter billet on the frontier, by the light of a smoking lamp, pouring into it everything a

twenty-three-year-old could not say to anyone else. He had believed, writing it, that she would read it and understand. It had never crossed a threshold except to be refused.

He read it now, on the stone bench, while Barto looked politely at the cypresses. The young man who had written it was almost a stranger: so certain of his own honour, so busy being noble, so utterly unable to imagine the machinery of his own family grinding forward without him. When he finished, the sun had moved and the fishpond was in shadow.

He folded it with the same care he gave all things, and put it inside his tunic, against his chest.

The ride back to Rome took the afternoon, and he made it mostly in silence, Stichus wisely keeping his distance on the narrow road. At the city gates the traffic slowed behind a column of ox-carts bringing stone for the emperor's new buildings, and he sat the mule in the press of animals and men, and thought about the mathematics of guilt.

He had not given the order. He had not known of the sale. He had been four hundred miles away, freezing in a German winter, writing letters that came back unopened. A reasonable man, an advocate, a jury of priests, would all acquit him. And none of it changed the central fact, which was that the whole engine of his life — the family, the name, the slaves, the clean conscience — had

acted in his interest, with his happiness as its excuse, and he had spent fifteen years spending the proceeds without asking where they came from. The slave girl's sale had bought him an untroubled marriage, a career without scandal, the luxury of being the honest one. He had not lit the fire. He had lived in the house it warmed.

At the temple of Fortuna on the Quirinal he dismounted, went in, and made an offering — not for success, he did not insult the gods with that, but for clarity. Then he rode down to the Esquiline, and in his own tablinum, while the household prepared the evening meal, he took a fresh sheet of parchment and wrote a single line, and crossed it out, and wrote it again, and crossed that out too. There were no words that could arrive ahead of him through that gilded door and do anything but harm.

He would have to go himself. And this time, he would ask before he assumed, and listen before he spoke, and accept whatever the cost turned out to be. It was, he reflected, the least that nine hundred and forty sesterces had ever bought a man.

“Barto. I'm grateful. There'll be money — a proper sum, enough to keep you in comfort, and your freedom papers if you'll take them, though I know you've refused twice.”

“Refused twice and will refuse a third. I'm too old to be free; freedom's a young man's burden. But I'll take the money, because I'm not too old to

be vain, and I want a proper sarcophagus with my name on it. Marcus." The old voice caught. "Be gentle with her, when you see her. Whatever she's become. She was sold for nine hundred and forty sesterces and buried a baby before she was eighteen. Whatever she's built since, she built it on that."

⁂

In the Carinae, Sabina was learning the alphabet.

Chloe had her in the garden court, where the light was good, with a wax tablet and a stylus and a cup of watered wine as a reward system, and the lesson had progressed from letters to the more difficult art of carrying one's body.

"You walk like a goat," Chloe said, not unkindly. "Not your fault — you've carried water jars since you were eight, and it builds the wrong muscles. Again. From the fountain. Slow. Head up, shoulders down, and imagine there's a book balanced on your hair. Romans believe a woman who walks steadily thinks steadily, and in Rome belief is nine-tenths of the truth."

Sabina tried again, fists clenched with concentration, and reached the colonnade without dropping the imaginary book.

"Better. Again."

They had been at it since noon, between the letters and a lesson in how to address men of different ranks, which Sabina thought was the

strangest lesson she had ever received, because every rule was the opposite of the rules her mother had taught her. Don't look down first. Don't fill every silence. Let a man wait; he'll pay more for the answer. Say no with the same face you say yes.

“Why are you teaching me this?” she asked, during the rest. “I'm a debt-bond. In the village, debt-bonds don't learn to walk.”

Chloe bit into an apple. “Because Antonia says so, and Antonia is never wrong about investments, and you are an investment. Because a woman who can read and walk and reckon can't be made helpless again, whatever happens to her papers. And because I was you once, and nobody taught me, and I had to learn it all in places I won't describe while you're eating.”

The tablet lesson followed. Sabina's first R came out backwards, and she laughed — the first laugh Antonia had heard from her, catching it as she crossed the courtyard with the morning's correspondence in her hand.

She stopped, watching. The sound reminded her of something she had no intention of remembering, and she let it pass, and went to her tablinum, and had barely sat down to the accounts when Festus appeared in the doorway, and his face told her everything before he spoke.

“Officer at the front. From the aedile's office, with a sealed tablet and two witnesses. I made him wait in the vestibule. He didn't like it.”

She broke the seal. The wax was official, the language careful, the meaning plain: on the complaint of Vipsanius, supported by a citizen of standing, the magistrate required the person of Sabina Aviania to be surrendered into safe keeping pending a hearing on the lawfulness of her service; any hindrance would be treated as contempt, and the licensing review of the house would proceed on the assumption that the house held free citizens against their will.

She read it twice. Then she laid it flat and weighted its corners, as she weighted all paper that might otherwise blow away.

“Festus. The women's wing is locked from now on, and you keep the keys yourself. No girl leaves it without me. Sabina sleeps where I can hear her. Send a boy to Hilarus at the docks — tell him I need him tonight, after dark, through the postern. And send Chloe to me.”

He went. She looked at the tablet a long moment, and thought of Beryllus in his counting house, and his crocodile smile, and his one cold truth.

Rome destroys people with documents.

“Paper,” she said aloud, to the empty room and the fish in the impluvium. “He wants a war of paper.” She picked up her stylus. “Paper I understand.”

CHAPTER FOUR

The Tiber Keeps Its Own

He came at the tenth hour of the night, through the postern, with his hood up and his feet moving fast, and Festus, who had opened many posterns to many frightened men, noted the particular quality of this man's fear: not drink, not debt, not a husband's anger, but the clean, cold fear of a man who knows he is being followed.

“Hector, Greek, clerk, expected,” the man said, in a voice trying hard to be steady. “She'll know the name.”

“She does. Come in, and stop looking at the street; it gives you away.” Festus shut the postern and barred it, and walked him through the torchlit service corridor to the small room beside the strong room where Antonia received the business that could not be seen by guests. Chloe was already there, and she stood up so quickly that her stool tipped over.

“Hector.”

“Little sister.” He took her by the shoulders, and for a moment the frightened clerk vanished and he was simply her brother, the older boy who had shared a slave cabin on Delos and been sold

away from her at eleven. “You're thinner. Rome doesn't feed you?”

“Rome feeds me beautifully; I waste away on worry. Sit down. Both of you.” She turned to Antonia. “Domina, this is my brother. The only family I have left in the world, which I mention because it means I am not objective about him.”

Antonia looked at the man across the table. He was thirty or so, slight, Greek, with ink stains on his fingers and a frayed mantle that had been good once and was now carefully mended, the garment of a clerk who took a pride the world did not reward. His eyes kept moving to the door.

“Chloe says you have papers,” Antonia said.

“I have evidence, domina. The difference is that papers can be explained away.” From inside his tunic he drew a bundle wrapped in oilskin, and unwrapped it: four wax tablets, bound with leather thongs, their seals unbroken, and beneath them a thin sheaf of parchment notes. “The duplicates. I keep the board's tallies — I've kept them for three years — and last month the numbers stopped making sense, so I began keeping my own. Two sets of accounts. The official ones, and these.”

Antonia took the first tablet and broke the seal. Her eyes moved quickly; she read Greek and Latin both, and read figures the way musicians read notes.

“Grain for the eastern schedule,” Hector said. “The army's ration contracts. In Ostia the

shipments are weighed at the public granaries — I've a friend among the measurers there. Three hundred and twenty modii in a hold, say. By the time the same cargo reaches the Roman tally, it's four hundred and ten. The grain doesn't grow on the river. Someone writes the difference, sells the phantom supply back to the treasury, and the gold walks."

"Names."

"The firms are shell work — freedmen's names, dead men's names, a different set every quarter. But the money converges." He turned the second tablet, and his finger, trembling slightly, touched a column. "Here. The subscriptions that capitalize the firms. Decimus Aelius Celer, eleven thousand. And here, the loans that bought the subscriptions: Sextus Perperna, lending at twenty-four per cent to half the men on the list. Perperna doesn't just know about the fraud, domina. He owns the men committing it."

The room was very quiet. The fountain made its sound in the garden.

"Celer," said Antonia. "The brother of the auditor."

"Yes." Hector swallowed. "The consul-designate's own brother, in up to his neck, and the auditor himself — with respect, domina, everyone in the counting houses knows Severus has been given the tallies — the auditor has no idea. It's a trap built like a temple. If Severus signs the accounts, the fraud passes with the most

honest name in Rome above it. If he digs and exposes it, his own brother hangs first, and the name of the Aelii is destroyed. They don't want him bribed. They want him paralyzed.”

Antonia set the tablet down with care. “Why come to me? You could have gone to the prefect. To the emperor's own office.”

Hector's laugh had no humour in it. “And how long do you suppose a Greek freedman clerk lasts after he accuses senators and Perperna to the prefect's doorkeeper? I've seen what happens. My predecessor on the board — a man called Phaon, very honest, very dull — resigned last year to ‘retire to Naples.' His grave's by the Ostian road. I went. There's a nice stone, paid for by persons unknown.” He looked at his sister, and the fear showed through fully now. “I came here because this is the one house in Rome where Perperna can't put a man at the table without you knowing it. Because you collect what men say when they're drunk, and I need the woman who knows where all the bodies are. And because Chloe says you keep your word, and I'm out of houses to trust.”

Chloe reached across and took his hand. “He needs to leave the city tonight. Hilarus has a barge going down to Ostia with the tide; he can lie up at the harbour, then take ship for Massilia—”

“No.” Antonia's voice was flat, and both of them looked at her. “Not yet. He's right about one thing: the tablets are evidence, but evidence in a drawer is merely paper. I need a witness who can

speak to the seals. The forgeries run through one engraver, don't they? Every false tally carries a seal-cutters' mark.”

Hector stared. “Syrus. On the Tiber bank, near the cattle market. How did you—”

“I know everyone who makes things that can be copied. Can he prove his hand? Distinguish a true seal from a forged one in court?”

“Blindfolded. He engraved half the official seals in the city. He'd know his own work from a forgery the way a mother knows twins.”

“Then tomorrow you'll take word to Syrus — not the documents, just the warning that his name may be wanted — and then you'll go to Hilarus's barge. One more day in Rome, under my roof, and then the harbour.” Antonia bound the tablets again with their thongs. “These go into the strong room, behind the silver, and no one but the four of us knows they exist. Festus?”

The ex-gladiator appeared in the doorway as though he had been part of the wall. “Domina.”

“Our guest leaves at dawn for the upper room, and he does not leave it. Food, water, a chamber pot, and your own man outside the door. If anyone asks, the room doesn't exist.”

Festus looked at Hector with the calm appraisal of a man measuring freight. “You'll be safe enough, Greek. Nobody gets past me except the wine merchant, and that's because I like him.”

Hector managed a smile. It did not reach his eyes.

Festus withdrew to the corridor, and the two Greeks sat for a while with the lamplight between them, and it was Chloe who spoke first, in their own language, the rough island Greek of the Delos slave market that neither of them had used in years.

“Tell me the rest. The part you left out of the letters.”

“There isn't much. After the dealer split us, I went to a counting house in Alexandria — clerk's boy, then clerk. The master found I could do sums in my head and treated me almost like furniture, which was a kindness in that house. I bought my freedom at twenty-six with the wages he didn't know I'd saved. You?”

“Delos to a rhetoric school, as the reader. Then Rome, then the house.” She poured him wine with her own hand. “I looked for you. Every Greek clerk who came through the Carinae got the third degree. There were a great many Greek clerks.”

“I know. I heard about a singer called Chloe who knew everyone, and I was afraid it was you, and then I was more afraid it wasn't. The market does something to people. I wasn't sure you'd still be—” He gestured vaguely.

“Human?”

“Kind. I wasn't sure you'd still be kind.”

Chloe's mouth trembled once, and was still. “Kindness in this city is an investment, like any other. Antonia taught me that. You spend it

carefully and it compounds. Do you remember our mother's hands?”

“Calloused. She did the weaving. She used to let us play with the shuttle threads.”

“That's all I have. Hands, and a song she hummed that I can't remember the tune of.” Chloe set the jug down. “When this is over, Hector, you and I are going to have a dull life. A little house somewhere — Neapolis, perhaps, where the Greeks are still Greeks. You'll keep the accounts of olive merchants and I'll sing badly at weddings. That's my price for surviving. Hold me to it.”

“It's a bargain.” He drank, and for the first time that night some of the fear left his face, replaced by the older, simpler thing that brothers and sisters carry, the certainty that the world contains at least one person who knew you before it made you.

When Festus had taken him away, Chloe lingered by the table, pleating the edge of her mantle between her fingers. “He was twelve when they separated us. Our mother was sold to a mine. I don't remember her face, only her hands. Hector I remember whole.” Her voice was steady, which cost her visible effort. “If Perperna has him—”

“Perperna doesn't have him. He has a missing clerk, and missing clerks are common; a body is a statement, and statements bring the vigiles.” Antonia paused. “I'll keep him alive, Chloe. It's the one promise I know how to make, because it's also

the one I most need to keep for myself. Now go to bed. Tomorrow's supper has fourteen covers, and I need you clever, not tragic."

Chloe went. Antonia sat alone with the tablets for a while, turning the cold wax in her hands, and then she too went up through the sleeping house, and somewhere a watchman called the third hour, and Rome, which never fully slept, shifted and muttered in the dark like a great beast at rest.

⁂

The next night's supper was a large one, given over to the contractors and merchants of the annona, the grain supply, and Antonia had arranged it with the care of a general choosing ground.

The great triclinium was full. Cossus, the grain contractor who had bragged of the eastern war's profits on Marcus's first visit, was there with two partners, and the room smelled of roses and pepper and the rich, close smell of successful men beginning to sweat into their garlands. Chloe presided over the middle couch, Tyche over the further one, and Antonia moved like a weaver's shuttle between them, pouring attention where it would do the most work.

She had dressed the room for annona men rather than senators: fewer roses, more light, the tables set with the good silver but nothing so fine as to make a contractor feel provincial, and a

menu of honest plenty — wild boar, mullet, three sorts of olive, the strong Alban wine rather than the delicate Greek. Men who weighed grain for a living distrusted elegance, she had found; they read refinement as a trick, and the whole evening's work depended on their reading nothing as a trick.

The work itself began before the first course. Tyche led the partners' junior clerk, a plump young man with ink on his thumb, into a conversation about harbour fees, and within ten minutes had him explaining the difference between the public weighing at the granary steps and the private re-weighing that happened inside, a difference, he confided, that “paid for a great many villas.” Chloe, on the middle couch, let Cossus explain his own importance to her for the length of two cups, nodding at the exact intervals, until the man, mellowed by being heard, began to name the firms he had beaten to the latest contracts — names Antonia had wanted in the air, because names spoken over wine could be compared against names written on tablets, and the gap between the two lists was where fraud showed its ankles.

Antonia herself worked the head of the table, where the senior partner, a grey-haired man named Varus who had supplied three emperors' armies, was holding court on the coming eastern campaign.

“Mark me,” Varus said, tapping his cup, “a war's fortunes are decided not by the eagles but by the contracts. A general can win a battle on short rations; he cannot win one on no rations, and the men who move the rations are the men Rome ought to cherish instead of taxing.” A murmur of agreement went round the couches. “The bureau understands it, anyway. Sensible fellows, the new men. Flexible. A contractor and a clerk who understand one another can move more grain in an afternoon than the law allows in a month, and nobody's the poorer — the army eats, the ships sail, the clerks eat. Where's the harm?”

“The harm,” Antonia said, smiling as she refilled his cup, “sounds like a question for an auditor, not a hostess. Tell me instead how a flexible clerk keeps his accounts. I'm a student of accounts; it's my one unfashionable vice.”

Varus laughed, and explained, and she listened with the bright, empty attention men found so flattering, while the part of her mind that did the real work placed each sentence beside the cold wax tablets upstairs: the fourth shipment, the ninety modii, the seal that repeated. By the time the boar came in, she had three new names, two new procedures, and one priceless phrase — *the private re-weighing* — which she would write down the moment the company was safely drunk, because Hector's phantom grain, she was now certain, did not appear at the public scale at all. It

was born in the second weighing, the one with no witnesses but the flexible men.

By the second wine service, Cossus was explaining the grain trade to a girl of nineteen who had been carefully chosen because she looked as though she admired him, and he had reached the stage of the evening where a man begins to reveal his importance through his indiscretions.

“—the thing people don't understand is that the tally *is* the grain. The army eats paper, my dear. A quartermaster in Syria doesn't know a modius from a mule; he knows a sealed tablet. So whoever holds the pen holds the harvest. Our group does very well out of the pen.” He laughed, and his partners laughed, and the girl laughed on cue, and across the room Chloe's eyelids flickered once toward Antonia, a single silent note.

“Won't the auditor catch it?” the girl asked, beautifully earnest. “They say the consul-designate Severus is ferocious.”

“Severus.” Cossus drained his cup and held it out for more. “Severus is a saint, and saints are the easiest men in Rome to manage, because you always know what they'll do. His own brother's in the subscription — didn't you know? Decimus Aelius. Charming fellow, terrible head for figures. When the saint finds that out, he won't dare cry fraud, because fraud means his family's blood in the gutter. He'll sign. Honest men always do, once you've taken their relations hostage.” He belched

softly, content with himself. “More wine. This is excellent. What is it?”

“Setine,” said Chloe, appearing beside him with the jug, her smile warm and her eyes like stones. “The emperor's own vintage. You have distinguished taste, Cossus. And such a gift for explanation. You must tell me about the pens again; I'm afraid I'm slow with figures.”

He told her. She drew him out for another hour, gently, expertly, until he had named the measurer at Ostia, the warehouse on the Aemilian wharf, and the name of the seal-engraver on the Tiber bank; and every word went into the room's true ledger, the one kept in Antonia Cassia's head.

In the pause between the roasts, Hilarus found her in the garden court, wiping his forehead with a napkin. He was a stout, sunburned man of fifty, freed in his thirties by a merchant whose trade he had inherited and multiplied, and he wore his wealth the way a soldier wears armour — comfortably, and never out of reach.

“I've insured two of those grain ships he's describing,” he said without preamble. “The *Isis* and the *Felix*. Both came in light. My measurer at Ostia weighed them himself; the Roman tallies gained ninety modii between the harbour and the wharf, which is a remarkable rate of growth for dead grain.”

“Can your man testify to the Ostia weights?”

“He can, if he's alive to do it. He's gone to ground in the harbour district; says men have

been asking for him at the taverns. Antonia, I did not get rich by being brave. I got rich by being absent when things became brave.” Hilarus lowered his voice. “But this is my trade they're stealing. Every phantom modius they sell the treasury is a modius that depresses the honest price and teaches the contractors that crime pays better than ships. If they get away with it, half my fleet is worthless inside two years.”

“Then bravery and self-interest have finally agreed, which is my favourite kind of partnership.” Antonia plucked a leaf from the jasmine and tore it slowly. “I want your Ostia offices open to me — every weight note, every wharf receipt. And I want your measurer kept alive. Hire him guards; put the cost to me.”

“Done. And the auditor? Severus? If the witness line on that loan is genuine—”

“We don't know yet whether he's a villain or a fool, and in Rome the distinction often doesn't matter, because the one is punished exactly like the other.” She let the leaf fall. “But he has the only name that can make a court listen. I'll need to arrange another conversation with the consul-designate, and this one won't be over wine.”

Hilarus looked at her shrewdly. “There's history between you two. The whole house knows, even the scullery boys.”

“The whole house knows nothing, and the scullery boys know less than that. History is a grave, Hilarus. Don't dig in mine.”

He held up his hands, palms out. “Not digging. Only observing that a woman usually hates a man less, or more, than you hate him. Never precisely that amount.”

She did not answer, because there was no answer that would not have cost her something, and they went back in together to the lamps and the noise.

The evening's ugly moment came late, in the smaller dining room, where a provincial tax farmer named Auctus had drunk past the point at which he could distinguish a paid companion from a possession. Tyche had been playing the lyre for his couch, and he reached for her wrist and pulled, and said something low and laughing that turned her face white.

The rule was the rule. Antonia was across the room before the sentence had finished, her own smile untouched, her voice low enough that only the nearest couches heard.

“Auctus. Let go of her hand.”

“Mind your trade, domina. I've paid for the evening.”

“You've paid for wine, music, and conversation. Her hand isn't on the menu. Let go, or Festus will explain it to you in the vestibule, and he demonstrates with the arm.”

The man's face darkened. He was fifty, rich, used to obedience, and for two beats the room balanced on a knife's edge. Then something in Antonia's still expression reached him — the knowledge that she would, without hesitation, ruin his standing with every man present and have him thrown into his own litter — and he let go, with a coarse laugh and a show of spreading his fingers.

“A joke. Only a joke. No sense of humour, you Greeks.”

“I'm not Greek,” said Antonia. “And I have a wonderful sense of humour. I'm saving it for men with manners.” She nodded to Tyche, who rose with the lyre and walked out with her head high, and to the room at large she said, “More wine, gentlemen. The night is young.”

But she made a mental mark beside the name Auctus, the way she marked every man who forgot the rule, because men who forgot it once were rehearsing for the time they forgot it where no one could stop them.

After the guests had gone, she found Tyche in the women's court, sitting alone in the dark with the lyre in her lap, and sat beside her without speaking.

“I didn't cry,” Tyche said.

“No. You were perfect.”

“I wanted to. I wanted to break the lyre over his head.”

“That would have been satisfying, and then we'd both be poorer and he'd be no wiser. Wanting and doing are different trades.” Antonia took the girl's hand, the same hand Auctus had gripped; there were red marks on the wrist. “Phyllis has salve. Remember what the house is: not a cage, a wall. Inside the wall, you decide. That's more than most women in Rome own, and I didn't build it to let a drunk farmer's son spoil it.”

Tyche leaned against her shoulder for a moment, briefly, the way a child does, and then straightened. “I'm all right.”

“I know you are. That's why you frighten them.”

⁂

Festus came up the garden stairs at dawn with the river still on his boots.

He had been down to the wharves before light, as he did twice a week, to talk to the watchmen and the stevedores and the tavern keepers who were the city's true morning gazette; and Antonia, who had slept three hours and bathed in cold water, saw his face as he crossed the atrium and felt something inside her close like a fist.

“Say it.”

“Vigiles fished a man out of the Tiber at first light, by the wooden bridge. Knife work, three cuts, professional. They'd weighted him with a stone, but the stone caught on a piling and he

came up. The centurion's a man I know — Vibius Longus, straight as a ruler — he sent word when they found the ink stains and the tablet case." Festus's voice was heavy. "It's the Greek, domina. Your guest. He got out of the upper room somehow in the night. The window bar's been sawed through, clean work, from the outside. Someone knew which room."

Antonia closed her eyes. Behind them she saw the careful, ink-stained hands, the frayed mantle, the fear.

"Chloe," she said.

"I'll tell her," said Festus.

"No. I'll tell her. Where is she?"

"Sleeping. She came off the second watch."

Antonia stood very still for a moment, and when she opened her eyes her face was the face the house knew in a crisis, smooth and cold and entirely without illusion. "Fetch her to the strong room. And Hilarus — send to the docks, now, before the streets fill. The barge plan may be dead, but the bargeman isn't; I want to know who knew it. Four people knew that room, Festus. Four. Find me the one who talks in his sleep."

She went out with him instead, through the waking streets, down to the Tiber.

The vigiles kept their district station in a converted warehouse near the cattle market, and the river dead were laid out in a stone-paved yard behind it, under an awning, where the water could be sluiced away. The smell was the smell of

all river yards, mud and fish and the cold sweetness of death, and Antonia wrapped her veil higher and crossed the flags with Festus beside her.

Vibius Longus was waiting, a square, grey-whiskered man in a stained tunic and a soldier's belt, the centurion's vine stick tucked under his arm. He did not bow or waste words; vigiles centurions saw too much of Rome to be impressed by it.

“Domina. Your man said you'd come. He's under the second sheet. Brace yourself; the river's had him half a day.”

He drew back the linen. Hector had not drowned. The three knife wounds were clean and close, the work of a man who did that sort of thing often; the throat cut was the mercy, or the habit. His hands were still ink-stained, the fingers slightly curled, and on one wrist there was a faint bruise where cord had bitten.

“They took him alive, then,” Antonia said.

“For a little while. Rope marks, no struggle cuts on the hands — he was bound before he was cut. Professionals, or soldiers; in this city sometimes the same men.” Vibius covered the face again. “The stone was a wharf stone, good and heavy, but the current rolled him onto a piling and the cord frayed. Lucky for us. The Tiber keeps its own, usually.”

“The window bar in my house. Sawed through, Festus says.”

“From the outside, and recently. Good blade, steady hand, knew which room. I'll come up and look at it, if you'll have me; my men double as carpenters, since Rome is mostly wood and fire.” The centurion's eyes were steady on her. “I'll be plain, domina. I know what your house is. I also know it's never given my watch a night's trouble in six years, while half the taverns on this street bleed a man a week. A dead clerk with knife work and contract tablets isn't a tavern quarrel. It's the kind of death that gets closed as persons unknown and forgotten by noon. If you want it remembered, you'll need to do the remembering yourself. I can give you the body for proper rites, and I can give you honest eyes when I have them. That's all the law's got in a yard like this.”

“It's more than the law usually offers. Take his statement about the bar, witnessed and sealed, and keep a copy yourself.” Antonia looked at the sheeted shape. “And find me who saw two men carrying a heavy bundle to the river between midnight and dawn. Wharf men sleep badly; someone always sees.”

“Someone always sees,” Vibius agreed. “Getting them to say it is the art.”

She left the arrangements in Festus's hands — a proper pyre outside the Esquiline gate, a Greek priest, the rites Chloe would want — and walked back up through the waking city with her veil drawn, carrying her grief for a man she had

known one evening the way she carried everything, behind a face no one could read.

She went down to the strong room herself, unlocked the iron-bound door, and took out the four tablets and the parchment notes, and carried them to the table where the lamps burned even in daylight. Chloe came in a little later, white and dry-eyed, the dryness more terrible than tears, and sat down across from her without a word.

“I'm sorry,” Antonia said. “I keep promises, and I failed this one. I'll say it once, and then I'll spend my life making it good.”

Chloe's voice was flat. “They got into your house. Through a barred window, in the night, and they killed my brother in your upper room or on his way out of it, and they dropped him in the river like a bucket.”

“Yes.”

“Then we're at war.”

“Yes.” Antonia pushed the tablets across the table. “Read them. All of it. He died for these, and they're going to be worth his life, or I'll know the reason why.”

Chloe read. In the strong room's lamplight her face moved through grief into something harder and more durable, the face of a woman who had discovered that the world had taken everything it could from her and could now be dealt with without fear. At the third tablet she stopped, her finger on a line, and looked up.

“Antonia. The subscriptions. There — the Aelius name. Decimus, yes, but look at the witness line on the loan beneath it.”

Antonia looked. Beneath Perperna's loan to Celer, in the column of witnesses, in a small, formal, senator's hand, was a second name.

M. Aelius Severus.

They stared at one another.

“He witnessed his brother's loan,” Chloe said slowly. “Marcus Severus put his name on Perperna's paper.”

“Either that, or someone put his name there without telling him.” Antonia's mind was already turning the possibilities like keys in locks. “If he knew, he's their creature. If he didn't, his own seal has been used to build the trap he's auditing. Either way—”

“Either way, he's inside it now.”

Antonia gathered the tablets and rebound them, her movements precise. “The Tiber took one man for these. It won't take the rest. We're going to need the auditor himself, Chloe. Whether he deserves it or not.”

They burned him at dusk beyond the Esquiline gate, in the field where the poor and the unlanded took their smoke, and the house closed its doors for the evening and went in force: Festus and the footmen, Phyllis with the offerings, Tyche and the other women veiled in dark cloth, Sabina at the back holding a lamp she had been told to hold and did not yet understand. Chloe had washed and

dressed the body herself at the vigiles yard, refusing all help, and she laid the coin for the ferryman between her brother's lips with hands that only shook once.

A wandering Greek priest said the old words, the words for crossing water, and the pyre took, and they stood in the smoke while the sun went down over the tiled city. Antonia watched Chloe's profile against the fire: no weeping, no dramatic grief, only the fixed attention of a woman recording a debt.

When the others had drawn back to the litters, Chloe stayed at the edge of the embers, and Antonia stayed with her.

“He wanted a dull life,” Chloe said. “A house in Neapolis. Olive merchants and bad wedding songs. We agreed it last week, in that room, over your wine. He got a pyre in a potter's field.”

“Then the men who owe him this will pay for the house in Neapolis,” Antonia said. “Whether they're alive to see it or not. I don't believe in the gods much, but I believe in ledgers, and his is open.”

Chloe knelt, took a handful of the cooling ash, and tied it into the corner of her mantle with a piece of cord. “For the house in Neapolis. When I have one, he gets a shelf.” She rose, and turned, and her face was the face Antonia had seen over the tablets in the strong room, grief annealed into something with an edge. “I want to learn the accounts properly. All of them. Not just sing for

them. If this war is going to be fought with paper, I intend to be a soldier."

"Tomorrow. First lesson, first hour. Now come home; the dead don't need witnesses any longer, and the living have work."

They rode back through the gates as the lamps were being lit in every window, Rome roaring around them in its thousand voices, the enormous indifferent life of a city that had swallowed Hector the Greek between one sunset and the next and would, if no one stopped it, swallow a great many more. Antonia looked at the lights as the litter climbed the hill, and thought that the city looked like a great beast lying down for the night, all gold eyes and warm breath, and she made herself the promise she made only once, in the presence of the dead: she would not be swallowed. She would make the beast choke.

CHAPTER FIVE

Contracts and Silence

The Curia Julia smelled of old wood, lamp smoke, and the wool of several hundred men in winter tunics, and Marcus, entering at the third hour with the roll of senators swelling around him, felt the familiar pressure of the place the way a sailor feels the deck change under his feet when the weather shifts.

The consuls had convened them on the eastern supply schedule, and the house was full. Senators greeted one another in the aisles with the elaborate warmth of men who would ruin one another before the month was out, and Marcus moved through them with the nod-and-word economy he had perfected over fifteen years: a name for everyone, a stop for no one, his face arranged in the expression of dignified attention that passed, in this building, for an opinion.

Stichus walked at his elbow to the door, murmuring. “Praetor Gratus is three rows ahead and wants a word; tell him nothing about the audit. The praetorian prefect's deputy is here, which means the Palace is watching. Your brother's by the back columns with the Baeticans;

he's been here since dawn, working the room like a candidate."

"Thank you. Go and walk in the forum; come back at the dismissal."

Inside, the consuls took their curule chairs, the augurs took the auspices with the usual dignified haste, and the sitting opened with a decree of public thanks for the health of the emperor's sister, which passed unanimously, as all such decrees did, and occupied the first half hour, as all such decrees did. Then the senior consul brought the house to the matter of the day, and the temperature in the Curia changed.

"The treasury requires confirmation of the eastern schedule's supply contracts," the consul said, in the flat voice of a man reading a document he disliked. "Grain, leather, tents, transport, and the associated finance. A review has been entrusted to Marcus Aelius Severus, whose report the house will receive before the spring sailing. Are there statements?"

There were. There always were.

The first speaker was a former governor with investments in three of the contracting firms, who rose to praise the schedule as a model of administration and to warn the house against unsettling the markets at a moment of national preparation. The second was a Stoic senator of austere reputation, who rose to say that he had no investments anywhere and therefore no opinion, which the house received with the scepticism it

deserved. A third wanted a full accounting of every contract since the beginning of the reign, which everyone understood as a method of ensuring that nothing would ever be accounted for at all.

Marcus listened, said nothing, and watched his brother. Celer was seated among the back benches with the Baeticans, his handsome face attentive, his applause perfectly timed, and once, when the former governor used the phrase “the proper confidence between the state and its contractors,” Marcus saw him lean to murmur in a neighbour's ear, and the neighbour nodded without looking at him. It was the body language of a man who had rehearsed.

Then Sextus Perperna asked for the floor.

He was not a senator. He sat with the equestrians and advocates at the back, in the position allowed to men of standing who were not members of the house, and he rose now with the diffident air of a man who regretted intruding upon his betters, and the consul, who owed him a favour Marcus had never been able to identify precisely, nodded him permission.

“Fathers conscript.” Perperna's voice was modest, well pitched, the voice of a schoolmaster explaining a difficult passage. “I claim no seat among you. I claim only the citizen's ancient right to warn. My profession, as the house knows, is the prosecution of fraud against the public; it has made me neither loved nor rich, and I have made

my peace with one of those conditions." A small laugh rippled through the benches, exactly where he had expected it. "I warn the house now. The eastern schedule is not merely expensive. It is, in part, invented. I have information — I will name sources only before the proper court — that certain contracts rest on inflated tallies, forged warehouse receipts, and subscriptions advanced by lenders who expect repayment from the treasury itself. A machine for turning public gold into private purses. And I warn the distinguished auditor—" here he turned, and his kindly eyes found Marcus with the accuracy of a bowman "—that the names in these accounts will reach closer to home than he anticipates. An auditor who cannot audit his own household audits nothing. The house should demand a report that fears no family."

He sat. The Curia hummed, the way a hive hums when a stone has been thrown into it from a distance.

Marcus asked for the floor, and received it, and stood for a moment in the hush with every eye in the building on him.

"The citizen Perperna has warned the house," he said. "I thank him, though warnings without evidence are among the few things Rome produces more cheaply than grain. I will say this. I accepted the audit because the consuls asked it, and I will deliver it because I gave my word. The report will name every firm, every tally, and every

subscriber the documents reveal, without exception of friendship, family, or rank. If any name in these accounts is a name I bear, the house will read it in my own hand before it reads it in anyone else's. That is my statement.”

He sat. The applause was genuine in the middle benches and careful everywhere else. On the back row, Celer was smiling, but the smile had the fixed quality of a mask, and Perperna, across the aisle, inclined his head with the mild, satisfied air of a chess player whose opponent has just made the move he wanted.

The sitting ran to the ninth hour, through two more minor speakers and a wrangle about the price of public seals, and Marcus spent most of it watching the back of Perperna's head and reviewing, against his will, everything he knew about the man's method. Perperna never lost a prosecution he had chosen to bring. He chose them like a fisherman choosing water: slowly, once, and where the fish had nowhere to run. That he had stood up in the Curia and named the audit before it had even begun meant he had already decided what the audit would find, and the only open question was whose neck he intended for the demonstration.

When it broke, Marcus let the crowd carry him into the Forum, and Perperna was waiting for him beside the statue of Porsenna, as though the encounter were the most natural thing in Rome,

eating olives from a paper cone with the calm of a man at the games.

“Severus. A strong statement. ‘In my own hand.' Brave. I do admire bravery, it's so seldom practical.” He held out the cone; Marcus declined with a motion of the hand. “Walk with me a little. The afternoon's fine.”

They walked among the bankers' stalls, two distinguished men taking the air, invisible in plain sight, which Marcus suspected was exactly why Perperna had chosen it.

“You made an accusation in there without a single document,” Marcus said.

“An accusation is a promise, and I keep my promises. The documents exist; I merely haven't decided who deserves to see them.” Perperna spat an olive stone into his palm and pocketed it, a man of tidy habits. “Let me save you a month of evenings. Your brother is fifteen thousand sesterces in my debt and his subscriptions are among the first I'd examine, were I auditing. You can imagine how it looks: the honest brother signs the tallies that absolve the debtor brother. The city's pamphlet writers have less imagination than I do, and they'll manage.”

“Is that a confession? That you hold paper on a subscriber to contracts under review?”

“It's an education. I hold paper on half of Rome; the difference between a banker and a villain is entirely a question of whose biography you're reading.” Perperna stopped by a fountain

and turned to him, the kindly face sincere. “Here is my advice, offered free, which tells you how much I value your good opinion. Sign the schedule as presented. The war needs the supplies, the treasury needs the schedule, and your brother needs silence. One signature settles all three. Then in the spring, when the consular elections come round, no one has any reason to remember the name Aelius except with respect. You'd be surprised how cheaply a clear conscience can be bought, when the price is merely one's signature.”

“And the alternative?”

“The alternative is that you discover your family's shame in public, your brother goes into exile or worse, your consulship drowns in the scandal, and the audit that was meant to purify the schedule becomes the spectacle that discredits it. Everyone loses, except the man brave enough to tell the truth in court — which, in the circumstances, would be me.” Perperna smiled. “Rome rewards its teachers. Think it over. I'm a patient man; it's my only virtue.”

He drifted away toward the Argiletum with his paper cone, and Marcus stood by the fountain with the winter sun on his face and the cold knowledge, settling in his stomach like stone, that the choice Perperna had offered was the choice he had been engineered to face from the beginning. The audit was never a duty. It was a trap with two doors, both of them leading where Perperna wished.

He walked home through the Forum with the sun low over the temples, and did not speak to anyone, and did not need to; Stichus, meeting him at the door of the Curia, took one look at his face and followed him in silence up the Esquiline.

⁂

The family dinner that evening was, on its face, a success.

The dining room was warm, the silver was correctly placed, the cook had outdone himself with a dormouse dish in honey and poppy seed, and Livia had arranged the guests as she arranged everything: Celer, of course; the children at the smaller table where they could be seen and not heard; Livia's own cousin, the wife of a praetor, to make up the women's side; and an elderly jurist of Marcus's acquaintance, brought in, Marcus suspected, to give the evening a respectable cover.

The jurist, one Pacilius, had been a praetor himself in the year of the Dacian triumph and now spent his retirement giving legal opinions over other men's dinners, a role he performed with the slow pleasure of a man whose advice could no longer cost him anything. Over the fish course the talk turned, as dinner talk did that winter, to the fashion for prosecutions under the older statutes, and Pacilius was drawn out upon the lex Iulia de

adulteriis, which he proceeded to explain to the table at the length of an entire sauce.

“The genius of the statute,” he said, waving a fish fork, “is that it makes the household itself the informer. The husband who fails to denounce within the statutory period becomes liable himself. You see the elegance? The law doesn't merely punish the offence; it punishes silence, and silence, dear friends, is the ordinary Roman husband's dearest privilege.” He beamed around the couches. “A reluctant husband is thus converted into a diligent prosecutor, and the treasury collects its share of the convicted woman's dowry. Everyone gains except, of course, the woman, which is customary.”

“Everyone gains,” Marcus said, carefully keeping his voice at dinner pitch, “or the delator gains? The statute assumes a husband with evidence. What of a husband presented with manufactured evidence, a seal used in his absence, a clerk's statement bought for coin?”

Pacilius blinked at the sharpness beneath the courtesy, and adjusted. “Manufacture is provable, where the manufacture is clumsy. Where it is skilled — and the skilled sort, I need not tell a senator, is the kind that reaches your table — the remedy lies less in the statute than in the household records. Diaries, steward's rolls, the daily account of who was where. Roman law, for all its grandeur, is in daily practice a great respecter of the household that keeps good

books.” He helped himself to more fish. “A family without records, Severus, is a family that has already lost whatever case it hasn't yet been accused of. I've said it for forty years. Nobody writes it down.”

Across the table, Livia's eyes met her husband's for one precise moment, and moved away, and Marcus understood the dinner completely: the dormice, the cousin, the jurist, all of it arranged so that the family could be told, in respectable company and at no one's instigation, to begin keeping the kind of books that survive a prosecution. He thought of the wax tablets on his desk, the diary entries from Praeneste, the steward's movements, and he made a private note to have Phaon's daily rolls sealed at each month's end from now on, in duplicate, the second copy lodged away from the house.

At the children's table, Gaius was listening with the fixed, silent attention his father had learned to recognize, and Marcus saw with a slight shock that the boy was following the law as other boys followed the races, storing the rules of the adult world the way he stored the names of charioteers. Some of it, Marcus thought, would be needed sooner than anyone at this table wished.

Celer, for his part, ate through the jurist's lecture with the cheerfulness of a man who assumed laws were for other people, and drank two cups of the Alban, and asked no questions, which was, Marcus reflected, precisely the

disposition that had filled his brother-in-law's life with creditors and would, before the winter ended, fill it with worse.

For an hour it held. Celer was at his most charming, telling a long story about a mule auction in the Forum that made even the jurist laugh, and Gaius, across the room, tried manfully not to laugh with his mouth full, and Vibia succeeded in teaching the cat — brought down from the nursery against all precedent — to sit beneath her couch like a small, bad-tempered guardian spirit.

It was Gaius, halfway through the dormice, who produced the evening's first difficulty, with the devastating timing of the young.

“Father,” he said, across the room, in the clear carrying voice of a boy trained in rhetoric. “Quintus's father says all the fathers go to a house in the Carinae where the women sing and no wives are allowed. Is that true?”

The jurist choked slightly on his wine. Livia's cousin became fascinated by her napkin. Celer burst out laughing and then remembered himself.

Marcus set down his cup. “Quintus's father should teach his son discretion before he teaches him anything else. The house exists. Women there are paid for their music and conversation. Men go because they enjoy both, and because Rome allows men pleasures it does not allow women, which is an injustice you are too young to debate and I am too tired to defend.”

“Are they wicked women?”

“There are no wicked women, Gaius. There are women with different misfortunes, and men who profit from describing them as wicked, which is cheaper than paying them honestly. Eat your dinner.”

Livia said nothing, but her eyes met her husband's across the couches with an expression he could not read, and later, when the children went up, Vibia paused at his couch to whisper that the cat had eaten three dormice and was now, in her professional opinion, the most distinguished person present, and the room breathed again.

But Livia's household ran on undercurrents, and when the women withdrew and the wine came round and the slaves had taken the second table, the undercurrent surfaced.

“You were magnificent in the house today,” Celer said, raising his cup. “‘In my own hand before anyone else's.' The whole Forum's quoting it. You could be consul twice with a tongue like that.”

“Consul once is sufficient for a man who intends to sleep at night.” Marcus set his cup down untouched. “What I require from you is not praise. Perperna all but named you in the Curia. Tell me plainly, before this goes further: how deep are you in the eastern subscriptions?”

The charm held; the colour did not. “Marcus, really, before our guest—”

“The jurist has heard worse, and probably ruled on it. How deep?”

“Eleven thousand.” Celer said it fast, the way a man tears off a plaster. “In the first subscription, and another four on a second note, most of it advanced by Perperna. There. I've said it. It's not a crime. Half the back benches—”

“It is a rope. Perperna doesn't lend money, Decimus; he distributes ropes, and he waits for the state to build the gallows. Why did you need fifteen thousand sesterces?”

The younger man stared into his wine. “The house on the Palatine. The games I gave as aedile — a man has to give games, Marcus, you know the rules, the crowd remembers a cheap aedile for twenty years. And the horses, and the dinners, and — oh, what does it matter. A gentleman's expenses are a gentleman's honour, and I have the expenses without the fortune.” He looked up, and for once the handsome face was open and wretched. “I'm sorry. There. I'm your little brother and I'm sorry, and I've been dreading this dinner since the audit was named.”

Marcus felt the anger drain out of him, leaving the older, heavier thing beneath it, the thing that had sat in his chest since the Tibur villa: responsibility.

“Can you clear the debt? Honestly, without the subscription profits?”

“Not before spring. If the contracts pay on the first instalment, I'm whole and Perperna has his

principal and the thing quietly dies. If they don't—" He spread his hands. "If they don't, he owns me, and through me he gets the pleasure of watching you audit your own brother."

Across the room, Gaius had gone very still over his dessert, listening with the entire attention of a boy who adored his father and worshipped his uncle and was beginning to understand that the two were not the same thing. Marcus saw him see it, and said, more gently, "We'll speak of this in the tablinum. Not at table."

But Livia, returning with the cousin at that moment, had caught the tail of it, and her face did not change, and that was how Marcus knew she had heard everything and intended to discuss none of it until the guests were gone.

The guests were gone by the tenth hour. The household settled into its night routines, the lamps were trimmed, the children sent up with kisses, and Marcus and Livia faced each other across the empty dining room like the commanders of two allied states whose alliance had outlived its purpose.

"You knew," he said.

"Of course I knew. I keep this household's accounts; I know the price of everything in it, including your brother's debts." Livia removed her earrings and set them in a small dish, one by one, the movements precise. "I've been moving our private funds for two months to keep the worst of his creditors quiet. Do not look at me like

that; it was your name they'd have dragged through the market, not mine."

"You should have told me."

"I should have been consulted, you mean. We are not in the habit of consulting one another, Marcus. We are in the habit of coexisting. It has worked very well for fifteen years, until your supper-house woman and your brother's debts arrived in the same season." She met his eyes, and hers were cool and direct. "I heard about the Carinae. All the wives heard. You came home like a man who'd seen a ghost. Then Perperna stands up in the Senate and talks about names close to home, and now this. Is she part of it? The woman?"

"Antonia Cassia is a witness to more conversations than any of us like, but she is not part of any fraud, if that's what you're asking."

"I'm asking whether she's part of *you*. There's a difference." When he said nothing, she gave a short, dry laugh. "You see? Even the honest man has his silences. Very well. I will not pry into the ghost, because ghosts are a wife's least dangerous rival; at least she's old. But I will say this about Decimus. Do not let sentiment for your brother bury your audit. The Aelii have survived worse than one ruined spendthrift. We have never survived a name for dishonesty. Choose the name, Marcus. The name outlives all of us."

"We were married at eighteen," Marcus said, more to the room than to her. "My father

arranged it on the day I came of age. I don't think either of us was asked."

"Asked? I was shown your family tree and told to be grateful, which I was, because the alternative was an old man with gout in Pompeii." Livia's voice was dry, but not unkind. "You were the handsomest bridegroom of the year, and you treated me with perfect, unbearable courtesy for the whole wedding. Courtesy, Marcus. Not warmth. I've had a great deal of time to consider the difference."

"I tried to be a good husband."

"You were a good husband, by every standard the law measures. You didn't beat me, you didn't spend my dowry, you didn't bring mistresses into my house, and the children are legitimate and healthy. Rome would give you a wreath." She paused at the door. "What Rome cannot measure is that for fifteen years I've been the manager of your life rather than anyone's beloved, and I made my peace with it because the alternative for a woman of my family was not freedom but another house with another manager. I am not complaining. I am explaining why I will not allow your brother's appetites, or your ghost, or anything else, to bring down the structure I've spent half my life maintaining. The name, Marcus. Always the name."

She picked up the earring dish and walked out, carrying herself with the erect dignity of a woman who had said exactly what she intended and

regretted none of it, and Marcus stood alone among the dismantled couches and thought that his wife, in her way, was the most formidable person he knew, and that he had never once in fifteen years succeeded in being a husband to her rather than a colleague.

It was at that exact moment that Stichus appeared, softly, with a sealed letter that had been left at the door by a runner already gone, and Marcus broke the wax and read, in an unfamiliar clerk's hand, four lines.

The auditor's name appears as witness on his brother's loan. Ask whether he wrote it. The grain is weighed at Ostia and rewritten at Rome. A dead clerk named Hector kept the true tally, and the Tiber has him now. Ask who profits by your silence.

No signature. No mark. He turned it over; nothing. He read it a second time, and a third, and carried it to the lamp and burned it, and stood watching the black flakes curl into the tray, with the unbidden, unwelcome image in his mind of a woman in a blue stola looking at him across a supper room as though he were a stain on her floor.

⁂

Earlier that evening, before the runner went out, Antonia had sat in the women's court while Phyllis combed out her hair, the old Roman ritual that

ended every working day, and the household had gathered the way it always did at that hour, in a loose circle of women with mending and music and the day's small injuries.

Sabina was there, practising her letters on a slate, and Tyche, with the salve still faintly smelling on her wrist, and two of the musicians arguing about a tune, and for a while Antonia let the noise wash over her and said nothing, because one of the house's deepest rules was that the mistress sat with the women and not above them.

Then Phyllis said, without looking up from the comb, “I owe you a story. I said I'd tell you, and I'm a woman of my word. Not all of it tonight. The beginning.”

The court quieted by degrees, though no one had asked for quiet; the women of the house had learned that Phyllis's stories were worth any tune.

“I was a slave in the Aelius household before any of you were born,” Phyllis said. “I scrubbed their kitchen and I nursed their babies, and one of the babies I nursed was the boy Marcus, and one of the children who ran in and out of my kitchen was a little Greek girl called Anthe, whose mother sewed the family's linen. Anthe's mother was a quiet woman. She died of a winter fever when the girl was nine, and the girl would have gone to the fields or worse, except that she was bright, and bright children in a great house get used. She ran messages, she learned to read from the tutor's

discarded scrolls, and later — much later — from the young master himself.”

Antonia felt the court's eyes turn toward her and did not move.

“I remember the year it began to change,” Phyllis went on, drawing the comb slowly. “I remember the mistress watching them. Not cruelly. Carefully. The way you watch a storm over the valley, deciding when to bring in the grain. The great houses don't have scandals, girls; they have solutions, and the solutions are always carried out by people like me, and paid for by people like her.” She laid the comb down. “That's the beginning. The rest is for another night, because the rest keeps me awake, and I'm old enough to choose my sleepless nights.”

“Did he love her?” Sabina asked, very low.

Phyllis looked at Antonia, and Antonia gave the smallest possible nod.

“Boys don't know what love is,” Phyllis said. “They learn it, or they don't, and the learning is the whole story. Now someone play something cheerful, before we all drown in our own reflections.”

The music started again, and later, when the court had emptied and the lamps burned low, Antonia sat alone a while with the remembered weight of the comb in her hair and the question hanging in the dark: whether the boy had become a man capable of learning, or merely another master of the house.

In the Carinae, the runner's report came back to the tablinum before midnight, delivered through Festus: letter accepted, read three times, burned. No alarm, no summons of the household, no message sent out.

“Self-contained,” Antonia said. “Good. A frightened man sends for help. A dangerous man thinks. He's thinking.”

Chloe sat across from her with Hector's tablets open, copying columns onto fresh parchment by lamplight, her eyes red but her hand steady. Beside her lay a wax tablet of her own, covered with the alphabet and the first principles of double-entry, the exercises Antonia had set her. The house was quiet around them, the night watch moving through the corridors with soft feet.

“Suppose he ignores it,” Chloe said.

“He won't. The letter doesn't ask him to do anything, which is why he can't leave it alone. It tells him his own seal may have been used without him. A man like Severus would investigate a stolen napkin; he'll investigate a stolen name.” Antonia leaned back in her chair. “What do the copies show?”

“That my brother was a genius with a column and a fool about danger.” Chloe touched the parchment gently. “The Ostia weights and the Roman tallies don't merely differ — they differ in a pattern. Every fourth shipment, the same gain:

ninety modii. It's a system. Somebody's signature work."

"Systems have authors, and authors have vanities, and vanities leave evidence." Antonia took up her stylus. "Tomorrow we begin on the lenders. Every loan Perperna holds on the contractors' names. Find me the one he can't afford to have called. Hilarus's Ostia receipts by the end of the week. And Chloe—" she paused, choosing the words "—I want you to start carrying a knife. The little one, strapped to the inside of your arm. Festus will show you how."

Chloe looked at her. "You think they'll come here."

"I think they've already been here. The window bar. They know the house's layout, they move at night, and they kill clerks. Hope for the best and arm for the worst; it's the only prayer that ever works in Rome."

Festus gave the knife lesson in the garden, before she dismissed them, and Antonia watched from the colonnade.

The blade was a small straight razor of Spanish steel, set in a bone handle, with a sheath that strapped inside the forearm beneath a wide bracelet. Festus had used similar knives in the arena, though for different reasons, and he taught Chloe without drama, the way he taught everything: slow repetition, no boasting, a professional's respect for the instrument.

“Up the forearm, under the ribs, or across the front of the thigh where the big blood runs,” he said. “You're not trying to win a fight. A woman your size doesn't win fights; she ends them, or she makes enough of a mess to reach the door. First lesson: drawing it. Again. Again. You're hiding the motion with your body, not your hand.”

Chloe practised until the draw came clean, and then they worked on the single upward stroke, again and again, into a sack of straw dressed in an old tunic, while the garden statues looked on and the fountain spilled its harmless water.

“Will it ever feel real?” Chloe asked, breathing hard.

“Everything feels real the first time,” said Festus. “After that it's just a tool, like a ladle. Don't make a romance of it. The men who make romances of knives are the ones who lose to the men who don't.”

Antonia said nothing from the shadows, but she made a note to herself: Tyche next, then Sabina when she was older, and the musicians if they were willing. The house's rule depended on Festus's fists; the women's own rule, the rule that lived inside their skins, depended on steel they could reach without asking.

She dismissed them then, and sat alone in the lamplit room with the ledgers and the soft sound of the fountain, and after a while she unlocked the small cedar box and took out the chipped wooden disc, and held it, and thought about a boy's hand

over hers on a stylus, and about a man in a senator's tunic reading an unsigned letter three times before he burned it.

“Think,” she whispered to the empty room, to the disc, to the past. “Think, and be worth the trouble I'm taking. Because if you're not, Marcus Aelius Severus, I'll ruin you with the same care I'm using to save you.”

Outside, the watch called the fourth hour, and Rome, indifferent and enormous, went on about its night.

CHAPTER SIX

The Soft Voice

Sextus Perperna came to the gilded door at the sixth hour, in full daylight, dressed like a visiting philosopher, and Festus let him stand in the vestibule for the precise length of time required to make a man of his importance feel it, which was about four minutes.

Antonia received him in the small reception room off the atrium, the one with the bird-painting on the wall and no couch low enough for a man to relax on. She was working at her accounts when he came in, and she finished the line, set the stylus down with deliberate care, and rose only as far as courtesy required.

“Perperna. My house is honoured, though my door is usually opened to men with names their fathers gave them. To what do I owe the distinction?”

He smiled, the kindly smile, and seated himself without invitation, arranging his mantle over his knees. “Directness. I approve; it saves the city's time. I've come as a friend, though I know friendship between us requires some imagination. May I speak plainly?”

“You may speak briefly. I'll decide whether it's plain.”

“Very well.” He folded his hands. “You are, at this moment, the most vulnerable wealthy person in Rome. Your licenses are under review. A magistrate holds a complaint for the surrender of a girl in your keeping. A murdered man was sheltered under your roof the night before he was cut, and the vigiles know it. Your women are enrolled, your accounts are clean, your taxes are paid — admirable, all of it. But cleanliness is a defence against honest prosecutors. It is no defence at all against a determined one.”

Antonia's face did not change. “You speak as though the determined prosecutor were in the room.”

“He is. He has been for two minutes.” Perperna's smile deepened, gentle as a doctor's. “I could close this house within ninety days. The licensing review finds irregularities — and every house in Rome has irregularities, if one has the patience to count them. The Aviania girl's case makes you a kidnapper of free citizens. The Greek clerk makes you a harbourer of fugitives, perhaps an accomplice in whatever fraud he was killed for. The charge of lenocinium does the rest. You would lose the house, the freehold, the bank deposits, and the protection your wealth has bought you. The women would scatter to the Subura, where the houses are cheaper and the

rules are whatever the doorman decides. I've seen it happen to better establishments than yours.”

“You've made it happen to better establishments than mine.”

“I have. It's my gift.” He inclined his head. “You think your walls keep secrets. Let me show you otherwise, as a courtesy between professionals. On the night of the eleventh, the praetor Gratus left his signet ring here for the second time; inside it, beneath the stone, is a miniature of a woman who is not his wife. The governor of Syria's agent gambles more than his salary permits and owes Hilarus four thousand on last month's dice. The procurator's cousin is afraid of his own father, which is why he performs so loudly in bed. And your newest girl, the debt-bond, cries into her pillow for the first hour of every night and stops only when she has recited the names of her family's farm animals.”

Antonia's blood went cold; her face did not. “You have someone inside the women's wing.”

“I have someone inside every street in Rome. Do not look for one traitor; you'd be hunting a hundred pairs of ears. The point is that your sealed room is sealed only against the honest, and I am not honest.” He gave her the gentle smile again. “Which is why I'm here instead of at the courts. Ruining you would be easy and, frankly, not especially profitable. I prefer arrangements. Three things. First: this house becomes my listening post. The men who dine here speak with

remarkable freedom; I want to know what they say, particularly the men around the supply audit. You will pass me notes — names, sentiments, anything useful — through a messenger of my choosing. Second: the girl Aviania is surrendered to the magistrate's keeping, after which she will be sold, lawfully, to a buyer I designate. Third: the freehold of this house is transferred to me at the public valuation, generous under the circumstances, and you remain as its manager on a salary."

The room was very still. The fountain made its small, cool sound.

Antonia said, "You want me to become your spy, give you a free girl to sell, and hand you the deeds to the house I built. In exchange for what, precisely?"

"Protection. The review vanishes, the complaint is withdrawn, the clerk's death never touches your name. You keep your money, your comforts, your women, your life. All you surrender is the thing no one ever needed anyway: the fiction that you are independent." He leaned forward slightly, soft-voiced and earnest. "Antonia. You are a freedwoman. The law does not love you; it merely hasn't noticed you yet. Every woman who has ever stood where you stand has ended in one of two places: a rich man's kept woman, or a name on an auction list. I'm offering you a third door. Walk through it."

She let the silence run. She had learned, long ago, that silence after an insult was more eloquent than any insult, and she watched him sit in it, the kindly face attentive, the clever eyes measuring, and she thought that she had never met a man so at ease inside his own corruption.

“No,” she said.

His expression did not alter. “No?”

“No to the listening, no to the girl, no to the deeds. My guests dine here because they believe the room is sealed. The day I sell what's said in it, the house dies; you'd be buying a corpse. The girl stays under a lawful contract that Vipsanius sealed himself, and if your magistrate wants her, he can say so in open court, where I'll be waiting with witnesses. And the house is not for sale at any price, because the house is the proof that a woman born with nothing can own something in Rome. Take it from me over my dead body, and make sure yours is the next will read, because I keep copies of every document I've ever touched, and my bankers and my partner hold sealed packets with instructions to open them if I die in mysterious circumstances. You know Hilarus. You know Beryllus. Ask them whether I'm bluffing.”

Perperna looked at her for a long moment. Then he sighed, a genuine-sounding sigh of regret, and rose.

“I was afraid you'd say that. The strong ones always do; it's what makes them worth the effort.” He adjusted his mantle. “Let me leave you with

one thought, since you're so fond of documents. The Greek came through your postern at the tenth hour. I know the hour. I know the room he slept in. I know the window. When a house can be entered in the night and a man taken out of it dead, the house is not a fortress, Antonia. It's a stage, and I've been watching the play for some time. Good day."

He walked out himself, without a slave to show him, and Festus appeared in the doorway a moment later with the particular expression he wore when he had restrained himself from killing a guest.

"I could have thrown him into the fishpond."

"And he'd have sued me for the fish. No. Let him walk; walking makes men careless." But her hand, on the table, was closed so tightly around her stylus that the point had scored the wax to the wood.

When the door was shut and the guest's litter had turned the corner, she sent for Festus and Phyllis and sat them down in the tablinum with the lamps trimmed, the way she held every council of war, with wine for them and none for herself and the door bolted on the household side.

"Say what you think, both of you. Start with the small things; the small things in this house are the whole of its safety."

Festus went first, because his trade was doors. "He came at the dinner hour with two clients and no litter of his own — hired, from the stand by the

fountain. A man with his money doesn't hire unless he doesn't want his liveried bearers to know the address. He watched the locks the whole way in; I watched him watch them. And he asked the kitchen boy where the strong room was, as a joke. The boy doesn't know anyway, but the question's not a joke coming from a man like that.”

“Phyllis?”

The old woman folded her hands. “He knows the women's names. Not the enrolled names — the birth names. He called Tyche by her island name, the one she hasn't answered to since she was fourteen. Someone has been talking to someone who knew them before this house, or paying the dealers for their old lists. That's not flattery, domina. That's a man showing you he can reach inside the walls.”

Antonia sat with that a moment. The birth names were the deepest lever the city had over women like hers; a delator who could produce a woman's slave name in open court could unmake her presentable self in a sentence. She thought of her own name, Anthe, and the price tag that went with it, and kept her face still.

“Then we do three things, starting tonight. First, every woman in the house writes down her history — the true one, the dealer's name, the sale price, every place she's been — one copy for the strong room, one for the temple coffer. If a name is going to be used in court, it will be used by us

first, in context, with the documents beside it. A secret he knows is a weapon; a secret we've already entered in evidence is a damp squib. Second, Festus: change the strong-room lock and add the inner bolt. The locksmith works here, in the atrium, where everyone can see him, so the street knows the door has new teeth. Third." She paused. "From tomorrow, no one leaves this house alone. The market, the temple, the music teacher — pairs, always, and the youngest never without one of the older women. He wants us frightened in our own rooms. Frightened women make mistakes. We'll make none, and he'll have to make the next move, and the next move is evidence."

Phyllis nodded slowly. "You've been waiting for a man like him."

"I've been preparing for a city like this. He's merely the latest shape of it." She unclenched her hand and laid the stylus down straight, parallel with the table's edge, the small act of order with which she ended every crisis. "Now. The evening meal. Tyche's singing tonight, and we will all look as though nothing on earth could disturb us, because the street pays for the story of this house, and the story tonight is calm."

The calm was deliberate and visible. Antonia changed into the blue stola, had her hair redone, and ordered the best Falernian opened for the women's own table rather than the clients', and the household understood the message without

needing it explained: fear that changed no routine was fear that had been beaten. When Tyche sang, the shutters stood open onto the lane, and the song carried to the fountain where the street's ears were paid to listen; the music said, more clearly than any denial, that whatever had walked through the gilded door that afternoon, it had not walked back out with anything worth having.

Festus changed the strong-room lock himself after dark, working by lamplight with the new inner bolt laid ready, and dropped the old lock into the well of the impluvium, where it joined the small archaeological record of the house's retired defences. “New teeth,” he said to Chloe, testing the bolt. “Let the next man bring better tools.”

⁂

Tyche came to her before the evening meal, in the small court where the jasmine grew, and the girl's hands were twisting a corner of her mantle into a rope.

“Domina. Something happened at the market. I should have told you sooner; I didn't know if it mattered.”

“Everything matters. Sit. Start at the beginning.”

“A man. Twice now, by the cloth stalls. Not young, not old, very polite. He asks after me — my name, where I'm from, whether I'm happy in the house. Yesterday he gave me this.” She opened

her hand: a small silver brooch, cheap but new, in the shape of a dove. “He said a friend of his admired me, and if ever I wanted to leave the house, the friend would pay for a room of my own and a servant. He said I was too fine to belong to a freedwoman.” Tyche's voice trembled. “I didn't take it. Well — I took it, but only to be polite, and I haven't worn it. Domina, I'm not disloyal. I swear it by the house gods.”

Antonia took the brooch and turned it in her fingers. The silver was thin, the workmanship Subura, and the dove's eye was a chip of glass. Nothing about it was dangerous, which was precisely what made it dangerous: a gift small enough to accept, a promise large enough to dream about.

“Listen carefully. The man is Perperna's, or he works for someone who works for Perperna; the style is his. Nothing you've done is wrong — they approached you, not the other way round, and you told me, which is the one thing they can't survive. Here's what you'll do.” She set the brooch on the stone bench between them. “At the next market, be friendly. Tell him you're frightened of me, which he'll want to believe. Take a second gift if he offers one. Report every word, exactly, to me and no one else. You're not betraying him and you're not betraying me; you're letting two proud people spend their money while you keep your hands clean. Can you do that?”

Tyche stared. “You want me to pretend?”

“I want you to survive, and I want his letters. Rome is full of women who became powerful by being underestimated, and he has just made the classic mistake of believing a lyre player has no mind.” Antonia softened. “But if it frightens you, say so, and Festus walks you to the market from now on and the man gets nothing. The choice is yours. Always, in this house, the choice is yours.”

The girl sat a moment, turning it over. Then she picked up the brooch and pinned it inside her mantle, hidden against her breast. “I'll do it. For Hector. He was kind to me once, when I first came. Nobody remembers that, but I do.”

When she had gone, Antonia sat on with the jasmine smell and the fountain sound, and made a mark in her mental ledger: Tyche, courage untested until now, testing well. It was the kind of small, private accounting on which empires, and houses, ultimately stood.

They gathered after dark in the strong room: Antonia, Chloe, Phyllis, Festus, the door bolted and a trusted slave outside it. The tablets lay on the table among the silver, and a lamp hung from a chain above them, and the four faces around the light looked, Antonia thought, like the faces of a council of war, which was exactly what they were.

“He knows about the postern and the room,” she said. “That means his people have watched the house from inside the street, or someone inside ours talked. The bargeman, the suppliers, the night soil cart — Festus, every person who

crosses our threshold gets a name, a sponsor, and a reason. No exceptions."

"Already started." Festus's jaw worked. "Vitalis, the carpenter, is fitting new bars to every upper window tonight, iron this time, set from inside. And I want two more men for the night watch. I know three ex-gladiators from the old school; they're loyal because I am, and they're cheap because nobody else will employ men with their records."

"Hire them. Cost doesn't enter it."

Chloe looked up from the tablets. "He called us a stage. He's right, and it's our weakness and our weapon both. If the house can be watched, it can also perform. Whatever he expects us to do, we do the opposite, loudly, while the real work happens where he isn't looking."

"Which is why the tablets stay here and the copies go somewhere else." Antonia unrolled a fresh parchment. "Chloe, your copy goes to Hilarus's Ostia office, sealed in his accounts. Phyllis, I want a second copy in the temple of Isis, with the priestess, among the votive records. A goddess makes a better strongbox than a banker; even Perperna hesitates before sacrilege, if only because it's bad for business."

Chloe drew the tablets toward her and spread the parchment copies beside them, the way a surgeon lays out instruments.

"Look here. My brother's private marks — he put a tiny theta beside every entry he'd verified

against an Ostia weight note. The thetas run for the first six months. Then they stop. From March onward, the tallies are clean copy work, no verification at all. That's when they brought him onto the board properly; that's when he stopped being allowed near the grain." Her finger moved down. "And here, every fourth shipment, the same ninety modii. A signature, as you said. Whoever runs the machine is vain enough to keep a rhythm. Men who keep rhythms keep habits, and habits are how they're caught."

"Can you reconstruct the money?" Antonia asked.

"Given time. The loan side's the cleaner half." Chloe turned a tablet. "Perperna lends to the subscribers at twenty-four per cent, more than twice a respectable rate, which means the subscribers were already desperate when he found them. Desperate men don't conspire; they're herded. The conspiracy is one man's, and the rest are cattle with signet rings."

Festus, who had been following with the strained attention of a man for whom columns were a foreign country, said, "So why not just kill Perperna? Men like him get knifed in alleys. I know men."

"Because a dead Perperna makes a martyr and leaves the contracts standing," Antonia said. "We don't want his corpse. We want his paper, in a court, under the right magistrate, with the

emperor's prefect watching. The knife is the last argument; we're still using the first ones.”

Phyllis nodded, but she did not write anything down, and after a moment she said the thing that had been waiting in the room.

“He means to break you the way they break every woman who stands alone. First the paper, then the fear, then — when the women start leaving because they're frightened — the house falls by itself. I've seen it. I saw it begin, once, a long time ago.”

No one spoke. The lamp flickered.

“Tell them,” Antonia said. “All of it. They deserve to know whose house they're standing in.”

Phyllis folded her hands. She was old, and her voice had the steadiness of water running along a course it had worn for years.

“I was there. In the Aelius kitchen, the year the young master went to Germany. Our Antonia was seventeen then, called Anthe, house-born, her mother dead, the quickest girl I ever raised. The young master taught her letters and fell in love with her, which is the oldest story in the world, and she loved him back, which is the part the world never forgives. She was carrying his child when he marched north. The elder mistress found out at the wash tubs. I remember it like yesterday; I can hear her voice. She didn't shout. The dangerous ones never do.”

“She sent for Dromo the steward,” Phyllis went on. “The master wouldn't see the girl; gentlemen leave these things to their stewards. Dromo sold her to Dinis the dealer, nine hundred and forty sesterces, money down. I was in the colonnade when they took her out by the service gate. She didn't scream. She asked, very politely, whether a letter could be sent to the young master, and Dromo said the family would decide what letters were sent. That was the last I saw of her for eleven years.”

Chloe's eyes were on Antonia's face. Festus had gone very still.

“The dealer sold me to a house in the Subura,” Antonia said. Her voice was flat, a voice reading a document. “I'll spare you the interior; you've all seen enough of the world to imagine it, and your imaginations will be kinder than the truth. I worked there four years. The child came early, a girl, small and dead, and I nearly followed her. When I came up from the fever, I was worth less, and cheap women in cheap houses get sold on. I was bought by a courtesan called Antonia Cassia Prima, who had grown too old to do the work and too clever ever to have enjoyed it. She taught me everything this house knows — how to read a man, how to keep accounts, how to make desire wait while money changed hands. She freed me in her will and left me her name and a little house with six couches. I've spent eleven years turning it into the door Perperna wants. That's the whole

story. There's no more to tell, and no one in this room is ever to speak of it outside it.”

No one spoke for a while. The lamp made the silver glow.

“I'll tell you one thing more, since we're being truthful in a locked room,” Antonia said. “The four years in the Subura taught me every lesson I've ever needed, and none of them was the lesson they intended. I learned that a woman without a man's protection is treated as prey by precisely the men who claim to protect women. I learned that the law is a language, and that people who speak it fluently can do almost anything to people who can't. And I learned that the body is a room other people believe they own, and that the whole work of a life is getting the keys back. Prima gave me the keys. Everything I've built is a house with bolts on the inside, and I will burn it to the ground before I hand a single bolt to Sextus Perperna.”

Festus nodded slowly. Chloe's eyes were bright, Phyllis's wet, and none of them said anything, because there was nothing to add, and the silence itself was a kind of oath.

“Right,” Antonia said after a moment, in her ordinary voice. “Back to the tablets. We've mourned enough for one evening; the dead don't pay the guards.”

“The letters,” Phyllis said. “The ones from Germany. Three came, with money. The mistress sent them back unopened. He never knew. She never knew he'd written. That's the part I carry.”

“It explains the man at the supper,” Chloe said slowly. “He didn't know.”

“No.” Antonia's mouth tightened. “He believed I walked away free and happy and never looked back, while I believed he let his family sell me without a word. Two stories, one lie, and the people who built it are all safely dead, which is very convenient for everyone except us.”

Festus, who had been silent throughout, said in his slow, deep voice, “What do you want done about him, then? The senator. I've seen how you look when his name's mentioned. I've also seen how he looked at you at the door, that night. A man doesn't look like that at a stranger.”

“What I want is irrelevant.” She bound the tablets with their thongs, one loop, two loops, precise. “What matters is that his name is on Perperna's paper and his brother's neck is in the noose, and the only honest auditor in Rome is the only man who can make a court believe these accounts. I don't have to forgive him. I have to use him. There's a difference, and the difference has made me rich.”

⁂

Sabina found her alone later, in the garden, feeding the fish.

The girl had been in the house nine days, and the change in her was visible already: she walked more steadily, she kept her hands still, she had

learned to say “I'll consider it” instead of “yes.” She carried her slate now like a shield, and she held it out with the first line of her first full sentence written on it, the letters careful and even.

The house is strong because the women are strong.

“One spelling mistake,” Antonia said. “And a split infinitive, which is forgivable in a beginner and unforgivable in a poet. Otherwise good. Who gave you the sentence?”

“Chloe. She said it was the house's motto, unofficially.” Sabina sat on the bench's far end, the careful space they had both learned to maintain. “Domina. The man who came today. The one Festus wouldn't let me serve. The girls say he's the reason the magistrate wants me. Is he going to take me?”

“No.”

“They said that in the village, too. ‘No one's going to take you,' the night before they came.”

Antonia turned to look at her. The fear in the wide, plain face was controlled now, managed rather than mastered, and she recognized in it the same thing she had built her own life out of: the refusal to be taken twice by the same terror.

“Listen to me, Sabina, and remember this as the second rule. The first was that no one touches you in this house against your will. The second is that no one leaves this house against their will while I have breath or money. Your debt paper is

in my strong room, your contract is lawful, and if a magistrate orders otherwise in open court, I will spend every sesterce I own appealing it into the next emperor's reign. Perperna wants you because you're a wedge. He thinks if he can crack the door over one girl, the whole house splits. He's wrong, because the door isn't wood. It's me." She tossed the last of the fish food into the impluvium. "Now go and correct the spelling."

Sabina went, and Antonia stood listening to the household settle for the night — music practice from the east wing, Vitalis's hammering at the new bars, the fountain, the distant street cries — and felt, beneath her composure, the slow, cold exhilaration of a woman who has been cornered and has decided to turn and fight.

It was at that moment that Festus brought the second message of the day, this one on good parchment, sealed with a senator's ring.

She broke it. The hand was formal, the words few.

I have received your letter, if the letter was yours. I require an hour of private conversation, on any ground you name, with witnesses of your choosing. I will come unarmed and alone, at any hour. The matter concerns the accounts, my brother, and a name I may have worn without deserving. — M. Aelius Severus.

She read it twice, as he had read hers, and smiled without humour.

“Send back word,” she said. “He will attend the races at the Circus Maximus on the day of the Saturnalian heats, as all Rome will. He may speak to me there, in public, where neither of us can be murdered for it. And Festus — make sure the word reaches Perperna's ears that the consul-designate and I have become sudden, visible friends. A friendship conducted in the open is the one kind he can't turn into a scandal.”

Festus grinned, the scar whitening. “You're going to make him dance.”

“I'm going to make us all dance,” Antonia said. “The trick is choosing the music.”

Phyllis, who had come in with the evening wine, waited until Festus had gone, and said, “You're careful with everyone else. Be careful with yourself where that man's concerned.”

“You mean Marcus.”

“I mean both of you, and the space between, which is the dangerous part. I've watched you carry that wooden disc for fifteen years. A woman doesn't keep a thing like that unless some part of her is still seventeen.” Phyllis set the wine down. “He may be everything you're hoping, now that he knows the lie. Or he may be a senator first and a man second, because that's what they make them into. Either way, don't give him the tablets until he's given you something that costs him. Proof isn't paper, Antonia. Proof is what a man loses by telling the truth.”

“Spoken like a woman who has survived the entire Julio-Claudian dynasty.”

“I survived worse than emperors. I survived being owned by people who thought they were kind.” Phyllis paused at the door. “The races will be loud, and crowded, and full of eyes. Good. Eyes keep men honest, at least while they're watching. Afterward is when you'll need your wits.”

When she was alone, Antonia poured the wine but did not drink it, and sat looking out through the colonnade at the garden's dark shapes. Somewhere beyond the rooftops lay the Esquiline, and the house of the Aelii, and a man reading her message with the same careful attention she was reading his. Fifteen years of silence, and now letters, and races, and a war of paper. She thought of the girl on the bench and the woman in the strong room and the child who had died in a dealer's house before she had drawn a proper breath, and she lifted the cup to each of them in turn, without drinking, and then she set it down and went to bed, because tomorrow's work required a clear head and Rome, as ever, would not wait.

Before she slept, she unlocked the cedar box, took out the chipped wooden disc, and placed it, wrapped in its old cloth, in the strong room drawer beneath the tablets — not because she had decided anything, but because she had learned that moving a thing was often the first step to deciding what it meant.

PART II

DEBTS

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Circus

The Saturnalian heats began at dawn, and by the fourth hour the Circus Maximus held a quarter of a million people, which was approximately a quarter of a million more than any structure had any sane reason to contain.

Antonia's party arrived in litters through the merchants' gate, Hilarus having hired one of the better wooden boxes above the turning posts, where the shade held until noon and the wine could be kept cool in snow. There were six of them: Antonia and Chloe, Hilarus and his wife Porcia, Festus in a clean tunic that made him look like an unhappy mountain, and Sabina, who had never seen the races and was doing her disciplined best not to gape, and failing endearingly at every turn.

“Breathe,” Antonia said as they climbed the wooden stairs. “You look like a girl being led to sacrifice.”

“I feel like one. Domina, there are *people everywhere*. Where do they all sleep?”

“Badly, on top of one another, which is why they scream so loudly here; the Circus is Rome's

only room with space in it.” She handed the tickets to the attendant and stepped into the box, and the full roar of the place hit her like a warm wave: the long oval of sand, the spina with its obelisks and statues, the coloured cushions of the senatorial seats opposite, the flags of the four factions snapping in the wind — Reds, Whites, Blues, Greens — and above it all the baking white sky and the smell of two hundred and fifty thousand sweating bodies eating sausages.

Porcia, a stout, shrewd woman who had sold oil with her husband before either of them could afford litters, laughed at Sabina's face. “First time? Mine too, four years ago. I cried. The noise, you know. Then someone won me ten sesterces and I've come every race since. Sit by me, child; I'll explain the criminals.”

She explained them with the precision of a woman who had made her own money. The four factions were not merely racing colours; they were companies, with investors, stables, spies, and the loyalty of neighbourhoods that had nothing else to be loyal to. The Blues drew the merchants and the ship owners, the Greens the market traders and most of the Subura, the Reds the old families who did things because their grandfathers had, and the Whites whoever was winning. Drivers were slaves or freedmen, adored like gods and buried like boys if they misjudged a turn, and the fastest of them earned sums that made senators' wives bitter.

“It's the one place in Rome the rich and the poor scream the same scream,” Hilarus said, handing round the dates. “An emperor ignores the Circus at his peril. The bread keeps them alive; this keeps them governable.”

“And the betting?” Chloe asked.

“The betting keeps them poor, which keeps them governable too.” He winked. “I own a share in two Blues. Don't tell the customers; they think I'm neutral.”

Sabina drank it in, the factions and the flags and the vast democratic roar, and Antonia watched her relax by degrees, the way a stray animal relaxes when it discovers the warmth is genuine. It struck her, not for the first time, that the house's deepest work had nothing to do with men and everything to do with this: the slow rebuilding of a person's expectation of safety.

The first heats were already running. Seven laps per race, eggs dropped from a frame to count them down, the chariots tearing around the spina at speeds that looked impossible and often were, the crowd rising as one at every turn. Sabina was on her feet by the second lap, shouting with the rest, her reserve gone, and even Festus permitted himself a low rumble of appreciation when a Blue driver took the inside post with a hand's width to spare.

“Your man's late,” Hilarus murmured, leaning over the rail with his dates.

“He isn't my man, and he won't be late; senators arrive after the consul's procession so that the crowd can see them arrive.” Antonia did not look toward the senatorial seats. “There. Watch the opposite rail.”

The consular procession was making its slow way along the front row: lictors with their fasces, the magistrates in purple-bordered togas, the senators in their brilliant white, and among them Marcus Aelius Severus, walking with his son beside him, his head held in that unmistakeable profile. The crowd recognized the name; there was a small, warm round of applause from the middle seats, the applause Rome gave to men it believed honest, whether or not it intended to keep them so.

Beside him, Gaius was looking everywhere at once, in the transports of a boy at his first Saturnalian heats. Behind them, in the matrons' section, Antonia caught a glimpse of Livia Marcella, erect and elegant in dark red, acknowledging greetings with the minimum movement required.

“Wife's here,” Chloe said softly, at her elbow.

“I can see that. Wives attend races; it's one of the few outings permitted them, which is why they dress for it as though for battle.” Antonia lifted her cup. “Relax, all of you. We're simply respectable people at the games. Respectability is a costume like any other; wear it lightly.”

⁂

On the senatorial benches, Marcus was having a worse morning than he had expected.

Livia had chosen the races with the same care she gave all public appearances, and she sat now among the consular wives in the section reserved for rank, receiving greetings, commenting on the teams, performing the ancient, exhausting office of being a great man's wife. Gaius was beside himself with delight, and Vibia, who had been brought along under protest, was asleep against her nurse's shoulder before the third heat.

Marcus had come intending to watch the horses; instead he watched the men, because the Circus Maximus was the one place in Rome where every rank sat in the same roar, and a senator could observe without being observed observing. Below the senatorial benches the equestrian rows curved away in a sweep of good wool and careful grooming, and there, three sections down, he saw the plain dark tunic and the kindly, attentive face: Sextus Perperna, not among the equestrians of his own rank but seated one row behind them, in the cheaper seats, where he could watch the backs of the richer men's necks. He was not watching the races at all. He was making his harvest of the crowd, noting who greeted whom, which wives arrived with which escorts, which young men drank too deeply before noon; a delator at the

games, Marcus realized, was a fisherman at a weir, and the Circus had been built for him.

Beside Perperna sat a younger man, expensively dressed, who talked with animation while the informer listened, and Marcus had Stichus identify him between heats: one Aquilius, an orator of the smaller courts, golden-voiced and expensive, whose practice ran to prosecutions bought by men who preferred not to show their own faces. The name went into Marcus's mental tablets beside the face, because the company a man kept at the races was the company he intended to use in the Forum.

Between the sixth and seventh heats, the crowd surged for the refreshment sellers, and Marcus found himself shoulder to shoulder at a wine stall with Cossus, the grain contractor, red-faced and garlanded and full of his own importance.

“Severus! The auditor himself. Come to see how Rome enjoys the money you're forever counting?” Cossus laughed at his own wit and waved a sausage. “You want a word of advice, man to man? Leave the annona contracts alone. There's a fellowship in the supply trade; we look after our own, and the bureau looks after us. A man can audit himself into a very quiet retirement if he doesn't understand the difference between what's written and what's done.”

“I've never been good at hearing that difference,” Marcus said. “My defect.”

“Defect?” Cossus grinned, but his eyes were small and assessing. “Call it what you like. The horses lose sometimes too, Senator, even the favourites. That's why they run the races.” He clapped Marcus's arm and moved off into the crowd, and Marcus stood with his weak wine and watched him go, and thought that threats at the Circus were the only kind Roman men made without lowering their voices, because the roar of two hundred thousand witnesses swallowed every word.

He looked across the great curved space, past the spina and its obelisk, to where the women's benches rose in their bright mosaic of parasols and veils, and found the dark, unadorned figure he was looking for, seated among the entertainers' section as though she belonged nowhere and everywhere. She was watching the track, or appearing to; and when the next heat burst from the starting gates and the whole Circus rose shouting around her, Antonia alone remained seated, turning her head slowly across the equestrian rows with the same fisherman's patience he had just recognized in Perperna. Two people, Marcus thought, hunting the same river from opposite banks; and somewhere between them, in the roaring sun, swam the truth about the grain.

“You've been watching the hired boxes more than the sand,” Livia observed, without taking her eyes off the teams.

“I've been watching the crowd. A senator should know his city.”

“A senator's wife knows he isn't watching the crowd when his eyes go to the same box every heat.” Her voice stayed light, perfectly social. “The Porcius box, isn't it? Hilarus the oil man. And his guest of honour. She does make an entrance; I'll give her that.”

Marcus said nothing. There was, he had learned, no answer to Livia in these moods that did not cost more than the silence.

“Go and speak to her, if you mean to,” she said. “Here, in daylight, with your son, it is merely politics. If you don't go, you'll think about it all afternoon, and I'd rather have your attention for the dinner with the prefect. Take Gaius; he needs the sausage stall, and the boy makes you respectable.”

He looked at her then, and she turned her face to him, and in it there was neither anger nor pleading, only the clear, weary intelligence of a woman who had made her peace with a disappointing marriage and refused to be made a fool of in public.

“You're remarkable,” he said.

“I'm practical. Remarkable women are burned as witches; practical women run Rome.” She waved a hand. “Go. And Marcus — whatever this is, remember the consulship. We have all spent too many years on it to waste them in a hired box.”

He took Gaius, and he went.

He came at the seventh heat, during the interval, when the crowd was occupied with food and a troupe of acrobats on the sand. Marcus crossed the long front promenade with Gaius, stopped to greet two senators, and then, with the unhurried certainty of a man who had known exactly where the box was since he entered the building, climbed the wooden stair and presented himself at its rail.

“Domina Antonia.” His voice was formal, pitched for the attendants. “A fine day for the Blues, though I'm told the Reds have a new driver from Africa. May I present my son, Gaius. Gaius, this is Antonia Cassia, whose hospitality your uncle enjoys so much.”

The boy bowed, correctly, and then looked up with the directness that the children of great houses either learned early or never learned. “You're the lady from the house in the Carinae. The one Quintus's father talks about.”

“Gaius,” Marcus said, in the voice he used for senatorial interruptions.

“It's quite all right; Quintus's father talks about a great many things, and few of them accurately.” Antonia smiled at the boy, the smile she kept for the young and the unarmoured. “Are you enjoying the races, Gaius?”

“Very much, domina. My father prefers the gladiators, because they're more serious, but I

like the horses. They don't know about politics, so they run for their own reasons."

"A philosopher already," said Chloe. "Rome is doomed."

Marcus's eyes moved to her, and Antonia made the introductions: "Chloe, of my household. Lucius Porcius Hilarus and his wife Porcia, whose box this is."

The two men measured one another — the senator and the freedman merchant — and then Marcus bowed slightly, correctly, and Hilarus bowed back, and Antonia watched the old Roman machinery of rank groan and adjust and, because it was a public day at the games and rudeness would be observed, settle into a temporary truce.

"Your servant, Hilarus. I believe your oil contracts cross the annona offices; perhaps we'll speak of grain one day."

"My door's always open, Senator. In my trade, a man's only as honest as his accounts, and mine are beautifully kept."

Marcus gave the small nod that passed, in him, for amusement, and then he said the thing he had come to say, still in the public voice, still with the attendants listening: "Domina, the interval runs a half hour. My son has been begging for the sausage stalls at the upper level. Would you and your friend walk with us? The view of the spina is better from the promenade, and I've a question about a Greek poet your singer is said to perform."

It was flawless: an outing, a chaperone, a literary excuse, the boy as witness. Antonia rose. “Chloe, keep Sabina out of the betting ring; she has the face of a girl about to lose her savings. Hilarus, hold the box. We'll take the air.”

They walked out into the promenade, four of them, Gaius ten paces ahead pretending not to be a chaperone, the crowd swirling past in a river of colour and noise, and for the first few moments they said nothing of substance, because there was no substance that could be said in such a river, and Marcus used the time to look at her properly, in daylight, the way he had not been able to across a lamplit supper room.

“You're older,” he said, low.

“Everyone is. It's the one reliable Roman institution.”

“You look well. More than well.”

“I am well. Wealth agrees with me; I recommend it.” She kept her face toward the sand. “Your letter was bold. A married consul-designate requesting an assignation.”

“It wasn't an assignation, and you know it. I need to know whether the unsigned letter was yours. The one about the witness line.”

“It was.”

He was quiet a moment, turning that over. “Then you know more about my brother's loans than I do. My own signature appears on Perperna's paper, and I have no memory of writing it. Explain that to me, if you can.”

“Easily, and without magic. At the contracts you witnessed as a family favour, did Celer present you with a single document, or a bundle?”

Marcus stopped. “A bundle. Three tablets, I think, sealed; he said the witnesses signed across the thongs, as usual, and I—”

“And you signed across the thongs without reading what lay beneath them, because he's your brother and the seals looked correct. Senators do it daily; it's how half the frauds in Rome are built. Your name witnessed a loan you never saw, at twenty-four per cent, to finance subscriptions that don't exist except as figures. You're not a villain, Marcus. You're a convenience.”

The noise of the Circus filled the space between them. Somewhere below, a roar went up as a chariot nearly overturned and saved it.

“I deserve that,” he said.

“You deserve a great deal more than that, but we're in public.” She glanced at him, and for one instant the mask slipped and he saw the seventeen-year-old in the woman, quick and fierce and wounded. “The point is that you're inside the trap whether you're guilty or not. Perperna doesn't require your guilt. He requires your silence, which your brother's shame will buy for him. The audit only works if you're free to name names. You're not free, because your own name is in the ledger.”

“Then what do you propose?”

“That you stop being an auditor and become a partner. Not mine — the truth's. There are documents. Real ones, duplicates of the board's tallies, kept by the clerk they've since murdered. I hold them. In return for what I know, I need your name where it matters: in a court, before a magistrate who can't be bought, with the prefect's office watching. And I need your brother kept breathing and in Rome, because a dead debtor closes the case and an exiled one takes the evidence with him.”

Gaius had turned at the sausage stall and was waving, holding up two enormous sausages like trophies. Marcus raised a hand in answer, and his face, Antonia saw, was the face of a man revising every map he owned.

“Give me a day,” he said. “I'll examine my own records. If what you say is true—”

“It is. Check the date of the witness signature against your diary of public appearances. You were dedicating a temple at Praeneste that morning. A man cannot witness a signing he wasn't in Rome for. They used your seal, not your hand. Ask Stichus; he keeps your diary.”

He looked at her then, fully, and the crowd might as well not have existed. “Why are you doing this? You could sell those tablets to Perperna for a fortune, or use them to blackmail half the Senate. Why hand me the means to prosecute?”

“Because the clerk who kept them was my friend's brother, and the Tiber is teaching Rome a lesson I refuse to learn. And because—” She stopped herself, chose again. “Because a city where men like Perperna buy houses with the proceeds of corpses is a city where my house doesn't survive either. Self-interest, Senator. I'm a very respectable woman.”

⁂

The crash came in the eleventh heat, and it came as catastrophes usually do in Rome: suddenly, completely, and in front of the largest available audience.

The African driver for the Reds took the turn too wide under pressure from the Blue, his wheel caught the stone base of the spina, and the chariot came apart in a long, tumbling explosion of timber and horses. The tangled team dragged across the path of the next two chariots, and within seconds the sand held a heap of screaming animals, splintered wood, and men, while above the crash the vast crowd surged to its feet with the sound of a single animal drawing breath.

The wooden barrier below the front boxes, old and half-rotted as half of Rome's public woodwork was, chose that moment to give way. A twenty-foot section dropped inward, and the spectators behind it spilled forward in a wave of

tunics and cushions, and the wave hit the lower promenade where the four of them were standing.

Marcus moved before he thought. He had Gaius by the back of the tunic in one motion, lifting the boy off his feet and driving him backward against a pillar; his other arm caught the woman beside him — a stranger, a merchant's wife with two small children — and hauled her clear of the falling rail. Across the promenade, Antonia was knocked off balance by a fat man in a green cap, and would have gone down under the press if Festus had not materialized through the crowd like a ship through surf, one vast arm around her, another scooping up a fallen child. Chloe had Sabina by the wrist and her back against a wall, her eyes hard and clear.

“Hold still!” Marcus shouted over the screaming. “Hold the pillar — *hold it* — don't run, the crush is behind you!”

It lasted perhaps five minutes. The vigiles and the stable hands waded in with staves, the injured were pulled clear of the broken barrier, the horses on the sand were cut loose or dispatched where they lay, and order returned the way it always returned in Rome: noisily, partially, and because enough disciplined men did their jobs.

When Antonia could breathe again, she found herself pressed close against the pillar beside Marcus, Gaius white and gripping his father's hand, the air thick with dust and the smell of frightened people.

“Everyone whole?” Marcus said, and his voice was steady, the officer's voice, and she understood suddenly how he had commanded men on the frontier.

“Hilarus's party is fine; Festus doesn't permit injury.” She looked down; the child Festus had saved was wailing in its mother's arms, unhurt. “You move quickly for a senator.”

“Germany. A winter of collapsing things. You don't survive it by standing still.” He released the merchant's wife to her husband, and then, in the dust and the noise, with the crowd still pressing around them, he did something uncharacteristic: he put his hand briefly over Antonia's where it gripped the pillar, not a caress, merely a steadiness, and said, low, “Are you hurt?”

The touch lasted two heartbeats. His hand was warm and calloused in the particular place a sword hilt makes. Fifteen years dissolved in the dust of the Circus, and she was back in the villa kitchen, and the hand over hers was the same hand, and the eyes were the same eyes, and she had to make a deliberate effort to remember that she was thirty-four years old and owned a bank.

“No,” she said. “I'm not hurt.”

He took his hand away. Neither of them pretended it had meant nothing.

A woman's scream from the broken barrier saved either of them from having to speak. A carter lay with a broken leg where the rail had fallen, white-faced and biting his belt, and the

crowd was flowing around him the way a river flows around a stone. Marcus was already moving; after a moment's hesitation Antonia followed, and watched him take charge without raising his voice — sending Gaius for the vigiles' stretcher party, ordering the gawkers back with the flat authority of a magistrate, kneeling in the dust to set the man's leg against a board with the competent hands of an officer who had done such things in field hospitals. The carter, who had expected to be robbed where he lay, stared at the consul-designate binding his shin with strips of the man's own tunic.

“Why?” he kept saying. “Why, master?”

“Because Rome doesn't leave its people in the dust,” Marcus said, and Antonia, standing behind him, heard the words and could not tell whether he believed them or was merely determined to make them true, which she suspected was the only honest kind of goodness available to a Roman.

When the stretcher party came, he stood and brushed the dust from his toga, and they walked back through the crowd together, and for a while neither spoke.

“You're different from the men in my house,” she said at last.

“The men in your house are mostly trying to be someone. I've spent my life trying to be worthy of someone who's dead. My father. It's a different cage.”

“Is it? Cages are cages.”

“Then tell me how to open this one.” He stopped in the lee of a pillar, away from the stream of people, and his face in the slant light was tired and honest. “I've been to Tibur. I've read the sale entry. Nine hundred and forty sesterces. My mother's hand beside it. I've spent fifteen years believing you walked away with manumission silver. My father told me that, and I let him, because it was easier. I'm not asking you to forgive me; I've no right to it and you've no reason. I'm asking you to believe that I didn't know.”

She looked at him for a long time, and the Circus roared around them like the sea around a lighthouse.

“I believe you,” she said finally. “I checked; I have my own ways, and they all say the same thing. You were in Germany, and the letters came back unopened, and they lied to us both. Believing you didn't know is easy, Marcus. What I don't know is whether it changes anything. Knowing the truth costs a man like you something. I haven't seen the price yet.”

“Name it.”

“It names itself. At the temple, when you see the tablets.” She stepped back into the crowd's flow. “Until then, keep your brother close and your seal closer. Whoever used it once will use it again.”

⁂

They found Hilarus's box again during the lull, and it was Chloe, with the singer's gift for seeing the whole room, who leaned close and murmured, “Don't turn around yet. Two boxes to the right, the narrow one with the plain awning. Perperna's man — I've seen him at the market, the one who courts Tyche. And he's not watching the races.”

Antonia did not turn. “Hilarus. The box with the plain awning. Whose is it?”

Hilarus squinted across the way. “Rented, I'd say, by the day. The man in it I don't know. The older one behind him — yes, I do. That's one of Perperna's clerks. They're here for somebody, and it isn't the horses.”

“They're here for us,” Antonia said. “For the meeting. He wanted to know whether I'd take the auditor's hand, and now he knows.” She drank wine, her composure restored. “Good. Let him carry home the news that the whore and the censor are friends. A scandal he can't prove is worth less than a partnership he can't break.”

Marcus, who had followed the exchange, said, “He'll move faster now.”

“Then so shall we. The day after tomorrow, at the temple of Isis near the Esquiline gate, in the afternoon; the priestess owes me a favour and the precinct is neutral ground. Bring your diary and your witness's eye. I'll bring the truth.” She met his gaze levelly. “And Marcus — bring no one who

answers to your brother. Not even family. Especially not family.”

He nodded once, gravely, and went back to his own seats with Gaius, and Antonia watched him cross the promenade through the thinning crowd, and beside her Chloe said very quietly, “His hand on yours. I saw.”

“It was the crush.”

“It was the crush. Of course. And I'm a vestal virgin.” Chloe ate an olive. “Just remember what Phyllis said. Proof is what a man loses by telling the truth. Watch what he loses at the temple, not what he says.”

The final heat ran in the lengthening afternoon, the Blues winning by a wheel, and the quarter-million poured out into the streets in a river of noise and colour, and somewhere in the narrow box with the plain awning a clerk made his careful note and slipped away through the crowd, and Rome, which had seen everything and forgotten nothing, rolled on toward another evening.

That night the house held its own council in the garden court, with the lamps floating in the fountain and the night watch doubled at the door.

Hilarus went first, counting on his fingers. “Perperna's clerk saw the meeting, so by tomorrow morning he'll know the auditor isn't isolated. That forces his hand; a man with a schedule moves faster when the schedule's threatened. Expect something before the temple

meeting — a legal move, a bribe, or a fright. He likes fright; it's cheap."

"Then we make sure the fright lands where it costs him nothing to give it," Antonia said. "Tyche's market man comes back to her tomorrow, Festus following two streets behind. If he offers money, she takes it. If he offers threats, she remembers every word. Chloe, the temple precinct arrangements: speak to the priestess tonight, and make sure the side entrance is open. I'll not be followed into the presence of a goddess by Perperna's clerk."

Sabina, who had been silent through the council, spoke up into the pause. "Domina. At the races, when the barrier fell — everyone pushed, and I thought I was going to die, and nobody in the crowd cared at all. And then Festus picked up a child like it weighed nothing, and the senator held up a whole family, and — and nobody paid them for it." She frowned, working it out. "Why did they do it?"

"Because there are two Romes, Sabina." Antonia chose the words carefully. "The one that pushes, and the one that holds. You've met mostly the first one. Don't let it make you doubt the second exists; just never assume it will arrive in time."

On the Esquiline, Marcus reached home before the evening meal and went straight to his tablinum, where Stichus kept the master's diary of public appearances — a meticulous document,

begun in the year of his quaestorship, recording where every day had been spent and who had witnessed it. He found the entry without difficulty, in Stichus's beautiful hand.

The third day before the nones of March: dedication of the restored temple of Hercules at Praeneste; present the praetor, the town council, the contractor Cornelius; slept at Praeneste.

He sat with it a long time.

"Stichus."

The nomenclator appeared. "Master?"

"Do you remember this day? The Praeneste dedication. We were gone two nights."

"I remember it well, master. The road was flooded; we nearly lost the luggage mule. You delivered the dedication speech in the rain."

"And Celer remained in Rome."

"He did. He said his knee troubled him." Stichus permitted himself the smallest pause. "Is something wrong, master?"

"Nothing you've done. Something that was done in my name while I was in the rain at Praeneste." He closed the diary. "Bring me the family seal ring from the strong room. And don't mention this to anyone. Not my wife, not my brother, especially not my brother."

When the ring lay in his palm, he turned it slowly, examining the intaglio of his ancestors' device, and thought of his brother's charming smile and the borrowed fifteen thousand and a signature that had never happened. The seal was

kept in the strong room, to which Celer had access as family. It would have taken the steward ten minutes and a pot of wax.

He wrote no letter tonight. Instead he sat late, reading the audit tablets he had brought from the treasury, the columns of grain and gold, and for the first time he read them not as an official reviewing figures but as a man reading the map of an ambush, and by midnight he had begun to see, between the neat lines, the shape of the machine that meant to swallow his family and his name together.

In the litter going home from the races, Sabina fell asleep against Porcia's shoulder with the taste of her first sausage on her lips and ten sesterces of winnings tied in her belt, and Antonia sat awake in the dark, and did not look at her own hand, which still remembered the weight and warmth of his.

CHAPTER EIGHT

A Father at the Door

Quintus Avianius came to the postern at the ninth hour of the morning, and Festus, who had been a slave and a gladiator and therefore knew every species of desperate man, recognized the species before the man spoke: the smallholder at the end of his resources, washed and combed for the city, his one good tunic belted tight against the loss of weight, his farmer's hands hanging at his sides like tools he had forgotten how to use.

“I've no appointment,” he said. “I know I've no appointment. But I'll not go to the front door, not with what I am. Tell the domina it's Sabina's father. Tell her I won't stay past my welcome.”

Festus looked him over once, the slow professional glance, and said, “Wait in the passage. There's a bench. Don't touch the wall; it's wet paint.”

Antonia received him in the garden court, with Phyllis present as chaperone and a slave set to bring bread and wine, and she let the man stand until he had been given something to eat, because a starving man cannot negotiate and she needed him able to think. He took the bread with the

careful dignity of the proud poor, broke it, ate half, and stopped, saving the rest.

“For my wife,” he said, catching her look. “She's worse. The ague. We've a neighbour woman with her.”

“Say what you came to say, Avianius. Farmers don't walk four miles to Rome for the bread.”

He set down the cup. “A man came to the farm. Two days ago. Fine cloak, soft hands, a clerk with him. Said he represented a gentleman who took an interest in my case. He said my daughter was being held in your house against the law — that she was tricked, that the debt paper wasn't properly transferred, that a magistrate would give her back to me if I made a complaint in writing. He had the complaint already written. I was to sign it, in front of his witnesses, and my debt would be cancelled into the bargain. Three thousand sesterces gone, just like that, and my girl home.”

The court was quiet. The fountain spilled its water.

“Did he give a name?”

“No name. The gentleman was ‘a friend of the family.' But the clerk talked when the soft one was busy with the mule. He said something about a prosecutor. Per—Perperna.”

Antonia's face did not change. “And you came here instead of signing. Why?”

For the first time something like anger moved across the weathered face, the anger of a slow

man whose patience has been mistaken for stupidity. “Because I may be poor, domina, but I'm not a fool, and I've one thing left, which is my daughter's good opinion. I sold her once. I signed the paper that put her in chains because there was nothing else to do and her mother needed a doctor. I'll not sell her twice, with a lie, to men who'd drag her through a court and then sell her on to whatever they've got planned. Whatever this house is, the girl's own letters say no one's touched her and she's learning to read. My Sabina, reading.” His voice shook; he mastered it. “I came to ask your terms. The truth of them. Not his.”

Antonia regarded him. She had dealt with thousands of men in fifteen years — liars, lords, bankers, buyers of women — and the rare honest ones always cost her more, because they made her feel the things she had trained herself not to feel.

“My terms are these. The debt paper is mine, at four thousand. I'll tear it up today, in front of you and my household, and Vipsanius gets nothing further from you. The farm stays yours; I'll have Hilarus's factor advance seed money for the spring sowing, at no interest, against next harvest's oil, and you'll pay it in olives, not grief. In exchange, when Perperna's man comes again, you'll tell him you consulted your daughter and refuse to sign, and you'll note the day, the

witnesses, and every word, and bring them to me. Not to the courts. To me.”

He stared. “You'd cancel the debt. Just so.”

“Just so. I've made worse investments. An honest farmer who owes me a favour is worth four thousand in any market; Beryllus the banker will tell you the same, in better Latin.” She paused. “There's a second matter. Your daughter wants to stay. Not because she's held — the door has no bolt on her side, she could walk out with you this afternoon and no one would stop her — but because she wants the education. I'll keep her, clothed and fed and paid, and you may visit once a month, at this postern, and she may write to you weekly. At any point, if she changes her mind, she leaves, with the wages she's earned. Those are the terms. Take a day; discuss it with her.”

“Tell me about the farm,” Antonia said, before he could answer. “All of it. The land first, then the money.”

He told her in the careful way of men who work the land, beginning with the soil — fifteen iugera by the fourth milestone, vines on the south slope, olives along the boundary wall, the lower field given to wheat in rotation. Two bad grape harvests, the olive fly in the third, a mule gone lame, the wife's ague and the doctor's bills stacked behind it. He had borrowed against the next two harvests at twelve per cent a quarter, and the compounding had done what droughts

could not: turned a competent farmer into a debtor before he noticed the turning.

“Vipsanius didn't lend you money,” Antonia said. “He sold you a foreclosure in instalments. The interest is designed to outrun the harvest; men like him don't want repayment, they want the land. Your farm touches the road, doesn't it? Three hundred paces of road frontage.”

“It does.” He looked surprised. “How—”

“Because that's what it's always about in Rome. Ground. The debt was the method; the road frontage was the object. Someone wants your land for a depot or a tomb garden, and Vipsanius is the instrument.” She made a note. “Hilarus's factor will find out who. Meanwhile, no more signatures. Not for anyone, however kind, however clean the parchment looks. The literate classes rule the world with paper, Avianius; your protection is to make your mark nowhere except before my witnesses.”

“I don't need a day.” He rose, stiffly, and did the last thing she expected: he bowed to her, deeply, the bow of a client to a patron. “I'll take them now, and I'll bring the olive oil myself, and you can dock the jars until I'm square. Domina — they told me you were a whore. In the village, they said—”

“I know what they said. They're partly right, and the part that's right is my business and the state's, not the village's.” She stood. “Phyllis, bring Sabina. And Avianius — when your wife's

well enough, bring her to the temple of Isis near the Esquiline gate. The priestess has medicines for the ague that don't cost a farmer's winter. Say my name."

⁂

Sabina came through the colonnade in her house dress, saw her father, and stopped dead; then she ran, and the dignity she had spent nine days building dissolved in the garden, and she was a girl in her father's arms again, and both of them wept without shame, and Phyllis turned away to the roses and even Festus, passing with a new hinge for the postern, developed a sudden interest in the sky.

When they could speak, the father told her the terms, and the offer from the soft-handed man, and the choice that was hers.

He told it the way farmers tell things, in the order of the work rather than the order of importance, and Antonia, who had taken a seat a little apart where she could hear without intruding, made herself attend to every word. The soft-handed man had come to the village in the autumn, with two litters and a clerk, and rented the best room at the inn for three days. He had spoken to no one about his business, but the clerk had walked the fields and the debt-rolls, and within a week the landlord's agents knew exactly which families held their land on the sharpest

terms. Avianius's own debt, a modest thing contracted for his wife's fever and a dead ox, had been bought from the local lender at full value, which no one ever did, and then the visits had begun: polite, unhurried, always ending with the name of the house in Rome where the daughter could earn her family's freedom in a single season.

“He knew the children's names,” Avianius said, marvelling still. “All four. He knew the boy's lame foot and the ague's pattern and what the rent came to at the next kalends. A Roman gentleman, with rings, and he knew our kalends. That's when I understood it wasn't chance. Somebody makes a living knowing villages like ours, domina, the way a wolf knows the folds.”

“Somebody does,” Antonia said. “It's called a subscription agent. The gentleman doesn't buy debts; he buys maps of desperation. Tell me the rest.”

The rest was the part the old man could hardly speak: the second visit, when the politeness thinned and the clerk had explained, with the door shut, what became of debt-bond girls sold to the public houses at the port, the places without contracts or lamps or witnesses; and then, by contrast, the warmth of the offer from the Carinae, where a girl could learn music and letters and keep her name, and where the debt, by the terms of the very tablet the soft-handed man had himself produced, would be worked off in four

years with a signed release. The trap was beautiful, Antonia thought, in the cold way she admired well-made instruments: the lupanar threat was real enough to terrify, the Carinae offer generous enough to feel like salvation, and neither the father nor the girl was ever meant to notice that the same hand held both doors.

“What decided you?” she asked.

“The wife. My girl's mother.” He looked at Sabina, and his face worked. “She said any house that lets a woman keep her name and learn her letters is a house built by a woman who was once inside the same wall. She said it twice. She's never been to Rome in her life, domina, and she read your whole house from one clause in a contract.”

“Your wife is wiser than half the senate.” Antonia rose. “Stay the night; the kitchen will feed you and there's a clean room by the stable. In the morning we'll draw the copy of the contract you should have been given in the first place — witnessed, sealed, one for your village and one for the temple. And Avianius: when you go home, tell every family on the sharp terms what the soft-handed man's clerk is doing with their names. Wolves hunt best in the dark folds. Let there be lamps in yours.”

Sabina wiped her cheeks with the heel of her hand, the old gesture, and thought about it with the new slowness the house had taught her.

“If I come home,” she said, “the debt comes back the moment someone changes his mind, and I'm sold again by winter, somewhere worse. If I stay, I learn to read and reckon and walk, and I earn wages, and the farm is safe and Mother gets a doctor.” She looked at Antonia. “Is it true? I could leave later? Truly?”

“Truly. Ask any of the women. Ask Chloe, who came here as a debt-bond and now keeps the house's accounts. The contract's witnessed by the priestess of Isis, if that makes it safer in your eyes.”

“Then I'm staying.” The girl's chin lifted. “Not because I don't love you, Father. Because I'll be more use to all of us as a woman with a trade than as a girl with a price. And when I come home, I'll come home on my own feet, with money in my belt, and nobody will ever carry me out of our yard again.”

Avianius looked at his daughter the way a man looks at a field he has planted and found, in his absence, grown tall. “Your mother said you'd be the strong one. She said it when you were five and you fought the goat for the turnips.”

“The goat started it.”

They laughed, shakily, and he finished his bread and wrapped the rest carefully for his wife, and Festus walked him to the postern with a jar of good wine and a packet of the priestess's herbs that Phyllis had produced from somewhere, and the farmer went back down the Carinae through

the morning crowds a free man with an unbroken daughter, which was more than Rome gave most men in his position.

When he had gone, Antonia found Sabina alone at the impluvium, feeding the fish with concentrated ferocity.

“Thank you,” the girl said, without looking round. “For the terms. For not buying me like he did.”

“I did buy you. I'm simply trying to be a better owner than the alternative, until you can own yourself. Never mistake kindness for absence of profit, Sabina; the women who do are the ones who get sold twice.”

“I won't.” A pause. “Domina — the men who came to my father. They'll come to the other women's families, won't they? To Tyche's, to the musicians'.”

“Yes. It's how Perperna works. He doesn't storm the wall. He pays the people inside to open the gate.”

“Then I'll learn faster,” Sabina said, and dropped the last of the fish food with a splash. “So I can be a wall too.”

⁂

Gaius Aelius had been planning the expedition for a week, in the meticulous fashion of boys with too many tutors.

His father's household believed him to be at the grammar school beside the Forum of Augustus, where he was meant to spend the afternoon on Greek composition. Instead, having persuaded the school's elderly doorkeeper with a silver coin and a story of a family errand, he slipped out with his writing tablets under his arm and walked into the Subura, the great crowded quarter his father's litters always hurried through with the curtains closed.

It was magnificent and terrifying. The street was barely wide enough for two laden mules, and it held, in the space of a hundred paces, a fishmonger shouting his wares, a barber shaving a man in the open air, a money-lender's stall, a shrine to the Lares with a smoky fire, a seller of hot sausages, and a crowd that moved like water around every obstacle. Gaius had read descriptions of the Subura in poets; none of the poets had mentioned the smell, which was rich and total and alive, or the noise, which had a rhythm, like an enormous argument set to music.

He had been there perhaps an hour, and was beginning to feel rather pleased with his own daring, when the argument beside the wine shop turned into a knife.

It was nothing dramatic by Subura standards — two carters over a loading space, a drawn blade, a shove — but Gaius, who had never seen a blade drawn except at the soldiers' drills, froze in the press, and the crowd flowed around him and

pushed him off balance, and his tablets fell under the feet of a mule, and when he scrambled after them a hand closed on his arm and lifted him clear of the hooves as easily as he himself lifted the cat.

“Careful, little master. Mules don't know you're nobility; they'll step on anyone.”

It was the big man from the races — the one with the scarred eyebrow who had saved the child at the barrier. Gaius recognized him at once, and the big man recognized him, and the scarred eyebrow rose.

“You're the senator's boy. The one who likes horses better than gladiators. What in the world are you doing in the Subura without a keeper?”

“Learning the city,” Gaius said, with as much dignity as could be managed while being held at arm's length like a puppy.

Festus set him down and retrieved the tablets, wiping the mule marks off with his sleeve. “Learning's good. Dying of it's bad. Come on; I'm buying you something hot, and then I'm taking you somewhere your father's men can find you, because if anything happens to you in my street, my mistress will have my hide, and she keeps her promises.”

They sat on stools outside a sausage shop, and Gaius ate a hot sausage in a roll, which was the most delicious thing he had ever tasted and quite unlike anything served on the Esquiline, and Festus ate two, and answered the boy's questions

with the unhurried patience of a man who had discovered that the children of the powerful were easier to talk to than the powerful.

“Were you really a gladiator?”

“Retiarius. Net and trident. Twelve years, forty-one fights, twenty-nine wins, the rest draws or men who let me live because I let them first.” He flexed the scarred arm. “The scar over the eye was a secutor who got past the net. I killed him in the rematch. He taught me more than any schoolmaster.”

Gaius's eyes were enormous. “Did you like it? The fighting?”

“No. I liked being good at something. There's a difference, and most people never learn it. I was born a slave in a school; I didn't choose the sand. But I chose to be the best man on it, because the best man eats and sleeps and sometimes gets given his wooden foil, and the worst man gets carried out through the gate of death. Your father's world has softer floors, little master, but it runs on the same rule.”

“Does my father know your mistress?”

The scarred face considered him. “Yes. And don't ask me what they are to each other, because I don't know, and she doesn't tell me, and that's the mark of a real question — the one even the doorman can't answer.” Festus stood, coins on the counter. “One thing I can show you, since you're learning the city.”

He walked the boy two streets over, to where a narrow lane gave a view of the Carinae and the gilded door, and pointed, very casually, at a man loitering by a fountain with a scroll he was not reading.

“See him? Third time this week. He watches our door, writes down who goes in. He works for the man who killed our clerk. Now watch what he does.”

The man at the fountain looked up, saw Festus looking at him, and with admirable composure turned and walked away.

“He knows you saw him,” Gaius said.

“Of course he does. That's the point. Now he'll tell his master the doorman's alert, and his master will change the plan, and the new plan is a thing we can prepare for. The best guards don't fight, boy. They make the other man waste his nights.” Festus clapped him gently on the shoulder. “Home with you. I'll send a runner to your father's door so you're not murdered for truancy as well. And Gaius — the sausage stays between us.”

Before the sausage, Festus had walked him through the market of the Macellum, and the boy from the Esquiline had seen his city as if for the first time. They watched the grain dole queue at the public granary, patient women and idle men with their tokens, and Festus explained the annona the way a soldier explains supply: not as the poets did, but as logistics. The city ate forty thousand modii of grain a day. Stop the ships from

Ostia for a week, and the streets became a war. Emperors were loved or hated on the price of bread, and senators made fortunes from the difference between what arrived and what was written.

“Those contracts my father's auditing,” Gaius said slowly. “If the tallies are false, someone's stealing the grain itself.”

“Someone's selling it twice. My mistress says the theft isn't in the warehouses, it's in the counting houses.” Festus bought him a cup of watered wine from a stall. “You're quick. Most boys your age want to know about the fighting. You want to know about the grain.”

“Uncle Decimus says grain is dull.”

“Your uncle's a charming man with a talent for being wrong.” The big ex-gladiator said it without heat, as he might have observed the weather, and Gaius filed it beside everything else he was beginning to notice that adults did not say outright.

They passed a public fountain where two women were shouting at each other over a broken jug, a workshop full of noisy fullers stamping cloth in urine troughs, and a street shrine where a priest was selling little clay figures to sailors' wives; and at every step Gaius felt the vast, humming, unwritten Rome beneath the Rome of scrolls and tutors, and understood, with the sudden clarity of the young, that his education

had been teaching him a map of a country he had never visited.

“Why does your mistress do it?” he asked. “The house. My father would say she could live respectably on her money.”

Festus laughed, a low rumble. “Respectable is what rich men call women who don't threaten them. She does it because a woman with money and no man has to be useful to the powerful or be devoured by them, and she'd rather be the one holding the door. Also — and this matters — the girls. Half of them would be dead in a ditch without the house. Rome's full of houses that take from women. Hers gives. That's a rarer thing than it should be.”

“The sausage stays between us,” Gaius agreed solemnly, and went up the Esquiline with his mule-marked tablets and his head full of nets and tridents and the peculiar discovery that the most honest man he had met all week carried a knife for a living.

⁂

Tyche's report came after dark, brought to the tablinum with the market baskets, and it was short and precise: the polite man had asked, twice, about her mistress's appointments outside the house, and specifically whether she ever visited the temples near the Esquiline gate.

“He knows about the Isis meeting,” Chloe said.

“Of course he does; he knows everything except what we'll do about it.” Antonia turned the silver dove brooch over in her fingers. “Send word to the priestess: change nothing. The meeting happens, in the precinct, at the appointed hour. But tell Festus I want every man he trusts inside that temple by noon, dressed as pilgrims, and Hilarus's litter at the side entrance, and a second litter — mine, with the curtains closed — leaving the front door at the same hour and heading for the Aventine. Let Perperna watch the wrong door. He's spent money on eyes; give them something expensive to look at.”

“And the senator?”

“Messengers to the senator too. Tell him only: the goddess expects him, and the goddess has arranged her own protection.” Antonia set the brooch down. “If Perperna wants a war in a temple, he'll discover that Isis has more worshippers in Rome than he has clerks.”

The decoy went out at the third hour the next day, and it was a small masterpiece.

Antonia's own litter, the one half the Carinae knew by its blue curtains and matched bearers, left the gilded door with the curtains closed and an armed footman at each corner, turned uphill toward the Aventine, and was at once picked up by the loiterer at the fountain, who passed the signal to a boy, who ran. Inside the litter, wrapped in Antonia's own mantle and veil, sat the cook's wife, a woman of similar build and excellent

nerve, who spent a comfortable afternoon at the temple of Diana, ate the offerings, and came home with a blessing and three sesterces in gratuities.

Meanwhile Antonia, in a plain borrowed mantle with Chloe at her side, went out through the new carpenter Vitalis's workshop, across a neighbouring courtyard whose tenant Hilarus owned, and through that house's postern into a grocer's cart, which carried them under a load of cabbages to within two streets of the Esquiline gate. Festus met them there in pilgrim grey.

“Followed?” he asked.

“Not unless cabbages have learned to walk. Our man at the fountain watched the blue litter all the way up the Aventine.”

“Good. The precinct's quiet. Four of ours inside, two at the gate, the priestess warned.” He offered his arm to Chloe with old-fashioned gravity. “Pilgrims, ladies. Remember to look devout.”

“I've looked devout for worse men than an Egyptian goddess,” Chloe said, and they went up the temple steps together, unhurried, anonymous, three more worshippers among the stream, and the great city, for once, did not know where Antonia Cassia was.

On the Esquiline, Marcus received the same day's news in pieces, as fathers do.

First Stichus, with the careful neutrality of a good slave, reported that the young master had been absent from the afternoon's Greek lesson

and had been seen, by a household runner, eating sausage in the Subura in the company of “a very large scarred man known at the Carinae house.” Marcus had dismissed the man and sat with this for a while, torn between the senator's instinct to forbid and the officer's recognition that a fourteen-year-old who could arrange his own truancy was a fourteen-year-old with initiative.

He sent for Gaius after dinner, and the boy came with his chin up and his tablets behind his back, ready for the storm.

“The school wrote to me,” Marcus said. It was not true, but he had been a lawyer once, and lawyers are allowed their tools. “Where were you?”

Gaius weighed it, and chose the truth, the way Marcus had taught him to by rewarding it more often than he punished its absence. “In the Subura. With Festus, from the Carinae house. I wanted to see the city, not read about it. I'm sorry I lied to the school; I'm not sorry I went.”

Marcus looked at his son for a long moment. “What did you learn?”

“That the city eats forty thousand modii of grain a day, and the annona is logistics, and that men steal it twice, in the warehouses and on the tablets. That the best guard doesn't fight; he makes the other man waste his nights. And that a retiarius killed the man who scarred him, in a rematch.” Gaius straightened. “And that the women in the Carinae house would mostly be

dead in ditches without it. Father — are you going to prosecute the mistress? The boys at school say she's a wicked woman."

"The boys at school are repeating their mothers, who are repeating their husbands, who have never read a contract." Marcus leaned forward. "Listen to me, because I'm going to say this once, and you're to remember it when you're old enough to be a magistrate. The law and the good are not the same thing. The law is a machine built by the powerful to make their comfort look like virtue. A woman may be technically what the law calls disreputable and be, in fact, a person of honour; a man may be technically blameless and be, in fact, a thief. Judge by what people do, Gaius. Not by what they're called. As for the mistress — I'm not prosecuting her. I'm working with her, on the audit, and tomorrow I meet her under the protection of a goddess, which is more protection than most witnesses get."

Gaius considered this. "Is she the ghost, Father? The one Mother mentioned."

Marcus did not ask how he knew; children in great houses knew everything, it was the only advantage they had. "She is a person I failed a long time ago. I'm trying not to fail her now. Go to bed. And Gaius — next time you visit the Subura, take Stichus. A boy with a nomenclator is less likely to end in a barrel, and I'd rather explain truancy to your mother than ransom."

When the boy had gone, Marcus sat late over the audit tablets and the diary entry from Praeneste, and at the household's last watch he wrote out, in his own hand, the questions he intended to ask beneath the eyes of Isis: about the seal, about the subscriptions, about the grain that grew on the river. And at the bottom, in smaller letters, he wrote one question he did not intend to speak aloud: what it would cost him, in the end, to be worthy of the trust he was asking.

He set down the stylus and opened the private drawer where he kept the things that belonged to no ledger, and took out the chipped wooden disc he had kept since boyhood, the token of a kitchen friendship in a house by the sea. Beside it lay the three letters returned to him unopened, their seals still intact, and the last letter, the one he had never sent, that Barto had pressed into his hand in Tibur with the news of the extra payment made “for the training.” He had read that final letter so often that the creases were beginning to part. Thirty years of a man's life, reduced to four small objects in a drawer; and the woman they concerned now kept a gilded door and a strong room full of evidence that could unmake an imperial secretary.

He thought about what a consul's life was supposed to contain: the lictors, the fasces, the curule chair, the carefully counted honours; and he thought about what it actually contained when the counting was honest: a returned slave girl's

silence, a dead clerk's tablets, and the question, written small at the bottom of a private list, of whether he was good for anything at all when no one was watching.

The audit was no longer merely an audit. He had understood that for some time. It was a test, administered by no censor and recorded in no register, of what the Aelian name was worth now that it had been left, at last, with no convenient door to slip through.

He blew out the lamp, and the Esquiline house settled into its Roman sleep, and across the roofs the gilded door stood closed and barred and watched, and the watchers were themselves watched, and the night was full of eyes.

CHAPTER NINE

The Baths

The temple of Isis stood in a grove of sycamores near the Esquiline gate, its columns bright with painted plaster, its air thick with incense and the low music of rattles, and it was, Antonia had always thought, the most honest sanctuary in Rome: a goddess for the imported people — the Greeks, the Syrians, the Egyptians, the freedmen and the slaves and the women — for everyone the old Roman gods had never quite bothered to know.

Marcus was already there, in plain dress with Stichus left at the outer gate, standing before the painted image of the goddess with the respect a Roman senator gives any god who might be listening. The priestess glided away with Chloe, leaving the two of them alone in the side chapel where votive candles burned in rows and the walls were covered with painted scenes of the Nile.

“You came alone,” Antonia said.

“I said I would. Romans of my class put enormous faith in the keeping of one's word; it's

nearly the only faith we have left.” He turned to her. “You were followed?”

“My litter was. I wasn't.” She sat on the stone bench, folded her hands, and came at once to the point, as she did everything. “Your diary.”

He produced it, open at the marker, and laid it between them. Stichus's hand, the Praeneste dedication, the flooded road, the two nights away. She read it carefully, though she already knew its contents from her own sources, and nodded.

“Then your witness signature is a forgery. The seal was taken from your strong room — your brother has access, and the steward keeps the ring for the family. They sealed a loan you never saw, at twenty-four per cent, and wrote your name across the thongs. If this ever reaches court, the diary is your defence: you were sixty miles away.”

“I've spoken to no one but Stichus. What do you want of me, exactly? Your letter said a partnership with the truth, which is a fine phrase. Give me the plain version.”

“The plain version is that Perperna means to own the eastern supply contracts and everyone attached to them, including your brother, and that the audit is the instrument he means to use — either you sign the false tallies and become his creature, or you expose the fraud and your family name is destroyed through Celer. I hold the documents that let you choose a third path: a real

audit, with the true accounts, prosecuted against Perperna rather than your brother.”

“At what price?”

“At the price of your name on the prosecution. Not mine — I'm infamis, my word carries nothing in a Roman court; a meretrix doesn't prosecute equestrians. You bring the evidence before the prefect's office under your own authority. In return, I get Perperna removed before he closes my house, and my people get to keep their lives and their trade.” She met his eyes. “That's the whole bargain. There's no hidden clause involving your bed, your money, or your conscience, though I expect you to suspect all three; men always do.”

He almost smiled. “And my brother?”

“Celer is a fool, not a traitor by design. He testifies to the loans, turns state evidence, and takes exile or bankruptcy rather than the rope. I don't care which; I care that he's alive and talking when the case opens. Perperna dead is a martyr; Perperna ruined in open court is a lesson.”

Marcus was silent a while, watching the candles. “I need to see the documents. The true tablets, not copies.”

“No. Not yet. The originals are the only thing keeping me alive; you'll see them when the magistrate does.” She softened, fractionally. “It isn't trust I'm withholding. It's prudence, and if our positions were reversed you'd do the same, and recommend it to your son.”

“Probably. You've become a Roman, Antonia.”

“I've become what Rome made me. There's a difference.”

The chapel was quiet. Somewhere beyond the columns the rattles sounded, thin and bright.

He said, without looking at her, “I have to ask. After the sale. Dinis the dealer. I know the broad shape of it from Barto; I don't know the rest, and I won't ask you to tell me in detail unless you choose to. But I need to know whether there's anything — anyone — I should hold myself to account for, beyond the sale itself.”

She considered him, the long Roman profile, the grey at the temples, the hands clasped between his knees like a man at prayer.

“You want absolution,” she said. “I can't give it. I won't. The baby was a girl, born too early in the dealer's house, dead before she cried. I nearly died of the fever after, and there was no doctor, because doctors cost money and I was a purchase going bad. Then four years in the Subura, in a house I won't describe, because describing it would give you the comfort of horror and the truth is mostly boredom and shame, which are less dramatic. Then a woman called Antonia Prima bought me, taught me, freed me, and left me everything. That's the account. You didn't light any of it, Marcus. But you lived in the house it warmed, and you believed the lie because believing was easier. I don't hate you for it. Hate is expensive. I simply haven't decided what you are to me now.”

He had gone white. “The child. Mine.”

“Yours. She never had a name; the dealer didn't name dead slave girls. I named her once, alone, in the fever. I called her Laeta, because it means happy, and it seemed only fair to give her the one thing the gods hadn't.” Antonia rose, smooth and composed, the composure itself a kind of armour. “Now you know why the documents matter more than feelings. The men who run this city can sell girls and erase their daughters and call it law. Perperna is what that system looks like when it's hungry. I'm going to make him choke on his own paper. You can stand with me or stand aside. I'd prefer the first; I'll survive the second.”

“I'll stand with you.” He said it quietly, without rhetoric, as one states a fact. “Not because of the past, though the past has its claim. Because the audit I've been given is a lie unless it's real, and I've never put my name to a lie.”

“Then we begin. Hilarus has the Ostia weight notes. Meet him at the baths tomorrow, men's hour, where talk is cheap and no one remembers it. And Marcus—” she paused at the chapel's edge “—don't tell your wife the details. Not because she can't be trusted, but because the fewer houses that hold this, the fewer doors Perperna can break.”

“She already knows more than you think. Wives generally do.”

“Then tell her less than she knows. It's the traditional Roman solution.”

The priestess returned at that moment, her linen robes whispering, her dark face serene, and murmured that two men had asked at the outer gate after a senator visiting the shrine — not pressing, merely asking, the way clerks ask when someone has paid them to remember. Marcus's hand went to his knife; Antonia's did not move.

“They'll have seen Stichus at the gate and guessed the rest. Let them. A consul-designate praying to Isis is eccentric, not illegal; half the nobility consult foreign gods in private and thank Jupiter in public.” To the priestess she said, “My thanks, Mother. The offerings I promised will come tonight, through the usual door.”

When the woman had glided away, Marcus said, “They move quickly.”

“They move constantly; speed is the only advantage money gives a man without rank. Remember that when the documents frighten you.” She rose and walked to the painted wall, where the Nile flooded its banks in bright pigment and the crops grew beneath a foreign sun. “While we're alone and off the record, as the lawyers say — tell me about Celer's part, as far as you know it. Everything, including the shameful parts.”

He told her: the Palatine house, the aedile's games, the horses, the dinners, the slow slide from borrowing to subscribing to signing things he had not read. She listened without

interrupting, her face still, and when he finished she said, “He's exactly the man Perperna hunts. Not the vicious, the vain. Vicious men understand consequences; vain men only understand audience. Your brother thought he was the hero of his own story. Perperna writes the stories; he only lets men think they're authors.”

“You don't pity him.”

“I pity him precisely as much as he'd pity me if our positions were reversed, which is none. But I'll use him, because used men can still be saved and ruined men cannot.” She turned from the painting. “One last thing. When the time comes, you'll be asked to choose between the name and the truth, publicly, in front of men who can end your career. Don't answer now. Just know the question's coming, and decide before it's asked, because in the Forum there's no time to think.”

“You speak as though I'll fail it.”

“I speak as though everyone fails it unless they've rehearsed. I've been rehearsing for fifteen years. You've had a month.”

⁂

The Baths of Trajan rose on the Oppian Hill above the ruins of Nero's golden house, the greatest bath complex the city had ever seen, and at the men's afternoon hour it was less a bath than a parliament, where senators and shopkeepers steamed side by side and half the politics of Rome

were settled in water too hot for dignity.

Marcus came with Hilarus as his cover, the two of them moving through the palaestra where men exercised with balls and weights, past the libraries and the shops, into the warm steam of the tepidarium, where conversation acquired the echo and intimacy of a cave.

The rule of the baths was the rule of the cave: names were rarely used, business was never named outright, and everything worth knowing was said in the third person, as anecdote. Hilarus, whose fortune had been built on understanding precisely this dialect, led Marcus to a bench beside two merchants whose backs were turned and whose talk, in the way of bath talk, was perfectly audible across the steam.

“...fourth shipment, every season, like clockwork. My factor at Ostia says the harbour masters don't even weigh them anymore; the tally's made out before the ship ties up.” A splash, a sigh. “And the difference goes where such differences always go. Up. It's an old river, this one. It's been running since the Dacian war; nobody digs a new channel while the emperor's winning.”

“Dangerous talk.”

“Dangerous to write down. Steam doesn't keep records.” The man laughed, a wet, comfortable sound. “Besides, everyone with a contract knows it. The only people who don't know it are the ones who audit by the official tallies, which is like

judging a woman's virtue by her veil. You'd need the harbour weights, the private ones, and those don't leave the granary. They'd have to fire every clerk in the annona to get at the truth, and who's going to do that? The bureau employs the clerks."

Hilarus caught Marcus's eye, the smallest flicker, and raised his voice just enough to enter the conversation as a third voice, the oil merchant's easy geniality serving as its own passport. "Gentlemen. Hilarus of the Aventine, oil and amphorae. My friend here is a student of harbour accounting — don't hold it against him, it's a sickness. You were saying the private weights don't leave the granary. Never? Not even for the military audit?"

"Especially not for the military audit." The merchant turned, red and amiable. "The audit gets the tallies. The tallies are made from the private weights. It's like asking a man to swear by his own reflection. Now, if you wanted the true numbers, you'd need a measurer with a memory — one of the Greeks who checks the loading and keeps his own count. They're the only honest thing on the wharf, because nobody's thought to bribe them all yet. But a measurer who talks? The river keeps those." A shrug, vast and wet. "Enough. Talk like this ruins the heat. The cold pool, gentlemen, before our courage fails."

The two men moved off, and Marcus sat in the steam with the water running down his face and the sentence settling into him: *a measurer with a*

memory. Hector, the dead clerk, had been one kind of evidence, the kind that lived on tablets and could be taken from a room. A man who carried the figures on his own skin, in his own head, would be another kind entirely — the kind that could not be stolen, only killed, and killing a man at Ostia left questions that killing a clerk in a Roman alley did not.

“Write it nowhere yet,” Hilarus murmured, eyes closed against the steam. “But tell your Carinae friend. Her house collects people the river would otherwise keep. If such a measurer exists, she'll know where he works before the week is out; her musicians have brothers on every wharf in the harbour.”

“The weight notes.” Hilarus spoke into the steam, barely moving his lips, the technique of a man who had done business in harbours. “My Ostia factor's copies. Every fourth shipment, the same ninety modii appears between the public weighing and the Roman tally. It's so regular it's almost artistic. The measurer who first flagged it is a man called Dorion; he's in my pay now, for his own safety, sleeping above my warehouse with two guards.”

“Can he testify?”

“He'll testify if the court is open and the guard is real. He's Greek, freed, and frightened; frightened men need to see the wall before they'll stand against it. Your name is the wall.” Hilarus dipped his head under the hot water and came up

blowing. “There's more. The short-weight grain doesn't vanish into thin air. It's sold a second time, privately, to the bakers and the marine contractors, and the gold goes to a private banker — not Beryllus, he's too careful — a smaller house on the Aventine. Follow the gold and you'll find the hand at the top.”

“Perperna's.”

“Or the hand above Perperna. Men like him don't invent systems; they're allowed to run them. Ask yourself who profits if the great prosecution fails, or succeeds, and remember that the emperor is raising an army for the East. A war on that scale needs supplies faster than the state can honestly provide. There are people very high up who'd rather not look too closely at how the miracle is achieved.”

Marcus turned this in the steam. It was the first time anyone had said aloud what he had suspected: that the fraud was not a conspiracy against the state but an economy tolerated by it, and that an honest auditor might find himself opposing not one villain but the convenience of the entire machine.

They were in the caldarium, sweating against the hot walls, when Celer appeared in the doorway with two young men of his own fast set, and the brothers saw each other through the steam with the particular awkwardness of relatives meeting naked in public.

“Marcus. Hilarus.” Celer recovered first, lowering himself into the pool with a hiss of pleasure. “The censor and the oil king. Should I leave, or are the times sufficiently degenerate that I may bathe in my own brother's company?”

“Bathe,” Marcus said. “The water doesn't care about your debts.”

The young men laughed a little too loudly, and Celer's smile thinned. “You know, then. I assumed you would by now; everyone else does. Let me save you the speech. I'm a fool, I've been a fool, and I will be a fool again, because our father gave me his charm and his appetites and none of his money. Perperna's been carrying me. There. Is the family honour satisfied?”

“Perperna has been *using* you. There's a difference.” Marcus kept his voice low. “The subscriptions aren't an investment; they're a rope. When the audit reports, you'll be the first neck offered, because your name makes the scandal respectable. I can protect you if you tell me everything, now, in front of Hilarus, with no more charm.”

The steam hissed. Celer looked at his brother, and for once the handsome face was entirely without performance.

“You really mean to fight him. Everyone says you're too honest to be real, and you're actually going to do it.” He let out a breath. “I'll tell you everything. Not here — I won't say his name naked in a room with twenty ears. At the house.

Tomorrow. And Marcus — I'm sorry. For the seal most of all. They said it was a formality, family witnessing family, and I let them. That's on me."

When he had gone with his friends, Hilarus raised an eyebrow. "That went better than I feared."

"Because he's frightened. Frightened charmers make honest brothers, briefly. We'll see what survives until tomorrow."

They moved to the palaestra afterward, where Marcus threw a heavy ball at the wall with controlled, soldier's precision and Hilarus, who hated exercise, watched from a bench with a towel.

"There's something else," Hilarus said. "The broadsheets. The old consular wasn't exaggerating. I bought every copy my factor could find this morning." He produced a damp, folded sheet from beneath the towel — cheap paper, rough Greek-influenced Latin, no printer's name. Marcus read it standing with the ball in his hand: a mock love-letter from the "censor" to his "Carinae mistress," full of innuendo about ledgers and bed-curtains, ending in a joke about the audit being conducted at night. It was funny, which made it worse; Rome memorized jokes and forgot denials.

"Perperna's writers?"

"His style, though he'd never print it himself. The point isn't the accusation; it's the association. Once the crowd sees you two as a pair, any

prosecution he brings against her gets to touch you. Adultery law, first of all — the lex Iulia doesn't require proof of the act, merely of the opportunity and the reputation. A man seen at a courtesan's house is half condemned by the gossip."

"Let him bring it. There's been no adultery; the law still needs an act."

Hilarus looked at him with the patient expression of a merchant explaining the weather to a landsman. "Senator. With respect. The law needs what a judge can be made to believe. You're an honest man in a dishonest system, and the system's been running long enough to know its business. Guard your movements. Meet her in temples, in crowds, through me. Never alone, never at night, never behind a closed door without a witness."

Marcus folded the sheet and put it inside his tunic, beside the old letter from Tibur. "I'll take the precautions. I won't abandon the audit."

"Nobody asked you to abandon it. I asked you to survive it. There's a difference, and it's the whole difference between a martyr and a magistrate."

An elderly consular, drying himself nearby, had watched the exchange over his oil flask, and now he drifted close with the unhurried purpose of a man who intended to be overheard.

"Severus. A word of advice, from a man who's watched three generations ruin themselves. Your

name is being linked in the street with the Carinae woman. Supper houses, races, private temple meetings. I don't care what's true; I care what's repeated. Perperna's pamphleteers are already at work; I've seen one of the broadsheets. ‘The censor and the courtesan.' Very neat. The city forgives vice; it never forgives a joke. Be careful.”

“I appreciate the warning.”

“Do you? You've the look of a man who appreciates warnings and ignores them.” The old man wrapped his towel. “I had a son like you. He's governing Mauretania now, which is safer than Rome, and perhaps that tells you everything.”

⁂

The women's bath, at the earlier hour, was a different country — quieter, denser with its own hierarchies, full of the particular laughter of women temporarily outside the keeping of men.

Antonia went with Porcia, who knew every matron in the room and owed deference to none of them, and they had barely reached the warm pool when Livia Marcella entered with her own retinue, and the temperature of the room changed by a degree, as it did wherever Livia went.

The two women's eyes met across the water.

Porcia, who had arranged nothing and understood everything, murmured, “Shall I drown someone, or are we being civilized?”

“We're always civilized,” Antonia said. “It's our weapon.”

Livia came to the pool herself, dismissed her attendants to the far side with a glance, and slipped into the water with the unhurried grace of a woman confident in her own body, her dark hair pinned high, her back straight.

“Domina Antonia. Or may I say Antonia? We've been discussed together in enough drawing rooms to be on first-name terms.”

“Names are free. It's everything else in Rome that costs.”

“I'll come to the point, since the steam makes long speeches ridiculous.” Livia settled against the pool's edge, and her eyes, direct and assessing, met Antonia's without flinching. “What is your price? Every woman in the city has one, and I don't mean it as an insult; the city prices everything. I want you to leave Rome. Take your house, your women, your money — I'll even add to it, from my own dowry, which is mine to dispose of. A year in Alexandria, two in Neapolis. Enough time for the pamphlets to die and the consulship to be secured. Name the figure.”

The pool murmured with other women's distant talk.

Antonia let the offer sit a moment, turning it like a coin.

“You've done this before,” she said. “Offered women money to go away.”

“Three times. Two took it and were sensible; one refused and made my life miserable for a year before she ran off with a dancing master. I've a high opinion of the sensible ones.”

“Then I'm sorry to be the fourth. No figure, Livia. I can't be bought out, because what I'm doing isn't a liaison that ends when the money's paid; it's a war, and my house is the battlefield. Perperna wants my doors and my women and the things my guests have said. If I leave Rome, he takes them anyway, and the women end in the Subura. I don't run from men like him. I bury them.”

Livia studied her for a long, considering moment. “You actually mean that.”

“I don't say things I don't mean. It's another of my bad habits.”

“Most people who say that are lying. You're not.” The senator's wife dipped her fingers in the water, watching the ripples. “I came here prepared to despise you. My friends say it's my wifely duty. Instead I find a woman running an enterprise larger than half my husband's clients' estates, speaking like a jurisconsult, and refusing a dowry-sized bribe for the sake of people the law doesn't even count as people.” She gave a small, dry laugh. “It's extremely inconvenient. I dislike being made to revise my opinions; it ruins the bath.”

“Then prepare for more inconvenience. Your husband is an honest man, which makes him

nearly unique in the Forum, and the fraud he's auditing is real, and it reaches into your own household through Decimus. If it succeeds as Perperna means it to, the consulship dies with the family name. My interests and yours point the same way, whether either of us likes it."

Livia's face sharpened. "Decimus. What has he done?"

"Ask him yourself — better, ask your steward. He visited yours three weeks ago, didn't he, asking about moving family funds? A man drowning looks for every hand on the boat."

The silence that followed was not the silence of surprise; it was the silence of a theory confirmed. Livia's eyes went very slightly wider, and then narrowed.

"You are remarkably well informed."

"I pay well for the privilege. I'll tell you one more thing free, because a wife who knows is safer than a wife who guesses. Perperna has filed or will file within days: a licensing review against my house, a custody claim against a girl in my care, and something aimed at the audit. Watch your husband's correspondence; watch your brother-in-law's creditors; and if anyone in your household is suddenly generous with money or kindness, remember that Perperna buys small people because they cost less."

Porcia, floating nearby with her eyes closed, said without opening them, "She's right, Livia. My Hilarus says the same, and Hilarus is never wrong

about money, which is the same as never being wrong.”

Livia ignored her, the way one ignores a beloved but inconvenient aunt. “Tell me about the women. The ones in your house. The matrons' version is that you keep them in gilded cages.”

“The matrons' version is comfortable for the matrons. The truth is that every woman in my house came from somewhere worse, and most of them will leave with money and a trade. Chloe runs my accounts now; she'll have her own business in three years. Sabina, the debt girl Perperna wants, is learning to read at an age when your daughter's still on the alphabet. Tyche plays the lyre and has more courage than half the knights I've met.” Antonia let a beat pass. “They're not caged, Livia. They're employed, in the only trade a woman without a man can enter in this city without becoming a thief or a corpse. Don't mistake the house for the world. The world built the cage; I merely improved the locks, and put them on the inside.”

“That's a very neat answer.”

“It's a true one. Neatness is optional.”

For the first time, something like genuine curiosity moved in Livia's face, beneath the senator's wife. “And you? Did you choose it? Any of it?”

“No. I chose to survive it, and then I chose to own it. Those are different choices, made in a different order, and I'd be lying if I said I knew

where one ended and the other began.” Antonia met her eyes in the steam. “Your husband once taught me my letters, in a kitchen, because no one else would bother. That's the whole romance. The rest is law, money, and two families' worth of lies. You can live with that, or not; but don't imagine I've spent fifteen years plotting to take your place. Your place requires a husband. I've worked too hard to need one.”

For a long moment Livia said nothing. Then she extended her hand across the water, not in friendship exactly, but in the older, colder Roman manner of a treaty between equals.

“I won't pretend to like this. I won't pretend my husband's — association — with you is anything but a wound to my pride and a danger to my children. But the Aelii do not lose, and it seems we've acquired an unlikely ally.” Her hand stayed extended. “Truce, then. Not affection. Truce.”

Antonia took the hand. It was firm and cool and held exactly as long as formality required.

“Truce. And Livia — if it's any comfort, I've no interest in your husband's name, his bed, or your place. I had my chance at those things fifteen years ago, in another life, and the world made its own arrangements. What I want from him is his signature on a prosecution, which is far less compromising than an affair and considerably more useful.”

“Somehow,” Livia said, releasing her hand, “that's the first thing you've said that I entirely believe.”

They bathed in a companionable, armed silence after that, two women at the centre of the city's gossip, and when they left at separate hours by separate doors, neither looked back, and the attendants who had been paid to notice things went home with very little to report, which was, for both of them, the evening's real victory.

Back at the house, the women's wing held its own small ceremony. Sabina, in her third week of lessons, read aloud from a simple scroll while the others mended linen and the lamps burned low, and she reached the end of a full paragraph without a single reversal of the letter R, and the room applauded with the genuine warmth of people who knew exactly what the achievement cost.

“Read it again,” Chloe said. “Slowly. The end is where beginners rush.”

Sabina read it again, slowly, and Antonia, listening from the doorway with her day's correspondence in her hand, felt the old tightness in her chest that she had long ago given up trying to name. It was the feeling of watching a person take possession of herself.

Tyche waited until the reading ended and the talk had scattered, then came to the tablinum with her report, delivered in the flat, rehearsed voice of a girl determined to be useful.

“He met me by the cloth stalls again. He knows I report to you — or he guesses, it's the same — because now he doesn't ask anything. He gives. Today it was a bracelet, glass, very pretty, and a story about a friend who protects girls from bad houses. He says his friend can help any of us, any time, no questions.” She laid the bracelet on the table. “I didn't wear it. I brought it.”

“Good. Keep the gifts; evidence is evidence, and glass doesn't frighten me.” Antonia turned the bracelet in the lamplight. “The man's changing tactics, which means his master's impatient. Fear first, gifts second; what comes third is the threat. If he mentions the magistrate, or names Perperna, or asks you to sign anything, you come to me before you sleep. Not the next morning. Before you sleep.”

“I will.” Tyche hesitated at the door. “Domina — he keeps saying I'm too fine to belong to a freedwoman. As if belonging to you were the shameful thing, and belonging to some man I'd never met were freedom.”

“Because shame is all they've got. They can't outbid us, so they try to make us ashamed of the house. Go to bed; you did well.”

When she was alone, Antonia opened the two dispatches that had arrived in her absence. The first, on good parchment, was Hilarus's invitation to his villa outside the Capena gate, a dinner three days hence in honour of his Spanish factors, with a postscript in Porcia's hand: *Wear the blue,*

it annoys the matrons. The second, on coarse official paper sealed with the aedile's mark, set the hearing on the custody of Sabina Aviania for the first market day of the next month, before the praetor peregrinus, and required the girl's person and all relevant contracts to be produced in court.

She read the second dispatch twice, then placed it in the strong room drawer beneath the tablets, beside the chipped wooden disc, and said aloud, to the lamps and the fish, “There it is. He's named the day.”

She sat a while in the quiet, laying the timetable beside the investigation like a general matching maps: the dinner, where Marcus could meet Hilarus's factors and the money could be traced; the hearing, where Perperna meant to take Sabina and crack the house; and somewhere beyond them, unannounced, the audit report that would decide which of them walked away from the spring.

Then she put out the lamps and went to bed, and slept, as she had taught herself to sleep in worse houses than this, quickly and without dreams.

CHAPTER TEN

Hilarus's Table

The ride out took an hour, and Chloe spent it coaching the evening's performance.

“Two Crassici, one philosopher, three Spaniards, two bankers, the brother, and the senator,” she said, counting on her fingers in the litter. “You're to be the cleverest person in the room and never look cleverer than the men. You're to let Hilarus lead the money talk until the second wine, when their guard's gone soft. And you're to keep your face absolutely neutral every time Marcus Severus speaks, because Porcia says the whole city's learning to watch that face.”

“Porcia talks too much.”

“Porcia loves you, which is the same thing in her case.” Chloe examined her profile in a little bronze mirror. “Are you going to be able to do this? Dinner across the couch from him, with the matrons counting your glances?”

“I've performed for harder audiences than a consular wife. The rule is the same as it's always been: the room is my house, wherever I'm sitting. Once I believe that, everyone else does too.” Antonia adjusted the blue stola's fold. “Besides,

tonight's not about him. It's about the Spaniards' receipts and the banker on the Aventine. He's a witness to a business dinner; that's all the record will show."

"You've an answer for everything."

"I've had to. Girls without answers end in other people's ledgers."

The villa lay a mile beyond the Capena gate, on the slope where the road turned south toward the Alban hills, and it was, Antonia observed as the litter climbed the cypress-lined drive, exactly the house a freedman built when he had decided to make the old families uncomfortable without giving them anything they could actually criticize.

The proportions were correct. The marble was Greek. The statuary was restrained. Only the scale, and the newness of the money, and the excellent Spanish staff, declared the owner's history. Hilarus met his guests at the door himself, in a flawless toga, with Porcia beside him in the blue that the matrons considered too bright for a woman of her station, and the two of them greeted their company with the particular confidence of people who had discovered that the best revenge was a better kitchen.

There were fourteen covers: three Spanish factors from Corduba and Gades, brown, capable men with oil under their fingernails; two Roman bankers; Marcus, alone, on the excuse of public business; a Stoic philosopher kept for ornament; the inevitable Celer, who had been unable to

resist any table with a reputation; and a consular couple, the Crassici, who had accepted because Hilarus's wine was famous and spent their time making sure everyone knew the sacrifice involved.

Antonia arrived last, in the blue stola, with Chloe and a single footman, and the greeting line produced the exact small storm Porcia had promised. Crassicia, the consular wife, took in the dress, the companion, the unmistakable face, and produced a smile like a door closing.

“Hilarus, you *dog*. You didn't tell us the entertainment would be joining the table.”

“She isn't entertainment, Crassicia,” Hilarus said, beaming. “She's my business partner, and the cleverest person in Rome with a ledger. You'll like her; she's richer than your husband.”

Crassicus, the consular, flushed in patches. “There are places for women of — for women in business. The dinner table of one's peers is perhaps not—”

“Then it's fortunate you're not my peer,” Antonia said sweetly, “or I should have to mind. Hilarus, the drive was lovely; Porcia, the blue was exactly right.”

She took her place without being shown it, beside Marcus's couch, and the party settled into its food with the determined brightness of people determined not to be awkward, which is the most awkward mood in the world.

Before the dinner, the company walked the villa's terraces in the dusk, the Roman prelude that let everyone inspect everyone else's standing, and Hilarus used the tour to make his one political statement, quietly, through objects. The olive press in the farmyard was new and German; the granary was stone, fireproofed at absurd cost; the household slaves wore good tunics and answered him without flinching. A freedman, Antonia knew, was permitted everything except the appearance of taste; Hilarus had solved the problem by making the whole estate a lecture on competence, and even Crassicus, who had arrived prepared to condescend, was reduced to asking questions about the irrigation, which Hilarus answered in sentences too plain to show off.

“Remarkable fellow,” the consular muttered to Marcus, within Antonia's hearing. “Thirty years ago he was loading amphorae.”

“Thirty years ago a great many men were loading amphorae,” Marcus said. “He's the one who kept count.”

The dinner was magnificent. Hilarus's Spanish cooks produced the dishes of his homeland: excellent ham from the Sierra, olives from his own groves, a garum so refined that even the philosopher asked twice for more, and a whole tunny in pepper wine. The wine came from his own Campanian estate, chilled in the old snow, and the conversation moved, as Roman dinner

conversation always did, from food to money to politics to gossip and back to food.

The factors were the evening's real prize. After the second course, when the women of the household had withdrawn and the wine had rounded every edge, the senior factor, a weather-beaten man named Secundus, began to talk trade with the freedom of a man three hundred miles from the customs officers.

“—the oil contracts for the eastern army are being bundled the same way the grain was,” he told Marcus, across the table. “A single firm wins the whole schedule, then sub-lets the actual supply at half the price and pockets the difference. The firm's registered to a freedman who can't write his own name. We know; we've met him. He's a door, Senator. Someone stands behind the door.”

“Did you bring the papers?” Marcus asked.

Hilarus answered: “Copies, sealed, in my strong room. The firm changes name each quarter, but the witness seals repeat. The engraver's mark is the same; Syrus on the Tiber bank identified it for me himself before he understood what he was identifying. After that he stopped answering his door.”

“Frightened?”

“Wise. There's a difference in our trade too.” Hilarus ate an olive. “He'll testify if the court's open and the guard's visible. He won't testify in a

magistrate's back room, and I don't blame him; the Greek clerk who tried that is in the Tiber.”

Celer, two couches away, had gone very quiet over his wine.

Secundus had more to say, and the factors' Greek, a sharp-eyed man called Phoebus, took up the thread. “The army's leather is the next scandal, if anyone cares to look. Tents and boots, contracted for hides that were never delivered; the tally says twenty thousand hides, the tanners delivered twelve, and the difference was paid to a name that dissolves when you ask for its owner. My cousin tans at Pompeii. He has the workshop receipts. Nobody in Rome wants them; the quartermasters want their tents, the senators want their dividends, and the only man who wants the truth is the soldier marching in boots that split at the first river.”

“Bring me the receipts,” Marcus said. “Through Hilarus, with your cousin's mark witnessed. Every paper makes the case heavier; a prosecutor can be disbelieved, but a tanner's receipt is a stubborn thing.”

The philosopher, who had been drinking in disapproving silence, could not resist. “You speak as though the truth will simply prevail, Senator. In my experience, truth is a commodity like any other, priced by the market of power.”

“Then we corner the market,” Antonia said, from her couch, and the table turned toward her. “The truth doesn't win by being true. It wins by

being better organized than the lie. We hold the receipts, the weights, the seals, and the witnesses; Perperna holds pamphlets and frightened men. Organization is the whole art."

"Spoken like a merchant," Crassicia sniffed.

"Spoken like a survivor," Porcia corrected her, smiling. "Try the ham."

Crassicus, to his credit, laughed, and even his wife's mouth twitched, and the table exhaled, and the wine went round again, and Marcus, looking at Antonia across the lamps, thought that he had never sat at a table where the cleverest person present was a woman the law called disreputable, and that the Republic his ancestors had built was stranger and more various than their statues admitted.

⁂

Before the sweet wine, while the second roast was being cleared, Hilarus drew the table's merchants into the kind of conversation that Antonia arranged suppers to produce: trade talk, apparently aimless, in fact charted like a sea voyage.

The question of the eastern contracts came up by way of the pepper, which was late and dear, and Porcia said her husband's factors had been told to expect worse, because the annona's ships were taking the best moorings at Ostia and the merchant fleet waited its turn like dogs outside a

kitchen. “Whatever the bureau is shipping in such a hurry,” she said, “it has priority over pepper, and pepper, in my experience, is only ever postponed for grain or guns.”

“Grain,” said Crassicus, who was three cups in and beyond caution. “The new levies for the eastern army. Huge contracts. A man could retire on one run if his name's on the right list.”

“Or his wife's cousin's name,” said the shipping merchant beside him, and guffawed, and then remembered the company and turned the laugh into a cough.

Antonia let none of it touch her face. She filed the phrase — *the right list* — beside Cossus's *private re-weighing*, and asked the table, with the perfect hostess's gift for making inquiry sound like flattery, how a contractor even came to be on such a list. The answers, offered over figs and warmed wine, built themselves into a picture: the lists were subscriptions, nominally open, actually controlled by a handful of names that renewed themselves from contract to contract; entry required a sponsor inside the bureau and, it was understood, certain arrangements about the surplus; and the firms themselves appeared and dissolved with the regularity of seasons, their papers witnessed by the same small circle of signatories.

“Shells,” Beryllus said unexpectedly, from the end of the couch, where he had been silent through the fish. The table turned. “In Alexandria

we called them paper boats. They carry one cargo and sink. You'll notice none of these firms survives two contracts; a firm that endures keeps books that can be compared, and comparison is the enemy of the arrangement.” He helped himself to a fig with the air of a man who had said less than he knew, which was his usual air.

Marcus, watching Antonia across the lamps, saw her acknowledge the banker's sentence with the smallest inclination of her head, and understood that the supper had already paid for itself a dozen times over, though the bill for it would arrive at his own accounts in the morning.

The snub came during the dessert, and it came, as these things do, from the woman rather than the man.

Crassicia had spent the evening nursing her grievance, and the sweet wine did what sweet wine always does, and loosened the bolt on her tongue. The talk had turned to the new emperor's forum and the public dedications, and she said, across the table, with the bright voice of a woman pretending to be charming, “It's a mercy these ceremonies have standards of admission. One meets such *interesting* people everywhere else these days. Why, at the races I saw a senator's wife actually seated within greeting distance of the Carinae.”

A small, awful silence opened around the table. Porcia's smile became dangerous. Hilarus opened his mouth.

Marcus spoke first, quietly, in the level voice he used in the Curia, which was why every head turned.

“Mrs. Crassicia, the woman beside me has more arithmetic in her little finger than your husband's entire client list, and I include his accountant. She has built, with no name, no dowry, and no man's permission, an enterprise that pays more in taxes than your family's estates. Rome has a great many women of impeccable ancestry who have never done a useful thing in their lives, and it calls them respectable. If your standards of admission exclude competence and reward idleness, I'm content to be excluded from them myself.” He sipped his wine. “Pass the honey cakes.”

The philosopher's hand froze halfway to his plate. Celer stared at his brother with undisguised awe. Hilarus beamed like a sunrise. Crassicia turned the colour of the wine, and Crassicus developed a sudden absorbing interest in his napkin, and the conversation lurched forward again with the frantic energy of a cart righted after a wheel had come off.

Antonia said nothing at all. She ate a fig, slowly, and her face gave nothing away, and when the women rose at the end of the course she moved with the rest, and it was not until they were alone in the garden, under Hilarus's imported roses, that she turned on Marcus with her eyes like flint.

“Don't ever do that again.”

He blinked. “Defend you?”

“Humiliate a matron in public on my behalf. Do you understand what you've done? By tomorrow every dinner in Rome knows the consul-designate quarrelled with a consular wife over the Carinae woman. Perperna's writers don't need to invent jokes; you've given them the whole plot yourself.” Her voice was low and furious. “I don't need a champion, Marcus. I need a partner. Champions are expensive and partners are useful, and I have spent fifteen years being useful because it was the only kind of safe I was allowed.”

“I won't apologize.” He was standing very straight, the way he stood in the Senate. “She insulted you in a room where I was eating. A man who lets that pass isn't prudent; he's a coward.”

“And a woman who lets a man fight her battles isn't prudent, she's finished. We're not the same, and we won't be, and the sooner you stop treating me like a matron whose honour needs your sword, the longer we'll both survive.” She stopped, drew a breath, and some of the fire banked. “That's the whole of it. I know you meant well. Meaning well is the Romans' favourite luxury, and someone else always pays the bill.”

For a moment he looked as though he might argue; then, to his credit, he thought about it, and the thought changed his face.

“You're right. About the politics, at least. I'm not sorry for the words; I'm sorry for the cost to you. Will that do?”

“It'll have to.” She looked away, toward the roses, and the anger drained out of her leaving the older, harder thing beneath. “We keep having this conversation in different shapes. You keep reaching for the world as it ought to be, and I keep standing in the world as it is. In the world as it is, a man like you and a woman like me can be allies. We can even be friends. Nothing else is on offer, and I'd rather you knew it now than discovered it at the worst moment.”

“I know.” He said it simply. “I've known since the chapel. I'm not asking for anything, Antonia. I'm merely — trying to become the kind of man who'd be worth asking, if the world were different. It may be the only atonement available to me.”

The garden was very still. Somewhere inside, the water organ started a tune, thin and sweet through the colonnade.

“That's a dangerous ambition,” she said, more quietly. “The men worth asking generally lose the things the other men want.”

“Then perhaps I'm tired of wanting the other things.”

He had stepped closer as he said it, not with intention, the way a man steps toward a fire in a cold room, and she had not stepped back, and for a held breath the garden held its breath too — the

roses, the lamps, the distant music — and she could feel the warmth of him and smell the clean wool and the oil and the particular scent of a man who had spent his life out of doors, and fifteen years rose up in her like a tide, and she thought, with perfect clarity, *if he touches me now I will let him, and that is the most dangerous thought I have had in Rome.*

"You don't get to say that." Her voice came out harder than she intended, and she reined it in. "You have a wife, a son, a daughter, a consulship. You can be tired of wanting things because you've got them. I built mine from nothing, and if I weaken, if I let some grand romantic gesture carry the house off course, eleven women lose the safest roof they've ever known. There's no version of this where my heart gets to decide."

"I wasn't asking it to."

"You were standing close enough to. That's how it starts." She turned to face him fully, the roses behind her dark in the lamplight. "Let me tell you what I can't tell anyone else, because it might be the only honest thing I say all month. I have dreamed, for fifteen years, of a man who'd come through a door and see me — not the house, not the woman the city buys, me. And then you walked through my door, and it turned out you were the original, the first one, and the dream got complicated in ways I haven't finished calculating. That's not an invitation, Marcus. It's a warning. I'm not immune. I'm just in charge."

He absorbed that with the same patience he gave the audit tablets. “In charge is acceptable. Immune was never a requirement. I told you in the chapel: I'm not asking. I'm trying to become worth asking. That includes respecting the wall.”

“Then respect it from over there. Another pace back. Thank you.”

He stepped back, gravely, and the formality of it made something flicker between them that might have been amusement, and the amusement was more dangerous than the near-kiss had been, because it assumed a shared world.

Chloe appeared in the garden doorway at that exact moment, with the practised timing of a woman who had been watching from inside, and announced that Hilarus was calling for the Spanish brandy and Secundus had a story about a tax farmer and a mule that required witnesses. The moment broke like a reflection in a pond, and they went back in together, at a careful distance, and neither of them mentioned the garden again.

Over the brandy, Celer drank too much, as Celer did whenever his brother was in the room and his debts were in the air, and the charm loosened into the slurred confessions of a man who has decided to be loved for his sins.

“You all think I'm a fool,” he announced to the table at large. “That's quite all right; I think most of you are bores, so we're square. But I'll tell you what no fool ever understands, and that's how expensive *dignitas* is. My brother was born with

it; it grows on him like moss. I had to *rent* mine. The games, the house, the dinners, the four Syrians — every sesterce was a ticket to a room I was born into and couldn't afford. Perperna understood that before I did. He's not a villain, you know; villains want things. He's a surgeon. He found the place where the old families were bleeding and he put his mouth to it."

"Decimus." Marcus's voice was quiet, and it cut through the brandy fumes like a blade.

"Oh, don't *Decimus* me. I'm being profound. The philosopher should take notes." Celer lifted his cup with an unsteady hand. "To the bleeding families. May the surgeons be gentle."

Hilarus, with the host's instinct for rescue, started the mule story, and the party laughed on cue, and Marcus watched his younger brother with an expression Antonia could not read from across the room, though she guessed its ingredients: shame, love, and the cold knowledge that the charming drunk at the table was the weakest wall in the city, and Perperna knew it.

⁂

The ride home, in Hilarus's litter with Chloe opposite her and the torches bobbing along the road, was where Antonia paid for the evening.

"Your face," Chloe said.

"My face is none of your business."

“Your face is my business; I read it for a living. You're furious and something else, and the something else is what's keeping you awake.” Chloe settled against the cushions. “He's good at that, the senator. The quiet defence, the old-fashioned honour. It would be easier if he were a hypocrite like the rest of them. Instead he's the genuine article in a city of copies, which is much more dangerous.”

“I know what he is. I taught him his letters, remember; I've known what he is since we were children. That's the problem. If he were merely handsome and useful I could handle him the way I handle the guests.” Antonia stared out through the curtains at the dark road. “The danger isn't him. It's the girl I was, who thinks she deserves someone honest. I killed that girl in the Subura. I can't afford to find she survived.”

“Maybe she didn't die. Maybe she just went into business.”

“Worse.” Antonia closed her eyes. “Watch the house tomorrow. Perperna will answer the dinner; he always answers. I want to know before the messenger reaches the door.”

The answer came sooner than the morning. The litter had barely turned into the Carinae when Festus met it at the door with his street face on, and behind him in the vestibule stood a public messenger in the aedile's livery, holding out a sealed tablet with the careful blankness of a man paid not to know what he carried.

“Came an hour ago,” Festus said. “He's been made to wait, and he doesn't like it. Two witnesses with him, official. Also a man across the street selling nuts who's never sold a nut in his life; I've seen his face at the fountain.”

Antonia broke the seal in the tablinum, with Chloe reading over her shoulder. It was not the custody hearing — that paper she already held. This was a summons to present the house's licensing rolls, enrollment tablets, and the contracts of every woman resident, for inspection by the aedile's officers at the third hour of the following day, under the general review of houses of entertainment. The penalties for irregularity were listed with bureaucratic thoroughness: fines, closure, the transfer of residents to licensed houses of the city's choosing.

“That's tomorrow,” Chloe said.

“He counted on the dinner keeping me late and the wine keeping me slow. He doesn't know I don't get drunk.” Antonia set the summons beside her plate and began, immediately, to issue orders in the flat voice she used for fires and deaths. “Phyllis: every enrollment tablet out of the strong room, checked against the women, tonight. Chloe: the contracts, all of them, and the tax receipts back three years; find every gap and tell me before midnight. Festus: the three new guards on the door at dawn, and tell Vitalis I want every bar he hasn't finished finished by the second hour. If

the officers find a single loose hinge, it goes into the report as evidence of disorder."

"Tyche?" Chloe asked.

"Tyche stays in view, smiling, with her contract in her hand. Every woman in this house is going to be so completely in order that the aedile's men will weep with boredom." Antonia poured a cup of water and drank it standing. "He wants paper. We'll give him paper until it buries him."

They worked until the third watch. The tablinum became a scriptorium: Phyllis with the enrollment tablets, checking each woman's name against the aedile's register; Chloe with the contracts, her new accountancy showing its worth as she matched every seal to a receipt and every receipt to a date; Sabina, pressed into service for her clear handwriting, copying the tax record; even the musicians sat folding documents, and Festus tramped in periodically with progress on the bars, trailing the smell of iron and honest sweat.

It was during the midnight pause, with bread and diluted wine passed round, that Tyche said the thing the room had been avoiding.

"What if they don't care whether the papers are in order? What if they just — take us anyway?"

No one answered at once. The lamps flickered.

"Then they take me first," Antonia said, "and the documents are already in three other hands — Hilarus, the priestess, and a sealed packet at Beryllus's bank with instructions for its contents

to be read aloud in the Forum if I'm ever held without a public charge. Perperna knows this; it's the one reason I'm still sleeping in my own bed. Rome can't disappear me the way it disappeared Hector, because my disappearance has a price attached, and the city always pays its debts when they're properly documented." She looked round the room, at every face. "That's the lesson of tonight, and I want even the scullery girls to know it. Paper is the weapon they use on the helpless. We're not helpless, because we keep better paper."

Sabina, copying the last tax line, set her stylus down with the small determination of a girl making up her mind. "Then I want to learn the law. Not just letters. The law. The actual words they use."

"Start with the Twelve Tables in the library tomorrow," Antonia said. "They're old, but everything Perperna does is built on top of them, and you can't break a wall you've never measured."

By the second hour the work was done, the rolls sealed, the women sent to their rooms for what sleep they could get, and Antonia sat alone a moment in the cleared tablinum, listening to the house breathe. Somewhere beyond the walls a watchman called the hour, and the false nut-seller across the street had finally abandoned his stall, and Rome turned in its sleep like a great animal, and she set her own tablets in order, and

prepared to meet its officers in the morning with the one weapon they could not forge: the truth, correctly filed.

On the Esquiline, Marcus reached home to find Livia in the tablinum with her accounts, which was where she always was when she intended a difficult conversation, and he sat down across from her and waited.

“You defended her at dinner,” she said, without looking up.

“News travels.”

“News gallops. Crassicia sent round a note before the second course was cleared; she's been composing it in her head since the insult. Marcus—” now she did look up “—I've asked nothing of you in fifteen years except the appearances that protect the children. I'm asking now. Be careful. Not for my sake; for Gaius's. A consulship fathers can pass to sons; a scandal fathers nothing.”

“There's been no scandal. There's been a business partnership over the audit, and one dinner-table argument with a rude woman.”

“And the races, and the temple, and the broadsheets, and the way you look when her name's said.” Livia set down her stylus. “I'm not a fool, and I'm not asking you to pretend you don't feel whatever you feel. I'm asking you to keep it out of the record, because the record is all Rome keeps. Do that, and I remain your ally; I've even met the woman, as you know, and she's more than

her reputation. Fail to do it, and I'll defend the children's name against both of you, and you won't enjoy the experience.”

He looked at his wife with the respect he had never quite learned to turn into love, and said, “You have my word. Nothing will touch the children, or the name. Whatever else happens.”

“Good. Then we understand one another, which is more than most married couples achieve.” She picked up the stylus again. “Your brother, by the way, has been up to something. My steward caught him this afternoon trying to have the Palatine house valued by a private agent. He means to sell it, secretly, to clear Perperna. I've had the deeds moved to my own strong box. You'll deal with him in the morning, or I will, and my version involves more witnesses.”

“The house isn't his to sell. It's family property, entailed on Gaius.”

“Entail is a moral rule, not a wall; a man with a forged witness will climb it. That's why the deeds are in my box, not his reach.” Livia permitted herself a thin smile. “You see why I keep the accounts. The Aelii produce heroes and spendthrifts in alternation, like a law of nature; the women do the actual surviving.”

He almost laughed. It was, he reflected, the nearest thing to a joke she had made in his company in a year.

“Will you tell me one thing honestly?” he said. “At the baths. You met her. What did you make of her?”

Livia considered the question, and him, with her head slightly tilted, the way she considered bids at auction.

“I made a woman who would have run the Senate better than half its members, if the Senate admitted women, which is precisely why it doesn't. I also made a rival who refuses to behave like one, which is infuriating.” She returned to her columns. “She's in love with you, by the way. Not that she'll admit it; she's far too disciplined. I've managed households for fifteen years, Marcus; I know the difference between a woman using a man and a woman pretending not to feel one. Use that knowledge carefully, because I will not repeat it, and I will deny it at need.”

Marcus sat very still. “And you?”

“I am the mother of your children and the keeper of your name, and I will be both until I die. What I feel is my own property, and Roman wives are allowed at least that.” She did not look up. “Good night. Deal with Decimus at dawn; he's always weakest before breakfast.”

Marcus sighed, and rubbed his eyes, and thought that between his wife, his brother, and the woman in the Carinae, he was being managed in three directions at once, and that the oddest thing was that all three of them were, in their different ways, right.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Borrowed Money

The aedile's officers arrived at the third hour precisely, four of them in official dress with a clerk and two witnesses, and they came through the gilded door with the careful blankness of men who have been told to find something and have not yet been told what.

Antonia received them in the atrium, dressed in the dark formal gown she kept for the law, with the household's documents stacked on the citrus-wood table in labelled piles and Phyllis standing behind her like a second, more terrifying document.

“Gentlemen. The rolls, the enrollments, the contracts, three years of tax receipts, and the house's entertainment license under the aedile's own seal. Wine while you work, or water? I'd recommend water; my wine tends to make inspections friendly, and friendly inspections look bad in the report.”

The senior officer, a tired-looking man named Fonteius who had spent twenty years inspecting things, allowed himself the smallest smile. “Water, domina. We'll be quick.”

They were not quick. They were thorough, because thoroughness had been ordered, and the house endured it with the disciplined calm of a fortress being measured for siege engines. The enrollment tablets matched the women, one by one, each woman presenting herself with her contract and her statement of consent, witnessed and sealed. The tax receipts were perfect; Beryllus had audited them himself. The license was current. The premises were measured against their permitted use, the water supply inspected, the kitchen examined, the sleeping rooms counted and found to contain exactly the number of beds the rolls declared.

Fonteius's clerk grew visibly frustrated. Scribbling in the margins, he kept glancing at his superior, and Fonteius kept his face on the documents, and Antonia watched the two of them and understood the shape of the morning: they had been promised irregularities, and the absence of irregularities was itself an inconvenience they would have to explain.

At the end, Fonteius closed the final roll and tied its thong.

“Everything appears in order, domina. One administrative point: the witness mark on the enrollment of the woman Tyche is dated the seventh, while the aedile's register records the eighth. A clerk's error, likely at our end. I'm required to note it and levy the standard penalty of fifty sesterces, pending correction.”

“Fifty sesterces for the city's dating error. Very reasonable.” She counted the coins onto the table herself. “Will that be all?”

“The review remains open. Further inspections may occur.” He met her eyes, and in them she saw the professional's silent message: *I do my job, nothing more, don't blame the messenger.* “Good day, domina.”

The room-by-room took two hours, and Antonia walked it with them herself, because the mistress's presence was itself a kind of order. In the dining wing the clerk tested the couch measurements against the permitted use; in the kitchens he examined the accounts of the food, as though bread were evidence; in the baths he counted the basins. In the women's wing each woman presented herself in turn, and Antonia had rehearsed them until the performances were invisible: Tyche with her contract and her steady voice, the musicians with their enrollment tablets, Sabina last and youngest, her debt-paper in her hand and her chin at exactly the angle Chloe had taught.

“What's this one?” the clerk asked, with the slight sneer minor officials use to feel major.

“Sabina Aviania, debt-bond under a sealed and witnessed contract, enrolled under the house's license, with a copy at the temple of Isis.” Antonia's voice was pleasant. “You'll find the seal matches Vipsanius's own mark, unless his mark has changed since last week.”

The clerk found nothing. In the garden court he lingered by the fountain, plainly searching for something to put in a margin, and Fonteius, who had seen twenty years of this, said, “The fish are licensed too, clerk. Write that down if you must, and let's be done.”

At the door, when his men had gone ahead, the senior officer hung back and spoke low.

“Domina. Off the record, which is a phrase I've learned in this trade. The instructions came from above the aedile, and the pressure came from above that. Someone wants this house. I don't know who; I don't want to know. But a clean inspection won't end it; it'll merely make them change tools. Watch the doors, watch the women's families, and watch for an informer in the street more than one in the house. They rarely get inside; they pay the people outside.” He lifted his chin. “Good day.”

When the door had closed behind them, Chloe let out a breath. “Nothing. They found nothing.”

“They found fifty sesterces and a clerk's error, which means he'll go back and report that the house is clean, and Perperna will have to decide whether the law is worth more to him as a weapon or as a story.” Antonia scooped the receipted penalty into the strong box. “The law was never the point. The point was to make us spend a night afraid and a morning performing. Fear is cheaper than evidence; he's testing whether we flinch.”

“Did we flinch?”

“Not where he could see. Tyche—” she turned, but the lyre player had already stepped forward.

“I was ready. I had my contract. I didn't cry, even when they wrote my name down.” Tyche's chin was up. “The man from the market was outside, by the fountain, watching the officers go in. I saw him.”

“Good. He'll carry home the news that the inspection found nothing but dust. Let him.” Antonia dismissed the household to its ordinary work and stood alone a moment in the restored atrium, looking at the gilded door, and thought that Perperna's failure here would not end the matter; it would move him to a sharper instrument, and she needed to know which one before it touched her.

⁂

On the Esquiline, the Aelii were holding the kind of family council that Roman families had held since the Republic, behind closed doors, with no servants present and the household gods looking down from the lararium.

Celer stood in the centre of the tablinum because he could not sit, and Marcus and Livia sat across the table from him like two judges, which, in effect, they were.

The debts were spread on the table between them, and Marcus had spent the morning arranging them in the order a banker would,

which was not the order Celer had kept them in, because Celer had kept them in no order at all, each in its own drawer of dread. Added and set in columns, they made a small, precise monument: gaming debts to two clubs, a bond for the Palatine apartment, sums borrowed against expectations from three professional lenders, and, at the bottom of the pile, the loans from the soft-voiced gentleman whose terms were so gentle that he had not seemed, at the time, like a lender at all.

“Read the rate on this one aloud,” Marcus said.

“Twenty-four. Per cent.” Celer's voice was small.

“Per annum. Compound. On a debt that's been rolled twice. Do you know what twenty-four per cent means in plain figures? It means that in three years, without borrowing another sesterce, you will owe twice what you took. In six years, four times. The man didn't lend you money, Celer. He bought you on instalments, and the instalments were designed to fail.” Marcus pushed the tablets away from him with two fingers, the gesture of a man forcing himself to keep his temper. “Who witnessed these? I don't recognize half the names.”

“Friends of his. He brought his own witnesses to every signing. I thought that was — efficient. Like using his own notary.”

Livia spoke for the first time, and her voice was colder than her husband's, because her husband still had the luxury of anger and she had only the

clarity of the family's accountant. “Efficient is the right word. Every document in this pile has the same fault, Celer: not one of them contains a single witness independent of the lender. In a Roman court that's not yet fatal, because your signature is your signature, but it means the whole structure was built to be operated by one hand. A lender who brings his own witnesses intends to use his own witnesses later, for whatever he needs them to say.” She tapped the lowest tablet. “This one. The one with the gentle rate. What else did you sign at those meetings, besides the loans?”

The silence that followed was the answer, and Marcus watched the colour leave his brother-in-law's face and felt, beneath his anger, the first cold touch of the larger shape. “Celer. What else?”

“Bundles. Sometimes there were other papers, with the loans. Subscriptions, he called them. Just formalities, to show I was a man of property worth lending to. I signed them with the loans, in the same sitting, without — I didn't read every line, Marcus, there were dozens, and the wine was good, and he never once made me feel like a debtor—”

“Of course he didn't. A man being made to feel like a debtor reads the contract. A man being made to feel like a friend signs it.” Marcus closed his eyes briefly and saw, behind them, the paper boats Beryllus had described at the Carinae

supper, carrying one cargo and sinking, witnessed by the same small circle of names. “Describe his seal. The lender's. And the steward or freedman who attended him. Everything you can remember; don't decide in advance what's important. The smallest detail is the one these men forget to hide, because no one's ever bothered to ask before.”

Celer, shaking, began to talk, and Livia wrote, and the winter afternoon shortened around the tablinum while the family's private disgrace slowly revealed itself, line by line, as the edge of a public crime.

He remembered, under their patient questioning, more than he had known he carried: the tavern near the Circus where the introductions happened, the landlord who always seemed to have a room free; the freedman with the Minerva seal who witnessed everything and wrote nothing himself; the dinners at which other young debtors sat at other couches, each one flattered, each one signing, none of them ever introduced to one another, because a network of debtors who knew one another was a conspiracy, while debtors who met only their creditor was a business. Marcus marked the isolation as the tell. Honest lenders assembled references; this one assembled strangers.

At the end Livia sanded the last tablet and said, without heat, “He doesn't lend to men who can repay, Celer. That's the part you've been too ashamed to see. He lends to men who can be

made to sign, and the debt was never the product. The signatures are. You're not his customer. You're his inventory.”

The young man put his face in his hands, and Marcus let him sit so, because some understanding arrives only through shame, and to shorten it would be to leave it unfinished.

“Again,” Marcus said. “From the beginning. Every figure, every name, every seal. Leave out the charm; I've no use for it this morning.”

Celer told it. It came out in pieces, the way truths extracted from charming men always do, but it came. The Palatine house, mortgaged. The aedile's games, overspent by two-thirds. The horses, the dinners, the loans from ordinary bankers, and then, when the ordinary bankers refused him, the introduction to Perperna, arranged by a man he called a friend. Fifteen thousand at twenty-four per cent. The subscriptions in the eastern supply firms, presented as the sure road to repayment. The witnessing of documents in bundles he had not read. And, finally, the request, last month, that he use his family access to place his brother's seal on certain papers “as a formality.”

Livia's face did not change. Marcus's did, by degrees, the way weather changes over mountains.

“You used my seal.”

“I didn't know what it was for! They said — Perperna said — it was family witnessing, that

everyone's name went on everything, that it protected me—”

“It protected *him*. You gave a forger the key to my name.” Marcus's voice was low and controlled, which frightened Celer more than shouting would have. “Do you understand that if the audit report goes against the schedule, the witness line puts me in the dock beside you? That's the design. You weren't borrowing money, Decimus. You were being assembled into a weapon.”

“I know that now. Gods, I know.” The handsome face crumpled, genuinely, and for a moment he looked like the small boy who had followed Marcus through the villa gardens. “I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. Tell me what to do and I'll do it. Sell the Palatine house—”

“I've already moved the deeds,” Livia said. “You'll sign nothing further without three witnesses, and I mean nothing, including dinner invitations. Your allowance continues, because the Aelii don't starve their fools in public, but every creditor is to be referred to me. Is that understood?”

“Yes. Yes, Livia. Thank you.”

“Don't thank me. I'm protecting Gaius's inheritance, not your feelings.” She turned to Marcus. “The legal question. If he turns his evidence and cooperates with the audit, what becomes of him?”

Marcus had prepared for this. “The praetor can grant relief to a witness who exposes fraud before

prosecution — restitution of what can be recovered, loss of the subscriptions, and probably exile rather than criminal conviction, if he's useful enough and early enough. Wait for Perperna to strike first, and he's merely a defendant, and the best he gets is total ruin and the mines."

"Then he goes early." Livia said it without hesitation, and Celer flinched. "Against Perperna? Husband, be realistic. One brother's testimony against the most successful accuser in Rome—"

"Not alone. There are the weight notes from Ostia, the tanners' receipts, the seal-engraver, and the duplicate tablets of the murdered clerk." Marcus laid it out as he might lay a campaign. "Perperna's strength is that no one has ever assembled the whole machine in one place before. We assemble it. Celer gives the inside of the loans; the merchants give the outside of the supplies; the tablets give the figures; Syrus gives the forgeries. And then it goes before a magistrate under my name, which is the one name in Rome he can't buy."

Celer stared. "You'd really do it. You'd bring it yourself, with *me* in the evidence."

"I'd do it if you were a stranger. That's the part you've never understood about me, and the part Perperna didn't count on." Marcus stood. "But first, you and I are going to the Aventine, to the little banker who handles the private gold. If the money has a head, I want to see its face. Go and

change; wear something respectable, and for once look as though you deserve it.”

The door opened. Gaius stood in it with his school tablets, having come in at some point through the colonnade, and his face showed that he had heard enough — the loans, the seal, the word exile.

“You were listening,” Marcus said.

“I didn't mean to. The door was open.” The boy looked at his uncle, and Celer could not meet the look. “Is it true? About the seal. Uncle Decimus used your name.”

“Your uncle has made a series of foolish mistakes, and he's going to help us put them right. That's all you need know.”

“It's not all.” Gaius's voice had the rigidity of a boy forcing himself to be a man. “If the family name is in the ledgers, then mine is too. I want to know what's being done about it.”

Livia, who had said nothing for ten minutes, studied her son with something like pride. “Your father is doing what the Aelii always do when the family's at risk: the difficult thing in the open. Go to your room, Gaius. Not because this doesn't concern you, but because it does, and you'll be better use to us with your rhetoric finished than standing in a council you can't yet vote in.”

When he had gone, Celer said, into the silence, “He looked at me as though I were a stranger.”

“You are a stranger to him now,” Marcus said. “You can become his uncle again by being worth knowing. Change your clothes.”

“I'd do it if I were you,” Livia said, with the first kindness she had shown him all morning. “The Aventine bankers despise shabby aristocrats almost as much as I do.”

⁂

The Aventine banker was named Longinus, and his establishment was deliberately modest — a small counting house above a wine shop, two clerks, a guard, and an air of having no importance whatever, which Marcus recognized instantly as the hallmark of the truly dangerous kind of bank.

Longinus himself was a thin, cautious man with the eyes of a dormouse, and the sight of a consul-designate in his doorway nearly stopped his heart.

“Senator. This is — an honour. If I'd known—”

“You didn't know, and that's why we're here.” Marcus sat uninvited, and Celer sat beside him, pale and silent. “I want the account history of the eastern supply subscriptions: the private deposits, the withdrawals, the names behind the names. I can ask with a magistrate's warrant tomorrow, in public, which will ruin you by noon, or you can show me the ledgers now, in private, and I'll

remember a cooperative witness when the case opens. Choose.”

The dormouse eyes flickered to Celer, and something moved in them — recognition, and fear.

“You don't understand, Senator. I don't own this bank. I run it. The names behind the accounts—” He swallowed. “They're names I've never written down. I keep them in my head, because heads are harder to seize than ledgers. And the name at the top—”

“Perperna,” Marcus said.

“Perperna is the instrument. The hand above him—” Longinus stopped, looked at his own two clerks, and lowered his voice until it was nearly breath. “I've a wife in Ostia and a daughter unmarried. If I tell you this, I need more than a remembered favour. I need a witness program, a sealed letter to the prefect, and my family's passage before the news moves.”

“You have my word, witnessed here by my brother and your own clerks.” Marcus pushed a tablet across the table. “Write the account structure now. Names, dates, sums. The hand above Perperna.”

Longinus wrote for the better part of an hour, in a small precise hand, while the wine shop below roared through the floorboards and Celer sat sweating into his respectable tunic. When the banker finally set the stylus down, the top of the tablet bore a name that made Marcus sit very still.

It was not Perperna's. It belonged to a senior imperial freedman, a man in the office of the rationibus, the central finance bureau — the official through whom the emperor's own supply correspondence passed.

“There's your hand,” Longinus said, and his voice had gone grey. “The fraud isn't a conspiracy against the state, Senator. Parts of the state are inside it. That's why the tallies pass every review. Now will you tell me what in the world you intend to do, because I should like to begin packing.”

Marcus looked at the name for a long time. He had expected a villain, and found a system; he had expected a fight in the Forum, and saw instead the long, dim corridor that led toward the Palatine itself.

“I intend,” he said finally, “to make sure that when this falls, it falls on the men who built it, and not on the soldiers waiting for boots in the East. Copy that tablet, Longinus, and make three copies. One for me, one for my — for Antonia Cassia's strong room, and one for the prefect's office, sealed, with a date for opening if anything happens to any of us. You're not the only one who needs insurance.”

Outside on the Aventine street, in the grey winter light, Celer said, very quietly, “Now do you see why I signed everything they put in front of me?”

“I see why you were frightened. I don't yet see whether you're brave. The next month will decide.”

They walked down through the Aventine lanes in silence for a while, past the tall granaries and the little temples to foreign gods, and Marcus turned the freedman's name over in his mind. An official in the office *a rationibus* changed everything. The audit he had been handed was not merely crooked; it was permitted. Somewhere above the contracts, a man with the emperor's ear had decided that the eastern war would be supplied by whatever means kept the gold moving, and the fraud was less a crime than an informal tax, collected by men like Perperna and laundered through men like Longinus.

“One thing,” Celer said, as they reached the busier street. “Perperna asked me, last month, about the Carinae house. Not business — the woman. Whether she'd ever — whether I knew her habits, the women's families, who came and went. I laughed it off, but he kept asking. He's building a case against her, Marcus, not just an inspection. Something public and loud.”

“I know. He means to use her house the way he uses everything: a door to something larger. If he can discredit her, he discredits anything her guests have said in her rooms, including anything I've learned there. The audit itself becomes a scandal.” Marcus stopped at the crossroads. “Go home. Stay sober. Speak to no one about

Longinus, not even Livia's steward. And Decimus — what you did today, coming clean, that's the first brave thing I've seen from you. Don't undo it tonight.”

Celer attempted the old smile, found it didn't fit, and merely nodded, and the brothers parted in the crowd, the one climbing toward the Esquiline and the other down toward the river, each carrying his own portion of the same dangerous knowledge.

Marcus did not go straight home. He walked instead to the Temple of Saturn, where the standards and the public reserves were kept, and stood a while among the money-lenders' stalls watching the treasury doors, and thought about a state that stored its gold in a temple and stole it back through its clerks, and about the difference between the law and justice, which his teachers had always claimed was small, and which his forty years were teaching him was the whole subject of Roman life.

⁂

In the Carinae, the same afternoon produced its own discovery, of a smaller but sharper kind.

Chloe had spent two days teaching herself the loan side of her brother's tablets, and she came to the tablinum with a parchment covered in her neat Greek hand and the particular expression,

Antonia knew, of a clerk who has found the pattern.

“The ninety-modii rhythm was the machine's signature on the grain side. I've found the equivalent on the money side.” She laid the parchment down. “Every transfer to the Aventine bank happens on the same day of the month, the day before the treasury pays the schedule. The phantom grain is sold, the gold is deposited, and the treasury reimburses the false tally inside twenty-four hours. It's circular; the state lends itself its own money and Perperna's circle keeps the difference.”

“Whoever runs it has an informant inside the treasury itself.”

“Or inside the bureau that tells the treasury what to pay.” Chloe pointed to a column. “And here's the seal story. The witness marks repeat across the changing firm names — four marks, always the same four, in the same order. My brother wrote a note beside them: *Syrus can name these.* The engraver isn't just a witness to one forgery. He made the seals for the whole machine. If he talks, every contract of the last two years collapses at once.”

“Which is exactly why he's stopped answering his door.” Antonia thought. “We can't wait for him to grow brave; frightened men don't. We'll have to make him safer than his fear. Hilarus can house him at the warehouse with Dorion. Festus can

collect him, quietly, through the back lanes. Send word tonight."

Tyche arrived before the message could go, and she was breathing hard, having run from the market, and the silver dove brooch was gone from her mantle.

"He changed. Today. No gifts, no stories. He asked me to bring him a copy of the house's guest list — who dines here, the names and the nights. When I said I couldn't, he got angry. Not loud; the quiet kind. He said his friend was losing patience, and women who didn't help their protectors had to take their chances with the law." She swallowed. "Then he said something else. He asked whether I knew where the Greek tablets were kept. Hector's tablets. He used Hector's name."

The room went cold.

Antonia and Chloe looked at each other, and the same thought passed between them without a word: the man's masters believed the tablets might be in the house. They had killed for them once, and failed to find them, and now they were hunting them through the women.

"Tyche, you've done exactly right, and you're not going back to that market." Antonia's voice was steady as stone. "From now on, two of Festus's men go everywhere with you. If you see him again, anywhere, you don't speak, you don't run — you signal, and we do the rest. Chloe, move the originals tonight. The strong room's been

named in their minds, so it's no longer safe enough. Temple of Isis, the priestess's own coffer, tomorrow at first light. Hilarus keeps the copies; the originals go to the goddess."

"And the engraver?"

"The engraver gets collected first thing, before they think of him too." Antonia picked up her stylus and began the night's orders, her hand as calm as if she were planning a dinner, and outside the window the December light failed over the rooftops, and the city lit its ten thousand lamps, and somewhere in a small house on the Tiber bank a frightened man with a gift for seals sat listening to every footstep in the street.

Festus went for Syrus that night, with Vitalis and one of the new guards, and he did it the gladiator's way: no litters, no torches, three men in dark cloaks through the back lanes by the cattle market, where the smell of hides covered the smell of fear.

Syrus's house was shuttered, and the door was barred from inside, and it took Festus two knocks and a low sentence through the wood before the bar moved. The engraver who opened it was a small, grey Syrian with clever hands that shook, and behind him in the lamp-lit room were a packed satchel and a wife clutching a box of tools.

"You're from the Carinae house," Syrus said. It was not a question. "I've been expecting someone. I did not know whose colours to hope for."

“Mine are blue, and so are the house's.” Festus stepped inside, filled the room, and spoke with the careful gentleness he used with frightened people. “You're not being taken. You're being moved, with your wife and your tools, to a warehouse owned by Hilarus the oil merchant, where two guards owe me their lives and a Greek measurer is already hiding. No one knows the address but the domina and me. In return, you'll be asked, in good time, to identify seals in a real court, before a real magistrate, with a consul-designate's protection. Refuse, and stay here, where the men who killed Hector already know your street.”

The engraver looked at his wife. She clutched the toolbox tighter and said, in the accented Latin of the Eastern ports, “We go. I have buried one husband; I will not bury another over wax.”

They went out through the back, along the river path, up through the market lanes, and reached the warehouse an hour before midnight. Dorion the measurer, hollow-eyed, met them with hot broth, and Festus barred the door and posted the guards, and came back through the sleeping city with the dawn beginning to grey the roofs, and reported to Antonia over bread and water that the house now held, between its own walls and Hilarus's, every witness and every copy it needed except one.

“Which one?” she asked.

“The one that can't be moved.” Festus sat heavily. “The name at the top. The freedman in the bureau. Men like that don't hide in warehouses. They live in palaces, and the only way to reach them is across an open forum with the whole city watching.”

“Then that's where we'll take it,” Antonia said. “Start polishing the story. Every case Rome has ever lost was lost before it reached the court; the winning happens in the preparation, and we have a great deal of preparing still to do.”

She took the original tablets to Isis herself at first light, with Chloe and Festus and no litters, wrapped in a cloth among the temple offerings of bread and lotus flowers. The priestess received them in the inner chamber where the votive records were kept, and laid the oilskin bundle in a stone coffer beneath a shelf of wooden hands and eyes, the goddess's grateful healed.

“These papers could ruin powerful men,” the priestess observed, in the calm voice of a woman beyond such arithmetic.

“They could save eleven women and a good name or two.”

“The goddess does not care about names. She cares about the oppressed, which is why Rome's masters tolerate her and Rome's slaves adore her.” She sealed the coffer with her own ring and pressed a second clay seal into Antonia's hand. “Two seals to open it, yours and mine. If you don't come for them, they stay with Isis, which is

perhaps the safest place in the city; even Perperna hesitates before the gods of the poor, because the poor have so little else."

Walking back through the waking streets, Chloe said, "You really believe she'll protect them?"

"I believe in walls, seals, and women with no reason to betray me. The goddess can do as she pleases; the priestess is what I trust." Antonia tucked the clay seal inside her stola. "And now we wait. He's failed the inspection, his witness inside the market's gone quiet, and the tablets are beyond his reach. A man like Perperna doesn't wait. He'll do something theatrical, and soon."

"What kind of theatrical?"

"The kind that makes the neighbours scream."

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Raid

They came at the tenth hour of the night, two nights before the Saturnalia, when the house was at its fullest and most respectable: a supper of twelve covers, three magistrates among the guests, music in the great triclinium, and the gilded door attended, as always, by Festus.

He heard them before he saw them — the measured tramp of boots in the street, not the loose shuffle of revellers, and the creak of official harness — and he had the inner bar across and the warning bell pulled before the knock came. The bell rang softly in the women's wing, once, the sound that meant *doors, bolts, no one alone.*

The officer at the front was not Fonteius. It was a hard man named Pulcher from the night watch, with a sealed warrant in his hand and eight men behind him, and behind them, Antonia noted from the shadow of the colonnade, the public slaves who carried the measuring rods and the portable brazier, the equipment of a search.

“Warrant of the urban praetor,” Pulcher said, when she came to the door herself, in formal dress and with every lamp lit behind her.

“Information received that a free woman is detained in this house against her will, that unlicensed women are employed in entertainment, and that stolen property is concealed on the premises. We're to search, and the residents are to give statements.”

“On whose information?”

“The warrant doesn't say. It says to search.”

“Then search, officer, and do it quietly. I have magistrates at supper, and the praetor's own colleague among them, which is a fact I'd mention in your report. Every room is open to you except the women's sleeping quarters, which may be entered only with the women present and one of my freedwomen as witness. Those are the terms of the law; I'm sure you know them.”

Pulcher's jaw tightened. He had expected tears, bribes, or panic; he got procedure, which was worse. He pushed past her with the men, and the raid began.

They did it thoroughly, because thoroughness had been ordered. Rods measured the rooms against the licensed plan. Lamps were lifted, couches dismantled, the strong room door examined and noted, the kitchen stores turned over. In the triclinium the twelve guests sat frozen with their cups halfway to their mouths, and the three magistrates turned the colours of their own wine, because a raid on a supper table was the kind of scandal that clung to everyone present; then the senior of them, a praetor of long

experience, set down his cup and said, very clearly, “Officer, my colleague and I are witnesses to every moment of this. Conduct yourself accordingly,” and Pulcher's back grew visibly stiffer.

Antonia moved through it all like a hostess at an awkward party, calm, polite, directing slaves to open this and carry that, and once, passing Chloe's couch, she murmured without moving her lips, “Tyche. They'll try her. Get to her first.”

Chloe was already moving.

They found Tyche in the garden court, where she had gone the moment the bell rang, and a clerk had her seated on a bench with a tablet on his knee and his voice pitched low and friendly, the voice of men who buy statements.

“—no trouble at all, just a few words, and the praetor's office is very grateful to girls who help. You saw the new girl arrive, didn't you? The debt girl. Were there papers? Was she frightened? Did anyone say what would happen if she wanted to leave? Just tell it in your own words and make your mark here—”

“Her own words would be wasted on your wax.” Chloe sat down between them, serene as a temple statue, with the household's enrollment roll in her hand. “Tyche is enrolled under the eighth clause of the aedile's regulation, and she gives no statement without a witness of her choosing, which is me. If you want her words, officer, you'll take them down in the tablinum, in

front of the domina, and you'll read them back before she marks. Anything else is coercion, and the praetor's colleague is thirty feet away.”

The clerk's smile thinned. “Perhaps the young lady would prefer to speak privately.”

“I would not,” Tyche said. Her voice shook slightly, and her hand was steady, and she did not look away. “I've nothing to say except that I'm here by contract, of my free will, and paid as agreed. You can write that, if it's useful.”

In the dining room the officers' search reached the couches, and a young provincial governor's secretary, two years in Rome and terrified of scandal, made the mistake of standing in their way and demanding their names. Pulcher's clerk wrote *his* name down with visible pleasure, and the young man went white. Antonia was beside him before the ink dried.

“Breathe. They record names because names are the only thing they've found. The praetor's colleague is a witness; nothing in this room touches a guest. Sit down, eat your dates, and let them measure the cushions.” She raised her voice just enough for the nearest officers. “Any statement taken from a guest without his own advocate present is void, as the officer knows. We're all very boring and very lawful in this house.”

The secretary sat. The officers moved on. The praetor, watching from the middle couch, gave

Antonia a small, grave nod, the nod of one professional to another.

In the strong-room passage, Pulcher tried the other door, the one to the upper stairs where Hector had died, and Festus stood in the gap.

“Private wing.”

“Warrant covers the house.”

“The women are dressing. Go up there in front of twelve guests and three magistrates and explain to the praetor why you're chasing half-dressed girls instead of stolen property.” Festus did not raise his voice. He did not need to. “I'll wait. Take your time.”

Pulcher looked at him — the scarred eyebrow, the neck like a bull's, the enormous calm — and decided against the stairs.

In the kitchens a searcher upended a flour sack, the classic gesture of the hostile inspection, and the cook, an artist with a temper that had survived three owners, said, in a voice like gravel, “Find anything in my flour and I'll expect it back by dawn; I've bread to make,” and went on slicing dates with a knife the size of a short sword, and the searcher moved on.

In the women's wing the musicians sat together on one couch with their enrollment tablets in their laps, as rehearsed, and Sabina sat among them with her debt-paper visible in her hand, and when a clerk put his head round the door and asked whether anyone was being held against her will, six women answered “No” in the

same breath, in the same tone, and the uniformity of it defeated him, because coercion does not produce choruses.

They found nothing. There was nothing to find; the original tablets were with Isis, the copies were under Hilarus's olive jars, and the house's only concealed weapons were Festus's legal knife and the little blades strapped inside the women's sleeves, which were not, strictly, weapons at all. At midnight, Pulcher assembled his men in the atrium, and the clerk read out the findings: a fine of two hundred sesterces for a technical irregularity in the night watch's registration, and a formal warning that the review remained open.

“Two hundred sesterces for a night watchman's signature,” Antonia said, counting the coins. “A bargain. Is that all, officer?”

“The praetor's office can return at any hour.”

“So can my guests' wives. Good night, Pulcher.”

When the door had shut and the bar had dropped, the supper party exhaled as one body. The praetor rose, adjusted his toga, and said to Antonia with dry formality, “Domina, your hospitality remains excellent and your paperwork remains exemplary. I'll mention at the Palatine that the city's officers are being used to frighten magistrates at dinner; perhaps someone will care.” He paused. “Or perhaps not. But I'll mention it.”

The guests departed into the night with the thoughtful faces of men recalculating their friendships, and the house set about restoring itself, and not one of the women cried until the doors were closed, and then two of the musicians did, quietly, in the women's court, and Phyllis sat with them and said nothing, which was the right thing.

By the third hour the couches were remade, the mosaics were washed, and the house looked, as it always looked by morning, untouched. That, Antonia said, walking the rooms with Phyllis, was the first answer to a raid: the city must see the door open at the usual hour with the usual flowers, and no trace of panic on the staff.

Hilarus came before sunrise with the counter-letter already drafted, written by a jurist he kept on retainer for exactly such mornings. It was a masterpiece of restrained offence: a calm statement that a warranted inspection, conducted in the presence of a sitting praetor, had found the house's licenses, enrollments, and contracts entirely in order, with only a minor watch-register technicality, and that the undersigned guests testified to the good order of the establishment. Twelve copies went out before noon to the twelve guests, with a request for their seals. Eleven came back by evening; the twelfth, the terrified young secretary, sent his through his superior, with a note of apology so abject it was almost worth the raid.

The street did its own accounting, as the street always does, and its conclusions arrived with the water sellers before the ninth hour. The raid had been watched from fifty windows: the officers, the praetor's unexpected arrival, the guests leaving unmolested at the proper hour, and — the detail that travelled fastest — the gilded door opening at dawn with fresh flowers in its brackets and the usual music practice drifting over the wall. A house that had been raided and stood open at sunrise was a house the raid had failed to break, and the Carinae, which loved nothing so much as a winner, adjusted its opinion with the speed of a market price.

The fuller, who had been wavering over the house's laundry contract, sent his boy round to confirm the year's terms before noon. The baker's wife brought a warm loaf “for the young women, after their fright,” and stayed to extract the whole story from the kitchen, which gave it back to her in the version Antonia had prepared: licensed, inspected, vindicated, and not at all frightened. Even the nut-seller at the fountain, whose reports to Perperna's agents Festus had long since identified, found himself the recipient of a free cup of warmed wine and a carefully edited account of praetorian praise, which he sold onward within the hour, exactly as intended.

Inside, the household's own recovery was conducted with equal discipline and rather more honesty. Antonia called the women together in the

garden court after the morning's work, with Phyllis beside her and Chloe taking the names, and she said the thing plainly, because plain speech was the house's currency.

“Last night was the first time most of you have seen officers at the door. It will not be the last. The men who want what this house holds will come with warrants, then with rumours, then, if those fail, with worse. I want you to know the drill the way you know your songs. If the door is forced, no one runs; running is what the frightened do, and frightened women fill prisons. You go to the garden court in your pairs, you stay together, and you answer no question without my presence or Chloe's. You have the right to a witness; the right is written into your enrollment, and Sabina has made every one of you copy it out in your own hand, so no one can ever say you were not told. Your rooms are your own; a warrant that names the strong room does not open the women's wing, and any officer who says otherwise is breaking the very law he serves, and Festus has instructions to write his name down.”

“Will they really come back?” one of the younger musicians asked, white about the mouth.

“Yes. But the next time, you'll know what to do, and knowing what to do is the whole difference between a house and a trap.” She let that settle, and then said the rest, the part no pamphlet would ever print. “Also: I am proud of you. Not one of you screamed, hid, or blamed another.

Whatever the city calls us, inside this wall we are people who keep our heads, and that is rarer and more valuable than anything the city sells.”

When they had dispersed, Phyllis said quietly, “You've made them soldiers.”

“I've made them citizens of the only republic that will ever have them.” Antonia watched the women return to their work, the music practice resuming note by note. “The raid cost us a night and some nerves. It bought us something worth more: eleven sealed statements and a household that now knows its own strength. Perperna thinks he tested us. He trained us.”

“Now the raid becomes our advertisement,” Chloe said, reading the sealed responses.

“It becomes a fact on paper, which is better than an advertisement.” Antonia filed them with the contracts. “The next time Perperna whispers about the disorderly house, the whisper has to pass through a praetor's witness statement. He's not stopped; he's merely been made more expensive.”

“And more dangerous,” Phyllis said, from the door. “Men like that don't forgive embarrassment. They just change the shape of the next thing.”

Sabina, who had not slept, appeared in the tablinum with her slate and a question written on it in her careful letters: *Can they make the women testify against the house in chains?*

“No,” Antonia said, reading it. “A free woman can't be compelled in a morals case except by a

magistrate in open court, and you're all under witnessed contracts. But it's a good question, and it deserves a better answer than no. The real danger isn't the law; it's a woman alone on her day off, frightened, offered money or threats. From now on, market days are in pairs. No one leaves alone. Ever.”

⁂

The council met in the tablinum at the first hour, with no wine and no servants but Festus at the door.

Sabina was there, white and composed, because Antonia insisted that the people most affected by the house's decisions be present to hear them; Tyche came too, and Chloe, and Phyllis, and Vitalis, whose new bars had held without a sound, and they sat around the table with the lamp between them like soldiers after a sortie.

“Read it to me again,” Antonia said, and Chloe read the clerk's note of the fine and the warning aloud, and they listened to the language the way doctors listen to a cough.

“He's not trying to win in court,” Chloe said when she had finished. “The fines are nothing. He's trying to make the house frightening — for the guests and for us. The magistrates won't come back; their wives heard about the raid by now. The girls' families will hear rumours. The

suppliers will want payment upfront. He's draining the pond."

"Then we stop being a pond and become a river." Antonia set her palms flat on the table. "Three things. First, Hilarus circulates a letter to every guest of standing: the raid was a malicious inspection, witnessed by a praetor, finding nothing, and the house's licenses are confirmed in writing. We turn the embarrassment into proof of our order. Second, every woman in this house gets a copy of her own contract and a day's wages in silver, kept in her own box, today. Fear of poverty is his lever; we remove it. Third—" she stopped.

"Third?" Phyllis prompted.

"Third, I've held the auditor at arm's length as long as I safely can. The house can't survive this alone; the law's next visit won't be a search, it'll be a seizure, and a magistrate's signature is the only thing that stops it." She looked around the table. "I'm asking Marcus Aelius Severus to put his name between us and the warrant. Does anyone here think that's wrong?"

No one spoke. It was Sabina who said, at last, "He came to the races and held up the family when the barrier fell. The doorman says he doesn't let men lie in the street. I think the name is a good one."

"Thank you. Festus, a message to the Esquiline, through the old channel: the house asks the auditor to come tonight, at the tenth hour, by

the postern, with one trusted man. Tell him the goddess's documents are ready for his eyes.” She stood, ending the council. “Back to work, all of you. Rome respects a house that opens its doors the morning after a raid more than it respects the raid itself.”

⁂

He came at the tenth hour, in a dark cloak with Stichus, who waited in the passage with Festus, and Antonia received him in the tablinum with the lamps trimmed low and the door open to the colonnade, so that anyone watching could see two people doing business across a table.

She had laid out copies of everything: the weight notes, the loan columns, the repeating witness seals, Longinus's account of the bureau freedman, the names of the hidden witnesses. He read for a long time without speaking, and she watched him read, the soldier's patience in the way he held a tablet, and said nothing until he set the last one down.

“If half of this is true, the schedule is a criminal enterprise with an imperial freedman at its head.”

“More than half is true. The originals are in the temple coffer, sealed twice. Your raid tonight—”

“Our raid, if you please. The city's been told I'm your creature already; I may as well have the use of it.” He rubbed his eyes. “What do you need from me?”

“An open declaration. Apply to the praetor for standing in the matter of the house — make the Carinae part of your audit's evidence chain, so that any warrant against it becomes a warrant against your investigation. Perperna can't seize the place then without seizing an auditor's documents in a case the consuls assigned.”

He nodded slowly. “That works. It also ties my name to yours publicly and permanently, which is presumably why you've kept this card until now.”

“I keep every card until it's worth playing. You taught me that, actually, though you won't remember; you were twelve and teaching me a board game, and you said the good player doesn't spend his best piece just because it's threatened.”

The ghost of a smile crossed his face and was gone. “I remember. You won that game.”

“I've been winning ever since. It's made me unpopular.”

For a moment the table, the tablets, the investigation all seemed to recede, and they were simply two people in a lamplit room with fifteen years between them and no way across it. He looked at her with the open, careful expression she was beginning to recognize, the expression of a man deciding whether he was permitted a feeling.

He made himself return to the tablets. “Explain the circular payment again. The treasury pays the false tally, and then—”

“And then the gold goes to the Aventine bank, where it's split: the operating firms take their cut, Perperna's loans are serviced out of it — which is how he keeps the subscribers like my brother in harness — and the top share goes to the bureau freedman.” Chloe's copy lay between them, her columns clean. “The state is effectively paying for its own fraud and paying interest on the privilege.”

“And the grain itself? The short-weighted modii.”

“Sold twice, privately, to bakers and marine contractors; Dorion has the buyers' marks at Ostia. The soldiers get the remaining grain and the phantom supply on paper, and when the campaign begins in earnest and the army's hungry, the shortfall becomes a disaster in Syria instead of a discrepancy in Rome.” Antonia's voice was level. “That's the part that should keep you awake. This isn't only money. Men will march on those tallies.”

Marcus was quiet a while. “Then the audit report can't merely expose Perperna. It has to reconstruct the real supply before the spring sailing, or we trade a scandal for a famine.”

“You're beginning to think like the house. The truth isn't enough; it has to arrive organized.”

He almost smiled. “And here I was raised to believe truth was a virtue.”

“Virtue is what the powerful can afford. We're buying ours on instalments.”

“Antonia. After the case — if it goes as we mean it to — what then? For us.”

“There is no ‘us' in the plan. There's a partnership, and a prosecution, and if we're lucky, a house that stays open.” Her voice was even. “Don't ask me to draw a map of a country that may not exist. We survive the winter first.”

“That isn't an answer.”

“It's the only honest one I have.”

He accepted it, the way he accepted everything, after a moment's stillness. “Then I'll take the partnership. Stichus witnesses my application to the praetor tomorrow. And Antonia — tonight, when my name goes into your records, I want it understood: whatever this costs me politically, I've chosen it. Don't carry it as another debt. I've enough of those in my family.”

Before she could answer, Festus appeared in the doorway, and the expression on his face ended the evening.

“Street. Two of them, watching the postern. Our men are shadowing. One's the fountain clerk. The other's new — and he just walked off toward the Tiber bank, fast, like a man with news.”

Marcus was on his feet. “The engraver's old house.”

“Syrus's family moved out two nights ago, but the street doesn't know that yet.” Antonia was already moving, orders crisp. “Festus, send a runner to Hilarus: double the warehouse guard tonight. Marcus, take Stichus home the long way,

through the cattle market; don't give them a quiet corner. If they've decided to start hunting witnesses in the night, the war's changed its terms."

At the postern, under the single lamp, he paused and looked back at her.

"Then let's make sure we're better at night than they are."

The door closed. She stood in the passage and listened to his footsteps die away, and somewhere beyond the roofs, toward the river, a dog began to bark and would not stop, and Rome held its breath in the old way, the way it did before the alarms, and Antonia Cassia turned back into her house and bolted every door with her own hands.

The news came at dawn, with Vibius Longus himself at the front door, in night-stained clothes and the expression of a man who had already seen too much of the morning.

"Tiber bank, the seal-engraver's house. Broken in at the third watch — door forced, rooms turned, toolbox smashed on the floor. Neighbours heard nothing until the wife of the new tenant screamed at first light." He stepped inside, lowered his voice. "Whoever did it knew the layout and knew the trade; they went straight for the seal stones. If Syrus had still been sleeping there, we'd be fishing him out of the river like the Greek."

"His old house has new tenants?"

"A mender of pots and his family, moved in two days after Syrus vanished. They're unhurt,

terrified, and can't tell a seal from a saucepan; I've spoken to them." Vibius's tired eyes were sharp. "This wasn't a burglary. Burglars take silver. This was a message: they know the engraver's gone, and they're making the street too hot to hold anyone who helped him leave. Domina, how many of your people are hidden in this city?"

"Enough. None at addresses written down."

"Keep it that way. My watch can't be everywhere, and the men who do this work don't wear livery." He accepted the cup of hot wine Phyllis brought, drank it standing, and added, "One more thing. They left a mark on the doorframe, carved small, easy to miss. A hand with the thumb folded in. My Syrian boy says it's an old Eastern sign for a debt called in. Whoever's paying them wants the city to know: the accounts are open, and everyone's on them."

When he had gone, Antonia stood in the atrium among the morning roses and the leaping dolphins, and thought about a carved hand on a Tiber-bank doorframe, and about the eleven women asleep upstairs, and the hidden engraver, and the frightened measurer, and the tablets in the goddess's coffer.

Then she sent for Chloe and Festus, and gave the day's orders in the calm voice of a woman who has decided that a war conducted in whispers must be answered with a war conducted in the light.

“Today,” she said, “we stop hiding. The praetor gets the auditor's application by noon. Let Perperna spend the rest of the winter explaining why he's afraid of an honest ledger.”

The praetor who received Marcus that morning was Cornelius Ursus, a jurist of the old school, old enough to remember the worst of the informers under Domitian and cautious in the particular way of men who had survived those years. He read the application twice, turned the supporting tablets over in his hands, and looked at Marcus over the top of them with something between admiration and pity.

“You understand what you're asking. Standing over the Carinae house makes its records part of your audit's evidence chain, which protects it from the aedile's people. It also makes you, in the eyes of the city, the patron of a meretrix and her establishment. The broadsheets already write about nothing else. By noon they'll have the official version.”

“By noon they'll have the truth, which bores them. Let them write.” Marcus sat straight. “The house is the most reliable source of evidence in this matter. Its mistress keeps better accounts than the treasury, and the murdered clerk's sister is in her household. If the law can't distinguish evidence from gossip, then the audit is theatre, and I've no interest in theatre.”

Ursus was silent a moment, weighing him. “You know Perperna will answer with a prosecution of

his own. He always answers. The lex Iulia on adultery is his favourite instrument; the law's penalties touch the man and the woman alike, and proof requires remarkably little once a reputation is fixed."

"I've committed no adultery."

"Nor have most of the men he's ruined. The charge is a doorway; the trial does the killing." Ursus dipped his stylus and signed the application, then sealed it and pushed it across. "There. Standing granted, under my hand, and I'll note in the record that I did so on audit grounds. One further thing, between us and the wall. I've served with the prefect Attianus; he's an honest man and hates informers by profession. When your evidence is ready, bring it to him before it goes anywhere else. The bureau freedman in your tablets is the emperor's household, and only the emperor's household can touch him. Walk carefully, Severus. Rome is full of honest men's graves."

Marcus took the sealed document with the small bow of one professional to another, and walked out through the forum crowds with the wax warm against his chest, and thought that for the first time since the audit began, he was carrying a weapon rather than a burden.

At the Carinae, the document arrived by Stichus's own hand an hour later, and Antonia read it in the tablinum with Chloe and Phyllis, and

for once permitted herself a smile that reached her eyes.

“He signed. Ursus himself.”

“Then the house has walls the law recognizes.” Chloe touched the seal. “What does Perperna do now?”

Antonia set the document beside the contracts in the strong box, and her smile was gone.

“He does what cornered men have always done in Rome. He stops trying to frighten us and starts trying to kill the case. Which means he comes for the witnesses, and for the name at the centre of it.” She paused. “We're going to need every one of them alive, credible, and ready to stand in the open. Starting with the hardest one of all.”

“Which is?”

“A courtesan's word against an equestrian, in a Roman forum. Mine.”

They made the witness list that night, the three of them, in the lamp-lit tablinum, and it was the soberest document the house had yet produced. Antonia dictated, Chloe wrote, Phyllis checked each name against the household's knowledge of who could be trusted under pressure.

Syrus the engraver, with his family and his hands. Dorion the measurer, whose arm carried the figures. Hector's tablets, and therefore Hector's sister, and therefore Chloe herself. Beryllus the banker, if he could be brought to spend his reputation. Hilarus and his Ostia factors. The carver's widow, the locksmith's boy,

every small voice that had spoken into a statement and could be made to disappear before a trial.

“Paper alone won't save them,” Antonia said. “A statement is only as alive as the person who can swear to it. From tonight, the witnesses come under the house's protection in fact as well as name. Festus moves Syrus and his family out of the Subura rooms; Hilarus has a safe house behind the Diana temple. Dorion goes to Ostia under the factors' eyes. Every statement gets a second copy, and the copies go somewhere the bureau can't reach.”

“The temple coffer,” Phyllis said. It was not a question.

“The temple coffer, under the priestess's seal and mine. If the house burns, the truth doesn't. And the originals of Hector's tablets go first, tomorrow, before any of this becomes dangerous.” She set down the stylus and looked at the list of small names, the people Rome did not count. “He'll come for them one at a time, the way he always does. We're going to be waiting, all at once, with better paper than he has. That's the whole strategy. There's no cleverer one available to people like us.”

Chloe sanded the ink and Phyllis fetched the seal, and the list went into the strong box beneath the contracts, the first stone of a wall that would take the rest of the winter to finish.

PART III

WHISPERS

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Terms

The two seals broke in the priestess's inner chamber, where the lamps burned before the image of Isis and the air smelled of myrrh and old stone, and Antonia laid Hector's original tablets on the cedar table between herself and Marcus with the care of a woman laying down weapons at a treaty.

Chloe stood against the wall with her arms folded, the priestess at the door, Festus outside it, and the room held the particular quiet of a place where history was being committed to wax.

“Four tablets,” Antonia said, “the duplicates the board didn't know existed. The theta marks are my clerk's verification against the Ostia weight notes; you'll find Dorion's notes match them tablet for tablet. The loan columns show Perperna's subscriptions. The witness seals repeat across the changing firm names. This is the machine, in the man's own hand.”

Marcus drew the first tablet toward him and read slowly, as he read everything, with his whole attention. The lamplight moved across the long, narrow face, and the two women watched him,

and the only sound was the chanting of devotees somewhere beyond the wall.

“He was meticulous,” Marcus said at last.

“He was frightened,” Chloe said, from the wall. “Meticulous was how he stayed alive, until it didn't work. He thought if he wrote everything down, the writing would protect him.”

“He wasn't wrong. It protects him now. The dead can't be cross-examined, but their ledgers can, and these will survive it.” Marcus turned the second tablet. “The circular payment. My brother's loans. The Aventine bank. And Longinus names the bureau freedman—”

“Zosimus. A rationibus. The official who handles the emperor's supply correspondence.” Antonia placed Longinus's copied statement beside the tablets. “The fraud couldn't pass a single review without someone inside the bureau routing the questions. Zosimus is that someone. Perperna runs the street; Zosimus holds the door.”

Marcus sat back. “Then the case can't go to an ordinary magistrate. An imperial freedman answers to the Palace, not the praetor's court.”

“Which is why Ursus told you to take it to Attianus.” She had prepared the terms as carefully as the tablets, and she stated them now without flourish, the way she stated prices. “Here is my proposal. First: you carry the complete evidence to the praetorian prefect, under your name, with the praetor's standing already

granted. I supply the documents, the witnesses — Dorion, Syrus, Longinus, and the tanner in Pompeii — and the house's records of what the contractors said over wine. Second: Celer turns state evidence at the moment you choose, early enough to earn relief, late enough that Perperna can't rearrange his affairs. Third: the house remains open and its women remain under their own contracts; the prosecution makes no use of their persons, only their testimony where they choose to give it."

"Fourth," Chloe said, stepping forward, "I testify. In open court, under my own name, to my brother's work and his murder. I'll not have him exist only as tablets."

Marcus looked at her, and inclined his head. "Granted, and the court will be the better for it." He returned to Antonia. "And in return?"

"Before we reach terms, the full witness list, so you know the shape of what you're carrying." She counted on her fingers. "Dorion, the Ostia measurer, in Hilarus's warehouse; Syrus, the engraver, with him; Longinus, the Aventine banker, once his family's aboard a ship; Phoebus's cousin the tanner at Pompeii, with the hide receipts; the Hilarus factor's copies; and the statements of your own guests, the men who spoke over wine about phantom grain. Those last are delicate; I won't force a guest, but I'll tell you which ones said what, and you can decide whether Roman honour will make them repeat it."

“Most won't.”

“Most won't. Some will, because the auditor asks them, and refusing an auditor is its own confession. We don't need all of them. We need the chain: Ostia to Rome, tally to gold, gold to seal, seal to Perperna, Perperna to Zosimus. Break any link and the case dies; keep them all and it can't.”

He nodded slowly. “You've built a prosecution. In a house of entertainment.”

“I've built an economy of trust. The prosecution is its side effect.”

“In return, the prosecution names the house as an honest source rather than a criminal scene, and your name stays between my doors and the praetor's office. No private bargain, no payment, no favour beyond the ordinary protection of a citizen's — a person's — lawful evidence.” She held his eyes. “I'm not buying you, Marcus. I'm hiring the only name in Rome Perperna can't purchase, and I'll have the terms clean, because clean terms are the only kind that survive.”

For a moment something moved behind his face, quickly controlled. “You've made this very easy to accept.”

“I make everything easy to accept. It's my trade.”

The priestess spoke from the door, calm as the Nile. “The goddess approves of clear contracts. Most human suffering arrives in the fine print.”

Marcus took the stylus Chloe offered and wrote his agreement on a fresh tablet, in his formal senatorial hand, and signed it, and passed it to Antonia, who signed beneath, and Chloe and the priestess witnessed. Then the tablets went back into the coffer and the two seals closed over them again, and the alliance that would occupy the rest of the winter existed, like everything powerful in Rome, as a document.

⁂

They walked in the sycamore grove afterward, while Chloe and the priestess walked behind at a respectful distance, and the winter sun made long shadows on the temple path.

Before the past, they settled the present, because both of them were people who did the practical thing first and the painful thing after. Marcus had questions about the coffer's mechanics, and Antonia answered them the way she answered everything, in terms of seals and copies.

“Nothing enters the coffer without two witnesses, and nothing leaves without both seals, mine and the priestess's. The temple holds the originals; Hilarus keeps a full copy in his warehouse strong room; the house keeps only the working tablets. If we're raided again, the officers find working papers, nothing more. If we're burned, the temple keeps the truth. If the temple

is somehow reached, Hilarus keeps the second truth. Three doors, three keys, none of them in the same street.”

“Beryllus would approve. He keeps his own ledgers in three cities.”

“Beryllus taught me the principle, over figs. The city's honest men survive by being dull, and the city's dishonest men survive by being nowhere in particular. We're going to be both.” She tucked her hands into her sleeves against the shade of the grove. “For your part: every statement you take from here on, take it before two witnesses and seal it at once. Your household diary matters more than you think; Pacilius was right, and Livia has already begun the daily rolls. A prosecution is a story a delator tells about missing paper. We are going to be the paper that does not go missing.”

“Celer's subscriptions, the shell firms — I've begun matching them against the annona contract lists. The names rotate, but the witnesses don't. Half the firms share the same three signatories.”

“Then the signatories are the machine, and the firms are only its shadows.” She nodded slowly. “Find where the shadows meet. There will be a hand there — a steward, a freedman, a clerk with a taste for better wine than his salary allows. We don't need to prove the whole conspiracy in a week; we need to build it the way they built it, one witnessed name at a time, until the shape is

unmistakable even to a praetor who'd rather not see it.”

“You speak like a general.”

“I run a house of eleven women in a city that would swallow eleven women before breakfast. It's the same trade, with better manners.” A pause. “One rule between us, while we're being practical. No protection I don't know about, no moves you make on the house's behalf without telling me first. The worst thing men in your position do to women in mine is help us in secret, because secret help is the kind that can be denied, and denied help becomes evidence against us. Everything in the open, or nothing at all.”

“Everything in the open,” he agreed, and the phrase, settled between them in the sycamore shade, would govern every harder decision of the winter, though neither of them yet knew it.

She watched him absorb it, and added the clause that mattered most to her. “And one more practical thing, while we're being exact. Whatever comes out in the inquiry, my house keeps its name and its licenses and its women's contracts. I am not to be rescued into respectability, Marcus. Rescued women become men's property in a softer vocabulary, and I've spent fifteen years refusing that bargain in every vocabulary Rome has. We cooperate as two free parties, or we don't cooperate; the alliance has no other form.”

“Two free parties,” he said, and the words came slowly, because he was measuring every one against the habits of his class. “I can agree to that. I'm not sure Rome can.”

“Rome isn't signing. We are.” She touched the coffer's iron band once, lightly. “There. Now that we've made the treaty, you may ask the difficult question. I saw it arrive on your face at the temple steps.”

The practical things said, the path narrowed, and the grove grew quieter, and the moment arrived that both had known was coming from the moment the coffer's seals had closed.

“You said once there was more to the past than the sale.” Marcus spoke to the path. “I've no right to ask, and you've every reason to refuse.”

“You've earned the question, which is rarer than the right. Ask.”

“The letters. Mine. Barto said three came, with money, and went back unopened. Did you never — was there nothing from me that reached you?”

“Nothing. Not a word. I believed you knew. I believed the family had paid you off with a clear conscience and a German commission, and that was the story I built my life on.” She walked a few paces. “It's easier, you know, to believe a man chose to betray you. Betrayal gives you anger, and anger is useful. The truth is worse: you were just absent, and absent people can't be blamed, and I've had to learn a new feeling at thirty-four, which is exhausting.”

“I wrote them in a frozen billet. The last one was mostly nonsense, I think; I was half delirious with a winter fever. I told you about the snow and the wolves and how I'd come home and we'd find a way, as if wishing were a plan.” He gave a short, bitter laugh. “It came back unopened, and I told myself that meant you'd chosen freedom. A man can build a whole philosophy on a letter he was too cowardly to investigate.”

“Your mother sent it back.”

“My mother. Dromo. The whole smooth machine of a great house, grinding on without anyone needing to give a cruel order aloud.” He stopped beneath a sycamore. “And the child. Laeta. You said — in the chapel, you said she was born before she could cry.”

Antonia stopped too, and the grove was quiet except for the doves.

“She was small. Six months, perhaps seven; the dealer's house had no midwife until it was nearly too late. I held her. She was perfectly formed, tiny and still, and I named her because no one else would bother. Then the fever took me, and when I woke she'd been buried somewhere in the common ground beyond the Esquiline, and I've never found the place.” Her voice did not waver; it had been used for this too many times in private. “That's the wound, if you've been imagining one. Not the men, not the house, not the work. The grave I can't visit. Everything else I could rebuild. A daughter doesn't rebuild.”

Marcus was very still. “I have a daughter. Vibia. Eleven years old, and she teaches the cat tricks and argues with her tutors. It never once occurred to me, when she was born, that there was another daughter, older than she is, who would have been mine.”

“The city prefers not to count the girls it kills. It keeps the ledgers clean.”

He said nothing for a long while. Then, with the formal care of a man performing an act he had rehearsed in fear, he took her hand — the left, the one without the rings — and kissed it, not as a lover, not yet, but as a man kisses the hand of someone he has wronged, in the old style, before the household gods.

They walked on, and after a while he asked, because he had made himself ask the harder things, “Tell me about the woman who freed you. Antonia Prima.”

“Small, sharp, older than any woman I'd met, and kinder than she could afford to be. She'd been the mistress of a wine merchant who left her money in a will his family contested for years; she won by being more patient than the lawyers. When she bought me I was eighteen, half dead of the fever, and worth very little, which is why she got me cheap. She said she could see the ledger-keeper in me. She kept a house of six couches, and she taught me everything: music, manners, the law's loopholes, and the one rule she said no courtesan ever survived forgetting —

never confuse being wanted with being loved. They're close enough to fool the eye, she said, and as different as an investment and a gift.”

“Did she love anyone?”

“Her accounts, her cat, and, at the end, me, in her fashion. She used to say Rome would give a clever woman exactly two choices: be owned, or own. She chose to own, and left me the deed.” Antonia's step never faltered. “I've doubled the house twice. I've buried her in a proper columbarium with a marble plaque. I visit at the Saturnalia and tell her the figures. She'd approve.”

“And my marriage.” Marcus chose the words. “You should hear it from me, since the city will tell you louder and less true. Livia and I were married by our fathers; we have two children and a functioning estate and no love that either of us would recognize from the poets. She's the ablest person in my household, and I respect her entirely, and I've never once made her happy. There've been no mistresses — that's not virtue, it's temperament; I've no gift for casual things. I'm telling you this not as an excuse but as an inventory. You deserve the truth of what I am.”

“A husband, a father, a consul-designate. A man with a great name and a great deal to lose.”

“Yes.”

“Then we're well matched. I'm a freedwoman with a house, eleven dependents, and no name at all that the law respects. We're precisely the pair

the law was written to keep apart." She said it without self-pity, as a surveyor states a boundary. "Which is why the terms are what they are. Whatever this becomes, Marcus, it can't become respectable. Rome will never permit it, and I'll never ask Rome's permission. Do you understand what that means for a man like you?"

"It means I must decide what I want the rest of my life to mean. I've begun. The beginning is uncomfortable."

"Good. Comfort's the luxury of people who've never had to choose."

"I can't give you back the grave. I can give you the men who make the graves. That's the only atonement I know how to make."

She let her hand stay in his a moment longer than the gesture required, then drew it away gently.

"Then make it well. We'll settle the rest of our accounts after the trial, if there's anything left to settle."

Behind them, Chloe watched the doves and said nothing, and the priestess smiled the small smile of a goddess who had heard a great many vows and trusted very few of them.

⁂

That evening, on the Esquiline, Celer signed his statement.

Marcus had dictated it himself over three nights, in the tablinum, with Stichus writing and Livia present as the family's second witness, and it contained everything: the debts, the loans at twenty-four per cent, the bundle witnessing, the use of the family seal, and the names of every man who had guided him through the machine he had been too vain to examine. Celer read it twice, and for once did not reach for a joke.

“Once this is sealed, there's no road back.”

“There was never a road back; there was only the road forward in chains or the road forward as a witness.” Marcus pushed the wax toward him. “Sign. For Gaius, if not for yourself.”

Celer signed. Livia witnessed, Stichus witnessed, and the tablet went into the family strong box beside the deeds, and when it was done the younger brother sat looking at his hands, and said, without looking up, “I've spent my whole life being the charming one. It turns out the charming one was the easy one. The honest one costs something every hour.”

“Welcome to the rest of us,” Livia said, and poured him a cup of wine, which was, from her, roughly equivalent to an embrace.

Gaius, lingering in the colonnade where he had been sent to bed and had not gone, watched his uncle's back with an expression his father recognized from his own youth: the first sight of an adult being smaller, and more human, than the child had believed.

Sextus Perperna learned of the praetor's standing grant over lunch, in the house of a friend on the Caelian, and he did not stop chewing, which the friend later described as the most alarming thing he had ever seen a man do.

By the fourth hour he was in the upper room of a bathhouse behind the Palatine, in steam so thick the lamp was a red ghost, with the man the ledgers called Zosimus.

The imperial freedman was fifty, soft, and carefully dressed even for a bath, with the soft hands and hard eyes of a slave who had discovered that the emperor's correspondence was worth more than most men's fortunes. He spoke Greek-accented Latin in a low voice, and he was, Perperna had long known, braver about gold than about danger, which made him useful and required management.

“The praetor's office confirmed it this morning,” Zosimus said. “Standing over the Carinae house, under the audit. Ursus signed. Your prosecutor-turned-guardian has built himself a legal wall around the woman.”

“Walls are for people who intend to stay inside. I intend her in the dock.” Perperna poured water over the hot stones and watched it vanish in steam. “How much does he have?”

“More than is comfortable. The Aventine banker's gone quiet, which means he's talked. The seal-engraver's vanished, which means she has him. The Ostia measurer likewise. The Greek's

duplicate tablets — I assume they exist, since everything else does.” Zosimus shifted in the steam. “If this reaches Attianus in one piece, the contracts unravel, and the contracts lead to me. I did not survive three emperors to be ruined by a whore.”

“Mind your language. She's a businesswoman now, according to the praetor's seal.” Perperna's voice stayed pleasant. “Listen carefully, because we have one season before the spring sailing, and the season must produce a trial that ends her before her evidence begins. Two instruments. The first is the lex Iulia de adulteriis. The auditor has been seen at her house, at her box, in her temple. Reputation plus opportunity is nine-tenths of that statute, and I'll provide the tenth with a willing witness.”

“From inside her house?”

“From near it. There's a girl — Tyche, the lyre player. My man's been working her for weeks. She hasn't turned; I didn't expect her to. But fear outlasts loyalty, and I mean to give her a reason to be afraid. A statement that the house profits from assigning women to named clients is lenocinium, and lenocinium closes the door and disbands the witnesses in one stroke.” Perperna drew a finger through the steam on the bench. “The second instrument is the auditor himself. A prosecution naming him as the adulterous senator doesn't need to convict. It needs to make him choose: denounce her and walk away, or stand beside her

and lose the consulship and the name. Men like Severus can resist money and threats. They can't resist the destruction of the thing they love most, which in his case is his own honour."

Zosimus was quiet, watching him through the steam. "And if neither instrument works?"

"Then there's the third, which has never failed me. Fire." Perperna stood, reaching for his towel. "But fire announces itself, and I prefer the law. Arrange the girl's summons through the aedile's office — a request for her testimony in the custody matter, nothing threatening. Bring her to a room where my people can speak to her alone. Fear, properly administered, is cheaper than bribery and leaves no accounts."

"You've done this before."

"I've done everything before. That's the advantage of my profession; the material is always the same." He wrapped the towel and paused at the steam-room door. "One more thing. The praetorian prefect is honest, which means he's slow. Honest men need the evidence presented like a dinner course, in order, with clean hands. We'll make sure the first course he tastes is ours."

Zosimus was not reassured. "If it fails, remember that my name appears nowhere. I route correspondence; I sign nothing."

"Everyone signs something. The art is arranging whose name sits above the line." Perperna's voice came gently through the steam.

“Don't trouble yourself with failure. I've prosecuted a Vestal's lover, a governor, and two consulars; the city provided me all of them wrapped in their own certainty. A freedwoman and an honest senator are merely the latest course. The trick, always, is to move first. By the time their evidence reaches the prefect, the prefect will have heard ten times that it's fabricated by a jealous brothel-keeper. Even truth, repeated against often enough, begins to sound like gossip.”

“And the emperor? Trajan dislikes informers; everyone knows it.”

“Trajan is preparing a war and trusts his household. I am part of his household's convenience, and inconvenient people are dealt with by convenient methods.” Perperna opened the door. “Relax, Zosimus. Rome has never once lost a war against a woman with no legal standing. It would scarcely know how.”

The cold air hit them, and the slaves came forward with oils and towels, and the two men dressed and parted in the street with no visible sign of acquaintance, the way conspirators do in a city of watchers, and each went home to his own dinner and his own calculations.

He went out into the cold air of the changing room, and the slaves brought his clothes, and he dressed with the unhurried neatness of a man completely at peace with his own methods, and by the time he reached the street his smile was back

in place, the kindly smile, and no one watching him pass would have guessed that he was composing, in his head, the ruin of a woman he had never once seen afraid.

⁂

The summons reached the gilded door at the eighth hour, polite, sealed, apparently harmless: the lyre player Tyche was requested as a character witness in the custody hearing of Sabina Aviania, to attend at the aedile's offices on the following market day, with the option of a private preliminary interview to refresh her recollection.

Antonia read it, handed it to Chloe, and watched her read it, and neither of them needed to say what it was.

“He's changed tactics on the weakest wall,” Chloe said.

“Then we make the wall stronger. She doesn't go alone, she doesn't answer questions without me in the room, and if the interview turns, she asks for the adjournment and leaves. Tell her tonight.” Antonia took the summons back and placed it with the others in the strong box, in the growing file marked with the name of the man who had decided to make her winter interesting.

Outside, the street vendors cried their wares, the water clocks dripped, and Rome went about its thousand appetites, and somewhere in a

bathhouse behind the Palatine two men were deciding the price of fear, and in a house in the Carinae three women were deciding not to pay it.

Tyche took the news standing up, in the women's court, with the lyre silent in her hands.

“It's not a witness summons,” Chloe said, going over it again. “It's a request, dressed up as one. They want you alone in a room where a clerk can write whatever the man with the soft voice tells him to write. You're not going alone.”

“What will they ask?”

“First, gentle things. Whether you're happy, whether you're paid, whether anyone's ever frightened you. Then the turn: whether the house tells you which men to sit with, whether gifts change hands, whether you've ever felt you couldn't refuse. Every question is a door; you answer only the one asked, you never volunteer, and if they touch the contract or the house's rules, you ask for me and for the adjournment.” Antonia had a wax tablet of her own now, with the questions written on it and the answers rehearsed beneath. “Read these tonight. Tomorrow we run it like a play, twice, until you're bored. Boredom is what brave looks like from the outside.”

Tyche read, and looked up. “What if I fail?”

“Then you fail, and we deal with it, and you still sleep here with the bolt on your door. That's the other thing they don't know about this house.” Antonia's voice softened. “You're not alone in the room because you're weak. You're never alone

because none of us is. The whole point of the house is that the door has eleven women behind it.”

The lyre player held the tablet against her chest like a shield, and nodded, and went off to memorize her lines, and in the garden the fountain spilled its cool water, and somewhere in the house a musician practiced a scale, and the ordinary, stubborn life of the place went on, which was, Antonia thought, the deepest answer she knew to men like Perperna: to keep making music while they sharpened their knives.

The preliminary interview was held in a bare room at the aedile's offices, on market day, with Tyche on a stool between Chloe and a house advocate and two clerks across a table, and the polite man from the market — she recognized his voice before she saw his face, the careful friendliness of it — sitting in the corner with his hands folded.

The first questions were exactly as Antonia had predicted. Her name, her origin, her enrollment, the terms of her contract. Tyche answered in the rehearsed, bored voice, the voice of a girl who had been told to make bravery look tedious, and the clerks' wax gathered nothing worth having.

Then the turn came, as turns do, smoothly, without warning.

“And when a guest asks for your particular company,” the senior clerk said, “who decides the price and the terms?”

“The contract sets the prices. I decide the company. No one sits with me without my agreement, and nothing beyond conversation and music happens in the house at all, under any terms, without my written consent before witnesses. It's clause nine. You have the copy.”

“Has anyone ever — persuaded you? Offered you a better arrangement away from the house? Encouraged you to leave?”

She let her eyes move, just slightly, to the man in the corner. “Yes, as it happens. A gentleman at the cloth stalls has offered me gifts and a room of my own, on behalf of an unnamed friend. I reported each offer to my mistress, as the house rules require, and kept the gifts as evidence. A silver dove brooch and a glass bracelet. They're in the strong box with the dates.”

The polite man's hands tightened once, very slightly, and loosened.

The clerk changed direction twice more and got nothing but the same calm, documented answers, and at last the clerk with the soft voice in the corner leaned forward and said, in the warm tone of an uncle at a wedding, “My dear, you may speak freely here. Are you afraid of anyone?”

Tyche turned to look at him fully, the way Chloe had taught her, eye to eye, no flinch.

“Yes,” she said. “I'm afraid of men who give bracelets to girls they don't know and ask them to sign things without their advocates. But I'm told

the law protects people who answer in front of witnesses, so I'm feeling much better.”

Chloe, behind her neutral face, wanted to cheer. The clerks looked at each other; the soft-voiced man said nothing at all; and the interview was closed with the thin-lipped record that the witness had nothing material to add.

Outside in the market, in the noise and the sun, Tyche's knees gave way for ten seconds on a bench, and Chloe held her wrist and said nothing until the shaking stopped.

“You were magnificent.”

“I was terrified.”

“That's what magnificent is, when anyone bothers to tell the truth about it.”

They went home through the crowded streets with the two guards a discreet distance behind, and when Tyche walked into the atrium Antonia was waiting, and said only, “I heard. The whole house heard, by now; news moves faster than the water. Go and eat something. You've earned the good bread.”

That night the lyre played later than usual in the women's court, and the tune was a defiant one, and even Sabina, struggling with the Twelve Tables, smiled over her scroll at the sound of it.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Blood on the Sand

The winter games were given by a praetor with a reputation to buy, and Rome turned out for them in the same spirit in which it did everything: completely, noisily, and at the top of its lungs.

The Flavian amphitheatre rose above the crowd like a stone bowl of thunder, four storeys of arches and statues, its awnings already creaking out over the fifty thousand seats, and the streams of people flowed up its stairways in the old, strict order of Roman rank — senators and magistrates down at the marble rings, equestrians behind them, then the ordinary citizens in their packed thousands, and in the highest wooden tiers the women, the foreigners, and the slaves, nearest the sky and the sun.

Hilarus, climbing with the party, gave Sabina the running lecture he gave every newcomer. The amphitheatre seated more people than most cities contained, and it emptied in minutes because there were seventy-six numbered gates and every ticket bore a number; the awnings were worked by sailors from the fleet, stationed at the top; the sand itself was imported from the coast, golden

and clean, so that the blood showed. The crowd brought cushions, snacks, dice, and grievances, and the emperor's popularity was measured less by his wars than by the size of the gift tokens he scattered into these seats.

“It's a machine for making Romans agree about something,” Hilarus said, finding their places. “Out there they're brawling over bread and faction colours. In here they all want the same thing at the same moment. Whoever controls the shows controls the city's feelings.”

“Even the women?” Sabina asked, settling her cushion.

“Especially the women. We let them sit highest so their shrieks reach the gods first.” Porcia winked. “It's the only advantage the law allows us; use it.”

Antonia said little. She was reading the room the way she read every room: the distribution of the guards, the quality of the senators' attendance, the presence of the prefect's officers, the absence of the emperor himself, who preferred the army and left the praetors to buy love. A city watching the sand, she had always thought, was a city not watching its accounts, which suited certain men very well.

Antonia's party sat high, among the freedmen and the merchants' families, where Hilarus's money could buy good sightlines but not the marble of rank. Sabina was beside her again, tense and excited, with Chloe on the other side

and Porcia behind with a basket of dates, and Festus somewhere in the standing crowd at the back, a wall in a clean tunic.

Down in the marble rings, Marcus sat with the senators, Livia on the cushions behind the women's rail with Vibia and Gaius, and Antonia did not look at him, because fifty thousand Romans were also looking, and the one skill the city demanded of a woman in her position was to be seen looking nowhere she ought.

The morning began with the beast hunts. Stags and wild boar were driven into the sand and killed with arrows and spears; then came the exotic animals Rome paid to see die — ostriches, a giraffe that moved with bewildered dignity before the hunters' ring closed, and a pair of lions that took three men's spears before they fell. The crowd cheered the lions longest, and Antonia, watching the great cat sink onto its haunches with the slow dignity of something that knew it had been betrayed, said quietly to Chloe, “They love the animals better than the men. Because the animals don't know the rules.”

“Nothing in this building knows the rules except us,” Chloe said. “That's the horror of it.”

At the midday break came the executions, the part of the games respectable women were said to avoid and almost no one actually left for. Condemned criminals, two men and a woman, were brought out for the fatal charades the crowd pretended were theatre, and killed in the sand in

a sequence of staged myths. Sabina, who had never seen a person die, went white and gripped the cushion, and Antonia put a hand over the girl's eyes without comment.

“Look or don't,” she said. “Neither is shameful. But understand what you're seeing. These aren't monsters. They're people the state found it convenient to kill publicly, so that everyone here remembers what the state can do. The games aren't entertainment. They're a lesson in power, with refreshments.”

The woman in the sand died quickly, at least, and the crowd applauded the professionalism of it, and the servants raked the sand clean, and the afternoon's real business, the gladiators, came out to the roar.

Festus had gone very still beside the back rail.

“You know them,” Antonia said, low.

“I know the school. The secutor in the third pair — that's old school, the Lanista's. I fought him once, nine years ago; he gave me this.” The scarred eyebrow moved. “He'll win. He always wins in the morning; they save him for the afternoon crowd.”

He was right. The fights were brutal, skilled, and carefully managed, the trainers keeping the deaths few enough to remain precious. Twice a man was spared when the crowd turned its thumbs upward, and once a retiarius died slowly in the sand with the noise of fifty thousand voices washing over him like weather, and Antonia

watched Festus watch it, and saw in the big man's face neither lust nor horror but the professional's recognition of the moves, and beneath it, very deep, the old relief that it was someone else under the net today.

The old secutor's fight was the afternoon's centrepiece, and Festus narrated it in the low voice of a man reading a scroll. The murmillo opposite him was younger, stronger, and less patient, and for two minutes he seemed to own the sand, pressing the older man backward with the shield. Then Festus said, “Now,” and the secutor stepped inside the wild overreach, turned his hip, and put the gladius through the gap beneath the younger man's arm, and the murmillo folded onto his knees in the strange, tidy way men do when the wound is mortal.

“He let him spend himself. Twelve years, and he still fights with his head. The crowd loves strength; the school pays for patience.” Festus's hands were clasped on the rail, the old arena tension in them. “They'll spare the boy if the editor has any sense; a fighter the crowd loves is money.”

The crowd's roar turned upward, thumb after thumb, and the editor raised the wooden foil, and the wounded murmillo was carried out alive to the gate of life, and Sabina, who had been holding her breath, let it out in a gasp.

“They can choose,” she said. “The people. They can say no.”

“Only to the men who've already been made to fight,” Chloe said. “Don't mistake the crowd's mercy for justice. The choice was made the day the boy was sold to the school.”

Antonia said nothing. She was watching the editor's box, where the praetor took the applause for the pardon he had granted on cue, and thinking that all Rome worked like this: the powerful arranged the deaths, and let the people choose a mercy or two, and called the arrangement liberty.

At the far end of the marble ring, Gaius was watching the same sand with his father's profile and his own thoughts. He had not flinched at the blood; what he could not stop watching were the slaves raking the sand between the acts, men with their own faces, their own tired movements, men the crowd never saw. Marcus, following his eyes, said, “Ask it. Whatever it is.”

“Could any of them be — men who didn't deserve it? Men like the clerk, Hector?”

“Yes. Some are criminals, some are prisoners of war, some are slaves sold for their master's debts. The law sorts them all into the same gate.” Marcus kept his voice low. “The city's cruelty isn't random, Gaius. That's what the poets get wrong. It's organized. Which means it can be examined, and argued, and one day, by men better than me, perhaps changed. You can't change a thing you refuse to look at. Look, and keep your judgement cold.”

⁂

He came during the interval of the second hour, when the crowd was occupied with the distribution of bread and wooden tokens for gifts, and he came the way they had arranged: Marcus through the upper walkways with Stichus behind, a senator stretching his legs among the common seats, entirely visible, entirely deniable.

He sat in the empty place Porcia vacated with a look Antonia could not read, and for a moment neither spoke, and they looked down together at the raked sand where the servants were smoothing the blood.

Talk at the games had its own grammar: short sentences, eyes on the sand, pauses whenever a vendor or a neighbour leaned near, and never a name that could not be mistaken for a charioteer's. Antonia began it.

“Your brother-in-law's subscriptions. We've finished the matching at the house; Chloe did the columns. Twelve firms, four of them annona contractors, and the witnesses recycle in the same triplet. The name that keeps recurring at the centre is a steward called Hermeros.”

Marcus kept his face toward the arena. “Hermeros. Greek freedman, employed in the imperial household, attached to the finance bureau. I know the name from the audit's pay lists; he handles staff disbursements. A man who

pays the bureau's servants can pay anyone's servants.”

“Exactly. And a man who works inside the palace can't be touched by a praetor; only the emperor's household can investigate the emperor's household. Which is why everything we gather has to gather around him without startling him. If he smells an audit, the bureau burns its loose paper in a night and we're left with the shells and no hand.” She accepted a handful of nuts from a passing boy and paid without looking. “My side: the lockpick they sent was a boy from the Subura, paid through two cut-outs, frightened more than vicious. Festus has him, fed and unwatched-feeling, and he's talking. Not the top of the chain — boys like him never see the top — but the next link, the man who paid him, and the place the money came from. When we have the money's origin, we'll have a name to set beside Hermeros.”

“The strong room held, then.”

“The strong room held because they sent a boy and a bent pin against a door Hilarus built. The next attempt won't be so cheap, and that's what worries me. Men who fail with locksmiths start thinking about fires and warrants and witnesses who suddenly leave the city.” She cracked a nut between her teeth. “The Diana temple safe house is being made ready; at the first sign of a move against him, Syrus and his family go there the same night. Dorion stays at Ostia under Hilarus's

factors' eyes, where the harbour itself is his guard. Chloe's tablets are already in the coffer. I will not have a single name on our witness list living where a soft voice can reach him without the street knowing it.”

Below them the next procession entered the sand, priests and images and the gleaming helmets of the gladiators, and the crowd roared, and under cover of the roar Marcus said the thing he had come to say.

“The audit office tried to reassign me this week. A flattering posting, the eastern commission, with the implication that a sensible man takes it before the winter's unpleasantness. I declined, politely, in writing. They'll try again, with less politeness. I wanted you to know before it becomes a pamphlet: they mean to separate the auditor from the witnesses. Whatever happens to the office, the evidence is already outside their reach, and I've made sure my own copies are sealed with the family strong box and the prefect's name on the receipt.”

Antonia looked at him then, fully, for the first time since he had sat down, and whatever she saw in his face made her own expression change by one degree. “You understand what refusing that commission costs. The consulship doesn't survive a man who won't be moved.”

“The consulship was always the price, wasn't it? From the first night at your table. Perperna offered me the bargain in two doors, and both

doors led to my keeping the chair and losing the case. I've decided I prefer the case." He turned back to the sand. "Don't thank me. Gratitude makes us both ridiculous, and I've enough ridiculous relatives without joining them. Just make sure none of it was necessary for nothing."

"That," she said, lifting her cup to the roaring arena, "is the one guarantee my house has never failed to give."

"Tyche's interview," he said, low. "My advocate has the record. They got nothing."

"Did you expect them to?"

"I expected them to try harder. Which means it was a rehearsal. Perperna doesn't spend a clerk's afternoon for practice; he wanted to measure whether the house can be made to crack. Your lyre player told him it can't, so he'll move to something he thinks can't refuse." Marcus's eyes moved across the arena. "Celer's statement is sealed. Longinus's family sails for Ostia tonight. The tanner's receipts arrived from Pompeii yesterday. The chain is nearly complete."

"Attianus?"

"Not yet. I won't take a half-built case to the prefect; he gets one hearing, and everything must be in order. Another two weeks, perhaps three. Can the house hold that long?"

"Can yours?" She kept her face toward the sand. "The broadsheets changed their tune this week. Now it's not just the censor and the

courtesan. Now I'm a spy, and you're my dupe. Someone's feeding the writers the audit's details.”

“Zosimus, through the Palatine clerks. It means they know we're assembling evidence and they can't see all of it; the temple coffer frustrates them. A frightened enemy is what we want.” He paused. “Livia sends her regards, in the Roman fashion, which means she said nothing and meant a great deal. She's sitting twelve rows down pretending not to know I'm here.”

Antonia smiled, briefly. “She's the ablest of us. Remember me to her, without warmth and without insult.”

Down in the arena the next pair entered to a roar, and the talk sank beneath it.

“One piece of news from the house,” Antonia said. “Festus caught a man this morning. In the service wing, at the strong-room door, with a turnkey's pick in his hand.”

Marcus turned fully. “Inside the house?”

“Dressed as a lamp boy, and he knew the morning routines, which means he was put in by someone who's watched us properly. Festus has him in the storeroom. He's a professional, not a brave one; he'll talk before the lamps are lit. My money says Perperna's people, looking for the tablets they've now guessed they didn't find on Hector.”

“Be careful what you do with him. A house that tortures a captured spy hands Perperna his next prosecution.”

“We don't torture. We *interview*, with Hilarus's best wine and the worst prospects in Rome laid out clearly. Men like that are rational; give him a better bargain than his employer did and he'll change sides faster than a chariot wheel.” She glanced at him. “Don't look so prim. It's the same thing you do in the Curia, with better wine.”

The ghost of his smile appeared and vanished. “When he talks, send me the name of whoever hired him through the usual channel. If it traces to Zosimus's household, the case gains a head.”

A roar swallowed the sentence; the old secutor Festus had named had thrown his opponent, and stood over him with the blade raised, and the crowd was on its feet screaming for the kill or the pardon, thousands of arms making the same gestures, and in the thunder of it Marcus looked at Antonia and Antonia looked at the sand, and for two heartbeats, in a crowd of fifty thousand, they were completely alone.

Then the crowd's thumbs turned upward, the beaten man was spared, and the moment broke, and Marcus rose.

“Two or three weeks. Hold the house.”

“Hold the name.”

He went back down the long walkway, and Chloe, who had watched the whole exchange while appearing to feed Sabina dates, said, “You're in love with him. I've stopped mentioning it because you've stopped denying it.”

“I deny it now.”

“Badly. You deny it badly, like a girl with no practice.” Chloe ate a date. “It's all right, you know. The world isn't going to end because of it. It's going to end because of grain tallies, which is much more Roman.”

⁂

Livia Marcella had, in fact, seen everything, because Livia saw everything, and she said nothing at the amphitheatre, and saved it for the walk home, when the children's litter was ahead and she and Marcus shared the second with the curtains half drawn against the winter sun.

“She's very handsome, your business partner. From up here, at any rate.”

“Livia—”

“I'm not going to make a scene; scenes are for wives who haven't made their arrangements. I made mine years ago.” Her gloved hands rested in her lap. “I'll say this once, clearly, and then I'll not repeat it. I don't care what you feel, and I don't require fidelity, which the law doesn't require either. I require two things: the children's name, and the consulship, which is that name's future. If this prosecution fails and the scandal takes the family, we lose both, and I will hold you responsible, and I will use every coin and connection I brought into this house to make sure the children survive their father's mistake. Is that understood?”

“It is.”

“Good. Then tell me the practical position, since my husband's advocate is discreet to the point of uselessness. Is the case strong?”

He told her, in the steady voice of a briefing officer: the tablets, the weight notes, the seals, the witnesses, the bureau freedman at the head of it, the timetable toward Attianus. She listened with the attention she gave the household accounts, and when he finished she was quiet a while.

“Then win,” she said simply. “I've no interest in being ruined for a good cause. Win, and afterward we'll all be very dignified about whatever comes next. The Aelii survive. That's the only vow I've ever truly meant.”

At the games, before the litters, she had sat through her own smaller war, among the consular wives in the women's section, where the conversation was a battlefield dressed in silk. Crassicia, still nursing her dinner-table wound, had spoken at some length about “women who forget the door they came in by,” and the circle had smiled and watched Livia's face.

“Some women come in by doors,” Livia had answered, examining her nails. “Others build the door. I'm not sure which is the greater achievement, but I'm certain it's boring to discuss at the games.”

The circle had laughed, carefully, and Crassicia had changed the subject, and Livia had spent the

rest of the afternoon treating the women around her to the full force of her attention, because that was her weapon: she knew the names of every woman's children, the state of every dowry, the secret of every unhappy marriage, and she dispensed that knowledge in small, perfect doses that made her the most valuable friend and the most dangerous enemy in the section.

But when she watched her husband climb to the high wooden tiers and sit beside the freedmen and the singers, what she felt, under the pride and the calculation, was the oldest wound of the married Roman woman: she had given her whole life to a structure, and another woman was living inside its walls. Not a rival — Livia had measured Antonia and found her too proud to take another woman's place. Something stranger: a woman whose existence proved that the structure was not the whole world.

She set the feeling aside, as she set aside all feelings that did not serve the children, and watched the sand, and made her arrangements. The Aelii would survive. That was the only vow she had ever truly meant.

The litter climbed the Esquiline, and below them Rome poured out of the amphitheatre into the dusk, fifty thousand voices arguing about the fights, and the lamps began to light along the streets, and the city looked, as it always did from a height, magnificent and indifferent and permanent, though Marcus knew by now that

nothing in it was permanent, and least of all the things that looked it.

⁂

The captured spy talked before the third watch, exactly as Antonia had predicted, over a cup of Hilarus's best Setine and a clear explanation of his options.

He was a thin, furtive man of thirty, with the locksmith's callus on his right thumb and a face trained to look harmless, and Festus had him on a stool in the storeroom with his tools laid out on a table beside him: the pick, a block of wax for impressions, a small knife, and the half-purse of new silver. Antonia interviewed him herself, with Chloe writing and Festus filling the doorway, and she began, as she always did, by removing the fear.

“No one's going to hurt you. Say that back to me, so I know it landed.”

“No one's going to hurt me.” He said it doubtfully.

“Correct. Here's why. If I hurt you, you say whatever I want, which is worthless in court. If I treat you fairly and witness the statement, it's worth a great deal, and you walk out of this house with your skin and perhaps your freedom. Your patron, on the other hand, has a dead clerk on his conscience and a habit of closing loose ends. The

Tiber is full of men who only knew one patron. Whose side is safer, Moschus?”

He stared at the wine, then at Festus, then at the quiet woman in the dark dress, and made the calculation that frightened men always make when the alternatives are laid out honestly.

He was a locksmith's assistant from the Tiber bank, hired by a soft-voiced gentleman he knew only as “the patron,” through two intermediaries, to make an impression of the strong-room lock and report what tablets it held. He had been paid half in advance, in new silver, and promised the rest on a drawing of the lock.

“The first intermediary's a runner called Afer, works the taverns by the cattle market. The second — I only saw him twice — he's a household man, soft hands, Greek accent, wore a signet of Minerva. He paid. Afer called him ‘the steward from the hill,' nothing more.”

Chloe's stylus moved. Antonia's eyes did not change. A steward from the Palatine, with a Minerva signet and a Greek accent, was not proof of Zosimus, but it was a door, and doors in Rome led somewhere if you pushed them correctly.

“Why the strong room? What did they tell you to find?”

“Tablets. Wax, four of them, bound. They said — he said — they were stolen property, that the house here was keeping what didn't belong to it. I was to copy the lock and count the tablets,

nothing else. I'm a locksmith, domina. I don't ask what the doors are for."

"Everyone asks. You asked less than most, which is why they hired you." She let him sit with that. "One question more, and answer carefully, because it's the one the praetor will care about. Were you told what would happen if you were caught?"

The furtive face worked. "Afer said if it went wrong, no one knew my name. That's all. No one knew my name."

"Yet here we are, names and all. You see the value of a promise from these men." She rose. "Festus, lock him up comfortably — food, water, a lamp — and put a guard on the door he'd thank us for. He's a witness now, and witnesses are expensive. Chloe, copies of the statement to the praetor's office and the auditor tonight. The silver goes to Beryllus for tracing; new coin moves through fewer hands than old."

"New silver," Chloe said, when Festus brought the statement to the tablinum. "Coins can be traced."

"They can if anyone keeps the records. Beryllus knows every large withdrawal in the city." Antonia read the statement twice. "The two intermediaries are the useful part. Find them, Festus. Quietly. If one of them belongs to Zosimus's household, the patron stops being a shadow."

"He'll run when he doesn't report back."

“He won't run tonight; he thinks the locksmith's boy succeeded, because we haven't raised an alarm. Let him think it. By tomorrow noon I want his name, his patron, and his route home.” She set the statement with the growing file. “And Moschus?”

“Locked in the old storeroom, fed, guarded. He's more afraid of his employer than of us, which is working in our favour.”

“Keep him afraid of the right things. Kindness for the turncoat, always; a man who changes sides once will change twice unless he likes the new side better.”

When Festus had gone, Chloe sat with her a while in the quiet, and the distant city noises came through the shuttered windows, and she said, “The arena today. I've never been to the games. I didn't know it would feel like that. Like the whole city was one mouth.”

“It is one mouth. The trick is never being the thing it eats.” Antonia poured two cups and pushed one across. “We're small people, you and I, by their measurements. No names, no rank, no ancestors. Small people survive by being better organized than the mouth. We have the evidence, the witnesses, the terms, and now their spy's own statement. When we finally stand in the Forum, Rome will discover that the smallest people in the room built the biggest case.”

“Perperna will have something ready. Something loud.”

“Let him. Loud men lose to prepared women; it's the one rule the Republic left us.” She raised her cup. “To the prepared. And to Moschus, who is having a very educational evening.”

Chloe raised hers, and somewhere beyond the walls the watch called the third hour, and the great city slept its uneasy sleep, full of mouths and knives and the small, stubborn people who meant to outlast both.

Beryllus's answer came before noon the next day, carried by a banker's boy with a sealed note and verbal instructions to wait for no reply.

The Alexandrian had run the new silver through his contacts at the treasury's assay office, and the coin was fresh-minted from a batch paid out, three weeks earlier, to the household staff disbursement of the imperial finance bureau. The batch lists did not name servants, but the amounts narrowed it; and Beryllus, whose genius was patience, had matched the sum to a single pay packet drawn by the steward's office for a Greek freedman named Hermeros, whose signet, the paymaster cheerfully recalled over a good lunch, was a Minerva.

Hermeros is one of Zosimus's people , the note concluded. *Your lockpick was paid, through two fools, by the emperor's own bureau. I have written nothing else down, because even my strong room has ears. Be careful, my dear. You are no longer fighting a prosecutor. You are fighting a wall, and walls do not bleed.*

Antonia burned the note, as she burned everything Beryllus sent, and sat a while with the ash in the dish, thinking.

Then she sent for Festus, and gave him the name and the description, and said, “Find him. Don't touch him. I want to know where he drinks, where he sleeps, and whose door he waits at. A man who works for a wall still has to walk home at night, and a man walking home has habits. The prefect's case needs a name with a face. We're going to give it both.”

Festus found him in three days, because Rome is a village for anyone with the right network, and the gladiator school's retired men were everywhere: the tavern keepers, the linkboys, the sedan-chair carriers, the porters at every gate. Hermeros turned out to be a small, dapper Greek of fifty, careful with his clothes and careless with his routine, and a routine, Festus explained to Antonia over the map of the city they kept marked in charcoal, was the shadow a man threw without knowing it.

“He leaves the bureau at the eighth hour, every day. Mondays and Thursdays, the Baths of Titus, where he plays dice badly. Tuesdays, a woman in the Subura — respectable, thinks he's a clerk with prospects; I've said nothing to her, that's her business. Fridays, the wine shop by the Aventine bank, where he meets the same man, an hour, separate tables, money never crosses the open, it goes under a napkin. Then home, a rented room

above an olive shop on the Caelian. Pays on the first, in good coin, keeps to himself, tips poorly.”

“Who's the Aventine man?”

“Working on it. The bank's a depositor of Longinus's circular payments, which makes the shop a hinge in the laundering. My guess is the Aventine man carries the coin from Hermeros to the next hand, and the next hand buys the shells.” Festus tapped the map. “He's small, domina. He's a courier with a nicer tunic. But small men walk the road between the big ones, and roads can be watched.”

“Watched, never touched. Attianus's inquiry must take him, not us; if he's found in a gutter the case gets sick. I want a record: his habits, his contacts, the Aventine meetings, all of it, in plain writing, one copy for the strong room and one for the prefect's office.”

“He'll know he's followed eventually. They always do.”

“By then it won't matter; the record will exist. The trick is to be boring long enough. A man who notices nothing alarming assumes nothing is happening, which is the assumption that has ruined more clever men than any trap.”

Festus grunted, the closest he came to laughter, and went back out into the streets with his charcoal and his patience, and for the next two weeks the dapper Greek walked through his Roman life with a gladiator's shadow he never once detected, and every line of his routine went

down on paper, the unremarkable daily evidence of how the money walked from the bureau to the wall.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Wife's Bargain

She came at the seventh hour, in a plain mantle with the veil drawn across her face, in a hired litter without insignia, and Festus, who had been warned through Porcia, let her through the gilded door without a name and closed it behind her before the street could make up its mind.

Antonia received her in the small garden court rather than the reception rooms, where no servants passed except those Antonia had chosen, and she had set out water and dates rather than wine, because this was not a social call and neither woman had any use for pretending it was.

Livia removed the veil, and they looked at each other across the fountain for a moment, the freedwoman and the consular wife, the two people on earth most thoroughly entangled in Marcus Aelius Severus's life, and Antonia said, “You're braver than your husband thinks. The street would eat this visit alive.”

“The street doesn't know my business, and my husband thinks I'm at my cousin's. I've been visiting my cousin on the same weekday for eleven years; no one will ever check.” Livia sat

without being invited, the habit of command sitting naturally on her. “I'll come to the point, since we've neither of us time for the other thing. I want to see the evidence. Not the originals in your temple, which I respect too much to touch; the copies. I want to know exactly what my family is standing on, because I've discovered I don't know, and I dislike the feeling.”

“You understand that seeing it makes you part of it. If the case fails, the women's names attached go down with it.”

“I've been attached to this family since I was eighteen. My name goes wherever the Aelii go; I'd rather steer than drown.” Livia folded her hands. “Show me.”

Chloe brought the copies, and for an hour the three women worked through them in the garden, the fountain spilling its quiet water, while the household moved around them at a careful distance. Livia read contracts the way she read her own accounts, quickly and without mercy, and her questions were better than most of the advocates' questions, Antonia noted; she went straight to the weak joins, the places where one man's word held up another man's paper.

“The weakest link isn't Perperna,” Livia said at last. “It's your witnesses. A Greek measurer, a Syrian engraver, a frightened banker, a lyre player, and the mistress of a supper house. Against an equestrian with twenty years of successful prosecutions and an imperial freedman

behind him. A court of Roman senators will believe the men with the names."

"Which is why your husband's name is the one that opens the case. The court believes him."

"Yes." Livia's mouth tightened. "And if they decide he's been seduced into persecuting an innocent man on a courtesan's evidence? Then the name destroys the case and itself together. He knows this?"

"He's known since the praetor's office. He signed anyway."

For a moment something moved in Livia's face, quickly controlled, and Antonia, who read faces the way Chloe read columns, recognized it with some surprise: pride.

"He would," Livia said. "The stubborn, inconvenient man. Very well. Then I'll give you what the case can't get anywhere else: the family's own records. Celer's debts didn't begin with Perperna; I've kept the household papers for eleven years, and I can show the slope, year by year, from the first respectable banker to the last twenty-four-per-cent loan. And I can show something else. The steward's access to my husband's seal. If Perperna's people used it twice, they may have used it more than twice; the only complete record of when that seal left the strong room is my own household diary."

Antonia studied her. "Why are you doing this? Be honest; I can work with anything except a reason I don't know."

Livia did not answer at once. She watched the fish move under the lily pads.

“Because my whole life is a structure I did not choose, and it has at least taught me to recognize when another woman is being made to pay for the convenience of men. Perperna would close this house and sell your women and call it morality, while the same men who pay at your door vote for him in the Senate. I find I've grown tired of it. Not today, not suddenly — it's been building, the way water builds behind a wall.” She looked up. “And because if my husband is going to risk the consulship, I intend to know whether the cause is worth the price. Having read the tablets, I think it is. That's all. Don't mistake me for a friend; I'm an ally, and allies are more reliable.”

“Allies, then.” Antonia lifted her water cup. “To the wall.”

“To the wall.”

They drank, and for a while the garden held only the fountain and the distant scales of a musician at practice, and then Livia asked the question she had come partly to ask, the one no note or diary could answer.

“Him. You and him. I'll have it plainly, woman to woman, and it stays in this court.”

Antonia set down the cup. “Plainly: we were children together in his father's house, before either of us understood what his father's house was. They sold me when I was carrying his child. The child died. Fifteen years passed, and he

believed I'd left him, and I believed he'd let me be sold. That's the whole of the romance, and it isn't one."

Livia's face changed, subtly, the way a careful map changes when a coast you've drawn wrong is corrected. "He never told me any of it."

"He didn't know it. He learned it the same month you did, more or less. Your husband is an honest man inside a dishonest education; the education is the harder thing to be married to."

"And now? The broadsheets say what they say. Give me the truth to weigh against them."

"Now we're two people with work to do who've decided to trust each other, provisionally, with the evidence and not with anything the law can touch. He's married. I know it; he knows it; neither of us is a girl who mistakes a closed door for an invitation. I won't lie and say there's nothing between us, because you'd know the lie and despise me for it. But nothing has happened that would give Rome its proof, and nothing will while the case runs. After that—" she spread her hands "—after that is a country none of us has reached."

Livia sat with it a long moment. "You're the calmest person I've ever met about her own heart."

"I had to be. Hearts are a luxury the freeborn can afford. Mine has always been an investment decision."

“Perhaps that's what he's drawn to. His whole life is women wanting things from him. You want nothing he can give.”

“I want his name on a prosecution. That's quite a lot, in Rome.”

For the first time, something like amusement softened the rigid elegance of Livia's face. “It is. Very well. The plain answer was the right one. I'll remember it.”

⁂

Livia's second discovery came in her own house, three nights later, and it came through the household diary.

She had kept it since her marriage, a plain woman's book, recording the movements of the strong box, the seal ring, the family silver, and the comings and goings of the senior slaves, because she had learned early that the great houses were held together less by virtue than by inventory. Cross-referencing the dates Marcus had been away from Rome against the recorded uses of the seal, she found two entries she did not recognize: a withdrawal to the steward's office on the Praeneste dedication day, and a second, six weeks later, when Marcus was at the Alban estate.

She did not confront Phaon at once. Confrontation, she had learned across fifteen years of managing a great household, was the indulgence of people who could afford

consequences; a steward accused before proof became a steward building a defence, and defended men remembered nothing. Instead she set herself to the older, colder discipline of observation.

For three days she changed nothing and watched everything. She noted that Phaon's accounts balanced to the sesterce, which was its own warning, since honest stewardships balanced to the denarius and carried small, human discrepancies; a perfect ledger was a performed ledger. She noted that the strong-box key, which the steward was supposed to wear at all times, spent certain afternoons in its drawer while Phaon visited the barber, and she cross-checked those afternoons against the diary and found, with the small, sinking sensation of a pattern closing, that they matched the days a particular messenger called at the garden gate — a Greek, well dressed, who never gave a name and always left by the same gate within the quarter hour.

Doris the maid supplied the rest, in the women's quarters over the steaming tubs, where stewards did not go and confidences rose with the steam. The Greek brought tablets, Doris said, and sometimes a small packet that clinked, and Phaon received him in the garden room with the door on the latch, and twice she had been sent away on errands exactly when he came, and a maid sent away on an errand at the same hour twice was a

maid who had learned more than the errands contained.

“Did you see his face?” Livia asked, keeping her voice at the pitch of laundry gossip.

“Once, domina. Smiling man, soft hands, rings. He had a seal on a chain, the figure of a woman with a helmet — Minerva, the cook said, when I drew it.” Doris hesitated. “Should I not have looked?”

“You should always look. Looking is the only thing the powerful can't forbid, because they never notice the women doing it.” Livia laid a fresh shift over the tub and asked, with the same casualness, whether Doris would say all of it again, slowly, before a tablet and a witness, and Doris, who had served the household since girlhood and loved the children, said she would say it before the praetor himself if it kept the family's name off false paper.

That night Livia wrote the whole sequence into the diary in her own hand — dates, afternoons, the gate, the Minerva seal, Doris's name — and sealed the entry with her personal signet rather than the household's, because a document that could be opened by the same man it accused was no document at all. Then she carried the diary to her own room and put it beneath the things she kept nearest her person, and slept poorly, and was down at the household shrine before dawn, making the offerings with a devotion her women had not seen in years. Evidence, she was

discovering, was a heavy thing to keep in a house that contained the man it threatened.

She sent for the steward, an elderly slave named Phaon who had served the family for thirty years, and questioned him in the tablinum with the diary open between them, the way her husband questioned witnesses in court.

Phaon went grey. He did not lie for long; he was too old and too frightened, and Livia was too well prepared.

“Master Celer came,” he said. “Both times. With a man I didn't know, a gentleman, soft-spoken. He said the senator had authorized family witnessing in his absence; he had the ring, or the man did — I don't know where it came from, I swear it, domina, I only saw it pressed into the wax. I thought—”

“You thought a steward who asks questions ends in the mines.”

“Yes, domina.”

“Who else in this household knew? Think carefully. Your life depends on the answer.”

He thought, visibly, about his life. “The maid, domina. Doris. She let the men in through the garden gate, both nights. I saw her take a purse. I'm sorry. I should have told you; I've not slept.”

Livia closed the diary. She did not shout. In fifteen years of managing five hundred slaves she had never once needed to shout; the women who shouted were the women who had not yet learned where the power lay.

“Go to your room. You'll remain there, fed and unchained, until I decide. Speak to no one, including the gods in your prayers, because the household gods are mine.”

Doris was younger, a Syrian woman with quick eyes and expensive earrings that Livia now examined with new attention, and she denied it twice and broke on the third question, the way they did, and the story came out: the soft-voiced man's agent, the gifts, the garden gate, the messages carried from the house to a contact near the cattle market. Not secrets of state — the Aelii were careful — but comings and goings, visitors, the timing of Marcus's absences, the state of Celer's debts. The raw material of surveillance, delivered for silver and earrings.

“Keep the earrings,” Livia said coldly. “They'll be in the evidence.”

She did not sell the girl, or beat her, which the household had expected. She did something more Roman and more permanent: she transferred her to the country estate, to the olive presses, for life, with a written record of the reason that would follow her to any owner who ever asked. The sentence was not cruelty; it was architecture, and the rest of the staff understood it perfectly.

Phaon she kept. The old steward had failed in courage rather than loyalty, and the household needed his knowledge more than it needed his punishment; but she moved the seal ring from the steward's office to her own bedchamber, and from

that day every use of it passed through her hands, with the time and the purpose written in the diary at once.

When Marcus learned of it, in the evening, he came to her sitting room and found her at the accounts, and stood in the doorway like a junior officer before a general.

“You've conducted an entire investigation in my own house without telling me.”

“I've conducted it in *our* house, which is the point. You were busy being audited; someone had to mind the seal.” She did not look up. “Phaon lives, Doris presses olives, and from now on your name leaves this house only when I write it down. You may thank me.”

He sat down, and after a moment he laughed — the rare, short laugh that the household heard perhaps twice a year. “I've been managed by my wife.”

“You've been *protected* by your wife. There's a difference, and if you can't see it, the praetor will explain it to you.” Now she looked up. “I've also given Antonia Cassia the diary and the statements. Before you object: the case is the only thing standing between your brother and the mines and your name and the gutter. I did not marry into a gutter. I'll be useful, Marcus, or I'll be nothing, and I refuse to be nothing.”

He studied her, this woman he had lived beside for fifteen years without fully seeing, and said,

“You should have been born a man. You'd have reached the consulship before me.”

“That's the second stupidest thing you've ever said. The stupidest was ‘I don't need a wife's advice' in our wedding month. Don't repeat either.”

He did not. He went to bed that night with the odd, unsettling sense that his household had acquired a second general, and that the army was better for it.

⁂

She brought the diary to the Carinae herself, on the next of her fictitious cousin-days, and laid it on the garden table between them like a weapon laid down at a treaty.

“Two unauthorized uses of the seal, with dates, and the steward's witnessed statement. The maid's statement as well. Your case now has the inside of my house to match the outside of yours.”

Antonia turned the pages with care. “This is dangerous for you. If the trial fails—”

“If the trial fails, my husband's career is already over, and a steward's statement changes nothing. If it succeeds, the Aelii are the family that exposed an imperial fraud, and my husband's name becomes a thing future consuls need.” Livia sat straight. “I've also done what I should have done a year ago. I've moved the family's liquid funds into my dowry account, which is legally

mine and beyond Celer's reach. The family can't be bled dry while the case is running. Hilarus can tell you the same; I've used his bank."

"You've been busy."

"I've been frightened. Frightened women with five hundred slaves are a considerable force." She paused. "One personal matter, and then I'll not raise it again. My husband. You and he. Whatever there is, or may be, I won't be made a figure of fun, and the children won't be made illegitimate by a divorce scandal, and the name won't be damaged by a public affair. Within those walls, I don't much care what Rome whispers; I care what Rome can prove. Are we understood?"

"We are. And I'll tell you the same thing I told him: I've no interest in your place, your name, or your husband's rank. I have a house to keep and eleven women to keep safe. Whatever exists between us exists inside that, not over it." Antonia met her eyes. "You might even believe me. It would save us both time."

Livia looked at her for a long moment, and then, slowly, inclined her head, the smallest possible concession.

"I might. In time. Now — the girl's hearing, the custody matter. When is it?"

"First market day of next month. Perperna's people will use it to reach the house; we'll use it to make the house look law-abiding in open court. Your husband's standing order protects us, but the praetor peregrinus is a man named Macer—"

“Macer I know. He's weak, and weak men follow the strongest voice in the room. The strongest voice must be ours.” Livia rose, adjusting the veil. “I'll be in the back of the court, with two consular wives who owe me favours. A praetor who sees the women of the old families on your side of the room finds his backbone remarkably quickly.”

Antonia rose too, and for a moment the two women stood face to face in the garden, and the fountain made its sound between them, and neither smiled, and neither looked away.

“You know,” Antonia said, “in a differently arranged city, you and I could have run the treasury between us.”

“In a differently arranged city,” Livia said, “we would have. As it is, we'll have to settle for saving it.” She drew the veil across her face. “The same day next week. Tell your doorman my cousin's health remains a burden.”

She went out by the postern, into the hired litter, and was gone, and Chloe, emerging from the colonnade, said, “I've met queens with less presence. What did she want, truly?”

“Her family's survival, and she's decided we're the road to it.” Antonia picked up the diary. “She's also the best witness I've ever been offered, and she brought herself. Mark this day, Chloe; Rome produced a patrician wife with the soul of a barrister, and Perperna doesn't even know she exists.”

“Nobody ever notices the women,” Chloe said.

“Exactly.” Antonia carried the diary toward the strong room. “That's our advantage. It's the only one we need.”

⁂

The custody hearing fell on the first market day, and the city gave them an audience whether they wanted one or not.

The praetor peregrinus Macer held his court in the old basilica beside the Forum, where merchants argued cargo disputes and foreigners came for the Roman law that ruled them anyway, and a custody case with a Carinae address had drawn the usual small crowd of idlers, law students, and professional spectators. Antonia arrived with Chloe, the house advocate, and Sabina herself, in a plain respectable dress and her documents in order, and found Livia already seated at the back between two consular wives, all three in the dark veils of respectable matrons, their mere presence changing the temperature of the room.

Vipsanius's advocates opened with the sentimental case: a freeborn girl, a father's debt, a house of entertainment, the natural inference of coercion. They were good; Perperna's money always bought competence. The court listened, the crowd murmured, and Macer, a round man

with a politician's instinct for the stronger wind, looked increasingly thoughtful.

Then Antonia's advocate put the documents: the sealed debt-paper with Vipsanius's own mark, the witnessed contract of service, the enrollment under the aedile's license, the copy at the temple of Isis, and — the decisive touch — a statement from Quintus Avianius himself, brought to Rome at Hilarus's expense, attesting that the transfer was lawful and that his daughter served with his consent and wrote to him weekly.

Avianius stood in the witness box in his one good tunic, weathered and terrified and absolutely truthful, and the sentimental case began to bleed from a dozen cuts.

But the moment the court remembered belonged to Sabina. Macer, who had intended to ask one routine question, asked instead whether she wished to remain, and the girl stood before the basilica full of strangers and said the thing Antonia had taught her, in the steady voice of the rehearsed and the brave.

“I am Sabina Aviania, daughter of Quintus. I came to the house under my father's lawful debt, and I stay by my own will, witnessed and written. I am taught to read and reckon and the law, and I'm paid, and no one in that house has ever touched me against my will. I ask the court to let me keep my contract, because it's the first piece of paper in Rome that ever protected me.”

The law students stopped whispering. Macer looked at Livia's row, found three pairs of aristocratic eyes fixed on him, looked at the documents, found them flawless, and ruled: the complaint was dismissed, the contract upheld, and the magistrate's own office noted the plaintiff's failure to produce evidence of coercion. Costs against Vipsanius.

Outside, in the market-day sun, Sabina's knees gave way on the basilica steps, and Chloe held her up, and the girl said, into the older woman's shoulder, “I said it all. I didn't forget a word.”

“You said it better than the words. Now breathe; the whole Forum is watching, and Carinae women do not faint on steps.”

Antonia hung back a moment, watching Livia descend with her party. The two women's eyes met across the crowd. Neither bowed; neither needed to. Livia gave the smallest inclination of the head, the nod of a general confirming a flank held, and moved on, and Antonia thought that the case had just acquired its most dangerous and most valuable witness: a woman the law could not classify at all.

Perperna's answer to the defeat arrived that same evening, not to the house but to the city: a new broadsheet, sharper than the rest, hinting that the Carinae establishment held documents stolen from imperial offices and that its clients' names were being recorded for blackmail. It did not name the source. It did not need to.

“He's lost the girl, so he attacks the records,” Chloe said, reading it at supper.

“He's preparing the ground for something larger. When the law can't reach us, the next move is to make us look like a danger to every man who dines here.” Antonia folded the sheet. “Send word to our regular guests, through Hilarus: the house keeps no records of names beyond the ordinary guest lists any host keeps, and their privacy has survived one praetor's inspection already. Trust, once frightened, has to be fed daily.”

Festus returned that evening with the report on Hermeros, and it was precise, because Festus's reports always were.

The Greek freedman lived in a tenement on the Palatine slope, drank at a wine shop on the street of the bankers, and reported, every third day, at a side door of the finance bureau. He had a mistress in the Subura, a weakness he kept from his wife, and he took his exercise at the baths of Trajan at the same hour twice a week. A routine man, Festus said, a man who believed the world rewarded order.

“Then the world's about to disappoint him.” Antonia marked the route on a slate. “Not yet. We don't touch him until the case is ready, and then we take his statement in front of the praetor's officers, in daylight, where he can't disappear. A man like that doesn't run; he bargains, and his bargain is the door to Zosimus.”

She set the slate with the others in the growing collection that mapped the conspiracy house by house, name by name, from the Tiber bank to the Palatine, and stood back and looked at it, the way a general looks at a campaign map, and allowed herself, for one moment, to feel it: the slow, certain turning of the tide.

The word reached Perperna at his dinner, delivered by a clerk who had waited three hours for an audience, and he heard the custody ruling and the matrons' presence in the basilica without changing expression, and sent the man away, and sat a while with his fish going cold.

The loss itself was nothing; one girl's contract was beneath his notice. The presence of the consular wives was everything. It meant Livia Marcella had chosen a side, and that the side now had the old families' respectable face in the open. A prosecution against the house would have to reckon not with a freedwoman alone but with the women of the class that owned the courts.

He did not become angry. Anger was a tool he kept for other men. He became more careful. That night he wrote two letters: one to Zosimus, advising him to begin moving his personal fortune into assets that did not bear his name, and one to the aedile's office, requesting the preparation of a fuller indictment than the custody complaint — a combined charge of lenocinium and adultery, with the auditor named as the married senator involved. The small cases had failed. It was time

for the case that could end things at a single stroke.

Then she went down to the women's court, where Sabina was reading the Twelve Tables aloud and Tyche was tuning the lyre, and sat among her household, and the ordinary music of the place closed over her like water, and the map and the names and the danger waited quietly in the tablinum for morning.

The household had its own life underneath the war, and Antonia made a point of keeping it. After the evening meal the women gathered as they always had, with mending and music and the small exchange of the day, and tonight the talk was of Sabina's triumph in the basilica, which had grown in the telling, as triumphs do, until the girl's single steady sentence had become a full Ciceronian oration.

“I said perhaps eight sentences,” Sabina protested, laughing. “Not an oration.”

“History is written by the survivors,” Chloe said, “and you survived. Let us enjoy it.”

Tyche played a light tune, and one of the musicians danced a few steps in the small space, and for a while the court was merely a room full of young women being young, and Antonia watched from her couch with the feeling a gardener has when the plants thrive in weather that should have killed them. It was, she thought, the answer to every question the city asked about her house: not the money, not the secrets, but this — a place

where women who had been sold, orphaned, widowed, and discarded could sit in lamplight and laugh without looking at the door.

Phyllis, beside her, said quietly, “You're thinking about the girl you were.”

“I'm thinking about the girls they are. The girl I was doesn't get rescued; she's done the rescuing, such as it is.”

“Such as it is,” Phyllis agreed, dry as old paper. “Eleven of them, fed, taught, paid, and now one of them has beaten a praetor's court. Rome's seen worse miracles, but not many.”

Hilarus's evening dispatch arrived before the music ended, brought by a factor who waited in the kitchen for no reply. The Ostia end was holding: granary seven was under a discreet watch, Capito the supervisor had grown nervous and begun quarrelling with his clerks, and Dorion's tattooed arm had been copied onto two fresh tablets, one for the harbour office and one sealed for the temple coffer. The factor also reported, with the satisfaction of a man passing on a good market price, that the annona clerk who had corrected Hector's tallies had been seen burning papers in his garden brazier two nights running.

“Guilty men burn paper,” Antonia said, reading it. “Innocent men keep it. Tell Hilarus the burning goes into the record; the date, the witness, the brazier. A man destroying his own accounts is half a confession, if the court's in the right mood.”

Chloe noted it, and said, “Sabina asked today whether she could begin learning the statute on witness standing. She says summons law is only the beginning.”

“Give her the Rubrius text and tell her to mark everything she doesn't understand; I'll have him explain the hard parts in exchange for a dinner, which is the only coin he enjoys.” Antonia watched the lamp flames. “Every hand we teach to read is a hand they can't use. Keep count of them, Chloe. Sometime, years from now, someone's going to ask what this house was really for, and the answer won't be the suppers.”

The music went on, and the lamps burned down, and one by one the women went up to their rooms with bolts on their doors, and the house settled into its night, and the two guards Festus had posted moved through the garden with soft feet, and somewhere beyond the walls Rome kept its usual watch, full of appetites and danger and the long, patient work of the small people who meant to outlast it.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Ostia

They left Rome before dawn, two separate parties by the old arrangement, and met where the road met the river, and the road and the river ran together toward the sea.

Antonia travelled with Chloe and Festus in Hilarus's covered cart, among the oil jars and account tablets, while Marcus rode ahead with Stichus on the public business of the audit, and the two groups were careful to arrive at Ostia through different gates at different hours, because Perperna's eyes were everywhere in Rome but thinner at the harbour, where the money was too busy to gossip.

The sea announced itself before the city did: a change in the air, salt and fish and open space, and then the masts, a forest of them, rising beyond the tiled roofs of the greatest harbour in the world. Ostia lay spread along the mouth of the Tiber, its quays crowded with ships from every province, its granaries towering like temples of bread, its streets full of the accents of the empire — Egyptians, Spaniards, Africans, Syrians, Greeks — all of them shouting, bargaining, hauling, and

watching the grain flow toward the insatiable city upriver.

The road gave them Rome's true scale. For miles outside the walls it was lined with tombs and villas and the camps of the night-soil carts, and then the city's noise faded behind them and the country opened in winter fields and olive grey, and the Tiber broadened beside the road with its endless traffic of barges, the grain and wine and oil and timber moving slow and steady as blood through the empire's veins. Chloe slept; Festus drove; Antonia watched the barges and thought, not for the first time, that Rome was less a city than a mouth, and that everything she and Hilarus and the honest merchants did was merely the work of keeping the mouth fed.

At the river mouth the mouth became a harbour. The new imperial port opened beyond the old town, a vast enclosed basin ringed with quays and warehouses, its lighthouse standing tall as a temple, and the sea beyond it stretched blue and enormous to the edge of the world. Even Festus, who was hard to impress, looked at the ships and said, “More wood than the whole of the Subura.”

Hilarus's factor met them at the warehouse gate, a lean, anxious Numidian named Iucundus, with ink on his hands and the look of a man who had not slept since the first threats.

“Dorion's inside, with the guards. And there's something else — you should see it before you

settle. One of the wharf clerks. They found him in the alley behind the customs house at dawn.”

The clerk lay on a pallet in the warehouse office, a young man with a broken arm and a face that had been worked over by professionals, breathing through swollen lips. Dorion, the Greek measurer, crouched beside him with a damp cloth, and rose when they came in, hollow-eyed.

“He's called Felix. He kept the public weight notes for quay seven. Two men came to his room last night and asked him, politely, whether he'd spoken to anyone from Rome. He told them no, which was almost true, and they broke his arm to keep him honest, and said next time it would be his writing hand.” Dorion's voice was tight. “He came to me because I'm the only Greek in the harbour he trusts. They're closing the doors, domina. One by one.”

Marcus arrived an hour later, in his senatorial tunic with the audit tablets under his arm, and Antonia watched him take in the wounded clerk, the guarded warehouse, the rows of amphorae, with the same cold attention he gave the Curia. He knelt beside the pallet and spoke to Felix himself, gently, as an officer speaks to a casualty, and got the whole story in ten minutes: the men, their accents, the name of the wine shop where they waited, and — the thing that mattered — the admission that the wharf's master copy of the weights had been altered after each weighing, by

an official who reported not to the harbour prefect but to a finance bureau clerk in Rome.

“Zosimus's hand at the harbour itself,” Marcus said, when they were alone among the oil jars. “It's worse than the tablets show. The fraud isn't hidden in Rome. It's committed here, on the quays, and the Roman tallies are merely the lie's second copy.”

“Which is why the witnesses keep ending up in alleys.” Antonia laid out Hilarus's factor's copies beside his tablets. “We'll take Felix's statement now, witnessed and sealed, while he's alive and frightened enough to be precise. Then he goes into the warehouse with Dorion and the guards, and I want a physician, the best in Ostia, on Hilarus's account. A dead witness is useless; a healed one can stand in court.”

Dorion himself told his story over a cup of hot wine in the factor's office, a small, precise man with a clerk's hands and a hunted man's eyes. He had measured grain for eleven years, first at the public scales, later for private shippers, and he had noticed the rhythm slowly, the way a man notices a leak, before understanding that the leak was the building's design.

“Every fourth shipment. Always the same gain. At first I thought I was mistaken; nobody falsifies the public grain, the grain is sacred, the annona feeds Rome. Then I made my own marks, here, on my arm.” He pushed up his sleeve; a row of tiny tattooed numbers ran up the forearm. “I kept

them on my body because they'd find any tablet. Your Hector found out about the marks through a friend, months ago. That's why he came to Ostia. That's probably why he's dead."

"Can you reproduce the marks as a statement?" Marcus asked.

"I can reproduce every weight I've taken in two years. The arm's my ledger; nothing can burn it." He looked from Marcus to Antonia. "I'll testify. I've decided. A man can't hide in a warehouse forever, and my daughter's in Rome, and I won't have her grow up thinking her father let them steal the bread and said nothing. But I'll say this too: if your protection fails, I'm a dead man at the bottom of the harbour, and so is Felix. We're staking our lives on your case."

"Then we'll make a case worth the stake," Marcus said.

Antonia said nothing, but she made a private note: Dorion was the strongest witness they had, the man with the truth written into his skin, and the strongest witness required the strongest guard. She would double the warehouse men and have Hilarus move the family quietly before they left Ostia. The powerful could buy soldiers; she would have to buy loyalty in advance, which was cheaper and more durable.

The granary inspection came first, while the light was good, and Marcus went in his official capacity, with the harbour prefect's reluctant secretary and a clerk to make notes, and Antonia

came as the representative of Hilarus's shipping interests, her own copy of the factor's weight notes in hand.

The public granary at quay seven was a vast, cool hall of arches and raised floors, full of the dry, warm smell of stored wheat, and the supervisor, a plump man named Capito, greeted the auditor with the particular smile of an official who has prepared for the visit. The tallies on his tablets were immaculate. The grain was stacked correctly, the ventilation was sound, everything was in perfect order on paper.

Antonia walked the stacks with Dorion at her heels, and said nothing until they reached the rear bins, where the factor's notes showed a shipment of three hundred and twenty modii. The bin was marked for four hundred and ten.

“Same grain?” she asked Dorion, low.

“Same shipment, same bin, same dust line. I watched it weighed.”

She said nothing aloud until they were back before Capito, and then she asked, in the polite voice of a woman asking a small favour, whether she might see the public scale. They weighed a sealed measure, and it was correct. They weighed a second, and it was correct. Then she asked the clerk to read aloud the entries for the last twelve shipments, and the room heard the rhythm Dorion had found in the tablets: every fourth entry, the same gain, ninety modii, as regular as a heartbeat.

“Remarkable consistency,” Marcus said, in the voice he used in the Curia. “One might almost think the grain grew on the river.”

Capito's smile did not leave his face, but it became a fixed thing, the smile of a mask. “The weighing has its variations, Senator; the harbour air, the moisture—”

“The moisture adds no ninety modii to every fourth shipment, in every season, for two years.” Marcus closed the tablet. “You'll preserve all your records, Capito, under seal, and the harbour prefect will receive a copy of this morning's notes. Nothing is to be moved, burned, or corrected. I'll have the clerk witness that instruction.”

Outside, in the salt wind, Antonia said, “He'll run before nightfall.”

“Let him. A running official is a confession; I've put a man at the gate to note which road.” Marcus looked back at the granary's arches. “I've audited ten years of accounts in Rome and found nothing but clean wax. The crime was here, in the dust, all along. The tablets were never meant to be read against the bins.”

“That's why they killed the one man who could read both,” Dorion said, very low.

The statement took the afternoon. The light went golden over the harbour, and the lamps were lit, and one by one the pieces of the chain were pressed into wax: the weighing, the alteration, the bureau clerk, the men with their polite violence. Felix, the beaten clerk, dictated

slowly through his swollen mouth, and the physician arrived while the last line was written, a grey Greek who set the arm with competence and took Hilarus's coin without asking questions. Festus stood in the doorway the whole time, and the warehouse guards stood outside it, and when the last seal was pressed, Marcus sat back and said, quietly, “They'll know we were here by morning. The whole case now turns on speed. I'll take these to Attianus the moment we're back. No more waiting on perfect order; the prefect gets what exists, and we fill the gaps under his protection.”

“Then we leave tomorrow at first light,” Antonia said. “Tonight, nobody sleeps alone. Festus, the guards double.”

While the physician worked and the lamps were trimmed, Marcus spread the day's statements across the warehouse table and did what auditors do at the end of a long counting: he checked the arithmetic of treachery.

“Lay the dates in a line,” he said to Antonia, who had drawn up a stool with her own tablet. “Felix's beating, the altered tallies, the fourth-shipment gains, the shell subscriptions Celer signed. If this is one machine, the dates ought to move in one direction, like water toward a drain.”

They moved. Within a quarter of an hour the table showed what neither statement showed alone: the bureau's corrections always followed

the shipments by precisely three days, the false tallies were always witnessed by the same two names, and the shell subscriptions, which Celer had been signing in Rome for a year, predated each Ostia contract by a matter of weeks, as though the paper boat were built in the harbour before the cargo existed to fill it.

“That's the shape of it,” Marcus said, sitting back. “The subscriptions create the firm; the firm takes the contract; the fourth shipment creates the surplus; the bureau corrects the tally to hide it; the surplus becomes silver; the silver walks back through the bank to the men who built the boat. Every step is legal-looking, and every step has a document, and the documents were meant never to lie on the same table.”

“Until now.” Antonia sanded her notes. “Hector's tablets are the keystone. He kept the pre-correction numbers, which means his figures and the official tallies can't be made to agree, and two ledgers that disagree are the one thing a fraudulent bureau can't survive in open court. That's why he's dead.” She looked at the sealed statements drying in their rows. “We carry these back like eggs. If we're stopped on the road—”

“We won't be. We travel as Hilarus's factor train, his seals on the wagons, his name on the passes; no one searches an oil merchant who supplies the palace.” Marcus rolled the tablets into their oilskin with the care of a man handling his own life, which, in a sense, he was. “But we

also make copies tonight, before we sleep. One set with Hilarus here, sealed in his warehouse vault; one set travels; the originals stay in the temple coffer in Rome. Three doors. Your rule.”

“My rule, learned from a banker over figs.” She rose, stiff after the long day, and looked out through the warehouse doors at the harbour, where the riding lights of the grain fleet swung in the dark water and the lighthouse beam turned its slow, indifferent circle. “All that food out there, Marcus. An army's bread, a city's bread, and a handful of men weighing it twice and selling the difference. Hector died for ninety modii of wheat. It's such a small number to kill a man for.”

“Small numbers are the only ones men kill for. A fortune in one stroke leaves witnesses; ninety modii a shipment leaves nothing but arithmetic, and nobody weeps for arithmetic.” He fastened the oilskin's ties. “That's why we're going to make them weep for it. In the Forum, if we have to, one figure at a time.”

Felix, the beaten clerk, was awake when they checked on him before the watches changed, his arm bound, his face a map of dried blood and fear. Antonia sat with him a while herself, because frightened men spoke differently to a woman who did not threaten, and she had the scrivener's questions ready.

“Tell me about the day's order of work. Not the men — the work. When do the tallies leave the

granary, who carries them, where do they change hands?”

He told her, haltingly, and the routine built itself into another small map: the morning weights, the midday copying, the evening corrections, and the single hour each week when the granary's own rolls travelled to the bureau for reconciliation. “That hour,” Felix said, wincing as he shifted, “is when the numbers stop being ours. Whatever we send up comes back different, and we're told to make our books match the returned ones, or find other work. Or” — he touched his bound arm — “other lessons.”

“Then the returned tallies are the damning documents,” Marcus said when they were outside again. “The corrections exist in two hands, and the bureau's hand is the one that changed.”

“Two hands, and now one of them has a statement and a physician's report of the lesson.” Antonia looked back at the shuttered room. “Keep him here until the prefect's protection covers him. A man who's been beaten once expects to be beaten again; the only cure is a door he believes will hold.”

⁂

The inn Hilarus used stood a street back from the quay, a respectable place for merchants with papers, and the factor had quietly taken the whole upper floor, so that the party had the run of it:

rooms along a balcony above a courtyard where an olive tree grew and a fountain splashed, and below, the ordinary noise of a harbour inn — sailors, dice, a singer with a lyre, the rhythmic thump of the sea.

They ate late, in the upper room, because no one had eaten since dawn: grilled fish, bread, the sharp local wine, and for once no servants but the innkeeper's wife, who served and withdrew and knew better than to remember faces. Iucundus took the first watch with Festus, and Chloe, with one long, knowing look at her mistress, gathered up the tablets and her mantle and went to the room she was to share with the innkeeper's daughter, and closed the door with a soft, final click.

Marcus and Antonia were alone.

They stood it for perhaps a minute, the fountain below them, the singer's voice threading the dark, and then he said, with the careful formality that always returned to him when he was moved, “I should go to my room.”

Before that, they had talked. The fish had come and gone, and the wine, and the long, strange ease of being a day's journey from the city that defined them. He told her about the German winter, the frozen patrols, the day his unit had walked into an ambush and he had learned, at twenty-two, that courage was mostly the absence of any dignified way to run. She told him about the early years of the house, the six couches and

the leaking roof, the first great banquet she had staged on credit and the senator's wife who had tried to have her expelled from the street.

“Prima used to say Rome forgives everything except a woman's success,” she said. “A man rising is a story; a woman rising is an accusation.”

“She sounds wise.”

“She was cynical, which is wisdom after its illusions have died.” Antonia turned the wine cup in her hands. “And you. The marriage. You've never said the whole of it.”

“The whole of it is that Livia and I were assigned each other like two accounts in the same ledger. She's magnificent, and I've never once made her laugh from anything except duty. We produced two excellent children and a functioning estate, which is what the contract required. The poets' version was never on offer.” He looked into his cup. “I've been faithful, if that matters. Mostly because I'm no good at dividing myself. Other men manage it; I've watched them with admiration.”

“It matters less than you think. Fidelity without feeling is just another kind of arrangement.” She said it gently. “I've been the other woman, Marcus, more times than I can count, though never in my own house, and not the way the broadsheets imagine. I know the architecture of Roman marriages from the outside. You're not the first unhappy husband at my table. You're the first one who knew it.”

“And now?”

“And now the wine's gone to my head and the sea is making me honest, which is a dangerous combination. Let's leave it there.”

But they did not leave it there, and the silence that followed was a different silence from any before it, full of the sounds of the inn and the night and two people listening to their own hearts.

“You could. The whole arrangement would remain exactly as it was.” She did not move from the balcony rail. “Or you could stay, and it would change, and neither of us would be able to pretend afterward. I've made a policy of knowing which thing I'm choosing. I'd like you to know as well.”

“I've known since the temple grove. Perhaps since the door. I'm merely trying to give you the chance to refuse me without a scene.”

She turned from the rail. “Have I ever struck you as a woman who needed chances to refuse?”

“No.” He said it almost sadly. “That's been the difficulty. You refuse the whole world so completely.”

“Not all of it.”

The distance between them was perhaps three paces, the length of a small room, and they crossed it in the end at the same moment, the way two people cross every distance that has been waited through too long. His hands came up to her face with the tentativeness of a man handling

something he had broken once, and she put her own hands over them and pressed them harder, because she had no use for tentativeness, and said, against his mouth, “I am not glass. I have never been glass.”

Then they were kissing, fifteen years of silence breaking like a held breath, and it was not gentle at first, it was urgent and almost angry, the kiss of two people discovering how much of their lives had been spent not doing this. Her back met the wall of the room; his hand found the fastening of her stola and fumbled it, and she covered his hand with hers and undid it herself, quickly, competently, the way she did everything, and the dark fabric fell, and the lamplight moved across her shoulders.

He stopped then, and looked at her, and she saw the soldier's composure fail entirely, and said, “What?”

“I had forgotten. I had made myself forget.” His voice was rough. “The kitchen. The light through the olive press. You were seventeen, and I was a fool who thought the world would wait.”

“The world didn't wait. It sold me. But this—” she took his hand and laid it against her heart “—this one thing it never quite managed to take. I checked, over the years. It was still here. Annoyingly.”

He laughed, and it came out broken, and kissed her again, and this time it was slower.

What happened between them then had nothing of the theatrical about it, and that was its mercy and its power. There was no performance, because there was no audience; no transaction, because nothing was being bought; no rule but the rule of two bodies deciding, at last, to stop being careful. She had known a great many men's hands in her life, professionally and otherwise, and none of them had ever trembled, and his did, and the trembling undid her more than skill could have. He undressed her with the same thoroughness he gave documents, learning her, and when she in turn undressed him she found the old scar on his shoulder from the German frontier and put her mouth to it, and he made a sound she had never heard from him, low and undefended.

In the lamplight, on the narrow inn bed with the sea beating its rhythm below the window, they were awkward and then not awkward, and the years did the work that no technique can do: he knew her history, all of it, the Subura house and the stillborn daughter and the price of every wall she had built, and he did not flinch from any of it, and she knew his — the duty, the marriage, the father's lies, the wall of virtue he had hidden behind — and did not flinch either. There was nothing to pretend. Two people who had been made strangers by other people's lies recognized each other in the dark, and the recognition was the whole of the love-making.

Afterward he lay with his head against her breast, and she held him, and neither of them slept for a while.

“Say something honest,” she murmured into his hair.

He was quiet long enough that she thought he might not. Then: “I am afraid. Not of the prosecution, of this. Of how much I wanted it. I've spent my life being the disciplined man, and it turns out the discipline was mostly loneliness with good posture.”

“That's honest enough to hurt.”

“You asked.” He lifted his head. “And you? Your turn.”

She considered the dark ceiling, the beam of lamplight, the moving shadows. “I'm afraid that I'll use this. That I'll turn even this into a calculation, because it's the only way I know to be safe. I love my house more than I've ever loved any person, and I don't yet know whether what's happening to me is an exception or a weakness.”

“Perhaps it's neither. Perhaps it's the first thing you've allowed yourself that didn't have to earn its place.”

She looked down at him, and for the second time in their lives — the first had been a kitchen, in another century — she let someone see her entirely unguarded.

“Careful, Marcus. You're beginning to sound like the man who taught me my letters.”

“He sounds insufferable.”

"He was wonderful. The world ate him."

"The world didn't." He kissed the place beneath her jaw. "It merely tried. It tries everyone."

Below them the inn sang and gambled and went about its business, and the Mediterranean came in against the quay in its long, patient waves, and somewhere in the warehouse the wounded clerk slept under guard, and the sealed statements waited for the praetorian prefect, and two people who should never have met again lay in each other's arms at the edge of an empire, and for one night the ledgers and the knives and the names could not reach them.

⁂

They were woken before dawn by Festus's knock, two measured beats, and they were already themselves again by the time the door opened — dressed, composed, the room restored, the only sign the dark circles under their eyes and a certain carefulness in the way they did not look at each other for the first few seconds. Chloe noticed everything and said nothing, which was her gift, and handed Antonia a cup with the expression of a priestess presiding over a rite.

Chloe said nothing in the cart, for which Antonia was grateful, and Festus drove with his eyes on the road and the particular blankness of a man who had decided not to know things. At the

river crossing, while the ferry took on carts and mules, Antonia walked a little apart along the bank, and Marcus joined her, and for a while they simply watched the brown water run toward the sea.

“Whatever comes of the indictment,” he said, “last night wasn't a bargain. I want that said, because everything else between us has been bargains, and this one wasn't.”

“I know. That's what frightened me.” She kept her eyes on the water. “I've made my life out of knowing what things cost. I don't know the price of this one.”

“Perhaps some things aren't bought. Perhaps they're merely paid for later, in whatever coin the city demands.”

“You've become a philosopher in your old age.”

“I've become a man who's finally noticed the world's rules don't cover everything.” He paused. “When the hearing comes, I won't deny you. Whatever the advocates write into their speeches, I won't stand in a Roman court and call you what Perperna calls you. I thought you should know before they ask.”

“I know. It's why I let you stay.” She almost smiled. “Now be useful and help me plan the defence, since we've apparently decided to be ruined together.”

They talked strategy until the ferry came, of witnesses and timetables and the order of evidence, and the talk was steadying, because the

work was the thing they both trusted; and when they boarded, and the cart resumed its climb toward Rome, Antonia felt the night settle into her like a foundation rather than a crack, which was, she supposed, what the poets called happiness, though she would never have used the word aloud.

The ride back to Rome was quiet, the two parties separate again, converging on the city as the gates opened with the morning traffic. At the Carinae, the household was intact, the guards were in place, and the only thing waiting was a sealed letter that had arrived the previous evening and been placed, as all such letters were, on the tablinum table.

Antonia opened it, read it once, and read it again, and her face went through no change at all, which was how Chloe knew it was serious.

It was from the office of the urban praetor, and it said that a formal indictment had been received and accepted for examination, under the lex Iulia de adulteriis and the statutes against lenocinium, naming the establishment in the Carinae and its mistress, and naming, as the married senator alleged to have consorted within it, Marcus Aelius Severus, consul-designate. A preliminary hearing was set for the third market day.

She set the letter down, and looked out through the colonnade at the morning roses, and thought of one night by the sea, and of a city that

never let a person keep anything without demanding its price.

Then she called for Festus, and for Chloe, and for wax, and began to dictate the replies, because whatever the indictment said, the house was still hers, and the case was still theirs, and the only answer Rome had ever respected from a woman like her was the answer written down, in order, before the other side had finished speaking.

By the third hour the replies were written: a formal denial delivered to the praetor's office, a request for the names of the indictment's accusers and witnesses, and a separate application, under the standing order Marcus had obtained, asserting that the house and its records formed part of the auditor's evidence and could not be touched without the praetor's hand. Hilarus carried the last himself, in his best toga, because a freedman millionaire at the praetor's door was harder to ignore than a letter.

“He'll fight on two fronts now,” Antonia said, when the messengers had gone. “The criminal indictment against us, and the quieter campaign to keep the audit from Attianus. We have to be faster on both.”

“Then I'll take the Ostia statements to the prefect today, not tomorrow,” Marcus said. He had come to the house by the postern, still dusty from the road, and he stood in the tablinum with the parchment roll in his hand and the weight of the indictment visibly upon him. “Attianus hates

informers and he hates inefficiency in equal measure. The Ostia evidence gives him both, in one case. If he opens an inquiry, Perperna's indictment becomes a counter-attack against a prefect's investigation, which even he can't afford."

"Go. And Marcus—" she paused at the door, with Chloe and Festus carefully looking elsewhere "—whatever they ask about us in that hearing, don't lie. Lying gives them the lever. Tell the truth about the partnership, about the evidence, about nothing else, and let them make what they can of it."

"Nothing else," he agreed, and was gone, and the house turned again to its work, and the indictment joined the growing file, and Rome, which had seen a thousand such indictments and forgotten them all, went about its morning.

Chloe waited until his footsteps had faded, and said, "Nothing else. That's very disciplined of you both."

"Discipline is all we have left," Antonia said, and touched, once, the place beneath her stola where his hand had rested over her heart, and then she put her own hand firmly to the accounts, and did not look up until noon.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Witnesses

Phyllis chose the night of the first winter rain, when the house was shut and the gutters ran and the street noises were drowned, and she came to Antonia's upper room with a small oilskin packet and the expression of a woman at last laying down a load.

“I said I'd tell you all of it. This is the all of it. Sit down. You'll want wine.”

Antonia poured two cups, and the old woman sat by the lamp with her keys at her belt and her hands folded, and began at the beginning, the way a careful witness does.

“I was thirty when the Aelii sold me. I'd been their kitchen woman eleven years. I nursed the boy Marcus, and I watched your mother, and I watched you grow, and when your mother died of the fever, you were nine years old and the household had no use for a bright Greek girl with no protector, so I made myself yours. That part you know. What you don't know is that I tried.”

Antonia set down her cup. “Tried what?”

“To stop the sale. When the elder mistress found out about the baby, I went to her. On my

knees, in her own room, and I told her the truth — that the boy loved you, that it wasn't a slave's trick to trap the family, that you'd done nothing but be born in the wrong room. She heard me out. She was very calm; the dangerous ones always are. Then she said that was precisely why it couldn't continue, because the boy's career needed a marriage with a clean name, and a house slave carrying his child was the one thing that could ruin it. She said the family was larger than any of us, and that kindness to one girl would be cruelty to the whole line." Phyllis's voice was level, the levelness of old, old anger. "I argued. I actually argued with the mistress. Dromo had me flogged for it, and sold within the week. That's how I came onto the market, and how Cassia Prima found me, years later, in the house where she bought you. She bought me too, eventually, because I asked her to, because I'd heard where you were and I wanted to be near the one person in Rome I'd failed."

"You didn't fail me."

"I failed to stop them. There's a difference between losing and not trying, and I've carried both." She opened the oilskin packet. Inside was a folded sheet, yellowed and soft with age, covered in a steward's cramped hand. "Dromo's private note of the sale. Not the household ledger — he kept his own book, the thief, because he skimmed every transaction and wanted the evidence against himself in his own hands. I stole it the

night I was sold. I've kept it since, because I've never believed the powerful should be the only ones with paper.”

Antonia took the sheet. It recorded the sale of Anthe, vernula, to the dealer Dinis, the price, the date, and, in a margin, the two words that mattered: *by order of the mistress*. Not the master. The mistress. Her memory had always blamed the father's house as a faceless thing; here was the hand.

“Your Marcus didn't know,” Phyllis said. “I've watched him this winter, and I've made it my business to find out. He was four hundred miles away, and his letters came back, and his money came back, and he was told a story. The guilty ones are all dead and buried in expensive tombs. The living one is the boy, and the boy has become a man who's trying to make it right, in the only way the world permits.”

“Tell me about the money he sent. All of it.”

“Three letters, and with each one a sum, for your manumission. Dromo brought them to the mistress. She had them returned unopened, and the money with them, and she told the household, publicly, that you'd been freed and gone south of your own will and refused all contact. That's the story everyone believed. The servants believed it. The boy believed it. Rome believes whatever the mistress says inside her own walls.” Phyllis leaned forward. “There's one more thing, and it's the hardest, and I'll tell it because you've a right and

I'm not getting younger. The dealer's house where the baby came. I got word of it through a woman at the market, after Prima bought me. The child wasn't stillborn alone in a garret. There was a midwife, and the midwife said the birth was early because you'd been beaten, in the first weeks, by the dealer's man, when you wouldn't be trained. The beating brought the labour. The girl child lived an hour. An hour. No one told you because you were out of your head with fever, and when you woke they said stillborn, because stillborn was easier."

The rain ran down the shutters. Antonia sat very still, and the lamplight moved on her face, and Phyllis watched her without pity, because pity would have been an insult.

"An hour," Antonia said at last.

"An hour. I've said prayers for her at the temple of Isis every year since. The goddess counts the unnamed ones; that's one of the reasons I trust her." Phyllis folded her hands. "There. Now you have the whole of it, and I've kept nothing, and if you hate me for waiting, I'll understand, and I'll still sleep tonight because the waiting's over."

Antonia rose and crossed the room and took the old woman's face in both her hands, and kissed her forehead, the Roman kiss of family.

"You didn't fail me. You're the only person who ever kept a piece of paper for me instead of against me. Now I need you to do one more thing.

Put all of that — the flogging, the sale, the returned letters, the beating and the birth — into a statement, witnessed and sealed, with Dromo's note as its exhibit. Not for revenge. For the record. Rome's paper is going to tell the truth about one girl, even if it never tells it about any of the others."

The old woman nodded, and sat a while with the rain, and then she said the thing she had kept longest, after the documents and the names.

"She came to me once. Your mother. The night before the fever took her. I don't think you remember; you were nine and they kept you in the kitchen. She gave me a thing to keep for you. I've kept it through two sales and a flogging and thirty years, because a dying woman's the only person in this world whose instructions are perfectly clear."

From inside her tunic, on a cord around her neck, Phyllis drew a small cloth bundle, blackened with age and wear, and unfolded it. Inside was a bronze ring, cheap, the kind a slave might own, set with a tiny carved stone; and on the stone, worn almost away, was the figure of a woman at a loom.

"She said it was her mother's, brought from Greece, and that you were to have it when you were grown, and you were never to believe the family's lie that no one had ever wanted you. She wanted you. That's the whole of it. I should have

given it sooner, but until this winter I didn't know whether you'd want anything from that life."

Antonia took the ring. Her face did not change, because it never changed, but her hands did, very slightly, and Phyllis, who had watched those hands for thirty years, looked away to give her the privacy of it.

"I'll wear it," Antonia said eventually. "Under the gloves, where it can't be used against me. Tell me her name."

"Eirene. She came from Corinth, before the sale. She sang while she sewed; the household used to stop to hear her."

"Eirene." Antonia said it once, quietly, the way one says a word that has been waiting all one's life to be spoken. Then she fastened the cord around her own neck, inside her stola, and poured more wine, and the two women sat together through the rain with the names of the dead between them and the lamp burning steady.

⁂

Marcus came to the villa at Tibur again in the same week, and this time he went through the store rooms rather than the colonnades, with Barto's help and a lamp, into the chamber where the household's discarded records went to die.

They found Dromo's other books at the bottom of an old chest, under a generation of farm accounts, and Marcus carried them to the kitchen

table — the same table, as he noted with a strange ache, where a girl had once written her first word — and read through two nights by lamp.

Barto, who had been a boy in the villa's kitchen when Dromo was its steward, sat across from him through the first night, mending harness and answering questions, and his memory turned out to be its own kind of ledger, illiterate but exact.

“Dromo kept everything,” Barto said, of the old steward. “Twice the books the household needed, because he said a man with one book believes it, and a man with two can catch it lying. The master laughed at him for it. Nobody laughs at a man like that until the day they need him.”

The store room bore the man out. Three generations of the villa's paper had been stacked there against the damp, on shelves Dromo himself had built, and the dust lay evenly except where the mice had nested, which told Marcus the chests had not been opened in years. He worked by the method the audit had taught him: first the inventory, every chest listed before one was opened; then the sort, farm accounts in one pile, household in a second, private in a third; then, only when the shape of the archive was clear, the slow reading. To rummage was to miss things; Dromo had hidden nothing, but Dromo had arranged everything, and a man who does not respect another man's arrangement deserves the confusion he gets.

Barto supplied the things paper doesn't hold: which chest had come from the mistress's own room, which steward had drunk and which had prayed, the year the olives failed and the year the old master's gambling did, and the single winter when the villa's people were sold off “like the spare oil,” as the old man put it, his harness needle moving steadily while he said it.

“Did they know,” Marcus asked, “the household, what became of any of them?”

“Nobody did. That's the point of sales; they make people vanish like smoke. The mistress said it was better for everyone concerned, and the household said yes, because households say yes.” Barto bit off a thread. “One or two didn't. You'll find their names in the books, if the books are as complete as he kept them. Dromo wrote the awkward ones the same as the rest; that's the one good thing about a thief with a system.”

Marcus made a note, though not on any tablet the household would see: a winter of multiple sales would tell a different story than a single one — a story of clearance, not punishment, which was the story the court would eventually need.

By the end of the first night the piles reached his shoulder, and the lamp had smoked a brown ring into the ceiling, and Barto had fallen asleep over his harness with his mouth open. Marcus sat on alone in the kitchen, in the silence of a sleeping villa, and looked at the table under his hands. A letter table once, a lesson table; a girl

had formed her first characters on this wood under his own boyish instruction, and the wood was still here, and the girl was a woman in Rome with a gilded door and a murder case, and the gulf between those two facts was the whole history of an empire that measured people in sesterces and called the measurement order. He did not yet know what the books would say. He knew, sitting there, that whatever they said, he would not be permitted the comfort of surprise; the household that raised him had kept the receipts, and receipts were the one thing Roman virtue had never been able to argue away.

Barto helped him carry the chests into the kitchen, and worked beside him in companionable silence, the old slave and the senator sorting the paper of the dead, and from time to time Barto supplied the things paper doesn't hold.

“Dromo ran the house like his own shop. Took a cut of everything, did Dromo. Your father knew, I think; gentlemen prefer not to know, it saves them trouble. The mistress knew perfectly and used it, because a steward with his hand in the till is a steward who'll do as he's told.”

“And the girl. Anthe. Did anyone in the household object?”

“Me. I objected, in my own head, which is where most objections happen in a great house. And Phyllis — you'd remember her, kitchen woman, sharp as a knife — she objected out loud, which is why she got sold. There, look, that's her

sale, two lines down from the girl's. Nine hundred for one, six hundred for the other; Dromo wrote it like a grocery bill.”

Marcus found the entry and stared at it. “I never knew what happened to Phyllis.”

“Nobody did. That's the point of sales; they make people vanish like smoke. Except people don't vanish, do they. They turn up somewhere else, being sharp.” Barto eased himself onto a stool. “Read the letters book, master. The thin one. That's where he kept what went out and what came back.”

The steward's private books were a careful record of his own corruption: kickbacks, skimmed sales, inflated purchases, and, in the volume for the year of the German commission, the full trail of the letters. Three entries, each with the word *returned* and the mistress's initial, and beside each the amount sent, and each amount was greater than the price for which Antonia had been sold. He had sent enough, three times over, to buy her freedom; the money had come home to him unopened, and he had been told she wanted nothing.

There was more. The final entry, in a different hand, recorded a sum paid to Dinis the dealer above the sale price, marked *for the training*, and Marcus understood then, with a coldness in his stomach that the lamp could not warm, that his family had not merely sold her. They had paid to have her broken to the trade.

He sat in the kitchen a long time with that open before him, and Barto left him alone, and outside the rain came down on the olives, and he thought about the clean, virtuous house on the Esquiline, and his father's dignity, and his mother's calm, and the price at which all that dignity had been bought: nine hundred and forty sesterces, and a girl, and a daughter who had lived an hour.

He brought the books back to Rome himself, wrapped in oilskin, and put them into Antonia's hands in the garden court, and told her what they contained, and watched her read the line *for the training* with a face that did not change, and he said, when she had finished, “I've no right to ask anything of you. I'll say it anyway. Tell me what to do with this. Whatever it is.”

“Use it.” She closed the book. “Not for me — the past's past, and I've made my life on top of it. Use it to understand the men we're fighting. Your mother and Perperna are the same machine. The one wrote *better for everyone concerned* and the other writes *the public interest*. The language changes. The knife doesn't. When you stand before Attianus, remember that the fraud and the sale are one habit: the powerful deciding, over paper, that some people don't count.”

“Will you let me apologize?”

“No. Apologies are for debts that can be repaid. This one can't, so we'll spend it on something that can.” She looked at him directly. “But since we're being witnesses tonight, I'll tell

you something I've said to no one. I love you. I have, in some form, since the kitchen. I built an entire life to make sure it couldn't matter, and it matters anyway. There. Now we've both paid the tax, and we can go back to the work.”

He reached across the table and took her hand, and they sat that way while the rain moved off over the rooftops and the lamps burned low, and neither of them said anything more, because nothing more was needed, and the silence was the first completely honest one either of them had known in fifteen years.

⁂

Phyllis's statement was signed three days later, in the tablinum, with Chloe and the priestess of Isis as witnesses and Dromo's stolen note sealed into its fold. The old woman's hand was steady throughout, but at the end she set the stylus down and pressed her own chest briefly, under the left breast, and Antonia saw it.

“That again.”

“It's nothing. Wind.”

“It's not wind, and we both know it. The physician tomorrow.”

The physician came, a Greek with a long face and longer bills, and he said the things physicians say: rest, no rich food, no exertion, potions of a bitter kind, and the unspoken thing in his eyes that said the heart was older than its owner's will.

Phyllis heard him out, paid him from her own purse, and ignored every instruction, because the household needed running and the household was her life's work.

But Antonia moved her into the room beside her own, so that she could hear her at night, and gave the keys of the strong room to Chloe, and made the household understand, without ever saying the words, that the old woman's burdens were being quietly lifted from her, one at a time, the way one removes weight from an ageing horse.

The women took it in their different ways. Sabina, who had lost one household already, began appearing at Phyllis's door at dawn with hot water, a service no one had assigned her. Tyche composed a small tune on the lyre and played it badly and then better, and the old woman pretended to dislike it and asked for it each evening. Chloe simply took the keys and the ledgers and the thousand small decisions, and learned in a week what had taken Phyllis thirty years, and said nothing about it, which was the greatest respect she knew how to offer.

Phyllis noticed all of it, of course. “You're burying me before I'm dead,” she said to Antonia, dryly, on the third evening.

“I'm preparing the house to run without you, which is the only kind of compliment I know how to pay. You can die on your own schedule; the household will be ready either way.”

“Spoken like a Roman.”

“Spoken like your pupil.”

That pleased the old woman more than anything, and she said no more about it, and took her potion, and complained about the taste, and that, Antonia thought, was probably the whole of courage, when you got close enough to see it.

The answer from the Palatine came at the end of the week, through Ursus the praetor: the praetorian prefect Acilius Attianus would receive Marcus Aelius Severus in a private audience, to hear evidence of fraud in the eastern supply, on the condition that the materials were complete, the witnesses named, and the auditor himself prepared to answer for every charge.

Marcus read the note in the Carinae tablinum, with Antonia and Chloe across the table and the tablets and statements stacked between them in their oilskin and wax, and he said, “This is the moment. Once the prefect's door opens, there's no road back for anyone.”

“There was never a road back,” Antonia said. “Only forward, and the speed of it. Assemble everything. We give him the whole machine in one hearing — Ostia, the Aventine, the seals, the loans, the bureau, the names. No surprises held back; Attianus is an honest man, and honest men require the full meal.”

They spent two nights assembling it, the house turned into a scriptorium. Hilarus brought the factor's copies and the insurance tallies; Livia's

diary and the steward's statements went in beside them; Longinus's account of the Aventine bank was copied three times; the tanner's receipts arrived from Pompeii by fast courier, still smelling of leather; and Marcus arranged the whole in the order he had learned in the courts — the chain first, the names last, each exhibit numbered and cross-marked so that a busy soldier-prefect could follow it without a lawyer.

“Attianus will ask three questions,” Marcus said, working by lamplight. “Does the fraud exist, who profits, and can it be proved without depending on a single disreputable witness. We answer all three before he asks. The weights answer the first; Longinus and the circular payments answer the second; the seals, the tanner, and the diary answer the third. The house's records support everything but stand alone nowhere.”

“You've learned my trade,” Antonia said.

“I've learned that evidence is architecture. Same stones, different temple.”

“And the indictment? Perperna's hearing is the same week.”

“Then Rome gets two trials in one season.” She permitted herself the thin edge of a smile. “Let the city enjoy itself. It's been a dull winter.”

Marcus gathered the documents into their case, and the household went about its evening, and later, when the lamps were low, Antonia sat with Phyllis beside the brazier and watched the

old woman's slow breathing, and thought about witnesses — the living and the dead, the ones who spoke in court and the ones who spoke only in sealed notes kept for fifteen years — and she made herself a second promise, beside the one she had made over Hector's pyre: when this was done, the names of all of them would be remembered somewhere, on something more permanent than wax.

The audience with Attianus was held in the prefect's offices behind the Praetorian camp, in a room of military plainness that Marcus found immediately reassuring. Acilius Attianus was sixty, a soldier from the Spanish provinces, with a grey head and the unhurried manner of a man who had commanded guards for two emperors and feared very little in Rome. He had a secretary and a legal adviser present, and no wine, and he opened the meeting by saying, “You have half an hour, Severus. Make it worth mine.”

Marcus made it worth twenty-two minutes. He laid the chain out as the house had built it: the Ostia weights, with Dorion's tattooed numbers recorded in a sworn statement; the phantom ninety modii; the circular payments through the Aventine bank; Perperna's loans and the trapped subscribers; the reused witness seals, with Syrus's identification; his brother's evidence and the unauthorized use of the family seal; and, at the end, Longinus's statement naming Zosimus in the bureau *a rationibus*.

Attianus did not interrupt. When Marcus finished, the prefect sat for a while turning one of the tablets in his hands.

“You understand what you're asking me to believe. That the emperor's own finance office is party to a fraud on the army's supply, on the eve of a Parthian war.”

“I'm asking you to believe the documents. If they're false, my name answers for it.”

“Your name's in the documents itself, on a witness line.”

“A forgery, established by my household diary and my absence from Rome. My wife's records and my steward's statement prove it. I've concealed nothing, including what tells against my family.”

The prefect looked at him for a long moment, the soldier's assessment of another soldier. “The woman who keeps this house in the Carinae. The broadsheets say she's your mistress.”

“The broadsheets say many things. Antonia Cassia is the source of the evidence and a witness under the praetor's standing order. Her records are better than the treasury's; I'll bring her account books if you wish. What she is, legally, is infamis; what she is, factually, is the person who did the work your own clerks failed to do.”

Attianus almost smiled. “You've learned the answer already. Good. Here's mine. I'll open a quiet inquiry, in my office, not the courts — yet. Your witnesses go under guard; I'll assign

praetorians to the Ostia warehouse today. The finance bureau will be watched, not touched; Zosimus is the emperor's household, and the emperor is with the army planning, so nothing moves until I can report to him through the proper channels. And Severus — the indictment hanging over you and this woman. I can't quash it; the praetor's court is its own house. But I can note for the record that the parties are material witnesses in a prefect's inquiry. A court that proceeds against them will have to do so knowing that." He rose, ending the audience. "Win your case in the open, and my inquiry does the rest in the shadows. That's how Rome works when it works at all."

Outside, in the winter sun, Marcus stood a moment by the camp wall with the case empty under his arm and felt the particular exhilaration of the soldier who has committed his reserves. There was no road back now, and the absence of a road was, he found, a kind of relief.

That evening he told Gaius the shape of it, in the tablinum, the boy across the desk with his school tablets forgotten. He told it without names he could not give, but honestly — the fraud, the danger, the reason the family's name might be spoken against in the coming weeks.

"Are we going to be ruined?" Gaius asked.

"Possibly. Ruin is a real possibility, and I won't lie to you about it. But the family isn't the house or the money. It's the people who tell the truth

when it costs them. Your mother understands that better than anyone."

"The Carinae woman. She's the one from the kitchen, isn't she. Uncle Celer let it slip once, when he was drunk. The slave girl."

Marcus weighed it, and told the truth. "Yes. And I failed her, a long time ago, and I've spent this winter trying not to fail her twice. You're old enough to know that the men the city calls disreputable are sometimes the ones keeping its word."

Gaius considered this with the seriousness he brought to everything. "Then I hope she wins. I'll put it in my prayers — the foreign goddess as well, if it helps."

"It can't hurt. The foreign goddess has more worshippers in this city than the Senate has members."

The boy went up to bed, and Marcus sat on alone among the ancestral masks, and thought that if the family were to fall, at least it would fall in front of a son who understood the reason, which was more than most ruined houses managed.

He told Antonia the prefect's answer that night, in the shuttered tablinum, and she heard him out with the still attention she gave the things that mattered, and said, when he had finished, "Then the two cases will run side by side. His inquiry in the shadows, Perperna's indictment in the open. He'll try to finish the open one first,

because a conviction destroys our evidence before Attianus can use it."

"That's my reading. The preliminary hearing is the key. If the praetor allows the indictment to proceed to a full trial, the house is under a cloud for months and the witnesses begin to reconsider their courage. If we break it at the hearing, Attianus's inquiry has room to move."

"Then we break it. We have the better paper, the better witnesses, and the better cause. What we don't have is the law's friendship." She considered the lamp. "There's a question you'll be asked, and you should decide your answer before they ask it. Whether you'll denounce me to save yourself. They'll offer it; they always do. The senator walks, the woman takes the full weight, and the honour of the Aelii is preserved."

"You know my answer."

"I know it tonight. I want it in writing, in front of witnesses, because I don't trust the version of you that gets frightened in a courtroom." Her voice was not unkind. "Not because I doubt you. Because I've never met a frightened person I did trust, including myself."

He wrote it, at her table, in his senatorial hand: that he would give no testimony against the house or its mistress, that he confirmed the partnership of evidence under the praetor's standing order, and that any statement attributed to him to the contrary was false. He signed, and Chloe

witnessed, and the document went into the temple coffer with the tablets.

“Now the same question to you,” he said. “If it comes to a choice between the house and me—”

“There's no choice. The house comes first; it has eleven people in it and you're one man with a name and a family. I'd ruin you without a moment's hesitation to keep the doors open.” She said it calmly, and watched him take it. “Does that shock you?”

“No. It reassures me. At least one of us knows exactly what she's doing.” He almost smiled. “Livia asked me the same question, in different words. The women in my life have a remarkable grasp of the worst case.”

“Livia's the ablest of us. Treat her accordingly.” Antonia poured the last of the wine. “One more thing, while we're being honest on paper. If we survive this, there's no respectable ending for us. You know the law. A senator can't marry a meretrix; the censors wouldn't even let her sit in the public rows. Whatever this is, it lives outside the rules, and so do I, and I'll not be kept, and I'll not be hidden, and I'll not apologise.”

“I've stopped expecting respectable endings. They've never once arrived.” He set down his cup. “What I can offer is simpler. Whatever survives the spring, you and I will know the truth of, and I'll spend the rest of my life being worthy of that. The rest, Rome can litigate.”

She looked at him a long moment, and then, briefly, she smiled — the real smile, the one the guests never saw.

“That'll do, Marcus Aelius. That'll do for now.”

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Citation

The citation arrived at the gilded door with four officers and a clerk, in the full public daylight that Perperna favoured for his smaller cruelties, so that the street could see the law arrive with its rods and its tablets and its careful, blank faces.

Festus let them in, because there was no lawful reason not to, and the clerk read the document in the atrium while the household stood in witness: an indictment under the lex Iulia, naming Antonia Cassia with lenocinium — the crime of profiting from vice under the colour of entertainment — and naming Marcus Aelius Severus as the married senator alleged to have consorted within the establishment, against the statute's prohibition. A preliminary hearing was set for the third market day, and citations were served on the resident women to appear and give evidence.

When the clerk had finished and the officers had withdrawn, the atrium was very quiet. The leaping dolphins mosaic gleamed under the impluvium's water. Somewhere in the kitchen a pan dropped and was cursed.

Across the street, the nut-seller who never sold nuts had abandoned his stall and was walking fast toward the Argiletum, carrying the news to whoever paid for it. The neighbours watched from behind their shutters with the bright, careful attention of Rome at its favourite occupation. By noon, Antonia knew, the citation would have done half its work without a single judgment: the suppliers would grow cautious, the guests would grow deaf, and the house's name would acquire the shadow that shadows only need to survive, not to be true.

That was the genius of the instrument. It did not need to win. It needed only to be served.

She sent for the household's accounts at once and paid every outstanding supplier in full, in silver, before the rumour reached them, and she had Hilarus circulate a note among the regular guests before the third hour: the citation was a known counter-attack in a supply-fraud investigation, the house's standing order from the praetor remained in force, and a formal denial would follow within the day. By dusk two replies had come back from nervous equestrians offering their regrets for the week's suppers, and three more had come from senators' stewards rebooking. The city, Antonia reflected, was neither loyal nor disloyal; it was merely attentive to which way the wind was paying, and silver paid better than gossip.

“Well,” said Antonia. “Now we know the shape of it.”

They gathered in the tablinum, the household's council around the table, and she read the citation again, slowly, in the advocate's way, and the room watched her face for the weather and found none.

“Three parts,” she said. “The lenocinium charge against me and the house. The adultery charge against the auditor, which doesn't need to convict, only to stick. And the women's evidence, which is the hinge. If they can make one of you say, on record, that the house assigns clients or coerces consent, the whole indictment walks into court on your word. Everything else is decoration.”

“Then they get nothing from us,” Chloe said.

“They get something. They've invested too much to walk away empty. Watch yourselves, all of you, and never be alone with a clerk, a neighbour's servant, or a man with a sympathetic face. Tyche especially — they know her name from the custody matter, and she's been watched the longest.”

Tyche, in the corner, nodded once, very pale, and no one in the room missed the way her hands gripped her lyre case.

Antonia made the council run through every woman's route aloud, the way a general hears his captains' reports, because a plan that exists only in one head dies with that head's liberty. Tyche's music masters and the cloth street; Sabina's

scrivener's lessons and the Forum bookshops; the cooks' market runs before dawn; the temple visits, the dressmaker, the bath hours. Each route was named, timed, and assigned its pair, and Festus marked them on the charcoal map with the new chalk lines of the altered routes.

“Change the patterns,” Antonia said. “They've watched us long enough to know our habits; a habit is a door left open. From tomorrow, market days rotate, the temple gets visited by different pairs in different weeks, and nobody, under any circumstance, follows a stranger through a door on the strength of a message. If a woman's aunt really lies dying in Capua, the message comes through this house's contacts, not a veiled stranger in a shop. Doris — you're Tyche's pair now, full time. The two of you eat, work, and sleep within call of each other until the hearing.”

Doris, a quiet girl with a musician's memory for sound, nodded. “And if they come anyway?”

“Then you remember everything and touch nothing. A witness who can describe a room is worth ten who arrive with swords. Note the door, the lock, the lamp, the voices, the hands — hands are harder to disguise than faces. And you scream. Not for help, though the street may give it; scream so that everyone in the lane knows something is happening at that address, because the one thing an abduction cannot survive is an audience. They rely on Rome looking the other way. We're going to make Rome look.”

After the council, when the others had gone to their rooms, she kept Tyche back, and sat with her in the jasmine court without speaking for a while, because the girl's fear had the particular quality of a fear already half-dreamed.

“Tell me the worst of it,” Antonia said at last. “The thing you're not saying in front of the others.”

Tyche turned the lyre case in her hands. “My brother. In the mines. It's the only thing they could offer me that I'd trade anything for. If they put his name in front of me and a stylus in my hand and tell me to mark whatever they've written, I don't know, domina. I've sung for worse men than that and kept myself, but this isn't my body they'd be buying. It's his life.”

“Then we take the weapon away from them first.” Antonia spoke slowly, because the sentence had to be built carefully enough to hold. “Hilarus has contacts in Sardinia; the mines run on contractors, and contractors run on money. We're going to find your brother's name on the depot rolls and begin the work of moving him — not out tomorrow, because nothing moves that fast, but onto a road, so that there exists a route and a date and witnesses. A man already being helped is less useful as a threat than a man completely in their hands. Meanwhile, if they take you, you have my permission to do whatever keeps you alive, including marking their tablet. Do you understand? No heroics. A mark given under

coercion can be voided; a dead woman cannot. The house would rather have you back, frightened and marked, than brave and gone.”

Tyche's eyes filled, but she did not cry; she was, Antonia reflected, the sort of girl who saved tears for private rooms. “No one's ever said that to me. That I'm allowed to survive it.”

“You're allowed everything that keeps you breathing. The pride, like the music, is for after.” She rose. “Now sleep. The pair system starts at dawn, and I've never known fear that survived a good breakfast and a locked door.”

The door was barely shut before Chloe spoke, from the shadows of the jasmine trellis where she had been waiting.

“You meant it. The part about marking their tablet if they take her.”

“Every word. I won't feed any woman in this house to my own case.” Antonia sat again, suddenly tired. “The cases come and go, Chloe. The house stays. A house that sacrifices its people to its paper is just the dealer's floor with better mosaics, and I didn't leave one floor to build another.”

“Phyllis said you'd say that. She also said to tell you, in her exact words, that sentiment was expensive and to keep it off the accounts.”

A brief, real laugh escaped her. “She's right, as usual. The sentiment stays in the court; the accounts stay cold. But the women stay alive. That's the one line I won't enter as a negotiable

item, and if the prefect or the advocate or the senator himself ever asks, you can tell him I said so, in front of witnesses."

Chloe nodded, and went to arrange the dawn pairs, and the lamp in the jasmine court burned down to its socket over a house that was preparing itself, quietly and competently, to be attacked.

⁂

They took her nine days later, on a market morning, with the simple efficiency of men who had watched the house's routines until they knew its seams.

The guards accompanied the women in pairs, always; but the fruit seller's cart had overturned at the lane's mouth, and the pair system meant one guard helping clear the cart while Tyche, thirty paces ahead with the musician Doris, turned into the cloth street — and in the cloth street two women were waiting, respectable, veiled, gently insistent, saying they had a message from her aunt in Capua, and wouldn't she just step through this door, it was a shop, perfectly public, her friend could wait outside.

Doris the musician did wait outside. It was, in retrospect, the mistake: the door was a shop, the women were respectable, and Tyche had an aunt in Capua. Inside, the back room held no aunt. It held the soft-voiced man from the market, and a

clerk with tablets, and the particular silence of a place designed not to be overheard.

They were kind. That was the worst of it, Tyche told Antonia afterward, weeping in the women's court with her head in the older woman's lap. They were kind, and reasonable, and the room was warm, and they explained that the house was going to fall, that everyone knew it, that the girls who helped the law would be re-enrolled in respectable houses and the girls who didn't would share their mistress's ruin. They said her own enrollment was technically flawed — a date, a witness, the kind of small irregularity every house in Rome carried — and that she could be prosecuted herself, at any moment, unless she made a statement. They had a statement already written. She had only to make her mark.

“I held out,” she whispered. “I said no, twice, I said I wanted my advocate, and they said of course, after the statement, and then they said — the soft one said — they knew about my brother, the one in the mines in Sardinia, and that men with friends could have him moved to easier work, or could have him sent deeper, and it was really up to me.”

Antonia's hand, stroking the girl's hair, did not stop. “And you marked it.”

“I marked it. I'm sorry. I'm so sorry. They said what it said, about clients being — assigned — and about the house keeping money from us, and none of it's true, but my brother's in the dark

under the ground and I could hear him in my head—” She broke.

Chloe stood at the colonnade with her arms folded, her face hard, and Sabina, white-faced, held a cup of wine no one was drinking.

“Listen to me.” Antonia took Tyche by the shoulders and made her sit up, and spoke with the calm that had held the house through raids and fires. “You are not ruined, and you have not betrayed us. They designed a room no one can hold alone; that's their whole profession. What matters now is what you do next. Doris saw the women, the shop, the door; you can describe every face and every word. We'll take your true statement tomorrow, before our own advocate, with every detail, including the coercion and the mark. A statement obtained by threats and promises is void, and we'll have the witnesses to prove the voiding. Do you understand? The mark isn't the end. It's their mistake, because now they've shown their hand.”

Tyche stared through her tears. “You're not — you won't turn me out.”

“If I turned out every woman who'd been broken by a room like that, I'd have no household and no conscience. You made a human choice under inhuman pressure. Now make the brave one in daylight, which is harder, and which you can do because you're not alone in it.” She lifted the girl's chin. “No more markets for you, ever. And the brother — Hilarus has contracts in

Sardinia; we'll see what money and the right name can do, quietly, with no promises, because I don't make promises about mines. Now Phyllis will take you to bed, and you'll sleep, and tomorrow we turn your weakness into their evidence."

When she had gone, Chloe said, low, "They'll use the mark. Whatever we do, the false statement exists."

"Then we make sure it enters the court already broken. The coercion statement first, Doris's witness second, the flawed-enrollment threat third — they've handed us the proof of their methods, which is worth more than Tyche's signature costs." Antonia's eyes were cold. "Send word to the auditor. And tell Sabina to bring her Twelve Tables; I want every procedural rule about coerced evidence by morning. This is why she's been reading."

The true statement took the whole of the next morning, in the tablinum, with the house advocate's clerk writing and Doris the musician giving her own account of the shop door, and Tyche going over every moment twice, then a third time, until the sequence was fixed beyond a cross-examiner's shaking. The brother in Sardinia she described in detail: name, mine, the last letter, the exact words the soft-voiced man had used. Hilarus, told the story, had contacts on the island through his shipping, and he wrote the

letters that afternoon without promising anything, because hope unbacked by paper was a cruelty.

“I keep seeing the room,” Tyche said, when the clerk had gone. “The lamp. How kind they were. It would have been easier if they'd shouted.”

“It would. That's why they're dangerous.” Antonia closed the tablet. “Remember the kindness. Put it in your face when you testify. Rome is terrified of women who remain calm about what's been done to them.”

Sabina, who had sat through the whole statement with her slate, said, “She's stronger than the statute. The statute only assumes witnesses are either willing or forced. She's neither — she's been managed. We can show the mechanism; that's what the praetor needs.”

The advocate, a tired old man who had spent thirty years losing and winning in the basilica, looked at her with new interest. “Where did you learn to think like that?”

“From the Carinae house, where I'm paid to think.”

He grunted, and made a note, and Antonia saw the small, private birth of a reputation: the debt-girl was becoming a lawyer, and the house would have its own jurist one day, which was worth more than any guard.

⁂

The pressure on Marcus arrived in the proper Roman form, at a dinner given by the consul-elect, in a room full of men whose names would decide the spring.

They separated him after the second course, the consul and two senior senators, in a private garden with a single lamp, and they did it gently, as everything in Rome was done gently, the better to make refusal look like ingratitude.

“The position is simple,” said the consul-elect, a plump, intelligent man who genuinely liked Marcus and would genuinely sacrifice him. “The indictment's going to run. A senatorial name in a morals case, even an acquitted one, is a wound. If you denounce the woman now — formally, in the preliminary hearing — say she traded on your audit, that you were misled, that the evidence she gave you was tainted — the case against you collapses, the consulship proceeds, and everyone important understands you were the victim of an adventuress. It's the standard path. It's the sane path.”

“Let me understand the bargain,” Marcus said. “I ruin the woman whose evidence is the only thing standing between the treasury and a fraud, and in exchange I keep my office.”

“You make it sound dishonourable. It's politics. The woman's infamis, Marcus; her word carries nothing in law without your name behind it. If you go down with her, the audit dies anyway, and the fraud survives. By saving yourself, you save the

only investigation that can expose it. Choose the greater good."

The second senator nodded. "And think of your family. Your son. A father condemned under the lex Iulia — the boy carries that his whole life."

Marcus looked at the three faces in the lamplight, intelligent, decent, utterly without malice, and understood that this was the true face of the machine he had spent his life serving: not Perperna's knife, but this, the reasonable men with their reasonable bargains, the steady pressure of the world as it was.

"My answer is no," he said. "I won't denounce her, because the denunciation would be a lie, and once I've put a lie into a Roman court, I've become the thing I'm prosecuting. The audit proceeds with her evidence, openly, and if the indictment takes my consulship, then the city will have to find its magistrates among men who've never told the truth at a cost. There seem to be plenty of you."

The silence that followed was not hostile; it was sad, the sadness of craftsmen watching a good piece of material spoiled.

"You'll be removed from the audit if the indictment proceeds," the consul said quietly. "The consuls can't leave a morals defendant in charge of a treasury review. You understand that."

"I understand that you can remove my office. You can't remove the evidence; it's already with the prefect. Whatever happens to me, Attianus

has the case.” He rose. “Gentlemen. My thanks for the dinner, and for the clarity. I prefer my ruin honest to my salvation arranged.”

He walked out through the house and into the street, where Stichus waited with the litter, and discovered that his hands were shaking, and was obscurely glad of it, because a man who could refuse such a bargain without trembling would have been a man no longer capable of feeling the cost.

At home, Livia was waiting up, as he had known she would be, with the lamp trimmed and no servants, and he told her the whole of it, the bargain and the refusal and the consul's warning about the audit.

She heard him out in silence, and then said, “You understand the arithmetic. If the indictment proceeds, they remove you from the audit, the consulship is lost or postponed, and the family's name is in the broadsheets for a year. If you'd denounced her, you'd have kept all of it.”

“And you'd have despised me.”

“I'd have understood. That's the worse thing; I'd have perfectly understood.” She folded her hands. “As it is, I find I'm proud of you, which is inconvenient, because I've spent fifteen years managing a man I respected rather than one I admired. What does she mean to you, truly? You may as well tell me; I'll know by your face anyway.”

He considered the lamp, and the question, and the long discipline of their marriage. “She means that the truth exists independently of what's convenient. I've lived my whole life among people who believe those are the same thing. She was sold for nine hundred and forty sesterces and still believes they're different. I can't go back to believing they're the same, now that I've seen the cost of the difference.”

Livia was quiet a while. “Then we'll lose the consulship properly, which is at least more interesting than keeping it improperly. The children will survive; I'll make sure of it. But Marcus — if you're going to be ruined, be ruined efficiently. No gestures in the Forum, no noble speeches I have to hear about from my friends. Do the work, win the case, and let the office go quietly. The Aelii can afford one quiet martyr; we cannot afford a noisy one.”

He laughed, the short rare laugh. “You're the most formidable woman in Rome.”

“I'm the best-informed. There's a difference, and it's why you'll need me before this ends.” She rose. “Go to bed. You look like a man who's refused a consulship, and you'll need your sleep.”

⁂

Sabina found the flaw at the second hour of the third night, and she found it because she had been reading the law like a girl memorizing the

layout of a prison.

“Here.” She put the citation and the statute side by side on the tablinum table, her finger on the line. “The lex Iulia requires a citation to be served in person, with two witnesses of standing, and the women's summonses have to name the matters on which they're to give evidence. Ours don't. They just say ‘to testify concerning the house.' And look at the date on Tyche's — it's the day before the indictment was formally accepted by the praetor's office. They served a process under a case that didn't legally exist yet.”

Chloe leaned over. “Can that hold?”

“It can if the praetor's a stickler, and Ursus is a stickler; that's why we wanted him.” Sabina's voice shook slightly, but her finger didn't move. “It's a procedural defect. It doesn't kill the indictment, but it lets us challenge the women's summonses at the preliminary hearing, and if those summonses fall, the lenocinium charge has no house witnesses, and all they've got is Tyche's coerced mark, which we can void.”

Antonia looked at the girl for a long moment, at the plain, earnest, seventeen-year-old face that had entered her house on a debt-paper and was now reading statutes like a junior advocate.

“Phyllis taught you this.”

“Phyllis taught me where to look. The Twelve Tables taught me the looking.”

“Then Phyllis was right to keep you, and I was right to teach you, and Rome has acquired a

lawyer whether it deserves one or not.” Antonia turned to Chloe. “Wake the advocate. We'll build the whole hearing around the defect. And send to the Esquiline: the auditor needs to know the law itself has given us a door.”

The hearing preparation consumed the house. The advocate came each morning, a dried-up little man named Rubrius who had survived forty years of the Roman bar by never expecting justice and never missing a technicality, and he ran the women through their evidence the way a lanista trains fighters: the same questions, again and again, until the answers came without thought and could not be shaken.

Chloe was to give the account of Hector's work and death. Tyche, supported by the coercion statement, would describe the back room and the mark. Sabina would present the procedural defect herself, because Rubrius, after one interview, had said bluntly that a debt-bond girl citing the lex Iulia's service rules in open court would do more for the case than three advocates. The other women would answer the summonses together, in identical, boring, documented calm.

“Boredom is our shield,” Antonia told them at the final evening's rehearsal. “They want tears, confusion, contradiction. Give them receipts. Every answer ends at a document. The court will want to go home; help it.”

Festus, who had been listening from the door, said, “And if it goes against us? In the street, I mean.”

“Then the documents go to the prefect's office the same hour, and the case becomes evidence in a larger one. We've built this so it cannot actually win for him, only delay us. The delay's the danger, not the verdict. Which is why—” she picked up the perfumed invitation that had arrived with the dawn.

Celer came to the Carinae by the postern the same evening, which was the measure of his fear, since the postern meant no litter, no witnesses, and no charm.

He looked smaller than Marcus remembered, the golden quality dimmed, and he stood in the tablinum twisting his ring and said, without preamble, “If they call me at the hearing, I'm supposed to be their witness, aren't I. The brother who saw the auditor consorting. They'll have coached me.”

“Have they approached you?”

“Perperna's man. Very polite. Suggested I might remember certain evenings — your visits, the temple, Ostia. Said a family that cooperated kept its property.” He swallowed. “I told him I'd think about it. That's why I'm here. To tell you I'm not going to. Whatever I am, Marcus, I'm not the man who sells his brother to the person who owns his debts. I've sold quite enough of myself already.”

Marcus looked at him for a long moment. “You understand what testifying for our side costs. Relief, not immunity. Bankruptcy, possibly exile.”

“I understand I've been a fool on credit for fifteen years, and the bill's come due, and I'd rather pay it than pass it to your son.” The handsome face attempted the old smile and managed something better than the smile: something honest. “Besides, the Carinae lady's lawyer says my statement's the inside of their loan case. I've spent my life being useful at dinners. Perhaps I'll be useful once for something that matters.”

When he had gone, Antonia said, from the shadow of the colonnade where she had heard the whole of it, “He might mean it.”

“He means it tonight. Men like my brother mean things in waves; the trick is catching the wave at the shore.” Marcus paused. “You've been talking to him. My brother, in your house.”

“Everyone comes to my house. That's the business. I gave him no promises and no wine, which is more than Rome's given him.” She folded her arms. “He'll hold. Shame is stronger than charm, once a man's actually felt it; I've watched it work on better material than him.”

The wedding invitation arrived with the dawn, on perfumed paper, sealed with a name Livia had arranged: the daughter of a consular family, marrying in the old style, with half the Senate invited and the city watching for who appeared on

whose side. Livia's own hand was on a slip inside: *The women will be veiled. There is room for three in our party. Let Rome see who stands together.*

Antonia held the invitation a moment, then set it with the court papers in the growing file, and said, to Chloe's raised eyebrow, “Yes. We go. A defence conducted in a courtroom can lose in the street. It's time the street saw the faces.”

That night Phyllis sat with her while the house slept, the old woman wrapped in a shawl by the brazier, her breathing a little too careful.

“You're thinking about whether it's safe for me to come,” Phyllis said.

“I'm thinking about your heart.”

“My heart's lasted sixty-three years without your advice, and it's decided it wants to see a Carinae woman walk into a noble wedding on the arm of the consul's wife. I'll sit at the back with the old women; nobody notices the old women, which is our great advantage.” She watched Antonia fold the veil. “You're frightened. Not of the court. Of being seen with him in the open.”

“Of what it means. In the open, it stops being a partnership and starts being a story. I've spent my whole life controlling the story.”

“Then let this one be true. It's a rare luxury; most people never get offered it.” Phyllis coughed, and pressed her chest once, and recovered. “I saw the boy in the kitchen, remember. He was worth the truth then. He's paid enough to be worth it now.”

On the Esquiline, Marcus read the same invitation and the same slip, and sat a while with his daughter's small cat on his desk, and wrote a single line to Antonia through the old channel, then burned the draft, as he burned everything, and wrote instead the only safe sentence: *The party will expect three veiled guests. The honour is ours.*

Behind the Palatine, in the same week, Zosimus was learning the difference between power and safety, and the lesson kept him awake.

Perperna found him in the bathhouse again, the steam their only reliable privacy, and the freedman's soft hands were trembling visibly around the oil flask.

“The prefect's guards are at the Ostia warehouse. I've seen the roster; Attianus has opened an inquiry. How did they get the witness statements? How does a supper-house keeper reach the praetorian prefect?”

“Through the auditor, which I explained to you when you insisted on the indictment. You wanted speed; speed makes noise.” Perperna's voice stayed gentle. “Calm yourself. An inquiry is not a prosecution. Attianus needs evidence the emperor will credit, and his evidence runs through infamis women and frightened Greeks. Our indictment reaches a court first, and a court that has already condemned the Carinae house gives him nothing worth bringing to the Palatine.”

“And if it fails? If the procedural challenge succeeds?”

“Then we use the time it bought. The bureau's correspondence will be found to contain certain — irregularities — attributable to a clerk who resigned last autumn and has since retired to the East. Paper can be corrected, Zosimus, by the men who hold the pens.” Perperna poured water on the stones and watched it vanish. “You're afraid of the wrong thing. The prefect is slow and lawful; the law is our element. What you should fear is the woman, because she thinks like we do. That's why the indictment exists. Not to punish her. To occupy her.”

“Occupy?”

“While she answers the charges, she can't assemble them. Every hour her advocate spends in the praetor's court is an hour not spent in Attianus's office. By the time her case is heard, the spring sailing will have begun, the army will need the supplies, and no emperor on the edge of a war will disrupt his own logistics for the grievances of a courtesan. The war, my friend, is the real defendant in this case, and wars are never condemned.”

Zosimus stared through the steam. “You've thought of everything.”

“I've thought of the likely things. The unlikely things are why I keep the third instrument.” He stood, toweled himself, and paused at the door. “Go about your work. Smile at the right people.

And if the guards come to your office, remember that you sign nothing; you route correspondence. There's a great distance between routing and deciding, and I've spent twenty years making sure the courts can't see across it.”

Outside, the city was waking to another market day, full of law and hunger and noise, and somewhere behind the Palatine a soft-voiced man was composing his next move, and the winter sun came up over the tiled roofs as calmly as if no one's life were being decided at all.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

A Wedding in Rome

The bride was the daughter of the Cornelii, the groom the heir of a consular house, and the wedding was, as everyone in Rome agreed before the first torch was lit, the event of the winter: a proper old ceremony in the family atrium, three hundred guests, and a procession through the streets that would give the whole city something to watch and judge.

Livia's party arrived in the fourth hour, three litters with the blue curtains of an old house, and the veiled women passed into the women's side of the atrium with the household slaves carrying the gifts, and the doorkeeper, who had been paid by both sides and therefore saw nothing, did not see the face beneath the third veil at all.

Antonia stood in the women's cluster at the edge of the lamplight, in a respectable matron's gown of dark green with no jewellery but the bronze ring at her throat, and watched the Roman aristocracy perform itself. The atrium was hung with garlands and white ribbons, the marriage couch waited in its alcove draped in scarlet, the augur had taken the auspices, and the bride stood

veiled in flame-colour at her father's side, very young and very composed, and Antonia thought, with the old cold clarity, that every face in the room was a ledger of arranged things — marriages, money, names — and that the bride's composure was the same skill she taught her own girls: the art of carrying what could not be refused.

Chloe stood beside her, equally veiled, equally watchful, and Phyllis sat at the back among the older women, small and grey and entirely invisible, the way old women are.

“Crassicia, two rows ahead,” Chloe murmured. “She's counting the veils.”

“Let her count. Livia's invitation is a better document than her curiosity.”

The ceremony proceeded: the joining of hands before the witnesses, the ancient formula, the tablet signed and sealed, the single cake shared and offered to the gods, and then the burst of congratulations and music, and the room relaxed into the wedding breakfast, and the social battle Antonia had been brought to win began in earnest.

Livia came to her first, across the whole width of the atrium, in full view of two hundred people, and kissed her on both cheeks in the manner reserved for old family friends, and said clearly enough for the nearest ten women to hear, “How kind of you to come. My husband will be

delighted; he values your — advice — more than most people's."

The word hung in the lamplight. *Advice.* Not company, not friendship: advice, the respectable coin, the thing a great lady could receive from a clever freedwoman without a breath of scandal. Antonia took the cue with the smoothness of a dancer.

"The house is at your service, as always, though I'm afraid my best advice today is simply to enjoy the breakfast."

Around them, the calculation moved through the women like wind through wheat. The consular wife had claimed the Carinae woman in public. The social weather changed by degrees; two matrons who had been looking the other way now found reasons to pass nearby, and one, a praetor's wife whom Hilarus's ships had quietly saved from a debt, even bowed.

Crassicia did not bow. She swept up at the second hour with two friends and a smile like a blade, and said, "Livia, my dear, surely not *the* Carinae person. At a family wedding. What *is* Rome coming to?"

The room did not go quiet, because Roman rooms never do, but the nearby conversations thinned to nothing.

Livia turned slowly. "She is my guest, Crassicia, and therefore under this family's protection. Unless you mean to suggest that my invitations require your approval, in which case

I'll have my husband's secretary write to yours and settle it between the men." A small, dangerous pause. "I'd hate for your husband's tax assessment to suffer from a misunderstanding; the censors are so particular."

Crassicia's face went through three colours and settled on dignity. "I merely—"

"You merely mistook a wedding for a debating hall. It happens as one gets older." Livia turned away, ending the woman as completely as a door closing, and said to Antonia, in the same clear voice, "Do try the honey cakes; they're from the same baker the emperor uses."

After that, the party was won. Rome, which respects nothing so much as a winner, absorbed the veiled women into its machinery, and Antonia moved through the breakfast with the careful, modest bearing of a respectable businesswoman, speaking of grain prices and temple funds and never, by so much as a word, of the house at night, while beside her Chloe did the same among the younger wives, and Phyllis, at the back, watched every servant's passage.

Perperna arrived at the third hour, as she had known he would, the invited guest of the groom's uncle, and he crossed the atrium with the kindly smile and the plain dark tunic, and he saw her at once, because he had been looking for her, and the smile did not alter by a fraction. He came over through the crowd, and bowed to Livia, and said,

“What a remarkable party. Even the city's more — interesting — residents seem welcome.”

“Rome is large enough for all its residents,” Livia said. “Perhaps that's why it governs the world.”

“A generous view. I shall try to learn it.” He turned the smile on Antonia. “Domina. I'm told your hearing approaches. I do hope the court appreciates how very — organized — your establishment is. Organization is so often mistaken for conspiracy.”

“And conspiracy for courtesy, in my experience.” She met the smiling eyes with perfect calm. “Enjoy the breakfast, Perperna. The honey cakes are excellent; you'll need something sweet, given how sour your winter's becoming.”

He laughed, genuinely, the warm laugh, and moved on, and Chloe, at her shoulder, murmured, “He's afraid.”

“He's annoyed. There's a difference; annoyed men make errors.” She watched him work the room. “Notice he didn't deny the indictment or name the charges. He wants us thinking about the law, not the supply contracts. Keep the witnesses' names out of every conversation today; this room is his ears.”

The bride was led out in the torchlit procession at dusk, the traditional obscenities sung, the nuts scattered, the groom's threshold and the lifted bride, and the great families poured into the streets behind the torches, and Antonia, watching

the young woman carried over a stranger's doorway, thought again of the universal Roman bargain, and of how few people in all this golden city ever crossed a threshold they had chosen themselves.

In the women's press on the way out, Livia walked at her side, close enough that only the veils could hear.

“How many of them watched us?”

“All of them. That's the point.” Antonia kept her eyes forward. “You've publicly made me your friend. It costs you; I know what it costs.”

“It costs me Crassicia, whom I never liked, and earns me a reputation for independence, which I find I don't dislike. We Aelii have been respectable for four hundred years; one season of being interesting won't kill us.” A pause. “My husband says the hearing could go against you before the larger case is ready.”

“Then the larger case must be ready regardless of what happens to me. That's why the copies are where they are. Whatever the court does with my person, the evidence doesn't live in my house any more.”

Livia's gloved hand found hers briefly, beneath the folds of the veils, and pressed it, the one un-Roman gesture of the whole day. “You speak like a woman who's rehearsed being taken.”

“I've rehearsed being taken since I was seventeen. It's the only preparation that's ever mattered.”

Marcus she saw only across rooms, the way she had seen him at the games: a nod, a raised cup, the public grammar of allies, nothing any pamphlet could use. Once, in the press of the congratulating crowd, their hands brushed, and neither of them looked down, and the contact lasted perhaps two seconds, and it was enough.

⁂

Celer vanished during the singing.

Festus, posted in the street with the litters, noticed it first: the younger Aelius leaving by a side gate in a plain mantle, walking fast toward the Capena road, no litter, no slave, the gait of a man making for the city gate before anyone noticed his absence. Festus did not shout, because shouting at a noble wedding was a mistake, but he sent one of the new guards running to the house and followed himself, at the distance of a careful man, through the thinning afternoon streets.

Tracking a man in Rome was an art the gladiator schools had taught him before any household had paid for his knife arm, and the rules were simple: keep the colour of the mantle in the corner of the eye, never the man's back; match his pace rather than close the distance; use the crowd as a wall and the shopfronts as mirrors. Celer walked fast but without craft, the walk of a frightened amateur, and he made every mistake

Festus expected — he looked behind him at every corner, which announced him; he chose the broad streets, which kept him visible; and he headed for the Capena gate by the most direct road, which meant he meant to leave the city rather than hide in it.

At the fountain of the Aqua Appia, Festus closed enough to read the message the young man clutched in his hand, folded small and sweat-damp, and to hear him ask a water seller the hour of the south-bound carts. A man with money would have hired a litter; Celer was travelling on foot with a message, which told Festus that the flight had been arranged for him, not by him, and that whoever waited beyond the gate expected the prey to arrive alone and anxious.

The guard he had sent ahead reached the gate first, and Festus saw the quiet word passed to the customs clerk, a man whose son had once trained at the same gladiator school and whose memory for favours was excellent. The clerk nodded, examined an imaginary fault in his register, and began the slow, bureaucratic business of being difficult, while Celer shifted from foot to foot behind two carts and a herd of goats, his eyes on the road beyond the arch.

Festus came up beside him without haste, as though they had met by the ordinary accident of the gate, and said, low, “Don't turn. Don't run. The road's the one thing they want you on, young

master; there are no witnesses between the tombs, and a gentleman found robbed on the Appian Way is a story Rome has heard a thousand times and never investigated once.”

Celer went white under the wedding garland he had forgotten to remove. “The message said — they said there was an arrest list, that my name was on it, that if I was inside the walls by dusk—”

“The message was written by the same hand that wrote your subscriptions. Think. Who benefits from a witness leaving Rome on the eve of a praetor's hearing? Not your brother. Not you.” Festus kept his eyes on the clerk's bent head. “I'm going to walk, and you're going to walk with me, slowly, back through the crowd, and we're going to find the senator, and you're going to tell him every word of that message and the name of the man who gave it to you. Do that, and by tomorrow you're not a fugitive; you're a cooperating witness under the praetor's own protection, which is the only wall in this city higher than the one you're trying to run through.”

For a long moment Celer stared at the open gate and the sunlit road and the dark line of tombs beyond it, and Festus saw the two futures fight behind his eyes, the road and the room. Then the young man's shoulders came down, and he folded the message into his tunic, and turned away from the arch, and said, in a voice that tried for dignity and nearly reached it, “Lead on.”

They went back through the city by a different route, Festus's rule for any road that might be watched, and the wedding noise was still drifting over the rooftops when they reached the gardens where Marcus had been told to wait. The senator read the false arrest message twice, his face hardening, and then looked at his brother-in-law with an expression Celer had never received from him before: not anger, which he could have endured, but pity, which he could not.

“Do you see now? The message didn't come from any court. It came from the men who hold your subscriptions. They don't need to kill a witness who can be frightened into running; a fugitive's statement is worthless, and a body on the Appian Way closes the file.” Marcus folded the message and put it inside his own tunic. “Tonight you write down everything: who gave it to you, where, the wording, the seal. At dawn I take you to the praetor myself, and you ask for protection as a cooperating witness. It costs you the last of your pride. It buys you your life and, if the gods owe you anything, your name.”

Celer, to his credit, did not bargain. “The dawn, then. And Marcus — I'm sorry. For the seals. For all of it.”

“Save the apologies for the statement. Sorrow isn't evidence; dates are.”

He found him at the Capena gate, negotiating with a carter for a place on an empty wagon going

south, and he approached with the gentleness of a man who knows his own size.

“Master Celer. Your brother's looking for you. The wedding's missing its best speech.”

Celer turned, and his face was the face of a man who has stopped sleeping. “Let me pass, Festus. I've got money, I'll give you — take this ring, it's worth—”

“I don't want your ring, master. I want you to think for ten seconds, which is nine more than whoever sent you that message allowed.” Festus moved his bulk between Celer and the wagon, not touching him, merely occupying the road. “Where's the message? The one that made you run.”

The younger man's hand went to his tunic, and stopped, and that was answer enough.

“Whoever sent it told you the indictment's going to name you, didn't they. That your brother can't save you, that exile's the best on offer and only if you're gone before the hearing. I know the speech; they use it on everyone.” Festus's voice was low and patient. “Here's the speech nobody gives you. A witness who runs is a witness who's guilty, and a guilty witness drags his whole family into the ditch. A witness who stays and tells the truth in open court is a man the praetor can use, and men the praetor can use get relief. Your brother's built you a road back, master. You're standing at the mouth of it, trying to climb into a dung cart.”

Celer stared at him. The carter, sensing trouble, clicked to his mules and pulled away empty.

“Perperna's man said they'd have me condemned before the month.”

“Perperna's man says what he's paid to say. I'm paid to keep you alive, which makes me the more honest fellow.” Festus offered his arm, gravely, as though to a consul. “Come back to the wedding. Eat cake. Make your speech. Rome loves a charming man, and you're the best I've seen at it; give it one more performance, for the family this time.”

After a long moment, Celer took the arm, and they walked back through the gate together, and no one at the wedding except Livia ever knew that the younger Aelius had been four minutes from the road south.

Marcus had the full story in the garden of the wedding house, under the pergola, with the torches guttering and the singing loud enough to cover them.

“The message said my name was on the arrest list,” Celer said, miserable. “That they'd take me at dawn, and the best I could hope for was exile if I ran first. It was on good paper, Marcus, a hand I — a hand I trusted.”

“Whose hand?”

“I don't know. That's the devil of it. Delivered by a boy, no seal I recognized.”

“Perperna's. It doesn't need a seal; it needs you frightened, and you were. Listen to me.” Marcus put both hands on his brother's shoulders, the way he had once steadied him as a small boy on a horse. “You will not run. Running is the only thing that makes the message true. Tomorrow you put yourself under the praetor's protection openly, as a cooperating witness, before anyone comes to arrest you. A man who surrenders his own statement at dawn cannot be seized as a fugitive at noon. Do you understand the difference?”

“I think so.”

“Then repeat it.”

Celer repeated it, like a lesson, and some of the panic left his face. “You really mean to save me. After everything.”

“I mean to make you worth saving. There's a difference, and it's the only mercy on offer.” Marcus released him. “Now go inside and find Livia, and tell her everything, including the message. She'll know how to keep you visible for the rest of this wedding; the safest place in Rome tonight is the middle of a crowd of witnesses.”

Celer went, and Marcus stood alone a moment in the torchlit garden, and thought about fear, and how it moved through a city like water, finding every crack; and then he went back inside too, and smiled at the right people, and gave none of them the smallest sign of the night his family was having.

⁂

The attack on the warehouse came that same night, while the wedding torches still burned and the city's attention was on the singing in the streets.

Four men came over the back wall of Hilarus's Ostia-road storehouse, where Syrus the engraver and Dorion the measurer lay under guard, and they came as the other men had come: quietly, professionally, with knives and no lanterns. But the guards Festus had chosen were ex-gladiators of his old school, and the back wall was watched from a loft, and the first man over it took a stave across the skull before his feet touched ground.

The fight lasted perhaps three minutes, a confusion of dark shapes and grunts in the warehouse yard, and it ended with two of the attackers down, one fled, and one held by two men with his arm twisted up behind his back, while inside, Syrus lay white-faced among his seal stones and Dorion gripped a bronze lamp he had been prepared to use as a weapon.

Syrus's own account, given over hot wine once the yard was secured, filled in the part the guards had not seen. The men had known exactly which room he slept in and where the seal stones were kept; they had gone past the stores of oil and grain without a glance. “They didn't come for the warehouse. They came for my hands,” the engraver said, holding them up, and they were

shaking. “They meant to take me, or cripple me. A seal-cutter without fingers is no witness.”

Dorion said nothing for a long while, then: “Hector. They did the same to Hector, didn't they. Not a quarrel. A witness removed.”

“The same hand, different instrument.” Festus wrapped his arm. “Which is why neither of you sleeps outside a guarded room again. Tomorrow you move again, and the day after if need be, until the court opens. Rome's a big city; it costs them to hunt, and it costs us nothing to move.”

The captive, when the patient interrogation began, was a dock-side tough named Afer — the same name Moschus the locksmith had given, the runner from the cattle-market taverns. At first he gave silence and bravado; then, with the charges of burglary, assault, and conspiracy to murder laid out clearly beside the alternative of a witnessed statement, he gave the tavern, the paymaster's habits, and the commission: to seize or disable the engraver, and, if the chance offered, to learn where the Carinae house kept its tablets. The Minerva signet appeared in his description of the paymaster without prompting, and Festus, who had been told what to listen for, had him repeat it twice for the record.

Festus reached the warehouse from the wedding streets at the third watch, out of breath in a way he hated, and found the captive already trussed, and his own right forearm bleeding from a knife that had found a gap. He examined the

wound, dismissed it with a word, and examined the man instead.

“Who pays you?”

The captive said nothing.

“All right. We'll do it the long way. Hold him.” Festus sat on a crate, the wounded arm wrapped, and began the patient, terrible work of an interrogator who had learned in the arena that fear was cheaper than pain and more reliable. By the fourth hour he had names — two intermediaries, a wine shop, and, the thing that mattered, a steward's commission that matched the Minerva signet. Hermeros. Zosimus's household. The chain had climbed another link, and the link led to the Palatine.

At dawn, while the wedding rubbish was being swept from the streets, the captured men were handed over to Vibius Longus of the vigiles with a witnessed statement, and the witnesses in the warehouse were moved, that morning, to a safer house behind the temple of Diana, and Syrus, whose nerve had nearly broken, sat holding his toolbox and said, over and over, that he would testify, he would testify to anything, if only they would keep men between him and the night.

⁂

They came for Antonia at the sixth hour, in the full daylight she had always known they would prefer for the final thing.

The urban praetor's officers, six of them, with a formal warrant and the aedile Macer's signature, arrived at the gilded door as the household was finishing the morning meal, and the street, which had been seeded with watchers for weeks, filled with the curious as though by a signal. The charge was the lenocinium indictment, the warrant was for her person pending the preliminary hearing, and the terms were precise: the house would remain open under a custodian, the residents' papers seized for examination, and Antonia Cassia would be held in the magistrate's custody, not a public cell — Macer was too careful of the praetor's standing order for that — but held nonetheless, away from the house and its women, on the far side of the city.

She heard the warrant standing in her own atrium, in her dark formal gown, with the bronze ring of Eirene at her throat and every lamp lit behind her, and she did not raise her voice, because she had decided long ago that Rome would never see her afraid in daylight.

“May I have the hour to settle the household?”

The officer considered. “Half. My instructions are explicit.”

“Half, then.”

She used every minute. To Chloe, in the tablinum, she gave the running of the house and the keys that were not already with the temple, and the names of the witnesses and the order of the hearing and the location of every copy, in a

voice so level it might have been a supper menu. To Phyllis she gave nothing to do, because the old woman's heart was its own war, and instead took both her hands and said, “Keep the women calm; you're the only one they'll all believe.” To Sabina she gave the Twelve Tables and a single instruction: be ready, because the court was about to need a girl who could read. To Festus, whose bandaged arm was already moving toward a knife, she said, “No. Not here, not now. Live, and run the back channels; a free man's worth ten of me in custody.”

Then she changed her mantle, checked the strong room's seals with her own eyes, and walked out through the gilded door between the officers with her head up, through the crowd of her neighbours, and the last thing she saw as the litter turned into the street was the door itself, the gold leaf bright in the winter sun, the door she had built from nothing, standing closed and guarded and still hers.

In the litter, behind the curtains, with the city roaring past, she permitted herself one moment — not tears, never tears where they might be seen — but one moment, in the dark, to be simply a person: the girl on the bench, the woman in the Subura, the mother of a daughter with no grave. Then she folded the moment away, as she had folded everything, and began, in her mind, to compose the answer she would give in court.

The custody house stood on a quiet street behind the temple of Juno, a private residence used by the praetor's office for witnesses and persons of standing who could not be put in the common cells without scandal. There were guards at the door, a clerk to log her effects, and a small, clean room with a barred window and a bed, and the officer in charge, a tired decurion, treated her with the careful politeness Rome gives to people whose cases might still go either way.

“No irons, domina, not under the standing order. The door's locked, and the window's barred, and your meals come from the house kitchen under seal; your own people may bring food and bedding for inspection. One visitor a day, in the presence of a guard. I'm sorry; those are the terms.”

“Then make sure the guard is the same man each day, so I don't have to learn new faces. And decurion — whatever you're offered to carry messages in or out, take it to the praetor's office first. The men who pay in this case pay twice, and the second payment is usually a knife.”

He looked at her sharply, and nodded, and she was locked in, and for the first time in eleven years Antonia Cassia lay down to sleep in a room whose key was held by someone else.

At the Carinae, Chloe stood in the atrium with the keys in her hand and eleven frightened women behind her, and said, in the voice the house had taught her, “Open the doors at the

usual hour. The mistress is detained, not condemned. We run the house, we keep the rules, and we give Rome nothing it can use. She's coming back.”

The custodian appointed by the aedile arrived at noon, a bland clerk with inventory tablets, expecting panic and disorder, and found instead the full household in formation: Phyllis with the enrollment rolls, the women with their contracts, Festus with the guard roster and a copy of the praetor's standing order, and Sabina with a wax tablet of the house's legal position, written out in her careful hand. The clerk inventoried, found nothing irregular, and left within the hour, and the doors stayed open, and the lamps were lit at dusk exactly as they had always been, and the city, which had expected a shuttered scandal, found instead a house behaving as though its mistress had merely stepped out.

That night Chloe sat in the tablinum with the ledgers open, where Antonia had sat a thousand evenings, and wrote the first letter of her stewardship: to Hilarus, to Beryllus, to the priestess of Isis, to the auditor's Stichus, the network held together now by her hand. Then she went the rounds of the rooms, as Phyllis had taught her, checking bolts and lamps and breathing, and in the women's court she found Sabina awake, the Twelve Tables on her knees.

“I can't sleep,” the girl said. “What if they keep her?”

“Then we build such a case that keeping her becomes impossible.” Chloe sat beside her. “She taught me that the house isn't the woman, it's the rule. The rule says we don't break. Now close the book and sleep; you've a court to be brilliant in.”

Marcus heard the news at the wedding's end, from Festus himself, who had run the long way through the streets with his bandaged arm and found the senator still in his wedding white.

They stood in the alley behind the wedding house among the discarded garlands and the sleeping drunk, and Marcus's face went through nothing and then everything, in the Roman way, and settled into the officer's calm.

“The standing order?”

“Noted, but not enough to stop the warrant. They've taken her to the custody house by Juno's temple. One visitor a day, in front of a guard.” Festus was breathing hard. “Rubrius the advocate says the preliminary hearing's been brought forward; they mean to rush it.”

“Of course they do. While she's inside, the house is headless and the witnesses lose heart. Speed is the whole of their case.” Marcus thought for perhaps ten seconds, the ally map moving behind his eyes. “First: Rubrius to Ursus at first light, with the procedural defect and the praetor's standing order, both. Second: I see her at the permitted hour, today, and we set the defence together. Third: Attianus's office gets written notice before noon that a material witness in a

prefect's inquiry has been taken into custody on a contested indictment — let the prefect's clerks make of that what they will. Fourth: Hilarus keeps the witnesses moving and the guards paid. Go."

Festus went, and Marcus stood a moment longer in the alley with the garlands at his feet, and then he straightened his wedding toga and walked back into the street to find his litter, because there was nothing to be done with his hands until morning, and the uselessness was the worst of it.

At home he said nothing to the sleeping house, but sat in the tablinum with the lamps burning and worked on the defence through the night, the way he had once worked through campaigns, and when Stichus came at dawn he found his master still in yesterday's clothes, with enough arguments written out to fill a small scroll, and the cold, set face of a man who had finished deciding what he was willing to lose.

Outside, the watchers noted the doors opening on time, and carried the news to the soft-voiced man, and the great city went about its day, indifferent and enormous, while behind the gilded door the women held the wall.

PART IV

PAYMENT

CHAPTER TWENTY

Custody

The custody house had its own rhythm, and Antonia learned it the way she learned every room she entered: by listening first and moving second.

The guards changed at dawn and dusk. The decurion, a man named Caprarius, was honest enough to be careful and careful enough to be kind. Meals came from the house kitchen under seal in the mornings, inspected at the door, and the other rooms on the corridor held two debtors' wives, a merchant accused of customs fraud, and a young woman awaiting a morals hearing of her own, who cried at night and tried to be silent about it. Antonia gave her fruit from her own meals and said nothing, the way one feeds a nervous cat.

She made her bed at dawn, dressed in the plain gowns Chloe brought, and spent the mornings on the defence: the statements, the order of evidence, the questions the advocate would ask and the questions Perperna's men would try instead. The barred window gave her a strip of sky and the roofline of Juno's temple, and she used the light as a clock, and the small,

disciplined use of the hours was itself a kind of freedom.

Chloe came on the first permitted day, with the guard at the door and the household's news delivered in the bright voice of a social call, which was how they had agreed she would deliver everything.

“The doors open on time, the women are well, Tyche sleeps again, and Sabina has learned more law than Rubrius and corrects him in the margins.” She laid out clean linen as she spoke. “The custodian came again and found nothing, and left looking personally offended. Hilarus sends word that the witnesses are all still breathing, which he says is the principal thing in his line of work. And there's a letter from the priestess; the coffer is intact and the seals unbroken.”

“Phyllis?”

“Managing everyone, pretending her chest doesn't hurt, refusing to rest. I've moved her bed to your old room, where I can hear her. She says if you write one more instruction about her health she'll resign, which is a hollow threat and we both know it.” Chloe sat on the stool, the bright voice thinning. “The street is strange. The watchers are back at the fountain, and there are new men, not the usual ones. Festus says they don't watch the front. They watch the rooflines and the neighbours' walls. He says that's how men think who mean to start a fire, not a scandal.”

Antonia's hands stilled on the linen. “Tell me exactly what he said.”

“That twice now, after midnight, there's been a smell of oil in the alley beside the carpenter's shop, and no lamp there. That Vitalis caught a man measuring the gap between our wall and the tenement next door. That the tenement's landlord changed last month, and the new one's a name nobody knows.” Chloe's voice was low now. “He thinks they may stop trying to win in court and start trying to make the evidence disappear.”

“The evidence isn't in the house. The originals are with Isis, the copies with Hilarus.”

“Perperna doesn't know that for certain. If he believes the tablets are in the strong room, the house is worth a fire.”

Antonia folded the linen with precise hands. “Then we do three things. Festus doubles the night watch and buys every bucket in the street; Hilarus quietly buys, or rents, the tenement next door, at any price, so the neighbouring roof is ours; and Rubrius asks the praetor, today, for a note that the house and its records are under the protection of the standing order. If a fire starts in a protected building, the vigiles and the prefect both have to investigate, and Perperna can't afford that kind of light. Send word before you leave.”

“Before I leave?” Chloe's mouth twisted. “You make it sound like a dinner engagement.”

“Everything in Rome is a dinner engagement, with worse wine. Go. And Chloe—” she held the younger woman's eyes “—the house is yours now, in fact if not in name. If the worst happens, you know the packets: the bankers, the priestess, the auditor. The rule doesn't depend on me. That's the whole point of building one.”

When she had gone, the guard outside shifted his weight, and Antonia sat alone in the small room with the strip of sky, and let the fear she had hidden from Chloe move through her for one measured minute, and then put it away, and took up the statements again.

⁂

The young woman in the next room was called Lalla, and she was nineteen, and she was accused, under the same lex Iulia, of adultery with a married man whose wife's family had money and grudges.

She told Antonia the story in fragments, through the bars of the corridor, the way prisoners talk because there is nothing else to do: a love affair, a married man, a pregnancy, the wife's denunciation, the man's convenient denial, and now the court and the possible loss of half her dowry and the child. She had not, she said, understood that the law punished the woman and forgave the man; she had thought love was a defence.

“It isn't,” Antonia said, through the bars, with the gentleness she used for new girls on their first night. “Love isn't a legal category. The law recognizes dowries, witnesses, and dates. Everything else, it calls evidence of character, and character in a Roman court is what other people decide about you after you've stopped speaking. Tell me the dates, not the feelings. When did the affair begin? Who knew? Who carried the letters?”

Lalla, blinking, produced them haltingly: a spring beginning, a shared litter that two slaves had witnessed, letters in the man's hand that his wife's family had somehow obtained, and a pregnancy that had ended, under pressure, before the denunciation. Antonia made her repeat the sequence twice, then sent for the writing things the custody rules permitted, and made the girl write it herself, in her own hand, with the days marked against the festival calendar, because a statement in the accused's own writing could be challenged but never called a clerk's invention.

“Now the important question. The letters. Do any of yours survive — letters from him, I mean, in his hand?”

“Some. My mother kept them; she said a man's promises ought to outlast his manners.”

“Your mother is wiser than the praetor. Have them brought here, through the visitor's channel, and we'll seal them with the temple. A married man's letters prove the liaison was not your

procurement, and a pregnancy proves intent on both sides; the statute punishes the woman alone, but the praetor's fairness — and praetors are vain about their fairness — can be moved by a paper trail showing the man pursued. You cannot win innocence, Lalla; the law's arithmetic doesn't allow it. You can win a smaller penalty, the keeping of your child, and the keeping of enough of the dowry to live. We aim at what paper can actually buy."

The custody house itself, Antonia had learned in her first days, operated by its own rigid grammar, and mastering the grammar was half the battle of surviving the place. The decurion Caprarius held the keys; the junior guards held the routines; the slaves who brought the food and emptied the slops held the true intelligence of the building, because nothing that happened in custody happened without their hands near it. She had begun, as she did in every new establishment, by mapping the economics: the guards' small exactions for extra blankets, the visitors' bribes for longer minutes, the price of clean water and the higher price of privacy, and the single, valuable fact that Caprarius was honest in the expensive Roman sense — he could not be bought, but he could be enlisted, because an honest man with a difficult post responds to competence the way a thirsty man responds to a well.

Her first gift to the house had been a properly revised duty roster, offered through Caprarius as a suggestion, which cut the guards' useless double watches and gave every man one unbroken night in four; her second had been a system for the women's linen, so that the wash no longer vanished into the guards' quarters. Within a week the corridor ran better than it had under three decurions, and within two the other prisoners had begun bringing their documents to the bars of her room, because the word had passed, the way words pass in locked places, that the woman from the Carinae could read a summons and tell you, in plain language, exactly how much trouble you were in and which piece of paper might reduce it.

Rome, Antonia thought, teaching a weeping debtor's widow how to date a receipt, was full of women whom the law had swallowed without ever teaching them its alphabet. The gilded door had always been, beneath the music and the silver, a school for that alphabet. The custody room was merely the same school, conducted behind a bar.

“It was never a defence,” Antonia said. “The law isn't interested in love. It's interested in whose children inherit whose property. You were charged because your womb became a question about money, not because of your morals.”

“They say you run the famous house. That you're rich and they still locked you up.”

“They locked me up because being rich only works until someone richer wants what you have. But the rich men's mistake is that they think a room with a bar makes a woman helpless. It makes her concentrated. What does your advocate say?”

“That I should throw myself on the court's mercy and weep.”

“Then get a new advocate. You have a witness, the man who delivered his letters; you have the pregnancy, which proves he didn't deny you at the time; and you have his denial itself, which contradicts his own letters. Weep in court if you like, but bring the documents. Mercy is a gift; paper is a right.” Antonia paused. “When I get out, send to the Carinae house. Ask for Chloe. We'll find you an advocate who reads.”

The girl stared at her as though the temple wall had spoken, and then, for the first time since she had been brought in, stopped crying.

Over the following days Antonia taught her the house's trade-secret version of the law, the version no advocate would trouble himself to give a debtor's daughter: how to make a statement the court could not ignore, how to keep the letters that contradicted the denial, how to weep only after the documents were entered, because a weeping woman with paper was a litigant while a weeping woman without it was a spectacle. Lalla, who had expected judgement and found

instruction, took to it with the desperate attention of someone learning to swim in deep water.

Rubrius came to the custody room on the fourth day, dry as old parchment, and walked Antonia through the hearing until she could have conducted it herself.

“They'll open with the reputation. Expect ten minutes on the nature of your house, the clients, the women, the so-called assignment of companions. Don't interrupt, don't blush; every blush goes into the record as proof. Then the lenocinium charge, then Tyche's mark — which we void with the coercion statement and the service summons defect. Your advocate speaks last, because the accused's word weighs least in that room and I want the law's own defects fresh in the praetor's mind when he rules.”

“And if he rules against us?”

“Then you're held for the full trial, and we move the whole argument to Attianus's inquiry, where your infamy matters less than your evidence.” Rubrius permitted himself the dry ghost of a smile. “I've lost cases in the hearing and won them in the war. The hearing is a doorway, domina, not a tomb.”

“Tell me the one thing to fear most.”

He considered it. “Not their evidence. Their theatre. A court is a crowd, and crowds are moved by the shape of the story. They'll tell a story about a powerful courtesan corrupting an honest senator. We have to tell a truer and better-shaped

story: about a woman who kept better records than the treasury, and a prosecutor who buries his clerks in the river. Stories win rooms; paper merely keeps them."

Porcia was the next day's permitted visitor, and she came with the kind of news that never reached the custody house through guards.

"The street's divided," she said, her voice low, her market basket open on her lap as though she were merely visiting a troublesome friend. "The pamphlets are everywhere — the house of whispers, the censor and the courtesan, all of it. But the neighbours don't sing that tune. The bucket line changed things; half the Carinae stood on your roof that night, and people don't denounce women they've passed water to. The baker's wife has started a collection for the rebuilding. The fuller says he'll hang your laundry free for a year. Rome's opinion is the Forum's; the street's opinion is the bucket chain's, and the street is ours."

"And the clients? The timid ones?"

"Some have run. The ones who always would. But three of the old names have sent quiet word that their tables remain booked for spring, and one of them — the praetorian tribune, no less — sent money, untraceable, with a note that said only *for the buckets*. Courage in Rome comes in amounts, domina. Small amounts, mostly. But it comes."

Antonia smiled at the basket. “And you, Porcia? The wife of an oil merchant being seen at the custody house of an infamous woman is not the safest company in the city.”

“Hilarus and I decided years ago that safety's a poor god to worship; it asks too much and gives too little.” She covered the basket again. “Also, the oil trade knows what your prosecutor's shell did to the tenement prices on this hill. A man who burns property for a case is bad for every honest merchant in Rome. My husband's guild is watching this hearing with more than curiosity. We're not alone, Antonia. You've made us understand that we're not alone.”

It was, Antonia reflected, the smallest and most Roman of victories: in a building meant to make women feel alone, to make two of them understand they were not.

The days took shape. Mornings for the defence, afternoons for the stream of permitted visitors and the careful coding of their news, evenings for Lalla and the other women along the corridor, and the nights, which were the hardest, for the disciplined kind of thinking that requires silence. She had always been a private person beneath the public face; now privacy itself had been taken away, and she discovered in herself a resource she had not known she had: the ability to be free inside a locked room, by arranging her thoughts as she arranged her house, each thing in its place, no wasted motion, no wasted fear.

Caprarius the decurion, who had expected either weeping or rage and got neither, treated her with growing respect, and after the third day he took to bringing her the morning gazette of the city, the hand-copied news sheets that the bookshops sold, so that she might see what Rome was being told about her. The broadsheets had reached their highest pitch: the censor and the courtesan, the house of whispers, the woman who held senators' secrets. She read them all without expression, and made notes, because even lies were evidence of the lie's design, and the design was what mattered in court.

“Doesn't it make you angry?” Lalla whispered through the bars, after one particularly foul sheet.

“Anger's a fuel. It burns hot and it burns out.” Antonia folded the sheet. “I'm building something that needs a slow fire. Save yours for the right moment.”

⁂

Marcus came at the third hour, in his formal toga, with Stichus behind him and the guard posted visibly inside the room, and they sat across the small table with the law's witness between them like a third person.

He looked at her face first, as she had known he would, searching for damage, and she let him look, because there was none to find.

“You're well,” he said.

“I'm confined, not ill. Tell me the useful things.”

He told them, the officer's briefing, low and exact: Rubrius had filed the challenge to the women's summonses on the procedural defect, with Sabina's analysis; the praetor's office had acknowledged the prefect's notice that she was a material witness, which meant any conviction would have to survive Attianus's inquiry; Celer had surrendered his own statement openly and was now under the praetor's protection, beyond Perperna's reach; the warehouse attackers were in the vigiles' cells, and the Minerva link was written into the record.

“Your own indictment?” she asked.

“Proceeding. The consul's office formally removed me from the audit yesterday, in writing, with expressions of regret.” For the first time something like humour moved in his face. “Perperna got my office. He also got an audit file already copied into the prefect's hands, so the office costs him more than it cost me.”

“The consulship?”

“Postponed, probably finished. Livia's already planning how to spend the free time; she says the children will survive one unconsul'd father.” He leaned forward, keeping his hands on the table where the guard could see them. “Antonia. The bargain I was offered — to denounce you and keep everything. It's still on offer; they renewed it through a friend of the family yesterday. I want

you to hear my answer from me and not from a pamphlet.”

“I already know your answer.”

“Hear it anyway. No. Not now, not at the hearing, not if the case goes against us. I've put it in writing and Chloe has a copy.” His voice dropped, though the guard could not have missed the words. “And if you imagine I'm doing this for honour, I've stopped being that young. I'm doing it because you're the only person in Rome who ever expected me to tell the truth at a cost, and I find I can't go back to living where no one does.”

The small room was very quiet. Somewhere in the house a door opened and shut.

“That's the most dangerous thing anyone's said to me in this building,” she said, “and a great many dangerous things have been said.”

“Then say something back, because I've been rehearsing for an hour and Stichus is pretending not to listen.”

She looked at him — the grey at the temples, the long honest face, the senator's hands folded on a prison table — and said the thing she had folded away in the litter and kept folded through every night of the room.

“I love you. I've loved you since a kitchen at Tibur, and I built a fortune and a fortress to make sure it couldn't matter, and it matters anyway. When this is over, there will be no legal marriage and no respectable house and none of the endings the city understands. I'll not be your kept woman,

and I'll not give up my doors, and if that's too small a life for an ex-consul, tell me now, in front of the guard, and we'll both be free of it.”

He said, without hesitation, “It's larger than any life I've been offered.”

The guard coughed delicately and looked at the wall, and they both smiled, briefly, the private smile of two people who had decided to be impossible.

The bell ending the visit rang too soon, as such bells do, and he rose, and said, low, “Two more days to the hearing. Hold the room.”

“Hold the city,” she said, and he went out, and the bar dropped behind him, and she sat a while with her hands over her own mouth, the way women do when they have said the largest thing and must immediately become practical again.

The guard, a young man with a farmer's face, kept looking at the wall, and after a while he said, awkwardly, “Begging your pardon, domina. Is it true, what the broadsheets say? That you know all the senators' secrets?”

“It's true that they talk too much in my house. Whether I remember what they say is my affair.” She considered him. “Why do you ask?”

“My father's a farmer. The grain dole's been short in our district twice this winter. The officials say it's the weather. My father says the weather doesn't weigh the grain twice.” The young guard flushed. “I just wondered, is all. Whether anyone

at your table ever said what's happening to the grain.”

Antonia looked at him with new attention. The empire's fraud, reduced to a farmer's empty bowl; that was the true shape of the case, the shape the court would never state so plainly.

“Come to the Carinae house when this is over,” she said. “Ask for Chloe. Bring your father's market receipts. I think you'll find several people who want to know exactly what's happening to the grain. And guard — thank you for asking instead of deciding.”

He went back to staring at the wall, but something in the set of his shoulders had changed, and she made a note of his name, because in Rome even a locked room could grow a useful witness.

⁂

On the Esquiline, the household made its own preparations for the hearing, and Livia ran them like a general.

The formal letter removing Marcus from the audit arrived with the consul's regrets and a private note from the consul-elect promising that the door would “reopen when the air cleared.” Marcus read both, set them in the file, and said nothing about the consulship, and no one else mentioned it either, which was its own kind of funeral.

“Gaius wants to come to the hearing,” Livia said, over the evening accounts.

“He's fourteen.”

“He's fourteen, he knows the whole case, and he asked in a sentence Cicero would have been proud of. I think he should. A boy who's going to inherit this name ought to see what it costs to carry it.” She did not look up from her columns. “I'll be there too, with the same two consular wives. The basilica needs to see the family in its seats.”

“People will say you're supporting her.”

“People already say it. The difference is now I mean it, which simplifies things.” She set down the stylus. “I've also moved the last of the liquid funds. If the house's creditors run — the suppliers, the timid guests — Hilarus can cover the gaps without touching the dowry. Her establishment survives this month on money of mine, routed through the bank so no one can trace the hand. I've decided I prefer being useful to being respectable; it's a great deal less dull.”

Marcus looked at his wife across the lamplit table, and said, “You've become the most unexpected person I know.”

“I've always been exactly this person. You were busy being virtuous.” She picked up the stylus again. “Go and see her tomorrow. Tell her the family arrives together. And Marcus — when you say whatever you say at the door of that room, remember the children are watching in two days'

time. Give them a father they can describe without lowering their voices.”

Beryllus came the next morning, in his best toga, with a banker's document case and a face composed for history.

He sat across the table, declined the fruit, and said, “I've made a decision, and I'd like you to talk me out of it, because my wife couldn't.”

“Testifying.”

“Testifying. To Perperna's loans, his interest rates, the forced purchases, the new silver, the whole architecture. I've three pages of notes.” He laid the case on the table. “I've spent forty years being the man who knows everything and says nothing. It's made me rich and it's made me safe. My wife asks why I'd give up safe at sixty, and I have no respectable answer, only this: a city where men like Perperna can put women like you in this room is a city where my own wealth is merely a longer lease. I'd rather own something than rent it.”

“You understand he'll come for your bank.”

“He'll try. My bank is three partnerships and a network of obligations older than his indictments. I'll lose some business; I'll keep the bank. And I'll keep my self-respect, which I discover is a ledger I've been neglecting.” The crocodile eyes were steady. “I'll say in court what I've said to you: the money, the rates, the names. Not gossip — figures. Figures don't weep.”

“Rome owes you for this, though Rome won't admit it.”

“Rome owes me nothing; I'm buying shares in the outcome.” He allowed himself a thin smile. “My wife said I'd be ruined. I showed her the accounts: Perperna's prosecutions have destroyed four banking houses that held the victims' deposits, because the treasury's share comes out first and the creditors take what's left. If he keeps winning, eventually it's my depositors' turn. Self-interest and conscience have, for once, written the same letter; a man of my age can't be expected to ignore such a miracle.”

He opened the case and laid out the three pages: Perperna's loans with their dates and rates, the forced property purchases below market value, the trail of new silver from the bureau disbursement, and the purchase of the tenement beside the Carinae house, traced as far as the Minerva witness.

“Read it slowly in court, if it comes to that,” he said. “Bankers' evidence is like good oil: it works best when nothing's rushed.”

“One question.” Antonia kept her voice level. “If I'm convicted, you've given these notes to a convict's advocate.”

“Then I give them to the prefect instead, and to your priestess, and to my own sealed packet at the temple of Saturn. Three doors, none of which Perperna controls. I told you once, domina: I don't burn letters. It's a professional defect.” He closed

the empty case. “I've also arranged for your house's banking needs to continue whatever happens at the hearing. Credit doesn't frighten me. Men who frighten credit frighten me, and I've decided which side of that line your prosecutor stands on.” “One thing more. The new tenement beside your house. The new landlord's purchase money passed through a small bank on the Aventine — Longinus's old house, now under different management. I traced it as far as a shell, and the shell's witness is a Minerva seal. If there's a fire, my notes will show who bought the fuel.”

Antonia's blood went cold and stayed cold, and her face gave nothing. “When did you learn this?”

“Last night. I sent a runner to your Festus before I came here. The woman who runs your house will have it by now.” He rose. “Be careful in here, Antonia. Men who can't reach the paper sometimes decide to reach the person.”

When he had gone she stood at the barred window and watched the sky over Juno's temple turn toward evening, and thought of the gilded door and the women behind it and the smell of oil in a midnight alley, and she did the only thing a locked room permitted: she sent for parchment, and wrote to Chloe and to Festus, and to the praetor and the prefect's office, four copies, four messengers, every warning she could put into words, and then she lay awake most of the night, listening to the city breathe beyond the walls, waiting for an alarm that did not come.

At the Carinae, the four letters arrived in the order fear dictates, and Chloe's council met before the lamps were trimmed: Festus, Phyllis, Hilarus, Vitalis, and the new guards, with Sabina writing the minutes because her hand was the clearest.

“The tenement.” Hilarus read the banker's news twice. “The Minerva seal again. They own the wall next to us, and a fire in a tenement is Rome's commonest accident. If it spreads to the house, the strong room survives — I built the vault myself — but the women's wing is timber, and in the confusion anyone could walk the storerooms.”

“Then we buy it,” Chloe said. “Today. Whatever it costs. Antonia's instruction said at any price, and she doesn't say that twice.”

Hilarus bought it before noon, through a third party so the seller's shadowy principals would not take fright, and by evening the tenement's street door had a new lock and two of Festus's old schoolmates on the stairs, and its tenants were quietly informed, with a month's free rent attached, that any smell of oil or any stranger on the roof was to be reported at once. The neighbours, who understood nothing but liked free rent, became the house's outer watch.

Vitalis meanwhile worked through the night, sealing the gap between the two buildings with plaster and brick, clearing the timber lean-to where the alley's rubbish had piled, and filling

every bucket and basin in the house with water. Festus walked the rooflines himself, marking the wind and the neighbouring heights, and set the watch in pairs, one pair always awake.

“You think they'll really burn us?” Sabina asked, near dawn, when the work paused for bread.

“Men who've failed with paper try fire,” Festus said. “It's the oldest argument in Rome. But fire's a coward; it only wins where nobody's ready.”

Phyllis, who had watched all of it from her chair, said, “The tablets. The house copies. If they're going to burn for anything, they'll burn for those. Put them somewhere the heat can't go.”

So Chloe, with Festus and a lamp, took the house's remaining copies down to the strong room at the third watch and placed them in the vault's lowest stone compartment, under the silver, where Hilarus's brickwork and the earth itself would protect them; and she was coming back up the stairs, with the lamp in her hand, that she smelled the first trace of smoke that was not kitchen smoke, and heard, from far off through the sleeping streets, the first thin cry of the vigiles' trumpets.

It came, in the end, not to the custody house but to the Carinae, and by the time the word reached her at dawn, the sky over the Esquiline was red with more than sunrise.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Fire

The tenement next door caught at the fourth watch, in the hour when Rome sleeps deepest and the night watch is at its coldest, and the vigiles' trumpets came over the rooftops like the voices of frightened birds.

Chloe woke to the smell before the shout: oil, and burning wood, and the particular sharp sweetness of fire already well begun. She was on her feet with the house drill running through her head — the drills Festus had made them run every night for a week, until the women complained in their sleep — and she was in the corridor before the first scream reached them from the street.

“Fire! Next door — everyone up, quiet and quick, the courtyard, now!”

The household moved the way it had been trained. No one ran, because running in a burning street is what kills people; they came out in their pairs, musicians and courtesans and kitchen slaves, each with her bundle and her neighbour's hand, down the stairs and across the atrium to the garden court, where the impluvium and the great

water jars stood full, and where Festus had placed the two strongest guards with the wet blankets.

Vitalis's brickwork held. The new plaster between the tenement and the house smoked and cracked but did not give, and the sealed lean-to was gone — he had demolished it himself that afternoon, with Hilarus paying for the loss without a murmur — so the flames, denied the bridge of timber, roared upward through the tenement's own dry wood instead of across the wall. But the wind was off the roofs, and the sparks came over in showers, and the house's upper eaves began to smolder in three places at once.

“Bucket chain!” Festus roared, from the front door, where he had thrown the whole width of himself into organizing the street. “You, you, and you — the well, now! Pass the buckets and don't break the line!”

Vibius Longus arrived with the watch within minutes, his vine stick in his hand and his men already deploying their axes and their siphon pump, and he took one look at the prepared house — the chains, the blankets, the cleared wall, the calm women in the courtyard — and said, to Festus, “Somebody knew.”

“Somebody always knows in this street. The question's over there.” Festus jerked his head at the tenement, where the fire was hottest at the ground-floor corner, far from any hearth. “No kitchen there. No lamp. That's an oil fire,

centurion; I've started enough of them in my life to know the smell.”

Vibius's mouth tightened. He had seen the carver's hand on a doorframe and a clerk in the river already this winter; he did not need to be told twice. “I'll have the origin examined when it's cool. If it's arson, the report goes to the praetor's office and the prefect both.”

The street became a battle line. Neighbors poured out of the surrounding blocks with their own buckets, because a fire in Rome was nobody's private misfortune; let one insula go and the whole district went, and the Carinae knew it. The baker from two doors down organized the well line, the fuller's apprentices hauled the vigiles' pump, and even the nut-seller who had watched the gilded door for Perperna found himself passing buckets, Rome's appetites forgotten in the older appetite to survive. Above them, on the roof walk, Festus's ex-gladiators worked in the smoke with wet hides, beating out each new spark as it landed, while below, Vitalis directed the wet blankets against the blistering paint of the door, saving the gold leaf by the simple method of keeping it permanently soaked.

“Watch the upper windows!” Vibius shouted, as a section of the tenement's roof caved in with a sound like a giant's cough and sent a fountain of embers over the street. The siphon pump answered, its jet arcing into the glow, and the bucket chains redoubled, and somewhere a

woman was screaming the names of her children, and two of Festus's guards went in after them through a stair that was already smoking and came out with both boys, one under each arm, to the rough cheer of the street.

It was in that noise and light, while the tenement burned like a signal on the hill, that Chloe, hauling a bucket with arms that no longer felt like hers, noticed the empty place in the courtyard's count.

⁂

At the custody house behind the temple of Juno, the same night arrived as noise without meaning.

Antonia woke to trumpets, distant but many, the sound she had been waiting for since Beryllus's tracing of the tenement's ownership, and she was on her feet before the guard had struck a light. The other women along the corridor woke too, crying out questions; Lalla came to the bars of her room with a face stripped bare by sleep and fear. From the high, barred window nothing could be seen but sky, and the sky, toward the Esquiline, was the colour of a heated blade, red and breathing, and now and then a gust of smoke smell reached even here, bitter and unmistakable, across a mile of rooftops.

“Where is it?” Lalla whispered.

“Toward the Carinae.” Antonia's voice was steady because she would not permit it to be

otherwise, though her hands on the bars were not. “It may be any street. The city burns every week.” But she had counted the trumpets, and the direction, and the hour, and the arithmetic was the kind she did better than anyone in Rome, and it came out against her.

The young farmer's guard — the one whose father's dole had been weighed twice — appeared with the others, and she saw by his face that he knew more than the regulations allowed him to say. She did not beg him for news; begging was a debt with interest. Instead she made her voice practical, the voice of a householder organizing rather than a prisoner supplicating.

“Decurion Caprarius will want the corridor secured properly, not gaped at. If the wind shifts, the ash comes this far and the women need wet cloths, not panic. Tell him I can organize the wet cloths; it's my trade.” It gave the guards something to do, which gave her something to watch, and watching was the only action left to a locked room. Through the rest of the night she moved along the corridor with the others, doling water, calming the girls who had never heard Rome burn, keeping her own face at rest, while above the temple the red sky swelled and faded and swelled again with the rhythm of a fight that was being won or lost a mile away, among people she loved.

Once, near the fifth watch, the glow dimmed suddenly and did not return with the same

strength, and she knew, with the householder's instinct that no custody order could take from her, that the worst of it had been turned or had consumed its fuel; but knowing a house still stood and knowing who stood inside it were two different sums, and the second one had to wait for daylight.

She did not sit down again. She stood at the window with her hand on the bronze ring at her throat, and watched the sky go from red to grey, and when at last the footsteps came down the corridor — heavy, familiar, the tread of a man who had carried a body's weight of bad news and meant to carry it honestly — she was already composed, and the only sign of the night was the whiteness of her knuckles.

Lalla came to the bars in the first grey light, and the two women looked at each other, and Lalla said, “Your house. It's your house burning, isn't it.”

“Perhaps. We'll know when the messenger comes.” Antonia's voice might have been arranging a supper. “Whatever the word is, watch what I do with it. This is the lesson no advocate can teach you: the worst news arrives once, but everyone in the building will read your face a hundred times. Hold the face, and you hold the room.”

“You're afraid. I can see you're afraid.”

“Of course I'm afraid. Courage isn't the absence of it; I've never met a brave person who

wasn't frightened, only people who'd decided what mattered more than the fear." She almost smiled. "For me, that's the women behind the door. For you, this morning, it's getting to your hearing with your letters dry. Hold to the thing, Lalla, and the face will follow."

The fire ate the tenement. Rome's insulae were tinder, and this one had been made tinderer: the investigators would find later that its ground-floor storage had been quietly filled with dry timber and pitch-soaked rags, the careful preparation of men who needed a neighbour's house to burn without an obvious crime. The flames went up four storeys in the time it took the trumpets to bring the next watch, and the heat reached across the street and blistered the paint on the gilded door, and turned the gold leaf black at its edges.

Inside the Carinae house, the bucket chains held. Water went hand to hand from the impluvium and the street well, up the stairs and along the roof walk, where the guards beat out the sparks with wet hides. The women passed the buckets alongside the slaves; Tyche, her lyre abandoned, carried water until her arms gave out and then carried it again; Sabina worked beside Chloe without a word, the drill carrying her where her courage might not have. The kitchen staff, under the cook, kept the jars full and the wet cloths coming, and even the cat was removed to the courtyard in Vibia's old basket, yowling with outrage.

Phyllis was last seen clearly at the second hour of the fire, in the garden court, counting the women.

She had refused to leave with the first evacuation party, the older slaves and the frightened, because someone had to count, and she counted with the lamp in her hand and the smoke beginning to curl across the atrium, and at the end of the count she said the thing that froze Chloe's blood.

“Where's Sabina?”

She was not in the courtyard. The girl, in the first confusion, had remembered the tablets — not the originals in the temple, not the vault copies, but her own Twelve Tables and, worse, the house's current accounts that Chloe had been working in the tablinum, the running records of guests and debts that Perperna's men could use to build a hundred accusations. She had slipped back inside, alone, up the smoke-filled stair, while everyone was watching the wall.

No one even saw Phyllis go. Festus was at the front with the pump; the guards were on the roof; Chloe was three buckets deep in the chain. The old woman simply put down her lamp, picked up a wet blanket, and went into the house after her, sixty-three years old and a heart that had been failing for months, moving with the particular, unhurried certainty of someone who had decided the price of things a long time ago.

She found Sabina in the tablinum, coughing on the floor by the strong room door, the accounts clutched to her chest, her eyes streaming, a fallen beam smoldering across the threshold. The upper landing was burning; the air was black and hot and full of the roaring that fire makes when it has made up its mind.

“On your feet, child. Under the blanket, low, follow my voice.”

“I can't — the smoke—”

“You can, because I'm telling you to, and I've never once been wrong about a household.” She got the girl under the wet blanket and her own body between Sabina and the burning threshold, and she half-carried, half-dragged her back down the stair, along the corridor, through the atrium where the smoke lay like a grey sea, to the garden door and the night air, and the waiting arms of the guards.

In the last stretch, with the garden door ten feet away and the voices outside, Phyllis stopped, and turned, and looked back into the burning house with an expression Chloe, fighting through the crowd toward them, would never forget. It was not fear. It was the expression of a woman checking her work. The strong room door was shut. The accounts were in Sabina's arms. The women were counted. Everything that could be kept was being kept. Then she turned again and walked the last ten feet, and stepped out into the courtyard, and put the girl into Chloe's arms.

They got Sabina out. They did not get Phyllis out whole.

She made the courtyard, and put the girl into Chloe's arms, and said, quite clearly, with the old housekeeper's precision, “The accounts are dry. Check the seals,” and then she sat down on the stone bench by the impluvium, because her legs had stopped being hers, and her hand went to her chest, under the left breast, and she did not rise again.

Chloe was beside her at once, and the physician came running from the street where the injured were being gathered, but there was nothing to be done, and everyone there knew it; the heart, overtaxed by the smoke and the stairs and sixty-three years, had simply finished its work. Phyllis took Chloe's hand, and looked past her for a moment at something no one else could see, and said, very low, “Tell her I kept the wall,” and died in the courtyard of the house she had helped to build, with the firelight on her face and the water from the buckets running over her sandals.

By the fifth watch the tenement was a black shell, the wind had changed, and the Carinae house — its upper wing scorched, its gilded door blackened, its women alive and its vault intact — stood against the dawn like a wall that had been tested and had held.

The street counted its dead at first light: two in the tenement, an old couple who had refused to

leave their room, and no one in the gilded house at all, a fact the neighbours repeated through the day with something like awe. The vigiles and the buckets had saved the walls; the drills had saved the women; and the old housekeeper, everyone agreed, had saved the girl.

Chloe walked the rooms at dawn with Vitalis, taking the inventory the way Antonia would have done it, in the cold light. The women's wing was scorched but standing, its new iron bars twisted by the heat; the dining wing had taken smoke but no flame; the atrium's painted walls were blackened at the edges and the dolphin mosaic was buried in ash; the strong room was untouched, its seals perfect, its vault dry. The gilded door was the saddest thing in the house, its bright leaf curled and blackened, and Chloe stood before it a moment and said, to Festus, “We'll have it regilded. Before she comes back. Whatever it costs.”

“Vitalis can start the frame today. The leaf takes the goldsmith a week.”

“Then tell him ten days' pay for six days' work. The door is the story, Festus. Rome has to see it shining again.”

The women set to work with the strange, fierce energy of people who have survived the night and refuse to give the day to grief. Ash was swept, linen was boiled, the smoke was chased out with burning herbs, and the kitchen produced a meal for the entire household and the neighbours'

besides, because in Rome after a fire the fed are the calm and the hungry are the dangerous. Sabina, her voice hoarse from smoke, sat wrapped in blankets in the garden and would not let the accounts out of her arms until Chloe herself had checked every seal.

“Phyllis said to check them,” the girl kept saying. “She said it, at the end. The accounts are dry. Check the seals.”

“The seals are perfect. You did exactly what she taught you.” Chloe sat beside her and held her while the shaking came, and said nothing, because there was nothing to say that the girl did not already know.

⁂

The word reached the custody house with the first light, brought by Festus himself, bandaged and smoke-stained, because he would not let a messenger carry it.

Antonia read his face through the little barred window of the door before he spoke, and the room, which had held so many disciplined hours, went very far away.

“Say it.”

“Phyllis. She went back in for Sabina and the accounts. The heart took her, in the courtyard, at the end. She didn't burn, domina. She went quickly, at the end, and she sent you a message.”

He had to stop. “She said to tell you she kept the wall.”

Antonia did not weep in front of the guard, or in front of Festus, or at all that morning; she had built herself too carefully for that, and the city, which had taken so much from her, would not be given the sight. She stood very still at the barred window with her hands closed on the wood until the knuckles whitened, and she thought of the kitchen at Tibur, and the flogging, and the bronze ring on its cord, and an old woman's keys, and the thirty years of a life spent keeping a wall around the people the world had sold.

Then she said, in the voice the household knew, “The women?”

“All alive. Sabina's coughing, nothing worse. The strong room held, the vault copies are dry, the originals were never here. The tenement was set; Vibius has the rags and the pitch and he's writing it for arson. Beryllus's paper ties the building to the Minerva seal.”

“Then nothing she died for is lost. That's the only kind of death the city can't steal.” She released the wood. “Festus. I want the rites she'd want. The temple of Isis, the priestess, the proper prayers for the dead. No expense. And her name on something permanent — not a wooden marker, stone. I'll choose it when I'm out. Tell Chloe she's the house now, and to run it the way Phyllis would: every seal checked, every woman counted.”

He went, and she was alone, and then at last, with the guard looking carefully at the opposite wall, she sat on the edge of the narrow bed and put her own hand over her mouth the way she had after Marcus's visit, and she grieved the only way she could, in complete silence, without giving the room a single sound.

⁂

The fire became, within two days, the least secret arson in Rome.

Vibius Longus filed his report with the vigiles' prefect and the urban praetor: the tenement's origin point had no hearth or lamp, the ground floor contained pitch-soaked rags and stacked dry timber, and the building's recent change of ownership ran, through two shells, to a purchase witnessed under a Minerva seal. Beryllus's bank records made the chain of money. The warehouse attackers in the vigiles' cells, offered the same bargain of evidence over oblivion, identified the same paymaster's agents. Perperna's name was never written down, because it did not need to be; every clerk who handled the file knew exactly whose hand was behind it, and that knowledge was itself a change in the weather of the city.

Vibius Longus conducted the sift himself at first light, while the shell still steamed, and he took Antonia's two men — Festus and Vitalis —

through the ruins with him, because he wanted independent eyes on what he found.

The origin point was unmistakable once the debris was cleared: the ground-floor storage room, its floor burned hotter than any hearth could explain, and beneath the ash the unmistakable remains of pitch-soaked cloth and split timbers stacked against the shared wall, as if the building's last tenants had been furnishing a bonfire rather than a lodging. The window onto the alley showed a new lock on the inside, fitted within the month, and the alley's mud held the print of two pairs of hobnailed boots, military issue, where no soldier had business at the fourth watch.

“Oil and pitch don't walk into a locked room by themselves,” Vibius said, prodding the blackened rags with his stick. “And this stack was built against the wall on purpose. They didn't want to burn the tenement. They wanted the tenement to burn your house. The tenants were fuel.”

“Two of them are dead,” Festus said.

“Yes. That's why this report writes itself, and why I'm putting my name to it without softening a word.” The centurion straightened, his face grim. “The boots, the lock, the rags, the ownership chain — the banker's paper will name the buyer. I've seen arson for insurance and arson for revenge. This is arson for evidence-destruction, which means the evidence was working. Tell your

mistress the fire is a compliment, if she can take one.”

Rubrius moved at once. The arson evidence was entered into the preliminary hearing's record, the house's protected status was reaffirmed in writing, and the praetor, who had no wish to preside over a case that now included a fire and a dead woman, grew markedly more attentive to the procedural defects in the indictment.

On the Esquiline, Marcus read the vigiles' report and the bank records together in the tablinum, with Livia opposite him, and when he finished he was quiet for so long that she asked him what he was thinking.

“That I've spent my life believing the law would protect people like her. The law has spent this winter proving me wrong at every turn. Every time they fail with the statutes, they reach for something lower: clerks, alleys, fire. The law's for the respectable. For the rest, there's only being richer, better organized, and more stubborn than the men who want you gone.”

“Then be those things. You've two days.” Livia folded the report. “And Marcus — the old woman. I only met her twice. I've thought about her since. Some people make a whole morality out of one unbroken habit. Hers was keeping the door. Say that at the rites, if you say anything; the city will understand it better than poetry.”

He did not speak at the rites, in the end, because the guards and the case made any words

of his dangerous; but he stood the whole time with his head uncovered in the cold, and Antonia, across the procession, saw him and knew the tribute for what it was, and that was enough between them for that day.

The funeral was held at the columbarium beyond the Esquiline gate, on a cold grey morning, and Antonia was permitted to attend under guard, because even the praetor's office balked at refusing a woman her own housekeeper's rites.

The household came in full, veiled and quiet, and Hilarus and Porcia, and Beryllus, and Vibius Longus in his uniform, and the priestess of Isis with the offerings; and Marcus came, with Livia, and stood with the family at the back, and did not approach her, because the guards were watching and the case was days away. Chloe spoke the eulogy, because Antonia could not, and she spoke it in Greek and then in Latin, the story of a woman sold at thirty who had spent the rest of her life making sure no one else was sold unaided, and the household wept openly, and even Festus had to look at the sky.

Chloe's eulogy told the whole of it that could be told in the open: the kitchen woman sold at thirty, the two great houses she had served, the flogging she had taken for arguing with a mistress, the girls she had raised and hidden and counted through every night of her life.

“She never held a title,” Chloe said, in Greek first, then in the careful Latin the court would have understood. “Rome gives titles to men who own things. She owned nothing but her word, and her word was better than any title in this city. When the fire came, she did the one thing the powerful never do: she went back into the burning room for someone smaller than herself. We are not here because a woman died. We are here because a woman lived, and the living in this city is the harder thing.”

The household wept without shame. Tyche played no instrument, but sang one of the old island laments, her voice carrying thin and clear over the columbarium, and even the vigiles' escort stood with their eyes fixed on the middle distance. At the end, Antonia placed the bronze ring of Eirene for a moment against the stone niche where Phyllis's ashes were laid, and said, for the dead woman alone, “You kept the wall. I'll keep the house.”

Then the guards closed around her again, and the procession went back down the road toward the city, and behind them the new stone waited for the inscription she had already ordered, in full:

PHYLLIS, FREE WOMAN, WHO KEPT THE WALL.

Marcus came to the house the day after the rites, in daylight, with no attempt at concealment,

because concealment no longer existed for either of them.

Chloe received him in the smoke-scarred atrium, where the ash was gone but the smell lingered, and walked him through the damage the way Antonia would have done, room by room, without dramatics. He saw the scorched women's wing, the twisted iron bars, the blackened upper landing where Phyllis had carried Sabina through, and he said very little, and that little in the voice of a man measuring an enemy's work.

“Tell me again the origin of the fire.”

“The tenement next door, ground-floor storage, pitch-soaked rags and dry timber, no hearth. The building changed owners a month ago; Beryllus has the money trail and the Minerva witness.” Chloe handed him a copy of the vigiles' report. “Vibius Longus will say it in court himself. He's angry; arson in his district is a personal insult.”

“The strong room?”

“Untouched. The vault copies are dry, and the originals were never here.” She permitted herself a thin smile. “They burned a tenement and blackened a door. The evidence is in a goddess's coffer and an oil merchant's warehouse and a praetorian prefect's office. They've spent their third instrument and gained nothing.”

“Except Phyllis.”

“Yes.” The thin smile vanished. “Except her. They'll answer for that, whatever else happens.

The house has eleven new reasons, Senator, and I've stopped counting my own."

He stood a while in the garden court, where the fountain still ran and the stone bench was scrubbed clean of the marks of that night, and he said, "At the hearing, Rubrius wants me to speak last among the defence witnesses. The praetor will allow it given the standing order. I'll put the whole audit connection into the record myself — the supply fraud, the murdered clerk, the reason this house became a target. If they want a scandal, I'll give them a conspiracy instead."

"She says you'd say that. She also says don't speak from anger; the court uses angry men for kindling."

"Your mistress knows me too well." He turned at the colonnade. "Take care of the door. Take care of the women. And when you see her, tell her the family's seats are at the front, and Livia's bringing the consular wives. Rome is going to see exactly who stands together."

Back at the custody house, Lalla was waiting at the corridor bars, having heard the guards talk about the fire and the dead housekeeper.

"I'm sorry," the girl said, simply. "You taught me paper was a right. Was she the one who taught you?"

"Something like that. She taught me that the rule is only real when someone keeps it at a cost." Antonia sat on the edge of her own bed and spoke through the bars, because the guards permitted it

and she needed to say the words aloud. “She was sold the way I was sold. Most people never recover from that; they spend the rest of their lives making sure no one gets a kindness they didn't. She spent hers the other way. I don't know if I'm that good. But I know the court's the only place I can prove it.”

“My hearing's the same week. I'm going to do what you said. The letters first, the tears after.”

“Then we're both ready.” She almost smiled. “If Rome insists on making us witnesses, Lalla, we'll give it more witnessing than it knows what to do with.”

That night, in the custody room, she wrote the last of her notes for the hearing, and when she had finished she sat a long time with the strip of sky over the temple, and she did not pray, because she had never quite believed the gods were listening, but she made a vow, which was different: that the men who burned houses and buried clerks and broke old women's hearts would answer in the open, in the Roman daylight, with the whole city made to hear the truth, word by word, whether it wanted to or not.

At the Carinae, the goldsmiths came on the morning after the rites, and the gilded door came off its hinges and went into their workshop, and Vitalis rebuilt the scorched frame with new oak while the house carried on around him. Six days, Festus had promised. The women watched the work from the atrium with the intensity of soldiers

watching a wall repaired during a siege, because they all understood what the door was: not vanity, but the first sentence of the story the city read about them. When it went back up, bright and new and even finer than before, the neighbours came out to look, and the watchers at the fountain wrote it down, and the door said what Antonia would have said herself: still here.

The hearing was in two days. She laid the notes beside the lamp and slept, finally, without dreams.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

The Forum, First Day

The basilica was full before sunrise, because Rome loved nothing so much as a respectable woman in the dock, and the praetor Macer's court, which handled a hundred dull merchant disputes a month, had acquired overnight the atmosphere of a theatre.

The spectators stood four deep at the back, law students with their tablets, idlers with their breakfast bread, and a scattering of the serious men in good togas whose presence told Antonia, as she was led in under guard, that the political classes had come to measure the wind.

She had dressed for the part the city had written for her and then refused every line of it: a dark gown of respectable cut, no perfume, no jewellery but the bronze ring at her throat, her hair drawn simply under a matron's veil. Let them look for the painted siren; they would find a woman in mourning colours with a ledger-keeper's face. Rubrius had approved the choice with one of his dry grunts. “Courts convict stories. We're giving them a story about a bookkeeper.”

The guards delivered her to the chair, and the decurion Caprarius, stationed at the side, gave her the smallest nod, the greeting of a man who had learned more in a custody corridor than he expected. Behind the tribunal the praetor Macer arranged his tablets, his round face already carrying the strained expression of a judge who wished he were somewhere else; beside him sat his legal advisers and the clerks who would keep the record, and at the prosecution table Aquilius conferred with two assistants, golden-voiced and expensively dressed, while his real client watched from the seats.

Perperna met Antonia's eyes once, across the width of the basilica, and gave her the smallest bow, the bow of a colleague at the games. She did not bow back. She looked at him the way she looked at a bad invoice: with mild, careful attention, as if estimating how much trouble he would be. His smile stayed, but she saw the change in the eyes, the tiny recalculation, and she marked it as the first small victory of the morning. She saw Hilarus and Porcia on one side, Beryllus on the other with his document case, and, in the front rows where the important families sat, the Aelii entire: Livia in dark and impeccable dignity, Gaius beside her with his schoolboy's face set hard, Celer pale and watchful, and Marcus standing with his advocate, in the full senatorial toga, the most composed man in the building.

Perperna was there too, not at the prosecution table — he had hired an orator for that, a famous voice from the courts — but in the equestrian seats, in his plain dark tunic and his kindly smile, the author come to watch the performance.

Antonia's own place was a chair before the praetor's tribunal, the accused's position, and Rubrius had instructed her carefully: stand when addressed, answer in short sentences, never interrupt, never weep, and let the documents do the fighting. She sat with her hands folded and her face at rest, the face she had built over fifteen years, and the crowd, which had hoped for something more dramatic, settled into disappointment.

The prosecution opened with the story Rome wanted to hear.

The orator, a plump and golden-voiced man named Aquilius, was very good. He did not begin with statutes; he began with pictures. The house in the Carinae, with its gilded door and its painted walls. The women within, “enrolled as entertainers, kept as merchandise.” The clients, “the first names of Rome, drawn through that door by a woman who understood that a secret in the hand is worth a fortune in the bank.” And then, slowly, with the pleasure of a man laying out a feast, he reached the heart of it: the accused had built, behind her gilded door, a market in vice under the protection of false licenses, and worse, had drawn into it a married senator of consular

rank, whose name and office had then been deployed to shield the enterprise from the law's inquiry.

“A house of entertainment is permitted,” Aquilius said, spreading his arms. “Rome is not prudish; Rome is honest. What Rome does not permit is the conversion of such a house into a machinery of corruption — the assignment of women, the trafficking of secrets, the capture of public officers. And we will show the court, by the words of one of the house's own residents, exactly how that machinery worked.”

The clerk read the charges. Then the witnesses began, and the first day showed its true shape.

Before Tyche, Aquilius called two minor witnesses of his own: a clerk from the aedile's office who testified, with visible discomfort, to the licensing review and the minor watch-register fine, and a neighbour woman from the Carinae who had been well coached in the view that litters came and went at all hours and “goings-on” were notorious. Rubrius let both speak, then took them apart in cross-examination with the polite indifference of a cook jointing a rabbit. The clerk admitted the review had found nothing irregular; the neighbour admitted she had never crossed the gilded door, could name no resident, and had been paid her day's wage to attend. The basilica laughed, once, and Macer did not rebuke it, and the prosecution's theatre was already thinner by the time Tyche was called.

The arson report was entered later, but its shadow moved through the morning: a court that had come to condemn a disreputable house kept being reminded that someone had tried to burn that house down, and that a woman had died in the rescue, and the crowd's sympathies, which Rome's prosecutors treat as weather, began to shift by degrees, the way wind shifts before rain. Antonia watched it happen without changing expression. Reputation was a wall; documents were a door. They had spent the morning turning every one of Perperna's walls into a door.

The afternoon produced Aquilius's most ambitious witness: a former porter of the house, a man named Gryphus, who had been dismissed for theft six months earlier and now presented himself as a penitent insider. He spoke with practised reluctance of “the ledgers,” of names taken and held, of gentlemen who paid for silence as much as for company. It was the blackmail story the prosecution needed, and the basilica leaned in to hear it.

Rubrius let him finish, then had the clerk read the record of the man's dismissal — witnessed, with the stolen silver itemized — and asked, gently, where he had lived since. At a tavern on the Aventine. Who paid for the room? A friend. The friend's name, after three refusals, came out: an agent of the same shell that had bought the tenement. The Minerva seal did not appear in this witness's evidence, but it did not need to; the

crowd could do arithmetic, and a dismissed thief living on the paymaster's rent was a witness whose testimony arrived already bent.

“One question more,” Rubrius said. “In all your months at the house, did you ever see a guest's name written into any ledger kept for purposes other than the ordinary guest lists any host in Rome maintains?”

Gryphus hesitated. “Not — written, exactly. But it was understood—”

“An understanding isn't an entry. The court deals in entries.” Rubrius turned away. “No further questions.”

Macer made a note, and the law students wrote faster, and Antonia saw Perperna's smile lose a fraction of its certainty, the way a lamp loses oil.

⁂

Tyche was called after the morning break, and she walked to the witness position with the pale, set face of a girl who had been through the worst of it in a back room and rehearsed the rest in a courtyard.

Aquilius handled her gently, because gentleness was the script. Her name, her enrollment, her years in the house; and then, the statement. The tablet with her mark was produced and read aloud, and the basilica heard the carefully written claims: that clients were assigned to particular women by the mistress,

that gifts and fees were taken against the women's will, that the house's true trade was concealed behind its licenses.

Antonia, in the accused's chair, watched the room watch Tyche, and read the crowd the way she read a supper table. The idlers were leaning forward, because a young woman's shame was the day's entertainment; the law students were writing without looking up, because procedure was their trade; the serious men in the good togas were watching not Tyche at all but Perperna in the equestrian seats, measuring the patron's confidence as the patron measured them. And Perperna himself sat with his hands folded and his kindly face arranged into sorrow, the sorrow of a man obliged to expose vice for the public good, and Antonia thought, not for the first time, that the man's true art was neither forgery nor prosecution but the management of faces; if his ledgers were half as good as his expressions, he might have been honest and rich instead of criminal and doomed.

She let none of it reach her own face. Rubrius had been exact: every blush entered the record as proof. She had practiced the stillness in the custody room for days, emptying her features one muscle at a time, the way she had once taught new girls to enter a triclinium without looking at the floor. The court could have its theatre; she would give it a mask of marble and save the living face for the cross-examination.

At her side, barely moving his lips, Rubrius murmured, “He's good. Notice he hasn't asked her a single question whose answer isn't already on the tablet. The whole performance is for the crowd, not the record. When I rise, we leave the performance behind.”

“And if she breaks?”

“She won't. She's a musician; she understands rehearsal. Watch her hands.”

Antonia watched Tyche's hands, visible at her sides, and saw what Rubrius meant: they were not trembling. They were curled, once each, into the small fist of the household's private signal — the gesture the women used in the triclinium to tell one another that all was well, that the song continued, that the house was present. A Roman court would see nothing; the Carinae would see everything. Antonia's own hands uncurled in her lap by one degree, and she gave the prosecution's golden voice the attention his fee deserved, and waited.

She used the waiting as she had been taught to use every interval: for observation. Macer the praetor, she noted, had begun writing during the reading of the statement, and judges who wrote during the prosecution were judges keeping their options open; the bailiffs' eyes moved with the crowd rather than the witness, which meant the room's mood was drifting toward the girl; and Perperna, across the basilica, had shifted his weight once, slightly, toward the aisle, the small

bodily confession of a man preparing an exit route before the room had decided there was anything to leave.

She also noted the thing no one else would: Tyche's breathing. The shallow, quick breath of the abduction room had steadied, in the witness position, into the long controlled breaths of a singer about to take a difficult phrase. The girl was doing what musicians did. She was finding her tempo. Whatever Aquilius had rehearsed her to fear, the basilica was only another hall, and Tyche had never yet lost a hall once the music began.

Tyche listened to her own alleged words with the expression of a woman watching a stranger wear her clothes.

Then Rubrius rose.

He did not attack her. He asked, first, for the circumstances of the statement, and Tyche told the court about the cloth street, the two respectable women, the back room, the soft-voiced man, the clerk, and the brother in the Sardinian mine. The basilica, which had begun the day murmuring, went quiet, because coercion narratives were common and this one had dates, names, and a face.

“Were you permitted to consult your advocate before making this mark?”

“No. I asked for my advocate. They said after the statement.”

“Were you threatened?”

“They said my brother could be sent deeper into the mines. Or moved to easier work. They said it depended on me.”

“And did any of the things written in this statement ever happen at the Carinae house? Were you ever assigned to a client against your will, or stripped of your fee?”

“No. Never. The contracts set the prices; I chose the company. It's clause nine; every woman in the house has the same clause.”

Rubrius turned to the tribunal. “The defence will enter the witness's sworn statement of coercion, the musician Doris's account of the shop and the door, and the house's standard contract, clause nine. We will also show that the service summonses issued to the house's residents are defective under the lex Iulia itself — a defect the defence's next witness will explain.”

Aquilius objected that a frightened girl had been “rehearsed into contradicting herself”; the praetor overruled him, and the mark, though it remained in the record, entered it already broken, the way a blade enters a sheath.

Antonia, watching from the accused's chair, allowed herself no expression, but her hands loosened fractionally in her lap. The first move had gone to them; she had not expected it to, which made her trust it less.

⁂

Sabina was the defence's next witness, and the basilica rustled when she took the position, because she was seventeen, plainly dressed, and had the unprotected look that Roman courts associated with victims rather than lawyers.

Rubrius began gently. “State your name and your standing.”

“Sabina Aviania. I serve under a debt contract in the house of Antonia Cassia, witnessed and sealed, with a copy at the temple of Isis.”

“You've studied the statute under which the summonses in this case were issued?”

“I have. The lex Iulia requires that a witness summons name the matters on which evidence is sought, and be served in person before two witnesses of standing.” Her voice shook once, then steadied, the courtyard drills holding. “The summonses served on the women of the house name no matters. They say only ‘to testify concerning the house.' And the one served on Tyche is dated the day before the praetor's office formally accepted the indictment. A process cannot be served in a case that does not yet legally exist. The women's evidence is therefore improperly summoned, and without it, the lenocinium charge has no house witnesses at all.”

The law students at the back stopped whispering among themselves and began writing fast. Macer, the praetor, leaned forward, because whatever else he was, he was a man who disliked being reversed on appeal.

Aquilius's cross-examination was blunter than Rubrius's. “You're a debt-bond in the accused's house. She feeds you, teaches you, keeps you. Would it be fair to say you owe her everything?”

“It would be fair to say she paid four thousand sesterces for a contract that another man meant to use to sell me into a public lupanar.” Sabina lifted her chin. “The court has my father's statement and the sealed debt-paper. I'm here because of documents, not gratitude. If you like, I can explain the difference.”

Somewhere at the back a man laughed, and the bailiff's glare silenced him, and Macer made a note, and Antonia, looking straight ahead, thought of the girl on the garden bench with her cloth bundle, and permitted herself one private moment of something the court would never see.

The afternoon belonged to documents. Rubrius entered the enrollment rolls, the contracts, the tax records, the praetor's standing order, the custody ruling from the earlier hearing, and then, with a change of tempo that Antonia recognized as the old advocate's favourite move, he shifted the court's attention from the accused house to the house's accusers.

“The defence does not deny that an indictment was brought. We ask the court to notice the timing of it. The same house has been inspected under warrant and found in order. Its mistress is a material witness in a praetorian prefect's inquiry into fraud in the army's grain supply.

Within days of that inquiry taking evidence, the indictment appears. We suggest the court is being used, and we will prove it with the documents of the men using it.”

He entered the vigiles' arson report, and the basilica's mood changed a second time, because a fire and a dead housekeeper were not abstractions, and the crowd, which had arrived for a courtesan, found itself being shown a conspiracy.

⁂

Livia came in the last hour, as the light was going, and she came not as a spectator but with a document case of her own, and the praetor recognized her himself, because her family had been marrying praetors for two hundred years.

“With the court's leave,” Rubrius said, “the wife of the auditor named in this indictment, Livia Marcella, has tendered evidence relevant to the misuse of a senatorial seal and the debts at the root of the supply fraud.”

Macer could hardly refuse a Livia, and he knew it. She took the witness position with the same erect dignity she brought to temples, and her voice, when she spoke, reached every corner without ever being raised.

She entered her household diary, the steward Phaon's witnessed statement, and the record of the maid Doris and the garden gate, and she

walked the court through the two unauthorized uses of her husband's seal on days when he was absent from Rome.

“The name of Marcus Aelius Severus appears in the supply loan documents not because he witnessed them but because his seal was used in his absence,” she said. “My household records prove it. My brother-in-law's own statement, under the praetor's protection, confirms it. The prosecution's claim that the senator was a willing partner in the accused's affairs is built on a forgery. I am aware that a Roman wife is expected to be silent in public. I am also aware that the law permits the truth to be spoken, and I have never mistaken silence for virtue.”

The basilica was very still. Even Aquilius, who had a reply for everything, took a moment to find this one, and found in the end only a question about her motives, which she answered before he finished asking.

“My motive is my children's name. The prosecution would bury it in a false adultery case to conceal a theft of the army's grain. You may decide which of those concerns the court exists to address.”

Marcus himself was not called on the first day, by design. Rubrius wanted the court to spend a night thinking about the women and the documents before the senator's name and reputation entered the room, and Marcus spent the evening instead at the prefect's office, making

sure that Attianus's clerks had copies of everything entered in the basilica, so that no piece of the record could vanish overnight, as pieces of Roman records had a way of doing.

“Two courts, one case,” he told the prefect's secretary, who had heard it before and would hear it again. “Whatever the praetor does with the indictment, your inquiry holds the originals.”

He wrote one line to the custody house, through the permitted channel, and it reached Antonia with her morning bread: *The family will be in the front row, and so will the truth. Sleep if you can; I cannot.*

She read it twice, and burned it as she burned everything, and slept, in fact, quite well.

On the Esquiline, the family sat late over the next day's plan, and for once the tablinum held no silences.

“Rubrius wants you after the banker,” Livia said, arranging the witness list. “The money first, the name second; by the time you speak, the court already knows the shape of the fraud, and you're merely confirming what the documents proved.”

“Celer goes before me,” Marcus said. “His statement's the inside of the loan. He'll be attacked as a self-serving debtor; we answer with the diary and the seal forensics.”

“Gaius wants to come again.” Livia paused. “I've said yes. He should see his uncle take the stand and survive it. Boys learn more from uncles than fathers; it's an historical law.”

Marcus almost laughed. “You've turned this into a school.”

“Rome is a school, and the lesson this week is whether truth costs more than convenience.” She folded the list. “I'll be in the same seat, with the same wives. If the praetor looks at me once when he makes his ruling, he'll see a woman who has not blinked in two days. Judges are cowards; cowards follow the confident.”

He looked at her across the lamp, this woman he had never learned to love and had learned, slowly, to esteem beyond measure, and said, “Whatever happens to me at this hearing, Livia, the children are safe in your hands. I've never doubted it.”

“No,” she said, after a moment. “You haven't. That's perhaps the kindest thing you've ever said, and I'll take it.”

Antonia herself was called before the close, because the accused had the right to answer and Rubrius wanted her voice in the room while the women's evidence was still fresh.

Aquilius's questions were designed for damage. Did she not profit from the companionship sold within her walls? Did gentlemen of high rank not visit her house at night? Was it not true that she kept, in her ledgers, the names of Rome's most powerful men?

She answered each one in the level voice he had hoped she would lose.

“I profit from entertainment, conversation, music, and the finest table in Rome, all under licensed and enrolled contracts. Gentlemen visit at night because that is when supper is served; your own patron dines after sundown, orator. And yes, I keep names — every host in Rome keeps guest lists, because invitations require addresses. What I do not keep, because it does not exist, is any ledger of secrets, any assignment of women, or any record of the vices you've been paid to invent. The court has inspected my strong room twice under warrant. It found the ordinary accounts of a licensed house, and nothing else, because there is nothing else.”

“Yet a man is dead after visiting your house, and another's property has been burned beside your walls.”

“Both facts prove my case, not yours. The clerk Hector was killed for documents he kept against the men who steal the army's grain, and the fire was set to destroy evidence those men could not seize. If my house were the criminal enterprise you describe, orator, no one would need to burn it. It would simply be closed.”

The basilica murmured, and Macer's pen moved, and Aquilius changed the subject rather than give her another.

In his chambers during the midday break, the praetor Macer faced his advisers with the expression of a man standing on a moving raft.

“The law's the law,” his senior clerk said. “The summons defect is real; if we proceed on the women's evidence, we're reversed on appeal and look like tools. If we dismiss the lenocinium charge, we're accused of protecting the Carinae house and insulting Perperna.”

“Perperna's an equestrian informer,” Macer said sourly. “The Aelii are four hundred years old, the praetorian prefect has an open inquiry, and there's a dead housekeeper in the file. Which of those people do I wish to have as an enemy?”

It was, his advisers reflected, the most honestly political sentence he had uttered all year, and they spent the rest of the break helping him find a path that postponed every hard choice until the second day.

As the first day ended and the guards formed around Antonia to return her to custody, she met Marcus's eyes across the basilica for one held moment. Nothing passed that the crowd could read; everything passed that they needed. Perperna, in the equestrian seats, was still smiling, but the smile had become a fixed thing, the smile of a man recalculating, and Antonia, carried out through the side door into the winter dusk, thought that the first day had not belonged to either side yet, but that the story in the room had changed: they had come to judge a courtesan, and they were being made to watch a machine.

At the Carinae, the household held its own evening court in the blackened atrium, where the

regilded door stood propped in the workshop and the smell of smoke still lived in the upper woodwork.

Chloe rehearsed her testimony one final time with Rubrius, and then dismissed him, and sat with the women in the garden court, and said the thing that had to be said aloud.

“Tomorrow I name Hector. I tell the court about his tablets, his death, and what the figures prove. Perperna's advocate will call me a singer with a grievance and a dead brother's fantasies. I have to say it so plainly that even a man who wants not to believe me can't.”

“Say the dates,” Sabina said. “They never expect the singers to know the dates.”

“Say the theta marks,” said Tyche, from her couch. “The private verification signs. No forger invents a thing like that; it sounds too dull to be invented.”

Festus, at the door, said, “And if he asks about the house itself, what it is, what we do — don't flinch and don't dress it up. The court trusts a woman who says exactly what she is. It's the pretending makes them cruel.”

Chloe looked around the lamp-lit court, at the women the city described in pamphlets, and said, “We're the only honest witnesses in this whole building. That's the secret, isn't it. Everyone else has been paid.”

“Then be expensive,” said Hilarus, who had arrived with the evening dispatches and stood in

the colonnade with his toga over his arm. “I've insured half the ships in this harbour; I know the value of a reliable name. Give them yours at full price.”

They laughed, briefly, and the music started after that, small and private, and the house made its usual evening noise inside its scorched walls, and that noise, Chloe thought, was the answer to the indictment: the stubborn ordinary life that no fire and no court had yet managed to stop.

Tomorrow, Rubrius had told her, came the hardest witnesses and the loudest voices, and the court would learn what the machine had cost the people who built it.

At the custody house, Lalla was waiting at the bars again, her own hearing two days off, and she had pieced together the day from the guards' talk.

“Did they believe you?”

“Courts don't believe. They weigh. Today the balance moved; tomorrow they'll try to move it back. The only rule is never to be the person who faints, shouts, or contradicts her own documents.” Antonia sat on the bed and pulled off the formal shoes with relief. “How's your statement?”

“Memorized. The letters, the denial, the dates. I keep dreaming I forget the dates.”

“Then write them on your wrist, under the bracelet. The court can't see it, and you'll know it's there; the knowing is half the courage.” She looked at the girl's white face and said, more

gently, “You'll do. You've already done the hard part, which is deciding to speak at all.”

On the Palatine, in a bathhouse that was never quite empty enough, Zosimus was discovering what fear did to a man who had thought himself the hunter.

“The first day went to them,” he said, and the steam could not hide the tremor in his voice. “The wife's diary, the arson, the girl with the statute. Aquilius says the lenocinium charge is hollow without the house witnesses.”

Perperna's voice came out of the steam unhurried, almost kind. “The charge was never the whole case. It's the weight on her arms while the real work happens elsewhere. Tomorrow I give them my own witnesses — men who'll swear to the house's secrets, the names, the influence. Conviction isn't necessary; ruin is. A reputation can be destroyed by an acquittal, if the stories are good enough.”

“And the prefect's inquiry?”

“Is still an inquiry, not an indictment. Inquiries die with the spring sailing, when the war takes the emperor's full attention. We have only to survive the winter, and we have nearly done it.” He poured the water on the stones and watched it vanish. “Stop trembling. The city has never once sided with a woman who keeps a better ledger than its senators. One bad day in court changes nothing.”

But when he dressed and walked out into the cold street, Perperna did not go home at once; he walked instead to the Aventine bank, and had a long, quiet conversation about the movement of his own funds, which was the thing he did whenever the word *survive* began to feel less certain than it used to.

At the Carinae, the household held its own version of the evening's debate, though no one there used the word survive.

Chloe went through the next day's witness list one last time with Festus, checking the routes by which each person would reach the basilica: Syrus and his wife by the oil shop's back lane, Dorion under harbour escort, Beryllus openly and in his best toga because a banker's dignity was its own bodyguard. “Nobody walks alone twice,” Festus said, marking the map. “They've used the street once; they don't get a second chance at any of ours.”

Sabina sat apart with her Twelve Tables and a lamp, reciting the summons law under her breath the way other girls recited songs, and Tyche, whose mark had been broken in open court, tuned her lyre without playing it, because sound carried and the house needed sleep more than music.

Antonia's own instruction, sent from the custody house with the morning bread, was one line: *Tomorrow we stop defending and begin explaining. Make the court see the machine, not*

the women. Dress plainly, speak in dates, and trust the paper.

Chloe read it aloud to the assembled household, and then folded it into the strong box, and said, “She's right. We've spent the winter surviving. Tomorrow Rome finds out what we were surviving for.”

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Forum, Second Day

The basilica was even fuller on the second morning, because Rome's fastest messenger is rumour, and the rumour by dawn was that a senator's wife, a banker, an engraver, and a frightened debtor were all going to swear to the same impossible thing: that the prosecution was the conspiracy.

Antonia took her chair again in the dark gown, and this time she let herself look at the room as a general looks at ground. The praetor's tribunal, the record clerks, the prosecution table with its golden voice, the equestrian seats where Perperna sat in the same plain tunic and the same kindly smile, the front rows of the important families, and behind them the standing crowd, two hundred faces that would leave at dusk and become the city's opinion by dinner.

Rubrius opened with the money, because money was the argument no crowd could refuse.

Beryllus came first, and gave his evidence the way he did everything: without heat, in complete sentences, with dates. The loans at twenty-four per cent. The forced property purchases below

their value. The pattern of prosecutions followed by acquisitions. The new silver traced from a finance-bureau disbursement to the men who had paid a locksmith to enter the Carinae house. And, placed last with a banker's timing, the purchase of the tenement beside it, through two shells and a Minerva-seal witness, the building that had been filled with pitch and timber and set alight.

Aquilius cross-examined him as a man whose business depends on it, and got nowhere; every answer came back to a figure, and figures, as Beryllus had once told Antonia, do not weep. When the orator suggested the banker was acting out of friendship for the accused, Beryllus permitted himself his thin smile and said, “I have no friends in my ledgers, orator. Only entries. Read them.”

The court read them. The court was impressed.

Syrus followed, his seal stones brought in a box under guard, his hands still bearing the small tremor the night raid had left in them. He identified, one by one, the witness seals repeated across the changing names of the supply firms; he showed how an engraved signet differs from a forged copy, the tiny imperfections a maker knows the way a mother knows twins; and he swore, with the engraver's professional pride breaking through his fear, that the seals on the loan documents naming Marcus Aelius Severus had never been cut to order by any honest hand,

but pressed from an impression taken of the family ring.

“An impression taken where?” Rubrius asked.

“Where the ring was kept. A steward's office, a strong room, a desk.” Syrus looked at the record clerks rather than the crowd; witnesses spoke better that way. “You don't need the ring to make the seal. You need ten minutes with it, and soft wax. Someone in that household had the ten minutes.”

Livia's diary and Phaon's statement, already in the record, supplied the someone's opportunities. The court connected the points itself, which Rubrius had known it would; a court that reaches its own conclusion is a court that cannot be shaken from it.

Dorion the measurer followed Syrus, and he brought with him the arm with its tattooed numbers, and the basilica, which had seen a great many things, had not seen that.

He held out his forearm and read the figures one by one, the actual weights of the suspect shipments, and the clerks compared them aloud against the official tallies in the record. Every fourth entry: the same gain, ninety modii, in season and out, in rain and harvest, a miracle of regularity that no honest accounting could produce.

“Grain does not grow on the river,” he said, in his precise Greek accent. “It grows in fields. On the river it can only be counted twice.”

Aquilius asked why the figures were cut into his skin.

“Because tablets are taken from clerks, and clerks are taken from their houses, and I had seen what happened to Hector.” The measurer's voice was steady now; he had rehearsed this in a guarded warehouse for weeks. “The arm comes with me. I wanted the truth to have somewhere the fire couldn't reach.”

The phrase went through the basilica like a draught, and the law students wrote it down verbatim, and Antonia, watching from her chair, thought of the tablets in the goddess's coffer and the vault beneath the strong room, and of how many forms the truth had to wear in Rome before anyone would let it speak.

⁂

The morning's adjournment gave the basilica its breath, and the crowd used it the way crowds do, surging out into the Forum's winter light to eat, argue, and place wagers on the afternoon. The bookmakers who worked the basilica steps had already shortened the odds on the indictment's failure, which Antonia, taking water in the side chamber with Rubrius, noted as a weather-sail of the city's true opinion.

“Don't trust it,” the old advocate said, following her glance. “The crowd's mood is a fair-weather god. One good theatrical turn and they'd cheer

your crucifixion. We win on the documents, not the wagers."

"Celer next. He's the weakest link we've chosen to show them."

"He's weak, which is precisely why he's strong. A witness who damns himself before he damns anyone else is the one witness cross-examination cannot break; what can Aquilius call him that he hasn't already called himself? The danger isn't the questions. It's the silence. A frightened boy in that chair, with two hundred faces on him, will forget his rehearsals and start inventing, and invention is where the truth gets holes." Rubrius wiped his chalky fingers on his toga. "I've told him to count to three before every answer. If he doesn't know the answer, he says he doesn't know it; honest ignorance beats brilliant guesswork in every court I've practised in, and I've practised in most of them."

In the courtyard outside, the family was holding its own small court. Livia sat on a stone bench with Gaius, who was white and silent, and she was speaking to him in the low, even voice Antonia had learned to recognize as the voice of the family's real generalship.

"Your uncle is going to stand in there and say shameful things about himself, in public, on purpose. I want you to understand the difference between shame and dishonour. Shame is what the room feels for him; dishonour would be what he'd carry if he stayed silent and let an innocent

woman take his family's forged seal. Keep your eyes open, even when it's uncomfortable. The Aelii don't look away from their own debts."

"Yes, Mother."

"And Gaius — when he comes out, whatever the room has done, you take his hand. Do you understand? In full view. The family enters together and leaves together; that's the one sentence the gossips can't rewrite."

Marcus himself stood apart at the colonnade, going over nothing, because he had prepared everything there was to prepare; he was simply waiting, the way soldiers wait before an engagement, with an empty mind and a set jaw. Antonia, crossing the courtyard with her guard, met his eyes for one moment across the stone and the lawyers and the lunchtime crowd, and the moment contained no comfort and no question, only the shared knowledge of people who had done the arithmetic together and accepted its total; and then the crier called the court back into session, and they returned to their places, and the basilica settled in for the ruin of a noble name.

Celer was called before the noon break, and the basilica settled in for the ruin of a noble name.

He was pale, and his hands shook slightly, and the old charm was gone; but his voice held, because Marcus had made him rehearse until the fear became a habit. He told the court about the debts, the games, the house on the Palatine; about the loans from the soft-voiced gentleman

who had seemed such a friend; about the bundles of documents he had witnessed without reading, and the day he had been asked to place his brother's seal on papers “as a family formality.” He named the intermediaries, the taverns, the Minerva steward, and he ended with the thing no cross-examination could take from him, because it was against his own interest.

“I signed what I did not read, and I let my brother's name be used because I was a coward who preferred being liked to being honest. I'm here because the men who lent me the money are the same men who burned the house next door and put a clerk in the Tiber. You can ruin me for the debts; they're real. But the forgery is theirs, and the grain is theirs, and the court should know the difference.”

Aquilius did his best. A self-serving debtor. A man buying his own relief. A younger brother shielding the elder. Celer took it with the fixed dignity of someone who had already convicted himself and therefore could not be frightened by anyone else's verdict, and when the orator ran out of questions, the record held a coherent, damaging, largely self-inflicted account of the machine's inside.

In the front row, Gaius watched his uncle with the face of a boy putting away childhood, and Livia, beside him, did not look away either, because she had decided that the family's shame,

if it had to be shown, would be shown with its chin up.

After the noon adjournment, the defence called the witness the whole basilica had come to hear.

Chloe walked to the witness position in a simple gown, without jewellery, her lyre nowhere in sight, and the crowd, which had expected a courtesan, found a Greek woman of twenty-eight with a clerk's hands and a face made steady by grief.

She told the court her name, her standing, her enrollment; and then she told them about Hector.

Her brother, born in the same slave cabin on Delos, sold apart at eleven and twelve, reunited in Rome by the same obstinate habit of hope. His work on the supply board. The day he noticed the rhythm of the numbers, every fourth shipment, the same phantom gain. The duplicate tablets he had kept because the board's own tallies were being corrected by men above him. His fear; his visit to the house in the Carinae, through the postern, with the oilskin bundle; his last evening, when he had spoken of a dull life in Neapolis and olive merchants' accounts.

“He was murdered because he could read a column,” Chloe said, and her voice did not break, because she had decided it would not. “His body came out of the Tiber by the wooden bridge, with three knife wounds and a stone that caught on a piling. The vigiles have the statement. I have his tablets, the originals, in the coffer of the temple of

Isis, under two seals, and copies in the custody of the praetorian prefect's inquiry. The court may examine every line. He didn't die for a grievance, orator. He died for figures. Figures are the one thing my brother loved more than his life, because he believed they were true.”

The basilica was very quiet.

Aquilius rose for the cross-examination with less of the golden confidence than he had shown the day before, and he made the speech the situation required: a singer, an interested witness, a sister's grief looking for a villain. He asked whether she had seen any forgery herself; whether her “tablets” might not be inventions; whether the house she served did not make its living from the very secrets the prosecution alleged.

She answered each one with documents. The tablets' theta marks matched the Ostia weight notes, which the court already held. The circular payments matched the Aventine bank statements, which Beryllus had entered. The witness seals matched Syrus's identifications. “My grief doesn't need a villain,” she said. “I know who killed my brother; the vigiles are holding two of the men who attacked the warehouse, and their statements name the same paymaster. What I need is for the court to read the figures, because my brother can't. That's the whole of my evidence. It's very dull, and very true.”

Aquilius tried the last weapon available to him, the one the law keeps for women like her. “You are, by profession, a courtesan, enrolled in the city's register. Why should this court believe your word over that of a Roman citizen of standing?”

Chloe looked at him with the level gaze she had learned in a house where men paid to be agreed with.

“Because I have no reason to lie and every reason to stay silent. My profession makes me infamis, orator; I know the law as well as you do. My word counts for nothing unless the documents agree with it, and they do, line for line, with the banker's entries and the measurer's arm and the engraver's seals. A Roman citizen's standing got my brother killed and his body dropped in the river. My word is the only thing he has left. You can refuse it. You can't refuse all of these.” She gestured, once, at the table of tablets and statements and sealed copies. “He wanted a dull life in Neapolis. He got a murder and a court case. The least Rome owes him is to read his figures.”

The silence that followed was the particular Roman silence in which a crowd decides, all at once, what it believes.

Someone in the back of the basilica applauded, once, and was suppressed, and the noise of the suppression itself told Antonia how the room had turned.

⁂

Marcus was called in the last hour of the afternoon, and the basilica, which had begun to think it knew everything this case could show, settled in for the sight of a consul-designate in the witness position.

He testified first to the audit: the scope of the army supply review, the pattern in the Ostia tallies, the anonymous reports, and the night the strong room was entered. Then Rubrius asked the question that the whole room was waiting for.

“Did you, as the indictment against you alleged, form an immoral liaison with the accused for the purpose of shielding her house from the law?”

“I formed a friendship with the mistress of a licensed house whose testimony was material to an audit of the public grain,” Marcus said, in the clear, trained voice of a senator. “I did not denounce her, as I was twice pressed to do, because the evidence she held was evidence the audit required. I stand by that decision, and I would make it again. The immoral liaison is a fiction built on a forged seal, which this court has already examined. The real offence is that a consul-designate who came close to the theft of the army's grain was removed from the audit for refusing to give up his witnesses. I'd be obliged if the record stated both facts.”

The law students nearly wore their styli down.

Aquilius's cross-examination was an exercise in salvage. The senator's visits, the gifts, the public association?

“All of it true, none of it criminal. Roman law does not forbid dining in a licensed house, or trusting a woman who kept better records than the finance bureau. If the prosecution has evidence of corruption, let him enter it. What he has is suspicion, and suspicion is what informers sell when documents fail them.”

“A man in your position must see the impropriety—”

“I see the impropriety of using the law of marriage as a crowbar to break open a public audit. My wife sees it too; she's in the front row, and her diary is in the record. The court will notice that the offended husband is the least offended man in this basilica.”

Even Macer nearly smiled, and the bailiffs had to work to suppress the crowd, and Perperna, in the equestrian seats, had stopped looking at the speaker and begun looking at the praetor instead, the way a man checks the direction of a fire.

The prosecution's collapse came, in the end, from its own witness, the way collapses usually do when the ground has been properly prepared.

Aquilius called the soft-voiced man's clerk, one of the two who had taken Tyche's mark, to prove the voluntary nature of the statement. Under Rubrius's cross-examination the clerk admitted, first, that the interview had occurred without the

witness's advocate; second, that a brother's Sardinian mine had been mentioned as a consequence of refusal; and third, fatally, that the written statement had been prepared in advance of the interview, in the office of “the patron,” and that the witness had merely been asked to mark it.

“Prepared before she spoke,” Rubrius repeated, for the record. “So the statement was not her statement at all. It was yours.”

The clerk looked at Perperna in the equestrian seats, and Perperna did not look back, and that refusal of the eyes was noticed by more people than the clerk.

It was then that Perperna made his one mistake of the winter, the mistake that the patient man makes when patience stops working. He asked leave to address the court, as an interested citizen, and Macer, who was increasingly interested in surviving the case, granted it.

He spoke well; even Antonia granted that. He did not raise his voice. He spoke of public morality, of the ancient laws, of the danger that houses of entertainment could become states within the state, holding the reputations of the great in hands unfit to touch them. He warned against “a fashionable sympathy for an organized enterprise of vice,” and he alluded, without naming him, to a distinguished senator whose judgement had been captured. The kindly face, the plain tunic, the sorrowful reasonableness: it

was the performance of a lifetime, and for a few minutes the basilica swayed.

Then he overreached.

“Let the court consider,” he said, “what use such a house makes of the confidences of the powerful. We are asked to believe that this establishment keeps no improper records. Yet its own defence parades before us bankers and engravers and clerks, as if a court of the Roman people were a counting house. Documents can be manufactured. Seals can be copied. The truth of these matters lies not in paper but in the plain moral sense that every citizen possesses—”

“Which is precisely why the law requires paper rather than moral sense,” Rubrius said, on his feet, and was allowed the interruption because half the court wanted it. “The citizen's moral sense is what my learned friend has been selling for twenty years, and it has made him a rich man out of the estates of the dead. This court has before it witnessed statements, sworn bankers' entries, identified forgeries, arson reports, and a murdered clerk's duplicate accounts. My learned friend offers the moral sense. We'll take the documents.”

The crowd's noise rose and was beaten down by the bailiffs, and in the noise Antonia watched Perperna's face, and saw the thing she had waited all winter to see: the moment when the kindly smile became, for an instant, simply a man's mouth, and the fear showed through.

Aquilius made his closing speech before the court withdrew, and even in a losing cause he was worth hearing, because the golden voice had not failed even if the facts had.

He did not argue the documents anymore; he argued the danger. Rome, he said, was full of clever hands and sealed tablets and plausible women, and the safety of the ancient state had never rested on paper but on the plain moral judgement of citizens who knew vice when they saw it. To acquit the house was to license every keeper of a supper table in the city to buy and sell the secrets of the great. To reject the tainted statements was to reward the very coercion the prosecution's witnesses alleged of the house itself. The court, he warned, was being asked to mistake an acquittal for a virtue, when it might in truth be merely a surrender to better bookkeeping.

It was a good speech, and it failed, and the failure was visible in the faces of the crowd, who had spent two days watching bookkeeping behave with more honour than the men who despised it.

Rubrius closed for the defence without rhetoric, which was itself a kind of rhetoric in that room. He walked the tribunal through the record item by item: the defective summonses, the coerced mark, the forged seal, the arson report, the murdered clerk's tablets, the banker's figures, the measurer's arm, the engraver's identifications, the steward's and the wife's

statements. Each item, a document; each document, witnessed; each witness, before the court. “The prosecution asks the praetor to trust moral sense over evidence,” he said at the end. “My learned friend's entire career proves the value of that advice — to men like my learned friend. The law, fortunately, is less fashionable. The law says: show the paper. We have shown it. The rest is noise.”

The phrase went into the law students' tablets before he had finished speaking, and Antonia saw two of them mouth it silently, memorizing, and knew that the old advocate's morning would outlive the case: in ten years' time, some advocate who was today a note-taking boy would say *the rest is noise* in some other basilica, never knowing whose winter had minted it.

That was the hidden victory of documents, she thought, while the bailiffs called the room to order for the praetor's withdrawal: a good line, like a good record, reproduced itself. Perperna had built his career on the evaporation of evidence — dead clerks, burned houses, coerced marks, the slow rotting of paper into rumour. The house had spent the winter doing the opposite work, making copies of copies, so that even if every person in this room vanished, the tablets would still speak, and the speaking would spread, student by student, court by court, the way water finds every crack in a wall.

Macer withdrew with his advisers for a long time. The basilica waited in the restless silence of crowds, and Antonia sat with her hands folded, and Marcus stood among the defence witnesses and did not once look away from the tribunal, and Livia sat in the front row with the consular wives, and Chloe held her tablet in hands that were steady now, because the shaking was over.

In the long wait, Antonia let herself think about nothing useful, the way she had trained herself to do in custody: the light on the coffered ceiling, the dust motes in the windows, the cold of the basilica's floor through the soles of her shoes. Somewhere near the back a child was being nursed. A law student dropped his tablets and cursed in two languages. The imperial clock in the Forum struck the hours, one after another, and Rome's ordinary life went on outside while in this one room five men decided what Rome would be allowed to know.

She thought of Laeta, who had lived an hour, and of Eirene, whose ring lay at her throat, and of Antonia Prima, whose 940 sesterces had bought a name instead of a lash. She thought of all the women the city had used and discarded and then written into laws that did not protect them, and she thought that if the ruling went against her she would survive that too, because she had survived worse and carried better records; but she wanted, with a fierceness that surprised her, to win in the open, not merely endure in the shadows. The

gilded door deserved a legal answer, not a whispered one.

At her side, Rubrius whispered, without moving his lips, “Whatever he says, keep your face still. The street watches the face.”

She kept it still.

When the praetor returned, his ruling was careful, as Roman rulings are, and built itself in stages.

The women's summonses were defective under the statute, and the evidence taken under them was inadmissible. The coerced statement of the witness Tyche was void, having been prepared in advance and obtained by threats against her family. The charge of lenocinium therefore failed on the evidence, and was dismissed. The adultery charge against Marcus Aelius Severus depended on the same tainted foundation and on a seal shown to the court to be a forgery; it was likewise dismissed, with a written note that the named senator appeared to be the victim rather than the author of the documents. And because the dismissed charges had themselves uncovered evidence of fraud, arson, and homicide, the whole record of the case would be transmitted, under seal, to the praetorian prefect's inquiry, with the praetor's own endorsement of its credibility.

The basilica erupted.

Perperna sat through it without moving, the smile restored now, fixed and formal, and he rose with the rest when the court rose, and he walked

out between his clerks with his head held in its usual angle, and not one person in the equestrian seats met his eyes, which was, in Rome, the true beginning of the end.

Antonia was released in the basilica itself, the custody order formally discharged, and the guards stepped back, and for a moment she simply stood, a free woman in her own city, with the noise of the crowd around her and the winter light coming high and pale through the windows.

Marcus crossed the open space of the basilica toward her, in full view of Rome, and stopped the correct distance away, and said, for everyone to hear, in the formal voice of public business, “Domina Antonia. The prefect's inquiry will need your continued evidence. The state thanks you for your records.”

Then, lower, for her alone: “The door's still standing. I checked.”

And Antonia Cassia, who had not wept through the custody, the fire, or the funeral, smiled at him in front of the whole basilica, and said, just low enough, “So am I.”

The street received her like a tide. The crowd that had gathered at the doors parted, not in deference, exactly, but in the Roman way, making room for the person the day's story was about; and the faces that turned toward her were the usual mixture — the curious, the hostile, the admiring, the merely hungry for a sight — but above them, across the Forum, she could see the

Esquiline roofs, and somewhere among them the Carinae, and the gilded door that the goldsmiths had finished two days before.

Chloe walked at one side, Festus at the other, and Hilarus's litter waited with Porcia inside it, and none of them spoke until they were moving, because the street has ears and the day was not yet over.

“Perperna left by the side door,” Festus said. “Two clerks, no litter, walking fast. He didn't smile for the street, which is new.”

“He's calculating. He's always calculating. Today's sums came out wrong, and a man like that needs a day to believe them.” Antonia looked out through the curtains at the passing shops. “He'll try the prefect's inquiry next, or run for the East, or turn on Zosimus to save himself. Watch the ports. Hilarus?”

“Watched since dawn. My factors at Ostia and Puteoli know his face, and so do the harbour guards I pay better than the state does.” Hilarus, opposite her, permitted himself a rare, broad grin. “Domina. You won. In open court. Before Rome. Say it, because I want to hear someone say it.”

“I won a dismissal. The case he built against me is dead. The case against him is only beginning; Attianus has the whole record now, and the praetor's endorsement.” She leaned back against the cushions, and for the first time in weeks let her shoulders drop. “But yes. For today, in the open, we won.”

At the Carinae, the household was waiting in the street, the women and the slaves and the new guards and the neighbours who had passed buckets on the night of the fire, and the gilded door stood open, bright and new and shining in the pale sun, and above the door someone — Sabina, it turned out — had hung a garland of laurel, slightly crooked, tied with blue ribbon.

Antonia got down from the litter and stood before it, and the street cheered, the genuine if temporary cheer of Romans on the side of a winner, and she raised one hand, and the noise redoubled, and then she walked through the door of her own house, which was the only threshold in the city she had ever truly chosen.

Inside, in the restored atrium with its new paint and its scrubbed dolphins, the women fell on one another and on her, and Tyche cried, and Sabina was kissed by everyone whether she liked it or not, and even the cat appeared and was passed from hand to hand, and the kitchen produced a meal as though for a festival, and Antonia let the noise wash over her and did not correct anyone's exaggerations, because Rome's victories, like its defeats, were mostly story, and tonight the story was theirs.

Later, when the lamps were lit and the house had quieted, she went alone to the garden court, and stood by the stone bench where Phyllis had died, and said, very low, to no one visible, “The court read them, old friend. Every line.”

Somewhere in the house a lyre began to play, and the fountain spilled its water, and the city beyond the walls went on with its enormous, indifferent life, but for one evening inside the gilded door, the people who had been sold and threatened and burned out and laughed at sat together at a well-lit table and ate like the winners they had decided to become.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The Consul's Choice

Rome took the verdict the way Rome takes everything, through the medium of talk, and for three days the story ran through the forums and the baths and the dinner tables in two versions. The serious version, among the men who knew the prefect's mind, was that the army supply audit had uncovered something large and that the courts had been used to bury it. The popular version, among everyone else, was much better: a beautiful courtesan with a head for ledgers had beaten the most feared informer in the city, and a consul-designate had stood beside her in open court and refused to say he was sorry.

Both versions were true, and both were dangerous, and the men who governed the empire spent the week deciding which truth to act on.

Marcus was summoned to the Palatine on the fourth morning, not to an audience with the emperor, who was at his villa and took no visible part, but to a long room where Publius Attianus waited with two senior councillors and a table of tablets, and where the conversation was

conducted entirely in the careful language of men whose words would be written down.

Attianus began with the inquiry. The praetor's record had been received and verified. The finance bureau's offices had been quietly sealed and searched; Zosimus was in custody, protesting, with the seal-maker's forgeries and the disbursement ledgers forming a wall of paper against him. The Ostia granaries were under military audit, and the true extent of the shortfall was being measured for the first time. The emperor, when the case was complete, would decide on prosecutions; but the machinery was broken and the men at the top of it were no longer free.

“That is the good work of the past two months,” Attianus said, “and the state owes the thanks for it, in part, to your audit and to the witnesses your friend's house preserved.” He paused, in the manner of a man approaching the difficult paragraph. “Now we must speak of the cost.”

The two councillors took up the rest, with the practised gentleness that surrounds unpleasant bargains. The consulship was the issue. A consul-designate who had been named, however falsely, in an adultery case; who had publicly associated himself with an infamis woman, however legitimate her evidence; who had been removed from his audit amid fire and murder and informers' pamphlets — such a man could not, in

the present mood, take the curule chair without making the office itself a subject of broadsheets and jokes. There were senators, men of the old families, who would not serve under him. There were equestrians who had lost money in Perperna's prosecutions and would not forgive the role of the house. The matter could be handled quietly: a withdrawal for reasons of health, the standard phrase, the lictors never taken, the fasces never carried. His rank retained, his property untouched, his career suspended rather than ended; in a few years, when the story was old, another office could be found.

“In return?” Marcus asked.

“In return, the inquiry proceeds without a political martyr at its centre.” The senior councillor did not flinch. “And you make no further public appearances with the woman. A quiet end to the association. The state cannot have a consul, or even an ex-consul, turning the Carinae into an emblem. The verdict settled the law. The rest is weather, and weather changes.”

Marcus sat with the tablets in front of him and thought, while the three men waited, about all the bargains of this kind he had watched other men accept. The safe phrase. The quiet withdrawal. The small, civilized abandonment dressed up as prudence. He thought of the words he had spoken in the basilica. He thought of a woman in a dark gown who had not wept. He thought of his father's ring on a forger's wax, and of a clerk in

the Tiber, and of a stone niche beyond the Esquiline gate.

Then he said, “I'll give up the consulship.”

The room relaxed fractionally.

“But not for health,” he continued, “and not in the form of a bargain. I'll write to the senate that I withdraw because I've concluded I cannot take the chair without the authority the office requires, and because I choose not to pretend otherwise. And I will not end the association, publicly or otherwise, on anyone's instruction. The state doesn't own my friendships, and if the prefect's inquiry is sound, it doesn't need my silence to protect it. What it needs is the truth in its records, which it has.”

The silence that followed was of a different quality.

Attianus regarded him for a long moment, and then, to the visible discomfort of the councillors, the corner of the prefect's mouth moved. “You understand this may end your career.”

“My career began as a service to the state. It's ended, if it's ended, the same way. A man could do worse.” Marcus rose. “One thing more. The inquiry's witnesses. The house and its women, the engraver and his family, the measurer, the banker, the warehouse families. I want their continued protection in writing. The state has used their evidence; I won't have them inherit my enemies after I leave the building.”

“That can be done,” Attianus said. “It will be done. And Marcus — the letter to the senate. Write it the way you said. The honest version. Rome has too few of them; I'd like one in the record.”

He walked home through the Forum on foot, in the winter sun, a man who had just given away the office every man in his family for four centuries had been born to want, and he discovered, stepping around a vegetable stall and nodding to a client who stared, that the weight that left his shoulders was greater than the one that remained.

Attianus sent for him again three days later, not to bargain but to report, and the report was delivered over plain wine in the prefect's office with the guards shut outside.

Zosimus had been taken in the night, at the bureau itself, with the seals still warm on the day's false tallies. The search of his rooms produced the instruments of his trade: the signet impression of the Aelian ring set in its wooden block, the subscription lists of the shell firms in Celer's name, and a strong box of the loan contracts whose twenty-four per cent rates Beryllus had already entered in the basilica. Confronted with the row of his own documents, the imperial secretary had wept, which Marcus said did not surprise him, and offered to remember everything, which Attianus said did not surprise him either.

“He's giving us the clerks,” the prefect said, “and the harbour supervisors, and the two men in the annona office who corrected the tallies after Hector's death. He's not giving us anyone above him, because there is no one above him but your informer, and the informer holds no office, which is why this was always so difficult to reach. The machine can be taken apart. The man who sold the machine has to be reached through the senate, not the bureau.”

“Then reach him through the senate.”

“We intend to. The hearing opens next week. Your praetor's record goes to the fathers with the imperial backing, and the confiscated estates do the rest; nothing persuades a senate like the chance to redistribute an unpopular man's property.” Attianus poured the wine himself, a gesture of unusual informality. “One thing I'll say to you, since you've paid for the right to hear it. This city survives because every few years someone like her keeps better records than the men robbing it, and someone like you refuses to be reasonable about her. I've put both your names in the report to the emperor. Nothing will come of it publicly; it never does. But the right men will know. That's the coin of my trade, and I've paid it in full.”

Marcus drank the plain wine and said, “Then we're even. I gave them a chair; you gave them the truth. Rome will call both of us fools, probably.”

“Rome calls anything it can't price a fool.” The prefect shrugged. “It's a reliable system; it leaves the useful work to us.”

⁂

Perperna fell the way informers fall, which is to say quickly, completely, and without friends.

The inquiry's sealed record went to the emperor's court, and came back in the form of a senate hearing on the conduct of delators, a hearing at which the praetor's findings, the banker's figures, the arson report, and the names of the murdered clerk and the dead housekeeper were arranged in a single, damning sequence. The men Perperna had ruined over twenty years found, suddenly, that their surviving relatives had voices. The men whose property he had acquired found that property documents could be re-examined. The men who had laughed at his dinners discovered urgent business in the country.

He tried, as Antonia had predicted, to move first. Hilarus's watch at Ostia caught the attempt: a modest cart, a hired ship bound for the East, a chest of the kind that carries portable fortunes, and Sextus Perperna in a travelling cloak that had seen better days, with two servants and none of the old confidence. The harbour guard, paid better than the state paid them, detained him on the prefect's warrant with polite efficiency, and

he was brought back to Rome in the same kind of custody he had arranged for so many others, though without the irons, which seemed to him, on the journey, a refinement of cruelty.

At the dock he made one last attempt at the old voice, asking for the names of the men who presumed to delay a Roman citizen, and the harbour officer, a veteran with twenty years of salt in him, had answered, “Not men. Paper. There's a warrant with your name on it, and paper's the one thing in this harbour that doesn't take bribes.” Hilarus, told the story at supper, repeated it at the Carinae for a week.

The aftermath of the audit ran on through the spring, quieter than the courts and more important than any of them. The military auditors finished the Ostia measurements; the granaries' true stocks were established, the supervisors replaced, and the shortfall, recovered where it could be from the confiscated estates, was entered against the army's accounts with the army's own witnesses. New rules came out of the finance bureau: double witnessing for every shipment weight, sealed duplicate tallies held outside the bureau, and a public posting of the monthly grain totals, the last of these an idea that had begun, Attianus's secretary let it be known, with a courtesan's question about why a farmer's dole could be weighed twice. Dorion's tattooed arm, measured and copied into the record, became the standard against which the new

tallies were checked, and the measurer himself, freed from his contract by way of thanks, took employment in the Ostia harbour office at a state salary, which he considered a dull outcome much improved by its safety.

The senate hearing itself was a study in the speed with which Rome disassembles a man.

Perperna was allowed to speak, and he took the full measure of the allowance, because speaking was the only power he had left. He defended the delator's trade as the empire's immune system, the office by which treason and corruption were exposed when ordinary men feared to name them; he invoked the ancient statutes, the names of emperors, the gratitude of the treasury; he warned the fathers that to punish an informer was to silence every future warning, and he did it all with the same kindly, reasonable face, the same plain tunic, the same carefully sorrowful voice.

It had worked for twenty years. It worked for no one now, because the room contained too many men who had seen the figures, and because among the spectators sat the relatives of three of his victims, in mourning, visible at every bench.

The turncoats did the rest. Clerks who had drafted his statements testified to their preparation. Agents who had served the summonses admitted to threats. The banker's records showed the acquisition of property at a fraction of value after each prosecution, a rhythm

as regular as the Ostia fraud itself. Zosimus, brought from custody, confirmed the route of the new silver and named, in his own defence, every name above his own; and a junior senator rose to read aloud, into the record, the arson report's account of the pitch-soaked rags and the dead housekeeper, which was the moment even Perperna's few remaining supporters stopped meeting his eyes.

The senate's judgement was pronounced in the first week of March. His property was confiscated to the treasury, his contracts and prosecutions were ordered reviewed, and he was interdicted from fire and water within four hundred miles of Rome — the old, terrible formula that meant no community might shelter him, and that his exile had no road back. Zosimus, in custody and now cooperating with the energy of a man who had suddenly remembered his own innocence, confirmed the bureau's part and named the remaining clerks, and the machinery that had eaten its way through the army's grain for years was disassembled, name by name, in the careful, vengeful way Rome cleans an office.

The restitution took longer than the condemnation, as restitution always does. A special board sat through the spring reopening Perperna's old prosecutions, and one by one the families he had ruined came forward with their copies of the documents he had assumed would burn with their owners. Some were restored to

property that had changed hands three times; some received only a formal note that the original judgement had been unjust, the paper worth more than it seemed to men whose children had inherited infamia. The board's clerks noticed that an unusual number of these documents were clean, witnessed copies in a fine Greek hand, and asked no questions; the Carinae house's scriptorium did not advertise, and its clients did not explain.

One case Antonia followed personally, because it taught her what the restitution actually cost. A provincial knight named Octavius had been condemned three years earlier on a delation for maiestas, the broad, elastic charge of treason-as-attitude; his estate had gone to the treasury at a fraction of value, his widow had been reduced to a single room in a relation's house, and his son, barred from office by the infamia, had been working as a clerk in a shipping office. The evidence against Octavius had been a single letter, read aloud in court and then misquoted in the record, and two witnesses whose names appeared on the payrolls of three other Perperna prosecutions.

The widow arrived at the gilded door by the side entrance, in the hour Antonia kept for such callers, with a bundle of her husband's papers held together with kitchen string and the expression of a woman who had been refused at eleven doors and expected refusal at the twelfth.

Sabina took the bundle first, because the scrivener's eye was the fastest in the house, and within an hour she had found the thread: the original letter, kept by the widow against every advice, did not say what the court record claimed it said, and the two witnesses' payroll entries were in the same Beryllus-copied bank statements already before the board. Antonia had the whole comparison written into a clean memorial that evening, witnessed by Chloe and sealed at the temple, and sent it to the board with no covering note from herself, because a courtesan's name on the cover could poison a cause that the documents could carry alone.

The board reversed the condemnation within the month. The son's infamia was lifted, the estate's remains were traced through their three sales and restored where they could be, and the widow came to the door again, this time by the front, with a small bronze lamp for the household shrine and nothing to say that her face did not say for her. Antonia accepted the lamp and refused the rest — there was no rest offered, only gratitude, and gratitude she took in the Roman way, as a debt now marked paid — and afterward said to Chloe, in the tablinum, “That's the work the court scenes leave out. The court clears a name in an afternoon; the name has to be learned again by a family over ten years. We can't give them the ten years. We can give them the paper that makes the years possible.”

“One house at a time,” Chloe said.

“One house at a time. It's how Rome itself got built, according to the poets, and the poets are right about exactly one thing: no one ever did it all at once.”

The scriptorium that did the work occupied what had been the old music storeroom off the women's court, and it ran to a discipline Antonia had borrowed from Beryllus and sharpened for her own people: every memorial in three copies, one for the client, one for the temple coffer, one sealed against the future in the vault; every statement witnessed by two hands and dated against the festival calendar; every name cross-entered in the roll she kept of the delator's victims, so that a widow arriving with kitchen string and a dead husband's letters could be told, within the hour, which other widows held the pieces of the same false prosecution.

Sabina came up from the Forum three afternoons a week to run it, and the women of the house learned the copying in rotation, because Antonia held that a hand trained to form a clear testamentary hand could never again be told its work was merely decorative. “The pamphlet shops call this place a house of pleasure,” she told the newest copyist, a girl who had arrived in the spring with no letters at all. “They're half right. My own view is that there is no pleasure in Rome more durable than making the city's paper tell the truth about somebody it wanted to forget. Copy

the next line slowly. A witness may flinch; a clean copy cannot.”

Antonia followed the board's lists the way other women followed the races, marking each restored name in a private roll she kept beside the strong room's key. “Why keep count?” Chloe asked her, near the end. “They're strangers. Most of them.”

“Because he counted them as income. Somebody should count them as justice, and the ledgers ought to balance in the end.” She closed the roll. “Twenty-three houses ruined that we can prove, eleven men dead or exiled, four widows restored this month alone. I want the number in writing where he can't reach it. That's how you kill a man like Perperna properly. Not with a knife. With an audit.”

Antonia was not present for the judgement, by her own choice. She spent the day at the Carinae, going over the quarterly accounts with Chloe, and when Festus came with the word, she set down the stylus and was quiet a while.

“Did he say anything?”

“At the end? He said the city would regret losing its best watchdog. He said it twice.” Festus's scarred face was impassive. “Then the lictors took him out the side door. Nobody watched the street. That's the part that'll kill him, if anything does; nobody watched.”

“Rome loves a winner and forgets a loser, and the difference is one good scandal.” She picked up the stylus again. “I'm not going to enjoy it, Festus.

I'd have preferred a man who could be ashamed. But I'll take the city being safer for the women behind me, and I won't pretend the justice is less real because it feels ordinary. Send word to the temple coffer; the originals can come home now. And tell the kitchen a proper supper tonight. Not a celebration. A completion."

That night, alone in her strong room, she took out the wooden disc, chipped and brown, that she had kept for thirty years, and held it, and thought of a boy's letter returning unopened and a girl sold for 940 sesterces and a door that had been gilded twice. Then she put it back in its compartment, closed the vault, and turned the key, because the keeping of the past, she had learned, was for the strong room, while the living was for the house above it.

Perperna left Rome on a grey morning with no escort and no spectators, which wounded him more than the judgement. The carter who took him as far as the coast reported, later, that the exiled man had talked for two days about the ungrateful city and the quality of the men who replaced him, and had only once fallen silent, at the crest of the hill where the road gives the last view of the rooftops. He settled, in the end, in a provincial town in the East, among strangers who did not know his name, which was the cruellest sentence the empire could have devised, though none of the judges had needed to write it. He lived some years, gave bad advice to lesser men, and

died in his bed; Rome did not record the date, and the Carinae house did not mark it, because Antonia had decided that the best revenge available to a woman of her profession was to outlive a man so completely that he became a chore to remember.

Other debts were paid in the same weeks, with less noise. Hilarus's contacts in Sardinia secured the transfer of Tyche's brother from the mines to a road gang and then, through the proper bribes and the proper papers, his manumission; he arrived at the Carinae thin and blinking in the spring light, and Tyche, who had sung through her own ordeal without breaking, broke completely at the sight of him and was found an hour later in the garden, teaching him the names of the herbs. Sabina's debt contract was cancelled outright, the four thousand sesterces paid from the house's own funds, and Antonia set her up as a scrivener of legal documents with a small shop near the Forum, where she proceeded to make a ferocious living correcting the work of advocates twice her age, and where young men with hopeless cases soon learned to seek the girl who knew the summons law by heart. Lalla won her own hearing with the letters-first method, and came to the house afterward with a jar of preserves and an application to be enrolled as a house musician, which Antonia accepted with the gravity due to a fellow veteran.

⁂

He told the family that evening, in the tablinum, with the letter to the senate lying sealed on the table between them.

Gaius read it twice, in the careful way he now read everything, and said, “You could have taken the quiet version. Health, and all of it. Nobody would have known.”

“Nobody except us. I've spent my life being the man who takes the quiet version; I've discovered there's a tax on it, and the tax is paid in what you think of yourself at night.” Marcus watched his son's face. “You're fourteen. In your life men will offer you the quiet version a dozen times, each time dressed up as wisdom. I wanted you to have at least one example of the other answer.”

Gaius considered this with the Aelian gravity that sat so oddly on his young face, and said, “Then I'll remember it. And if the school says things about the house, or about her—”

“They will. Say that your father chose the truth over the lictors, and that the Aelii have been consuls for four hundred years and can survive one year without. The name doesn't live in the chair. It lives in the letter.”

Livia said nothing until Gaius had gone, and then she picked up the sealed letter and weighed it in her hand.

“My father would have taken the bargain and then spent twenty years telling everyone about

the bargain he didn't quite take.” She set it down. “You've made the name smaller and the man larger. I'm not sure Rome understands the exchange, but I do. Send it. I'll send my own to the chief Vestal, so that the women hear your version before the men invent theirs.”

“Livia. If the association continues — the open friendship — you understand that people will speak of you as well as me.”

“People have spoken of me since I was fourteen; I've decided the only mistake is giving them dull material.” She rose, and paused at the door. “Invite her to dinner. Here, properly, with my name on the invitation. Rome can either grow up or gossip, and I've exhausted my patience with gossip.”

Marcus came to the Carinae in the evening, by the front door, in daylight hours, because there was nothing left to hide and no office left to lose.

They sat in the small dining room, the two of them, with the wine between them and the lamp flame steady, and he told her about the room on the Palatine, the bargain, and the letter he had sent.

“You gave it away,” she said, when he finished. “The consulship. For not abandoning me.”

“For not abandoning myself.” He turned the cup in his hands. “I gave away a chair. I kept the thing that made me fit to sit in one, which I'd nearly lost by being too careful. Do you know what I've discovered? That the most expensive

things in Rome are the small acts of courage men put off until tomorrow. I've paid at last. The accounts are clean."

"Livia?"

"Livia said the letter was the best prose I'd ever written and that she'd have despised me if I'd taken the bargain. She's begun referring to the whole affair as her year of being useful, and the consular wives have started a fashion for public-spirited wives, which I'm told is extremely inconvenient to their husbands. Celer's debts are being settled from Perperna's confiscated estate where the fraud touched him, and he's been sent to manage a family property in Sicily, where the temptations are fewer and the olive merchants are dull."

Antonia smiled, and then was serious. "And us. The councillors said no association. You refused it, in the room, for the record. What does that mean, Marcus, in the actual days? I won't be a private comfort at a back gate, and I won't be a scandal that costs you whatever remains. You know the terms. I gave them to you in custody."

"I know the terms." He did not look away. "It means friendship, in the open, in daylight, at your front door, under the gilded panel everyone in Rome can watch. It means dinners and letters and whatever the years make of us, without lies and without the marriage the law won't permit and you wouldn't accept. It means I'm no longer a consul, so my friendship is no longer an offence

against an office. They took the chair; they can't take the company. I've made sure of it.”

“You understand what people will say.”

“People already say everything. Let them say it over excellent food; your table has always been Rome's most reliable way to improve a gossip.” He set down the cup. “I'm not asking you for anything, Antonia. I'm telling you what I've chosen, and then I'm leaving the choosing with you, where it has always belonged.”

She looked at him across the lamplit table, at the man who had kept his three returned letters in a strong box and his hands off a slave girl in a kitchen and his word through a whole winter of fire and courts, and she thought that love, when it finally arrived in a life as fortified as hers, did not arrive as a conquest but as a treaty between two people who had separately decided the price of things.

“Then choose with me,” she said. “Dinner, the first night of spring, in the garden court. In the open, where the household can see, and Rome can hear. And after that, we'll find out what two free people do with a door that isn't locked on either side.”

He lifted his cup, and she lifted hers, and the cups met with the small, dry sound of an agreement, and outside, somewhere beyond the Carinae roofs, Rome went about its enormous business, indifferent as ever, while inside the

gilded house the lamps burned steady and the winter, at last, began to end.

The first night of spring came with the almond trees in blossom along the Esquiline, and the garden court was set for twelve, in the open, with the new lamps and the blue hangings and the fountain freshly cleared of its winter leaves. The household attended in its best, and the allies came — Hilarus and Porcia, Beryllus with his wife, Vibius Longus out of uniform, Rubrius looking surprised to be enjoying himself, and Festus at the door with his forearm newly healed — and Livia came, with Marcus, and walked through the gilded door on her own feet in full view of the street, and Antonia met her at the threshold, and the two women looked at each other for a held moment, and Antonia said, “Welcome to my house,” and Livia said, “Thank you. I've been admiring its accounts,” and the household, watching, exhaled.

They did not become friends, exactly; they became something more Roman, an alliance of two clear-sighted women who had decided the same men were worth more than the rules that separated them. The dinner was excellent, the wine was honest, the music avoided the sentimental, and Marcus was seated on Antonia's couch in the open position, with no secrets for the servants to overhear, and when the party ended he left by the front door at the proper hour, and

the door closed behind him with the sound of a thing settled rather than concealed.

Festus bolted it, as he bolted it every night, and said to Chloe in the atrium, “A good winter, all counted. We're still here, and most of them aren't.”

“Most winters,” Chloe said, taking the keys, “the door only has to shut. This one it had to hold.”

And in the strong room beneath them, the tablets slept in their sealed coffer, and the bronze ring hung at its mistress's throat, and the chipped wooden disc lay in its compartment, and all of it kept, and all of it true.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

The Gilded Door

In the spring of the year when the consuls were Publius Aelius and Lucius Celsus, the emperor Trajan left Rome for the East, and the army went with him down the Appian Way in a glittering column that took a whole morning to pass the Capena gate: the legions with their eagles, the cavalry in their dust, the siege trains groaning behind the oxen, and the long, ordinary tail of clerks and surgeons and sutlers and slaves, without whom no Roman army has ever marched a mile.

The city watched from the walls and the rooftops, because Rome always watches its armies leave, half in pride and half in the old fear that the world beyond the gates is larger than the world within them. Among the crowd at the Carinae end of the Caelian hill stood a woman of thirty-five in a plain gown with a bronze ring at her throat, and beside her, in the senatorial toga of a man holding no office and wanting none, Marcus Aelius Severus, and between them, with the unselfconscious height of a boy who has

grown three inches in a year, Gaius, counting the cavalry squadrons under his breath.

“They'll say in the market that he's marching to settle the Armenian question,” Marcus said.

“They'll say in my house that he's marching because the grain contracts are finally honest and he can afford the campaign.” Antonia watched the eagles pass. “The audit held through the winter. The new tallies were posted publicly for the first time this month; I had Sabina copy them. An army marches on its stomach, and its stomach is weighed at Ostia, and this year the weighing is true. That's our share of the triumph, if there is one. Nobody will put our names on an arch.”

“Nobody puts accountants on arches. It's one of the republic's few consistent cruelties.”

Gaius turned from the parapet. “Father says you're to teach me the grain accounts this summer. The real ones, not the school versions.”

“Your father flatters me; the real ones are duller. But yes. On condition that you also learn the household accounts of a house like mine, because the grain of empires and the grain of kitchens are measured by the same vice, which is the hope that no one will check the second weighing.” She looked at the boy's serious face and said, “You'll be a better senator for knowing both.”

“I'm not sure I'll be a senator,” Gaius said, with the immense judicial fairness of fifteen. “Uncle

Celer says the provinces are where the actual work happens."

"Your uncle, after a year among Sicilian olive merchants, has become an authority on work. Both can be true; decide later, and don't decide from a rooftop."

The column went on past them toward the south, and the dust hung over the road, and the city's noise resumed behind them as the last of the eagles disappeared, because Rome has never permitted even its emperors to interrupt trade for very long. They walked back down the hill together, the three of them, through the waking streets, toward the Carinae.

⁂

The house had been rebuilt better than it was before, which was the whole point.

Vitalis's new walls were brick-faced and sound, the upper wing enlarged, the women's rooms opening now onto a proper colonnade where the old timber stair had been. The atrium's dolphins swam again in fresh mosaic, the painted walls were brighter than the smoke-stained originals, and the strong room stood as it had always stood, because some things do not require improvement, only trust. A second stair and a second street door had been added against the possibility of another fire, and the water system now ran to every floor, an expense Antonia had insisted on personally

and charged, with perfect justice, against the value of sleeping through the night.

But the door was the thing people came to see.

The new gilded door was wider than the old one, oak under beaten gold leaf, with a frame of worked bronze and a small, discreet carving at its centre that most viewers took for a pattern and the household knew for a wall. It had been finished in the summer after the fire, and Rome's pamphleteers, who required symbols, had made it one: the door that had been blackened and restored, the house that had been indicted and acquitted, the woman who had been sold and now owned the threshold. Antonia tolerated the symbolism because it was good for trade and because she had built her whole career on letting men believe the stories that made them comfortable, while keeping the ledgers that told the truth.

The household had changed, as households do, and mostly upward.

Chloe was now the house's manager in everything but the title, and the title would come; Antonia had already begun the manumission papers, the gift made sweeter by the fact that Chloe could now afford to buy her own time and preferred, for the present, to stay. Her brother's tablets had a place of honour in the strong room, in a cedar box, and once a year, on the anniversary of the recovery of his body, she placed a small offering at the household shrine

and sang one of the Delos laments, and the house fell quiet and let her.

Sabina's scrivener's shop near the Forum had taken a second clerk, and her services were sought by litigants who had learned, the hard way, that a correctly drafted summons was worth three advocates. She kept her own accounts, voted nowhere because the law did not permit it, and gave legal advice to the neighbourhood's women for whatever they could pay, which was often bread, and once a goat.

Tyche's brother worked in Hilarus's warehouse, where the work was heavy and the wages were honest and the mines existed only in his sister's songs. Tyche herself remained the house's chief musician and had turned down two offers of marriage, explaining to Antonia, with perfect composure, that she had tried one household's control and found the stage more generous.

Festus still stood at the door, his forearm scarred and his school of ex-gladiators now formally in the house's pay as its guards, an arrangement so respectable that two neighbouring merchants had copied it. Beryllus banked for half the Esquiline and dented his reputation for coldness by endowing a small school for clerks' children. Rubrius had retired to a villa he claimed was wretched, from which he sent Antonia dry letters about the incompetence of the modern courts. Vibius Longus had been

promoted, and sent the house a yearly jar of wine from his own vineyard with a note consisting, the first year, of a single word: *Paper.*

On the Esquiline, Livia ran the family and the new fashion for public-spirited wives, and had begun, in her middle years, to study law in earnest, which her tutors found terrifying and her husband found restful, because an occupied Livia was an unimprovable Livia. Celer, leaner and quieter, came home from Sicily each winter and had become, against everyone's expectation, a shrewd manager of the family estates; the debts were gone, the Palatine house was repaired, and he had not gambled since the night he had fled the Capena gate, a fact he attributed, when pressed, to having learned that the only bet worth making was on the truth.

Marcus had no office and wanted none. He served on the odd senatorial commission, wrote an influential memorandum on the public posting of grain accounts, and was asked to advise by men who would not, two years earlier, have been seen at his door. The consulship remained, like a lighthouse passed in fog, the great un-taken thing of his public life; and he had discovered, in not taking it, a freedom the chair could never have given him, the freedom of a man whose ambitions no longer had a price on them.

The grain lessons he had promised Gaius began in the Carinae tablinum in the heat of July, with the shutters drawn against the sun and a

bowl of cooled wine between the three of them, because Antonia had said from the first that she would teach the boy nowhere else: he would learn the empire's accounts in a house the law called disreputable, and carry that lesson into every temple of respectability he entered afterward.

She began, as she began everything, with the physical thing rather than the word: a modius measure, a pair of balance weights, and a page of two columns.

“Grain leaves the field in one weight and reaches the army in another. Between those two facts stand seven pairs of hands: the farmer, the collector, the river captain, the harbour measurer, the granary keeper, the bureau clerk, the contractor. Every one of those hands can make the number change, and every one of them will explain the change as spillage, shrinkage, or the will of the gods. Your job, when you're a senator with a commission, is not to know which man is lying. It's to know that two honest weighings, in two places, by two men who don't know each other, cannot disagree. If they disagree, the difference is a man, not a miracle. Write that down.”

Gaius wrote it down, in the careful hand his rhetoric master had despaired of improving. “And the private re-weighing?”

“Clever boy. Yes — the private weighing inside the granary, with no outside witness, is where the old fraud was born. The new rule is the public

posting of the monthly totals, which your father helped write. Watch what it does: it doesn't make theft impossible. It makes theft visible, and visible theft requires a conspiracy, and conspiracies have members, and members have prices and grudges and, best of all, tablets. The law can't forbid a greedy man. It can make his greed expensive and complicated, and most men, given the choice between complicated vice and simple honesty, will surprise you."

Marcus, listening from the couch with his cup untouched, said, "She's teaching you what I learned in a winter of courts, at the cost of a consulship. Take notes on the teaching as well as the subject."

"I am, Father." Gaius hesitated, stylus hovering. "Domina Antonia. The boys at school say the house is — they say things. About what it is."

"I know exactly what they say; their fathers said the same things in louder rooms." She did not soften it, which Marcus saw the boy respect. "The house is a licensed house of entertainment, and the women in it choose their company under written contracts, and the city calls that by the ugliest names it knows because the city is made uneasy by women who own the door. You may decide the city's right to be uneasy. What you may not do, having sat at this table, is pretend the alternative is better — the dealer's floor, the lupanar, the unnamed girls whose weights no one

posts and whose contracts no one keeps. Keep the two facts together for your whole life, Gaius. The men who can hold two uncomfortable facts at once are the only men fit to govern, and Rome has always had too few of them.”

The boy wrote that down too, slowly, and Marcus said nothing, and in the shaded tablinum the only sounds were the stylus on wax and the fountain in the court and, far off, the enormous, ordinary commerce of the city going about its measured, double-weighed, imperfectly honest business.

⁂

She went out to the Esquiline gate one morning in early May, before the heat, with the annual offering for the columbarium, and Chloe came with her, because the visit belonged to both of them now.

The stone niche was weathered a little at its edges but the inscription, cut deep, was as legible as the day it was set: *Phyllis, free woman, who kept the wall.* Antonia set down the wine and the bread and the small garland, and poured the libation with the words the priestess had taught her, and they stood a while in the quiet of the tombs, where Rome's enormous noise came only as a distant murmur.

“The new girl comes this week,” Antonia said. “Thirteen. Capua. Debt sale.”

“They keep coming,” Chloe said.

“They'll always keep coming. The city needs the door as much as the girls do; the city just won't admit it.” She laid her hand for a moment on the warm stone. “I used to think the point of the house was survival. Then I thought it was the evidence, and the case, and the courts. I've decided the point is the one Phyllis understood before I did: that someone has to keep the wall, without ceremony or office or anyone recording it. The courts were a season. The wall is the whole life.”

“Hector's got his own offerings,” Chloe said, nodding toward the cedar-shrine tablet she had placed nearby, with her brother's name and the line he had wanted, the dull life in Neapolis written into stone as a joke between the dead. “I tell him every year how dull the harbour office is. I think he'd have liked the joke more than the revenge.”

“He'd have liked being read. That was the whole of him. Read and believed.”

They walked back through the gate into the living city, and Antonia said, on the road, “Begin the manumission papers for yourself this month. Not because I want you to go — because I want the world to have to call you a free woman out loud. Stay as long as you like, in whatever name you like, but the paper should say free.”

Chloe was quiet for a long stretch of the road, and then said, “I'll do the same for Tyche. And the new one, when she's earned it.”

“That's how it works. Every woman who gets through the door holds it for the next one.” Antonia adjusted her veil against the sun. “We're not a house, Chloe. We're a relay.”

The girl came to the gilded door in the third week of May, brought by a dealer who had learned, like most of Rome's dealers, that the Carinae house paid fair prices and asked no questions it did not need the answers to.

She was thirteen, from a farm near Capua, sold for debt, thin and watchful, with the particular stillness of children who have already worked out that movement draws the eye. The dealer's pitch was professional and brisk; Antonia heard it out in the atrium, as she heard them all, and then sent the man away with a receipt and a sum he did not argue with, and the girl stood in the bright atrium among the dolphin mosaics with her cloth bundle in her hands and the expression of someone waiting to be told the shape of the next cruelty.

“Look at me,” Antonia said, and the girl looked. “What's your name?”

“Marcella, domina.”

“Marcella. In this house you keep your name; if it fails you, you may choose another, but no one gives you one. You will eat three meals, sleep behind a lock that you hold the key to, and be taught to read and write and play something,

because an unskilled woman in Rome is a woman with one thing to sell, and this house trades in more than one. No one will touch you until you understand the contracts, and the contracts will be in your own hand before you sign them. Do you believe me?”

The girl considered it, the way the young consider the incredible, with suspicion rather than hope. “The dealer said houses like this—”

“The dealer sells what he's paid to sell. I'll show you the contract school. Sabina teaches part of it; she was once standing where you're standing, with a bundle exactly like that one. Ask her what the bundle feels like now.”

Later, when the girl had been taken away to the bath and the new room and the unavoidable, restorative business of being fed, Chloe found Antonia alone in the strong room, standing before the cedar box and the bronze ring's empty cord, for she wore the ring today and had only come to check the seals.

The girl's first day ran according to the house's unwritten rules, the rules that existed nowhere but in practice and were older, Antonia suspected, than the laws of the Twelve Tables. First, food, before questions. Then a bath, and clean clothes chosen by the girl herself from a pile, so that the first act of choice in her new life was small and safe and hers. Then the room, with its own key, its own lamp, its own shutter she could close against the world. Then, and only then, the conversation,

in the garden, where nothing could be overheard and nothing could be mistaken for a scene in a bedroom.

Antonia sat with her there in the afternoon light and answered the questions the girl could not yet frame: whether she could ever leave, and on what terms; whether she could keep her name; whether the reading lessons were real; whether men could take what they wanted here, as they had at the farm. To the last question Antonia answered slowly, because it was the one that mattered.

“Nowhere in Rome is fully safe from men. Not this house, not the temples, not the empress's own rooms. But here there is a contract, and a lock, and Festus at the door, and a mistress who has been exactly where you are and will not have it happen under her roof. The difference between here and the farm isn't that men are better. It's that the paper is. Learn the paper, Marcella. The paper is the only weapon the city can't take off you.”

The girl turned the new key over in her hand, feeling its weight, and said, “The dealer said you were the most expensive house in Rome.”

“We're not the most expensive. We're the most carefully run. Men pay for certainty, and the certainty they're buying is that nothing happens here without consent and a receipt. Even the vices, in this house, keep accounts.” She said it without apology, the way she said everything.

“Now. The music master comes tomorrow. If you hate the lyre, there's the double pipe; if you hate both, there's the kitchen, and the kitchen's no disgrace. I began in a kitchen.”

It was the first thing she had said that the girl plainly believed, and Marcella's watchful face relaxed by a fraction, the fraction by which all such houses, at their rare best, are won.

Chloe found her mistress in the strong room after that, standing before the cedar box and the bronze ring's empty cord, for she wore the ring today and had only come to check the seals.

“You always do that,” Chloe said. “When a new one arrives. You come down here.”

“I come to remember what the alternative looked like. There's a woman in this city, Antonia Prima, who bought herself out of it for nine hundred and forty sesterces and bought me my name with the same coin. She's dead ten years now. I keep the figure because it's the price of a human being, and a house that forgets the price becomes a house that charges it.” Antonia closed the vault. “I was thirteen on a dealer's floor, Chloe. I had a bronze ring my mother gave me and the certain knowledge that the world was arranged against me. The world is still arranged against girls like Marcella. But this one door, on this one street, is arranged for them. That has to be enough, and then we have to make it more.”

“You're going to keep going, then. I've heard the rumours; that you might retire, that the senator would—”

“The senator would never presume, and I would never accept.” She smiled. “Retire to what? A villa and a quiet old age while the dealers keep bringing the thirteen-year-olds? The door doesn't retire. It opens, or it doesn't, and I've spent my life making sure this one opens.”

⁂

The house held its spring dinner in the garden court a week later, the same table under the almond trees, enlarged now by the years. The allies came, as they always did: Hilarus and Porcia, Beryllus and his wife, Rubrius up from his “wretched” villa for the occasion, Vibius Longus with his annual jar and his single-word note, now framed in the kitchen. Livia came with Gaius and, to the general interest, a scroll of legal notes she wanted Sabina's opinion on, and the two women were soon deep in the vexed question of women's witness summonses while the men ate the first course without them.

After the music, the old stories made their round, as old stories do at successful dinners, growing slightly in the telling. The warehouse fight, with Festus's knife wound, had by now involved twice as many men. The basilica verdict had acquired a thunderstorm that had never

occurred. Perperna's departure had shrunk, year by year, into a single departing cart seen by nobody in particular, which was the truest version of it and therefore the one nobody believed.

Antonia let the stories run and said little, as hosts do, watching the table with the pleasure of a woman who had built the room that held these people. Slaves moved among the lamps with water and wine; the new girl Marcella, three weeks into her letters, watched everything from the musicians' bench; the fountain spilled its measured water; and beyond the rebuilt walls Rome made its ten thousand suppers, most of them in houses with worse accounts and fewer friends.

“To paper,” Beryllus said, raising his cup in the banker's toast he had invented for this table, and they drank it, even Rubrius, who claimed to dislike toasts on principle.

Marcus came that evening, as he came most evenings, through the gilded door in the last of the light, and the household greeted him with the easy familiarity of long custom, and Festus unbolted and rebolted without commentary, and they took their wine in the small dining room, the two of them, the way they had done a hundred times since the winter of the courts.

He brought news, as he often did: the latest dispatches from the East, the senate's manoeuvres, a new pamphlet that had got the grain scandal wonderfully wrong and assigned the

whole victory to a fictitious freedman of the emperor's. She listened and laughed and gave him the house's news in return: the new girl, Sabina's goat, Tyche's refusal, Festus's vineyard, the thousand small transactions of a working establishment. They were, by now, two people who knew each other's days the way old friends do, not in the manner of lovers who keep nothing, but in the better manner of free people who keep everything by choice.

After the wine, he walked with her to the threshold, because the evening had reached the hour when he always left, and the leaving was part of the treaty and had its own small ritual. The street was blue in the dusk, the lamps were being lit along the Carinae, and the gilded door stood open behind them, spilling the house's warm light across the pavement.

“Gaius asked me today whether we'll marry now that Livia's—” He stopped. “He put it clumsily. He's fifteen.”

“Livia's well and likely to outlive us all, so the question's premature in every sense.” Antonia leaned against the doorframe, the bronze ring warm at her throat. “But I'll answer it anyway, since he won't be the last to ask. No. Not because of the law, though the law's against it, and not because of Livia, who has her own life and doesn't want me in it. Because marriage in this city means the door becomes yours, or I become yours, and either way one of us stops being free. What we

have is rarer than a marriage, Marcus. Two people, equal at the threshold, neither inside the other's walls. The whole city arranges itself to prevent exactly this, and we've achieved it. I won't trade it for a ceremony."

"I didn't ask you to." He stood in the street, not the house, the line between the lamplight and the dusk falling exactly between them. "I came to tell you the opposite, actually. I've been offered a post in the East, with the emperor's staff. The grain supply for the campaign. It's the work I'm best at, and they're honest enough now to ask for the man who knows the frauds. Two years, perhaps three."

She did not let the surprise reach her face at once; she examined it, as she examined everything, before she let it speak. "And?"

"And I said I'd decide after I'd told you. That's the whole of my question. Not whether to stay. Whether you'd think less of me for going to do the work, or think the treaty broken because the door keeps its hours across a sea."

For answer, she stepped out onto the pavement beside him, into the dusk, so that they stood together outside the door, the equal lamplight on both their faces.

"I'd think less of you if you didn't go. The accounts are honest here; make them honest there. An army's stomach, remember. Write to me; I write better letters than I get. And when you come back, the door will still be here, because doors are easier than men, and this one has been

gilded twice and survived worse than a campaign.”

He smiled, the smile she had waited thirty years to be the cause of, and said, “Then I'll go. And come back.”

“And come back.”

He took her hand, once, in the open street, the single permitted gesture of all their years, and then he released it, and turned, and walked away up the Carinae toward the Esquiline, and she watched him go until the dusk took him, and she did not weep, because this was not an ending but a deployment, and she had never once in her life mistaken the two.

The letters began within the month, carried on the military post and the merchant ships, and they kept coming across the two years that followed, steady as accounts. He wrote of the harbours of the East and the weigh-masters of Antioch and the endless inventiveness of men who believed no one would check the second weighing; she wrote of the Carinae and the new girl's progress with the lyre, of Sabina's goat, of Chloe's manumission and Tyche's third refusal, of Livia's summons reforms and the city's pamphlets, which now described her as “a respectable householder of the Carinae,” the phrase she had spent a lifetime earning and pretended to disdain.

Once, in the second winter, his letter carried a pressed olive leaf from a grove in Syria, and she put it in the cedar box in the strong room, beside

the tablets and the chipped wooden disc, where the kept things of a life lay together: the evidence, and the memory, and the small green proof that distance was not absence.

She did not travel to see him off at Brundisium, because the door could not be left and because both of them disliked the Roman sentimentality of quays. Instead she stood on the Esquiline in the early light on the day the column passed, as she had stood for the emperor's, and saw the small staff group at its rear, and one figure among them who raised a hand once, without turning, the gesture of a man who knew exactly where on the hillside she would be. She raised hers. The road took him. The hillside kept her.

He came back in the third spring, as he had said he would, with the eastern tan still on him and a new scar on one forearm from a mutiny of muleteers, and the campaign's grain accounts behind him in perfect, boring, audited order. He came through the gilded door at the familiar hour, and Festus, who had been informed by the harbour watch the day before, unbolted without a word, and the household, which had been instructed to behave as though no time at all had passed, did exactly that, because it was the welcome he wanted. They ate in the small dining room, and she gave him the house's news from the ledger of the years, and he gave her the East from memory, and at the end he walked with her

to the threshold, as he always did, for the hour and the ritual had survived the distance.

Behind her the household was making its evening noise: the music, the kitchen, the fountain, the voices of women who had been sold and had nevertheless become people. Marcella, now fifteen and the house's best young lyre, appeared at the end of the atrium with a writing tablet and a question about a contract clause, and Antonia turned from the street and went back through the door, and showed her.

Festus came to shut up for the night. He looked at her, at the lamp-lit atrium, at the gold leaf gleaming in its frame, and he said the line he said every night, because some things bear repetition.

"All secure, domina."

Antonia Cassia, once Anthe, sold at nine hundred and forty sesterces and bought back at a far higher price, stood inside her own house with the night behind her and the lamps before her, and she gave the answer she had earned the hard way, the answer the city had spent thirty years trying to make impossible:

"Yes," she said. "It is."

The gilded door closed, and the bolt went home, and Rome went on beyond it, enormous and indifferent and eternal, while inside, for one more night, the light burned, and the accounts balanced, and the door opened.

FINIS